BLOSSOM RESEARCH

The Eisman Playbook Decoded

Every episode of Steve Eisman's podcast, read end to end, including the paid tier. The recurring theses, the guest bench, the frameworks he teaches, and the calls he made, tracked as they changed. Third edition, current to 25 September 2026: 152 episodes with a synopsis each, 92 interviews and lectures with a full dossier, and every premium subscriber episode read.

152	152	1122k	106.2	19	76
EPISODES	TRANSCRIPTS	WORDS READ	HOURS	PAID EPS	GUESTS



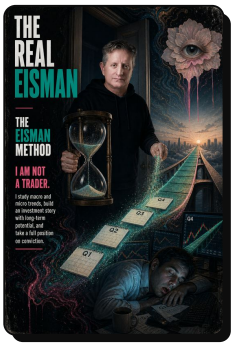
THE SHOW

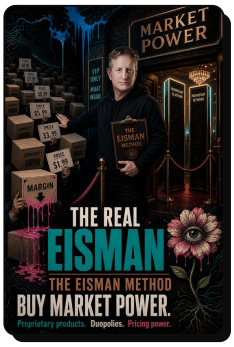
Steve Eisman has published weekly since June 2025 across YouTube, Apple, Spotify and Substack. This report reads the whole run.

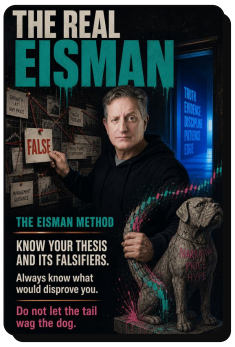
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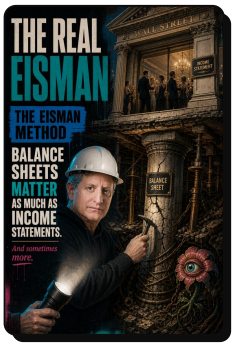
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POSTER ART BY MLOW

THE FORMAT

Two shows wearing one name

The podcast launched on 5 June 2025 and has run without a real break since. A strict weekly rhythm holds it together, and the two halves of that rhythm do entirely different jobs.

MONDAYS

The numbered episode

Forty-five to eighty minutes. One expert, usually a sell-side or boutique analyst rather than a famous name, taken through a single sector in forensic depth. Eisman plays the intelligent generalist and interrupts constantly to make the guest define terms. Since roughly Episode 50 he closes each one with a solo lessons-learned coda.

FRIDAYS

The Weekly Wrap

Twenty to thirty-five minutes, solo and scripted. Index statistics, then earnings walked company by company, then a mailbag answering listener questions. It began as The Friday Market Wrap and became The Weekly Wrap around September 2025. Here his own views run undiluted, across 57 episodes.

Three other formats sit on top. Masterclass lectures on the 2008 crisis, financial literacy and private credit run as university lectures with no guest. Panels gather three analysts at once. Reaction episodes include one where he watches scenes from The Big Short and marks what the film got right.

He frames the show as apolitical and says so repeatedly. This is a business and markets podcast, he takes government policy as given, and he will not tell anyone how to vote. A disclaimer closes every episode.

> *“In the business world, we don't call the game. We just take the pitches.”*
>
> WEEKLY WRAP, 12 JULY 2025

BACKGROUND

Who is actually talking

His authority on the show rests on a specific career shape, and he returns to it constantly, because he learned nearly every framework he teaches at one of these stops.

PERIOD	ROLE	WHAT HE LEARNED THERE
1980s	Penn, then Harvard Law	Practised law briefly and did securitisation document work for The Money Store, which is how he later got the subprime beat.
1991 to 2000	Oppenheimer, sell-side analyst	A banker walked into his office and handed him subprime coverage almost by accident. He built out to subprime mortgage, subprime auto, Fannie, Freddie, Sallie Mae, credit cards, asset managers and investment banks, and taught himself to model.
2001 to 2003	Buy side, large hedge fund	Picked up banks and the whole insurance sector for the first time.
2004 to 2011	FrontPoint Partners, portfolio manager	The Big Short years. He ran a long-short financials equity book and a credit default swap book against subprime paper at the same time.
2012 to 2014	Emrys Partners, founder	His own fund, later wound down.
2014 to 2024	Neuberger Berman, managing director	Ran the Eisman Group inside private asset management.
2025 onward	The Real Eisman Playbook	Podcast, Substack and YouTube channel, managing his own money.

Steve Carell played him in the 2015 film of Michael Lewis's The Big Short, a fact he treats with visible ambivalence. He corrects the film's details often and dismisses the perpetual-crisis punditry the fame invites. He left Neuberger Berman after the firm placed him on indefinite leave in September 2024 over a social media post about Gaza that it called irresponsible and objectionable. He deleted his X account at the time. The podcast is his post-institutional act.

Two other pieces of context surface on the show itself. He disclosed his breast cancer diagnosis on air on 19 July 2025, in that week's wrap, and framed it deliberately: he wanted men to know the disease is not confined to women. A February 2026 episode looked back on it. He also mentions owning a small business, reads heavily in historical fiction, recommends Colleen McCullough's Rome novels, and reads comics.

The framework he built on air

Unusually for a podcast, Eisman formalises his own thinking twice a year and then holds himself to it. Two documents matter more than any single episode.

The four themes of 2025 (19 December 2025)

1. **The K-shaped economy.** GDP growth is real but concentrated almost entirely in AI capital spending.
2. **The AI revolution, or an AI bubble.** He refuses to pick, deliberately.
3. **Fears about the growth in private credit.** Note the word fears. At that point he would not call it a problem.
4. **Affordability.** The cumulative effect of inflation on the consumer, not the current rate.

The five structural themes for 2026 (9 January 2026)

These are longer-arc claims about market structure rather than year-ahead calls. The through-line: the S&P has become something other than a mirror of the American economy.

1. Tech and tech-related stocks dominate the index to a degree no other developed market approaches, above 40%, and by his mid-2026 count closer to 50%.
2. Consumers drive roughly 70% of the US economy, yet consumer stocks drive less and less of the index.
3. Index investing reinforces the concentration. About 60% of flows go into funds that mechanically buy what they already own, in the size they already own it.
4. The market has therefore come unmoored from everyday life. Whole sectors can rot without the index noticing.
5. Any real break will therefore be violent. Passive flows that push a market up smoothly reverse without a bid.

> *"Even if parts of the K-shaped economy get worse, even if the overall economy stagnates, the market might, I repeat, might power through it. As long as current tech and AI trends remain intact. However, if AI trends falter, I would expect an enormous correction."*
>
> WEEKLY WRAP, 9 JANUARY 2026

That sentence carries more weight than anything else on the show. Nearly every other position follows from it.

THE CHRONOLOGY

Sixteen months, one arc

Read in order, the 152 episodes tell a single story: a market that began the period celebrating AI capital spending and ended it auditing every dollar of it. Along the way the show absorbed a war, a government shutdown, a private credit panic and the host's cancer treatment, without missing a week.

JUNE TO SEPTEMBER 2025

The establishing phase. Launch with Patrick McGee on Apple, the short-selling pair with Ganapathi and Safalow, the Melissa Lee role reversal, and the first statements of method. AI is the market's engine and capex announcements are unambiguous buy signals.

OCTOBER 2025

The vocabulary arrives. He names the K-shaped economy, splits 89 reporting companies into AI and everything else, and starts asking the return-on-invested-capital question out loud. Sorkin's 1929 book gives the season its historical frame: credit plus leverage plus FOMO.

NOVEMBER TO DECEMBER 2025

The two-sided market. Nvidia accelerates at a 4.4 trillion market cap and the tape sells off anyway. Burry's depreciation argument, the Ferguson railroad analogy and the binding constraint framework (power) all enter the show's standing repertoire. The year ends with the four themes codified and the 2008 masterclasses delivered.

JANUARY TO FEBRUARY 2026

The repricing begins. Gary Marcus makes the scaling-sceptic case; Daniel Guetta answers that good enough already disrupts. Software becomes guilty until proven innocent, the SaaSpocalypse gets its name, and identical capex headlines start sinking the stocks they once lifted. He finishes chemotherapy and thanks Valerie Feigen on air.

MARCH TO APRIL 2026

The stress tests. The Iran war suspends stock-level analysis for weeks, oil breaches 100 dollars, and private credit cracks in public: Blue Owl gates redemptions, Gober lays out the life insurance triangle, and Eisman's sharpest line lands, executives mistaking a benign cycle for genius.

MAY TO JUNE 2026

The single trade. Premium launches with A Conspiracy of Credit. The 10-year breaches his 4.5% Rubicon and he lightens up. Hyperscalers turn to shareholders to fund capex, Google raises 85 billion, and he concludes the stock and bond markets have collapsed into one AI bet.

JULY TO AUGUST 2026

The audit. Torsten Slok puts AI at roughly half of US growth. Free cash flow at the hyperscalers goes negative, a credit cycle forms inside the AI trade, and he names the single point of failure: the day Anthropic and OpenAI stop buying compute. The Strategas pair close the corpus by raising the rate threshold the market just absorbed.

SEPTEMBER 2026

The bill arrives in rates. The war heats up again, oil nears 110 dollars, the Fed raises by 25 basis points to 3.75 to 4%, and the ten-year runs through 4.9% to a multi-year high above 5.1%. He concedes his 4.5% line was wrong, moves it to 5%, and says a correction is probably imminent if the yield holds there. He names OpenAI as the single failure that could tip the economy into recession, partially hedges his biggest gains, and lists the defensive funds he would rotate into.

The through line is his own subprime education applied in real time. Theses develop in stages, the data decides, and the job is to know the argument well enough to measure its risk before the market forces the question.

THEME 01

The K-shaped economy

He starts using the phrase around October 2025 and it becomes the show's organising metaphor, appearing in 27 episodes. The claim is arithmetic before it is rhetorical. US GDP grew roughly 2% in 2025, which on a base near 25 trillion dollars comes to about 500 billion, and AI-related capital spending for the year ran north of 400 billion. Strip that out and growth rounds to nothing.

UPPER LEG: The upper leg

- Hyperscalers, semiconductors, Nvidia and its supply chain
- Power and grid: GE Vernova, Vertiv, turbines, small modular reactors
- Industrials, but only where AI-adjacent
- Investment banking, M&A advisory, trading
- The top 10% of households, who account for nearly half of all consumer spending

LOWER LEG: The lower leg

- Housing and the whole housing ecosystem
- Consumer staples, with Procter organic growth at zero and McCormick weak
- Domino's, which he calls the poster child
- Residential solar, obliterated
- Subprime auto, with 60-day delinquencies at 6.65%, the highest since 1994
- Youth employment, and computer science graduates in particular

He checks the claim against the market with one tell he repeats: the gap between the S&P 500 and the S&P 500 equal-weight index. In 2025 the cap-weighted index rose about 16% while equal-weight managed 10%, and 37% of index constituents finished the year down.

He is careful about what this does not mean. On its own it produces no recession. His stated recession tripwire is bank credit quality, and through mid-2026 he reads it as benign. On Episode 68, Torsten Slok adds the decomposition Eisman then adopts: the K exists in three separate dimensions, wealth, wage growth and inflation exposure, with the bottom cohort spending a larger share on food, energy and housing.

He also rejects the fatalistic reading. When a viewer commented that a K-shaped economy has always existed, he disagreed. The distribution may be unfair, but everyone is materially wealthier than before, and he cites John Cassidy, a critic of capitalism, conceding the same point.

THEME 02

AI: he will not call it

This is the most-covered subject on the show and the one where his position visibly moves. He owns the stocks, says so constantly, and narrates his own growing discomfort instead of resolving it. Tracked chronologically, the arc is the most valuable thing in the corpus.



The Elevator

WATCH CORRELATION BETWEEN LONGS AND SHORTS

JUNE 2025

Nvidia posts 69% year-over-year revenue growth. He calls the AI story still in its infancy and says the US economy is more dynamic than at any point in his lifetime. Only a trade war could derail it.

SEPTEMBER 2025

Morgan Stanley's 2.9 trillion dollar data-centre estimate through 2028 lands. He notes approvingly that roughly half comes from hyperscaler operating cash flow, which he calls healthy and the key distinction from the dot-com bubble.

OCTOBER 2025

The K-shape framing arrives. He admits for the first time to a twitch in the back of his eyeball after a long bullish run.

NOVEMBER 2025

Michael Burry argues hyperscalers stretched compute depreciation from three to five years out to five or six, inflating earnings. Eisman takes it seriously but rules it academic: no catalyst forces the write-down, and auditors will not force it.

DECEMBER 2025

He sharpens the real risk. Not valuation, not accounting, but whether ever-larger models stop paying off. If scaling stalls, chip orders stop and the virtuous cycle reverses. He cites the estimate that big tech needs two trillion dollars of AI revenue by 2030 to justify the spend.

JANUARY 2026

The Rubin chip strengthens Burry's case. Blackwell shipped in late 2024 and already looks obsolete, which sits badly against a six-year depreciation life.

FEBRUARY 2026

The narrative inverts. Google guides to 180 billion dollars of 2026 capex, double 2025 and 60 billion above consensus, and the stock falls. Amazon guides 200 billion against 146 billion expected and drops 7%. Capex used to be a buy signal. Now it is a sell signal.

JUNE 2026

The moment he flags as a sea change. Google raises 85 billion dollars in equity rather than debt. Hyperscalers can no longer self-fund. Owning AI stocks while the AI companies foot the bill is one thing; owning them while they ask public shareholders to foot it is another.

JULY AND AUGUST 2026

Hyperscaler capex approaches one trillion dollars for the year. He concludes the entire market is now a single bet and identifies the Achilles heel: OpenAI and Anthropic account for roughly 70% of AI revenue at the big clouds, with cheap Chinese open-weight models threatening a price war. He reduces exposure and sells Alphabet after years of holding it.

SEPTEMBER 2026

The dependency argument narrows to one company. He calls OpenAI the Achilles heel of the US economy, citing a June quarter in which revenue rose about 1 billion dollars to 6.7 billion while costs rose about 3 billion to 12.3 billion, and argues its failure would cause an almost immediate recession because AI spending is carrying GDP growth. He dismisses the AI extinction talk from Anthropic and OpenAI as convenient, since neither can afford a slowdown, and adds an accounting charge: data centers financed off balance sheet through vehicles like Meta's Beignet, 80% owned by Blue Owl and Pimco, echo Enron and the 2008 SIVs. His own position follows: he is more and more nervous, will not add AI risk even indirectly through investment banks, and has partially hedged his largest gains.

The four arguments he keeps separate

He refuses to call it partly because people keep collapsing four distinct questions into one.

QUESTION	HIS POSITION
Will language models scale to general intelligence?	Outside his expertise, so he leans on Gary Marcus, who says no. He treats this as the fundamental risk to the whole story.
Is there a capex bubble?	A different question entirely. Real orders from real companies, unlike 1999. But outside capital increasingly funds it.
Are the accounts honest?	Burry is probably right on depreciation, but nothing forces the issue, so it does not trade.
Are there moats?	His growing worry. If the models are near-identical and commoditising, the spend has no defensible return.

The trigger he watches is a single hyperscaler cutting capital spending. He says repeatedly that the day Meta announces a 25% cut, the market goes straight down, and that by the time it shows up in a print it is already too late. Stacy Rasgon, the semiconductor analyst on Episode 63, agrees on the mechanism and disagrees on the timing, arguing capex is if anything too low.

The SaaSpocalypse

Software is the corollary trade, and he treats it as structurally impaired rather than cheap. AI threatens seat-based pricing and terminal value at once, valuations have halved, and the group trades at a discount to the S&P for arguably the first time in its history. He reads that as a symptom, not a signal, because software investors have never cared about valuation. Buying it, he says on Episode 54, is catching a falling knife.

He draws one exception: proprietary data beats AI disruption. Moody's held up where S&P Global wobbled, because when a company owns a proprietary database, AI inroads become difficult to impossible.

THEME 03

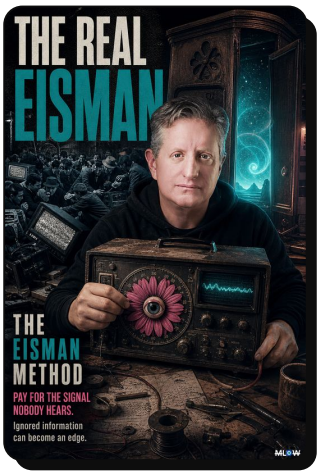
Private credit: the slow conversion

This is the most intellectually honest sequence on the show. He begins as the sceptic of the sceptics and ends as the house bear, and the reason he gives for changing is that the data finally arrived.

The starting position, June 2025. People are calling private credit a bubble. He will not, because no credit-quality data exists. He contrasts this with 2006, when he and his team subscribed to the Moody's securitisation database and watched delinquencies deteriorate month by month like a Rosetta Stone. His refrain through most of 2025: it will not cause a recession, but when a recession comes, whoever made mistakes gets exposed.

AUTUMN 2025

Tricolor and First Brands fail. He is careful to note both were bank loans rather than private credit, yet the market shoots the private credit stocks anyway. He flags this as a lesson in narrative rather than fundamentals.



The Radio
PAY FOR THE DATA NOBODY ELSE BUYS

NOVEMBER 2025

Blue Owl rescinds a fund merger after investors complain. He starts dissecting the BDC fee structure: fees charged on gross assets at up to two-to-one leverage, which mechanically rewards maximum leverage, with managers in the upside and out of the downside.

FEBRUARY 2026

Blue Owl restricts redemptions. He calls retail distribution of illiquid long-dated loans with quarterly liquidity a ticking time bomb, and predicts more gates.

MARCH 2026

The prediction lands. Apollo's 25 billion dollar flagship receives an 11.2% redemption notice and honours only the 5% cap. Blackstone's BCred takes 7.9% against a 5% cap and self-funds rather than gate. Moody's downgrades a KKR-linked fund to junk. The sector is down 24% to 31% for the year.

APRIL 2026

The verdict sentence: an entire generation of private credit executives has mistaken the absence of a credit cycle for genius.

AUGUST 2026

Episode 72, Private Credit's Clock is Ticking.

The three structural objections

1. Circularity

Eighty percent of US direct lending goes to companies backed by private equity. The largest private credit fund, BCred, is a non-traded BDC wholly owned by Blackstone. One arm of the firm buys companies and another lends the money to buy them. As he puts it, if that sounds circular, it is only because it is.

2. Software concentration

Private credit is over-indexed to software buyouts, publicly estimated at 20% to 25% of the market and, per a Wall Street Journal piece he cites, understated. Slok puts it near 500 billion dollars of a two trillion dollar direct-lending market. Here is the collision: the sector most exposed to AI disruption is the sector private credit lent into most heavily, at high valuations, with rates higher for longer.

3. The life insurance channel

The one he calls potentially systemic, explored across several episodes with the former insurance examiner Tom Gober. Private equity firms own life insurers and sell their own originated paper into those captives, then use offshore captive reinsurance in Vermont, Bermuda or Barbados to lever further than onshore statements reveal. Two things changed over twenty years: riskier assets, and hidden leverage. He discloses no position, long or short.

Where he stops short. He does not think this is 2008 again, and says so plainly. The banks are genuinely well capitalised this time. Expect losses and possibly a recession, not systemic collapse. His reason for focusing here at all is a pattern rule rather than alarm: when a credit cycle turns, problems surface where the growth was, and private credit grew from roughly 300 billion dollars a decade ago to somewhere between 1.8 and 3 trillion.

THEME 04

Affordability, and why housing is broken

This is his most policy-forward argument, and the one where he insists most firmly that the consensus diagnosis is wrong.

> *"This is not a demand problem. If we could build affordable homes, people would buy them in a heartbeat."*
>
> REPEATED ACROSS WRAPS, DECEMBER 2025 TO MARCH 2026

A politician's instinct, he argues, always reaches for a demand-side fix: subsidies, credits, rate relief. He says the binding constraint is supply, and specifically local. Zoning and permitting rules run slow, add materially to cost, and in many places make smaller homes illegal to build. His test for political seriousness is explicit. A president who tackles the local rules means it; anything else is theatre.

On the stocks, homebuilders remain rate-sensitive and no one escapes that. Through the period they have propped up volume with incentives and rate buy-downs financed through captive mortgage arms, which protects volume and destroys margin. He has been clear this can only run so far, then bought Meritage Homes in January 2026 anyway, on the rule of thumb that you buy builders at or below tangible book. He later interviewed its chief executive on air while disclosing the position.

He separates today's housing problem from 2008 emphatically. Capital requirements after Dodd-Frank made subprime mortgages uneconomic for banks. In 2006 originations of 600 billion dollars made up 20% of the mortgage market, and that industry effectively no longer exists. Today's problem is affordability and supply, not credit.

COVERAGE

Banks, the Fed and rates

Banks are safe, and he is the one saying it

Coming from the man who shorted them into the crisis, this is his most counterintuitive standing position. He credits a specific mechanism. Dodd-Frank created the Fed's vice chair for financial supervision, and he notes how astonishing it is that the United States had no head bank regulator before that. Daniel Tarullo held the role de facto, and Eisman calls him possibly the only great bank regulator in American history. Through the annual stress tests, leverage fell by more than half, and the risk tails were cut off inside that. Citigroup went from roughly 35 to 1 down to 10 to 1, a distance he likens to Pluto and the sun.

He teaches the plumbing rather than asserting the conclusion. Capital ratios divide common equity by risk-weighted assets, not by assets. The binding constraint on large banks is the stress capital buffer, not the statutory minimum. And the risk-weighted asset concept itself was, in his view, a root cause of 2008, because of the leverage it permitted. He also warns against ratcheting the test forever. Push it far enough and banking stops being an economic business.



The Submarine

BALANCE SHEETS MATTER AS MUCH AS INCOME STATEMENTS

His recession indicator is bank credit quality. As the banks go, so goes the economy was his line for a year, until July 2026, when he revised it. This time the banks are not the leading indicator, because the economy's fate now hinges on AI. He also argues repeatedly for a wave of regional bank consolidation.

The merger wave he wanted is not coming, and he says so. His two-part paid lecture on analysing banks in September 2026 restates the case for regional consolidation, since technology costs favour scale and JPMorgan's deposit share has roughly doubled since the crisis, then abandons it as an investment case. Bank chief executives like being bank chief executives, and First Horizon, the obvious target, declared itself a buyer. His advice now is to stick to the large banks and to buy even those only after recession fears have crushed their valuations.

The Fed and the dollar

He dismisses two popular anxieties. On the dollar losing reserve status, people have worried for forty years without asking why it never happens. His answer: the global system runs on Treasuries, through the repo market and sovereign wealth allocation, and no alternative exists. Not crypto, which is too small. Not Chinese bonds. Not European ones. Given an alternative he would worry about deficits; absent one, he does not. On the deficit generally, he calls the public hand-wringing Wall Street's version of virtue signalling.

On Greenspan he is unsparing. History will not be kind, because Greenspan allowed the leverage, and people told him directly about fraud in the subprime market in 2005 and 2006, and he did not care.

The Fed turned in September 2026. With the war pushing oil toward 110 dollars and inflation fears back, the Fed raised by 25 basis points to a range of 3.75 to 4% and pencilled in another increase, in defiance of the White House. It is the first rate increase in the sixteen months the corpus covers, and it arrives with the ten-year above 5%.

COVERAGE

Crypto and stablecoins

His crypto critique is narrow, and he repeats it almost verbatim across dozens of episodes. He does not argue it is worthless. He admits owning a little, just so he is there. He argues the price action falsifies the stated thesis.

> *"Bitcoin acts contrary to its own thesis."*
>
> RECURRING, FROM JULY 2025 ONWARD

Holders justify it as a hedge against fiat debasement. Were that true it would rise on days of fear. It falls on those days, correlating with tech stocks. Whatever it is, it is not the thing its owners say it is. He adds a separate worry: the risk sits less in the asset class than in the players and the infrastructure, and he names venues like Binance as the source of the violent volatility.

Stablecoins he treats as a genuinely interesting payments question, and explains carefully. Not a cryptocurrency, but the same underlying technology. You hand over dollars, the issuer buys Treasuries, and crucially you need a network to move the money. That last point drives his conclusion. Circle and Tether are challenging Visa and Mastercard, who already own trusted global networks. He doubts disintermediation in payments and thinks remittances is the beachhead that actually works, a far easier market to break than the card rails.

This generalises into one of his firmest sector views. Payments is a brutal, hyper-competitive space where nearly everyone attacks everyone else's business, and only Visa and Mastercard hold genuinely impregnable franchises. He owns Visa. He watched Fiserv collapse and PayPal struggle and treats both as confirmation.

The Eisman method

Scattered across the wraps and the financial literacy masterclass sits a fairly complete statement of how he works.

Core operating rules

01 **He is not a trader.** He does not trade in and out of quarters. He studies macro and micro trends, builds an investment story with long-term potential, and takes a full position on conviction.



02 **Buy market power.** His most consistent screen: proprietary products, duopolies, pricing power. Moody's, Visa, T-Mobile, Progressive. Without a proprietary product, as with Super Micro and Dell, you get price wars and margin compression.



03 **Know your thesis and its falsifiers.** Always know what would disprove you. He names the failure mode thesis creep, quietly rewriting the thesis as the stock moves and letting the tail wag the dog, and says flatly that every investor eventually succumbs.



04 **Balance sheets matter as much as income statements,** and sometimes more. His teaching case is the MLP collapse, where investors who read only the income statement got wiped out.



05 **In good times people care about stories. In bad times they care about balance sheets.**



06 **All my best ideas are stolen.** He rates boutique research above bulge-bracket, subscribes widely, and treats talking to people as equal in value to staring at screens.



07 **Pay for the data nobody else buys.** The Moody's securitisation database is the origin of this rule, and the absence of any equivalent is exactly why he distrusts private credit.



08 **Measure risk with beta, not stress tests.** He tried the expensive scenario services and found them useless. They told him he would lose money in a crash, which he knew. Position-level and portfolio-level beta is the pragmatic tool.



09 **Watch correlation between longs and shorts.** Long Goldman and short FICO is a real hedge, because the theses are independent. Long every automaker and short every carriage maker is one bet wearing two hats.



10 **Charts are a tool, not a substitute.** After a collapse he waits for a base before buying. If a chart on something he owns deteriorates, he rechecks the fundamentals.



11 **Do not invest overseas.** A stated personal preference, on the grounds that the United States is the most dynamic developed economy.



12 **Turnarounds are fixer-uppers or gut renovations.** Know which one you bought. UnitedHealth investors thought they had the former.



What he says about chief executives

A recurring panel subject. The good ones share a willingness to go against the grain and absorb severe criticism for it, and Jamie Dimon is the consensus best in financial services. The bad ones share balance sheets that grew too fast, absent controls and high-risk lending. His nuance on Dimon: being a great chief executive does not make you right when you pontificate about policy, and Dimon was wrong about Tarullo forcing banks to delever too far.

His case study in a chief executive who was good, mediocre and bad in sequence is Hank Greenberg, whom he shorted at AIG in 2005 as his largest position. Greenberg built a powerhouse, ran it so loosely that AIG Financial Products could write credit default swaps on tens of billions of subprime unsupervised, and left behind a company with 200 operating systems that took fifteen years to fix. His summary: a chief executive who stays too long becomes all three.

On mergers: doing the deal is half of the first inning. Integration is eight or nine tenths of the game.

Staged disagreement: how he actually uses guests

The guest list looks like a parade of sell-side analysts. Watched closely, it is something more deliberate: he books his own opposition, stages second opinions against his own guests, and runs multi-episode investigations that individual episodes only hint at.



The Beekeeper
ALL MY BEST IDEAS ARE STOLEN

The deliberate rematch

Gary Marcus makes the LLM-sceptic case in January; Daniel Guetta, a Columbia professor who built the systems, answers in February; Marcus returns in June. Eisman sides with neither and keeps the only question that matters, returns on the spend, explicitly open.

The second opinion

Tom Gober's forensic alarm on private equity in life insurance is followed within weeks by Tom Gallagher of Evercore, who is broadly comfortable. Eisman admits on air he expected the veteran to be more scared. He aired both anyway.

The serial investigation

Healthcare runs as a four-part inquiry across five months: Michael Ha on the UnitedHealth collapse, Warris Bokhari on claim denials, Mark Cuban on drug pricing, then Ha again on whether any insurer is investable. Each episode inherits the last one's open questions.

The bench also widened in kind. The first management interview arrives in November 2025 (Glass House Brands, with his shareholding disclosed up front), followed by the Meritage Homes chief executive inside a wrap, Amy Butte on taking companies public, and Apollo's head of originations answering the private credit critique from inside the machine. Operators joined the analysts once the show had standing questions only operators could answer.

Two guests interview him: Melissa Lee of CNBC in the August 2025 role reversal, and Ivy Zelman hosting the Case Western event where he retells 2008 for students. And one pattern holds across all 69 people indexed in this corpus: when a guest disagrees with the host, the disagreement survives the edit.

The second opinion doctrine

Version two noted that he books his own opposition. The dossiers show it is a repeatable procedure with a fixed shape: air the alarming case, name the discomfort, book the credible opposite, then state which way he moved and what stays open.



The Pawnshop
ALL MY BEST IDEAS ARE STOLEN

THE ALARM	THE COUNTERWEIGHT	WHAT HE DID WITH IT
Gary Marcus, 19 January 2026, scaling is a dead end and hallucination is architectural	Daniel Guetta, 16 February 2026, a practitioner who agrees on AGI and says it does not matter	Sided slightly with Guetta on usefulness, refused both men on returns, then rebooked Marcus in June
Tom Gober, 2 March 2026, private equity has turned life insurers into captive buyers	Tom Gallagher, 15 June 2026, a decades-trusted analyst who is broadly comfortable	Kept the thesis, narrowed the target to smaller insurers, kept the sector as a monitoring post
His own private credit bearishness, running since late 2025	Chris Edson of Apollo, 27 April 2026, answering from inside the machine	Conceded Apollo's software exposure is genuinely small, kept the view that a credit cycle is coming through software
Michael Ha, 22 September 2025, UnitedHealth is structurally impaired	Michael Ha again, 23 March 2026, after six months of evidence	No counterweight booked, because the first call kept being right. He ends more bearish instead

The procedure has one honest limit, and the dossiers make it visible. When he agrees with a guest at the outset, no counterweight gets booked at all. The Glass House management interview, the cannabis position he had already taken, and the Meritage interview, a stock he had already recommended, are both conducted as friendly examinations. He discloses the holding in each case, which is the safeguard he actually applies, but nobody is invited to argue the other side.

What the disagreements have in common

- **Disagreement survives the edit.** George Noble's gold thesis, Itay Michaeli's Tesla constructiveness, Adrian Wooldridge relaying Greenspan's account of the crisis: in each case the guest's position is left standing and Eisman's objection is stated beside it rather than over it.
- **He scores himself out loud.** The Noble episode ends with an explicit tally: open-minded but unconvinced on energy rotation, a declared skeptic on gold, in complete agreement on crypto.
- **Panels are used for coverage, not for conflict.** The three Evercore analysts on the consumer, the two MoffettNathanson analysts on media, and the Strategas pair are booked to cover a surface, and he synthesizes rather than adjudicates.
- **The strongest pushback is procedural.** His most effective move is not a counter-thesis, it is a disclosure question the guest cannot answer, which is how the UnitedHealth gain-on-sale detail and the

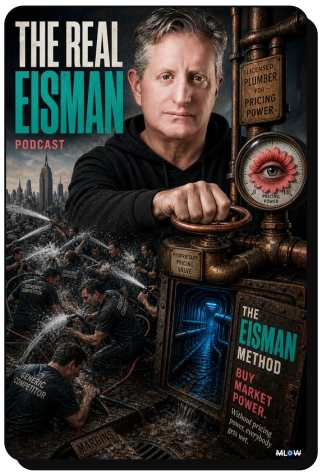
FICO pricing history both surface.

DISCLOSURE

His disclosed portfolio, from the source

Versions one and two reconstructed this from positions mentioned across the public episodes, and got it materially wrong. The paid episode of 1 July 2026 states the book in full, and it is shorter and more concentrated than the public mentions implied. He holds 16 longs, groups them into five themes of his own naming, and explains each one. What follows replaces the earlier reconstruction.

His stated method sits alongside it: he has run 15 to 30 longs for years and is at the low end now after pruning, he almost never trades, he takes a full position rather than leveraging in slowly, and he sells when the thesis breaks rather than when the price moves. The discipline he names as hardest is guarding against thesis creep, finding a fresh reason to keep owning something after the original reason died.



The Pricing Power Plumber
BUY MARKET POWER

AI, four positions

- **Nvidia.** The bellwether. First-quarter revenue growth of 85%, and a one-year-out multiple near 23 times, which he calls not expensive for that growth. Needs no capital
- **Arista.** Bought once he realised data centers need more than chips. Roughly 45 times 2026, so no room for error: it fell 14% on a first quarter that beat but did not raise enough
- **Microsoft.** Cut back, on the software disruption debate and the possibility it must raise capital. Roughly 23 times 2026
- **Amazon.** Held for the cloud business, which he calls a necessary AI investment. Roughly 27 times 2026

Power and infrastructure, three

- **GE Vernova.** His best pick ever. Pitched to him near 165 after the 2024 spin, against his own scepticism from watching GE for decades; market value near 250 billion at recording. Expensive at roughly 45 times, defended on visibility
- **Quanta.** The same thesis one step along: rising electrical demand means new plants, and Quanta builds them. Roughly 50 times 2026
- **Eaton.** The disappointment he names as such. First-quarter earnings growth of 3%, dragged by its non-data-center businesses. He says his patience is not infinite

Value, three

- **Charter.** Roughly 3 times 2026 earnings, on capital spending falling from 11 billion in 2026 toward 7.5 to 8 billion by 2028, converting to buybacks. He owns the bad quarter: 120,000 broadband subscribers lost against a 100,000 estimate
- **Meritage Homes.** At 1.0 times tangible book while profitable, retiring roughly 11% of shares this year, with a homebuilder takeover wave printing at 1.25 to 1.3 times book
- **AIG.** The Citigroup analogy: a subpar 8% return on equity and 1.05 times book, now a pure property and casualty business, with Chubb and Travelers near two times book as the gap to close

Great franchises, five, plus one speculation

- **Apple.** Not an AI builder, so no capital raise, but any AI company reaching consumers may have to go through it. The risk he names is China manufacturing
- **Moody's** and **Visa.** The duopolies he says he loves, with the caveats that ratings track issuance and payment volume tracks the economy

- **Progressive.** Possibly the best insurance company in the world, in a pricing trough that puts 2026 earnings growth at negative 11%
- **Eli Lilly.** Won the GLP-1 war outright, with earnings growth of 100%, then 86%, then roughly 50% expected, against Novo Nordisk going negative
- **Glass House Brands.** Explicitly speculative and not for everyone. Priced near 13 against his own three scenarios of 40, 49 and 58, on cannabis rescheduling opening states where the price is roughly 800 a pound against 200 in California

What he sold, and why it matters

The single most informative disclosure is the exit. He sold **Alphabet, Meta and Oracle**, three long-held AI positions, on one argument: the business model changed underneath them. Software used to be capital light, and Microsoft last raised capital when it went public in 1986. Now Alphabet's capital spending runs from 90 billion in 2025 to 180 to 190 billion, it has raised 85 billion in equity, Oracle is raising, and he expects Meta and Microsoft to follow. His conclusion is that investors will rotate away from the hyperscalers that need capital and toward the power, semiconductor and equipment names that do not, which is exactly the shape of the book above.

SHORT

Fair Isaac (FICO), on the thesis that its consumer scoring monopoly is eroding, Trupanion, disclosed in September 2026: short for years, a product he likes and a business he calls bad

SOLD IN 2026

Alphabet, Meta, Oracle, Charter, capitulated 31 July 2026, after this episode

EXPLICITLY NOT HELD

Tesla, previously shorted, and he says he got his head handed to him, Any bank, the last was Citigroup, right thesis and wrong management, Any private credit name, long or short, Bonds and commodities, and he does not count his home as an investment

Since the disclosure

September 2026 changes the risk rather than the names. He says he has partially shorted some of his high flyers against the box in his own account, to protect large embedded gains through the autumn, and calls it a timing decision rather than a verdict on the companies; he intends to close the short near year end and take the risk back in 2027. Nvidia is his worked example, not a named trade. Listeners pointed out that the tax code treats this as a constructive sale, and he accepted the limits on air. He also names the defensive funds he would move toward if the ten-year holds above 5%, a low-volatility dividend fund, a low-volatility S&P fund and a property and casualty insurance fund, while saying he has not made that call yet. In the Big Short reunion, he and one of his former partners both say they own Glass House Brands. He was tempted to short AeroVironment on its drone pricing and did not.

He also names the four conditions that would change the book: hard evidence that data centers are much harder to build and open than assumed, evidence of companies backing away from AI on usage cost, a ten-year yield holding above 4.5% for more than a few weeks, which would send him toward defensives that are not rate sensitive, and a weakening economy, which would open short opportunities. Failing those, he says he would rather hold and not pay the capital gains.

> *“Guarding against thesis creep is unbelievably important. No one likes to admit they have made a mistake.”*
>
> PERSONAL PORTFOLIO EPISODE, 1 JULY 2026

One mistake he volunteers without being asked: he owned Arista and not Cisco, and says the cheaper, weaker company would have worked too, because a rising tide lifts all boats. That is the same admission pattern the errors section documents, made here about a position nobody would have known to ask about.

THE DISCIPLINE

Errors, owned in public

The show's most unusual habit is administrative: he keeps score on himself. Recommendations are dated, revisited and graded, and the failures get more airtime than the wins.



The Optometrist

KNOW YOUR THESIS AND ITS FALSIFIERS

FEBRUARY 2026

He recommends Charter Communications and Meritage Homes on air, with the theses spelled out: a free cash flow yield above 20% signals suspected bankruptcy, and the balance sheet says otherwise.

MAY 2026

Charter falls 25% in a day. He restates the thesis publicly and adds to the position: when you recommend a stock publicly, own the bad quarter in public too.

JULY 2026

Two bad quarters on the core metric. He opens the wrap by capitulating without hedging: bottom line, he gives up, and simply put, he made a mistake.

SEPTEMBER 2026

The threshold he held for a year gives way. Originally, he says, he thought the market could not stomach a ten-year above 4.5%, and that was wrong. He moves the line to 5% on 18 September and, a week later, with the yield at 5.1%, says a correction is probably imminent if it stays there.

The same register covers the older record. He shorted Tesla and got his head handed to him, which hardened the never-short-a-cult rule. He covered the Big Short trades in spring 2008 because a bailout, not the fundamentals, had become the risk, and he describes the mechanics of exiting flatly, calling swap desks and accepting their prices. Asked to name the next black swan, he answers that the question misunderstands what a black swan is.

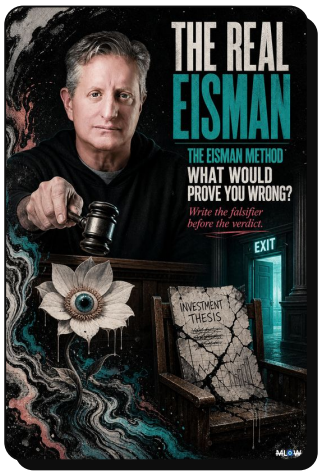
- **Thresholds are held loosely.** His 4.5% line in the sand made him lighten up in May 2026. When the market absorbed it, he said so plainly in September 2026, called it wrong, and moved the line to 5%, where it now stands as a dated test.
- **Timing is part of being right.** A bear case a year early is indistinguishable from a wrong one, his standing warning to every would-be short seller.
- **Positions are opinions, not identities.** On disclosing his FICO short: he is short because of the research, and he is not trying to convince anyone to join him.
- **Survival beats thesis quality.** Being right over five years is worthless if margin forces you out in five weeks, his reading of the August 2026 hedge fund liquidation.

> *“Bottom line, I give up. Simply put, I made a mistake.”*
>
> ON CHARTER COMMUNICATIONS, WEEKLY WRAP, 31 JULY 2026

THE EVIDENCE

When he actually changes his mind

Reading the first 70 interviews and lectures for one question, what moved by the end, turns the show's stated open-mindedness into something measurable. The answer is that Eisman updates often, but along strict lines: he adopts frameworks readily, adopts timing calls almost never, and hardens fastest when a guest cannot answer a disclosure question.



The Courtroom

KNOW YOUR THESIS AND ITS FALSIFIERS

He adopts the frame

When a guest supplies a way of seeing rather than a forecast, he takes it whole and redeploys it within days. Steve Tusa's proprietary versus derivative test shows up in that week's wrap. Stu Elman's venture capital depression is repeated almost verbatim to Melissa Lee the following week. Ben Kallo's physical constraint, Helima Croft's mission creep and Torsten Slok's overindexation all become standing vocabulary.

He resists the clock

Timing is where he stops. Lakshmi Ganapathi's consumer crack gets accepted as a direction and refused as a date, twice, once with a six to nine month clock attached. Gary Marcus wins the concession that the scaling question is real and never the concession that it resolves this year. His own formulation, that a bear case a year early is indistinguishable from a wrong one, is the rule he applies to guests as well.

He hardens on opacity

The interviews where nothing converges are rarely about valuation. Michael Ha twice, Kelsey Zhu on FICO and Rob Oliver on software all end with Eisman more negative than he began, and in each case the sticking point is that the numbers cannot be checked. Against a company he cannot audit, a guest's optimism moves him backwards.

The three admissions worth marking

27 OCTOBER 2025, ANDREW ROSS SORKIN

He concedes his own model of 2008 was wrong in a specific way. He had assumed the authorities were knowingly slow; the archives say they were genuinely ignorant and out of bandwidth. This is the rare case of a guest correcting the episode of history Eisman is most identified with.

16 FEBRUARY 2026, DANIEL GUETTA

After booking Gary Marcus and then deliberately booking his opposite, he says on air that he sides a little more with Guetta: the products are good enough to disrupt without being intelligent. He still refuses the returns question, and dates it two years out.

15 JUNE 2026, TOM GALLAGHER

He arrives primed by Tom Gober's alarm on life insurance and admits surprise that an analyst he has trusted for decades is comfortable. He does not abandon the worry, he relocates it, from the large alternative insurers to the smaller aggressive ones.

The solo episodes carry the two cleanest reversals, because there is no guest to credit. On 1 September 2025 he retires his own doomsayer posture, saying corrections once made him want to raise cash and no longer do. In the second 2008 masterclass he goes further and argues for a wave of bank mergers, which is the man who shorted the banks into the crisis making the case for letting them get bigger.

The 22 interviews and lectures added since fit the same shape. In September 2026 he gave up a timing call, the 4.5% threshold, the moment the market proved it wrong, and kept the framework, that some level of rates breaks the market, intact. He did the same with bank consolidation: the logic survives, the trade does

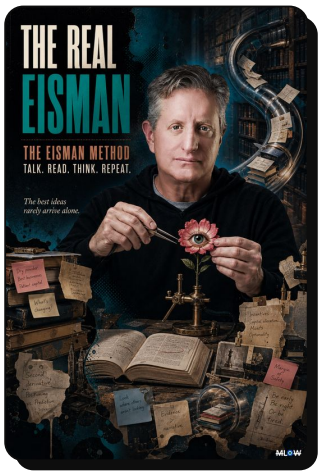
not. The line he used about it is the most honest summary of the pattern in the corpus.

> *“The only thing my thesis has going for it is its impeccable logic. But that's not enough.”*
>
> HOW TO ANALYZE BANKS, PART 2, 23 SEPTEMBER 2026

THE DISTILLATION

The curriculum hidden in 152 episodes

Every episode synopsis in the explorer now carries a what-can-be-learned list. Read together, they resolve into a short course he never announces but teaches continuously. These are the lessons that recur most, each traceable to multiple dated episodes.



Talk, Read, Think
ALL MY BEST IDEAS ARE STOLEN

Reading markets

- Watch what investors punish, not what companies report. Identical beats now get opposite receptions depending on capex exposure
- Narratives flip without warning, and once one hardens, fundamentals stop mattering in the short run. Fighting it is like fighting a ghost
- A flat index can hide a genuine flight to safety. Watch rotation and breadth, not the level
- When two markets price the same risk differently, tight credit spreads against obliterated equities, one of them has to give

Credit

- Credit problems emerge where the growth was: subprime then, private credit and AI data center debt now
- Opacity itself is the systemic risk. Small unknown losses panic everyone who might be holding the bag
- Watch securitization data and bank credit quality; both lead the official statistics
- Prosperity degrades underwriting. When results beat expectations year after year, standards loosen

Valuation

- How a sector is valued is set by consensus, what he calls the mafia. Accept the terms of debate or do not play
- At perfection multiples a company cannot disappoint on any metric, actual or perceived
- Cheap is not the test. An improving story beats a cheap broken one, and cheapness in software reads as a symptom
- A backlog can matter more than the quarter, and a backlog is only as good as its counterparty

Behaviour and process

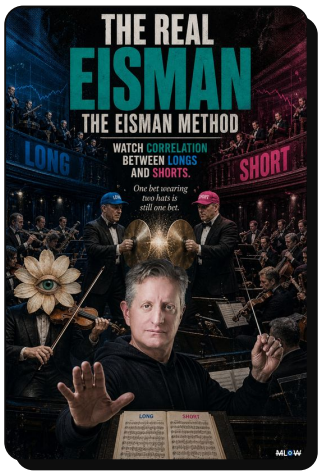
- Never short a cult, and never assume the authorities have read the research
- Know the falsifiers of your own thesis, and keep a graveyard for dead indicators as well as dead stocks
- Seek the second opinion deliberately, especially against your own conclusions
- Diversification means uncorrelated positions. When longs and shorts are mirror images of one trade, there is no hedge

If the corpus has one sentence-length summary, it is his own: investing is being practical and pragmatic. There is no one way to value stocks, no reliable oracle for turning points, and no substitute for knowing an argument well enough to measure its risk.

MASTERCLASS

How to short, according to people who do it

Two consecutive July 2025 episodes with boutique short researchers, Lakshmi Ganapathi of Unicus Research and Brad Safalow of PAA Research, produce the most concentrated practical material on the show. Eisman interjects his own rules throughout.



The Conductor

WATCH CORRELATION BETWEEN LONGS AND SHORTS

The don'ts

- **Never short a cult.** Cultists care about things you consider irrelevant, and they buy on them. Carvana went from 83 dollars to 4 and then above 300. Ganapathi covered at the bottom and now refuses Carvana requests on principle.
- **Never short purely on valuation.** Eisman's most-repeated rule. He says he has learned it painfully too many times to try again, and cites passing on Palantir for exactly this reason.
- **Never short at a 52-week high.** Wait for one missed earnings. Leave money on the table rather than get run over on a breakout.
- **Never short a roll-up before its anniversary.** Acquisition accretion masks the problem for about a year.
- **Never short an emotional stock.** Nobody gets emotional about Stellantis. That is the point.
- **Beware heavily shorted names.** Forced covering makes squeezes worse however good the case.

The dos

- **It is always the management.** Investigate every board member and executive: where they worked, and why they left.
- **Do primary research at scale.** Ganapathi called 100 to 300 car dealerships on Stellantis, and 100 to 150 solar installers to establish that advertised failure rates below 1% ran nearer 40%.
- **Read the balance sheet** for rising receivables, rising warranty expense and rising liabilities.
- **Prefer secular decline to fraud.** Safalow's hierarchy runs secularly challenged first, then fad, then cyclical, then fraud, because frauds persist for a decade.
- **Understand who owns it.** His four Ps: passives, processors (quants and algos), pods, and positioning. Where passive ownership dominates, valuation barely matters and flows are everything.
- **Carry both kinds.** High-maintenance shorts you go to war over, and set-it-and-forget-it shorts on quiet secular decline. The boring ones nobody calls about often deliver the best return on time.

> *"Every single great short will have at least three to five movements against the downtrend on the way to zero. A 50 to 100% movement feels like absolute agony."*
>
> BRAD SAFALOW, PAA RESEARCH, 28 JULY 2025

Eisman ranks short quality in three tiers. Best is a pure microeconomic short, driven entirely by company fundamentals with nothing else involved. Second is microeconomic with some macro or political overlay. Last is a short that depends on politics, because you are then betting on an administration.

He frames the psychological difference often. Being long and watching a stock rise is cheerleading. Being short is going to war, and it demands an entirely different mindset.

MASTERCLASS

The 2008 lectures

Delivered as formal solo lectures in two parts, Episodes 38 and 39 in December 2025, and revisited in the Big Short reflection episodes. The structure is a compact causal model he reuses to assess every new risk on the show.



The Financial Dentist

BALANCE SHEETS MATTER AS MUCH AS INCOME STATEMENTS

	CAUSE	DETAIL
1	Too much leverage	Especially at globally systemic institutions. He blames the risk-weighted asset concept for permitting it, and pointedly not the repeal of Glass-Steagall, arguing the same loans would have been made regardless.
2	A large asset class blew up	Subprime mortgages. Securitisation removed funding as a constraint on growth. The industry went from 20 billion dollars of originations in 1993 to about 150 billion by 1998, died in 1999, and was resurrected by Wall Street after Greenspan cut to 1% and bond investors needed yield.
3	Systemic institutions owned it	The irony he stresses. By 2006 volume ran 600 billion dollars a year and Wall Street could no longer sell it all, so it kept it. The desks knew. Everyone was paid on volume, not on loan quality.
4	Derivatives	The only genuinely novel element. Credit default swaps tied balance sheets into a web nobody could map. It was also his instrument. He describes shorting a specific New Century 2006 BBB-minus tranche at about 3% a year, and the dawning realisation that his counterparty was repackaging his cash into a CDO.

The first three appear in almost every financial crisis in history, and he stresses that. Only the derivatives were new. This is why the framework travels. Applied to private credit it fails the test, because the banks are not levered and do not own the asset class in size.

The moral argument underneath

His explanation for the crisis is not stupidity, and he is emphatic about that. Asked whether incompetence causes crashes, he answered that if only that were true, we could screen for it. Instead he invokes Minsky and rational irrationality: people behave rationally inside a mania because the incentives make it rational. Chuck Prince's line about having to dance while the music plays is his exhibit. The chief executive who stops dancing earns less, underperforms, and gets fired.

> *“Incentives trump ethics almost every time.”*

HIS MOST-REPEATED MAXIM, STATED IN AT LEAST FOUR EPISODES

He recalls asking heads of securitisation how they could make those loans, and being told it was legal. His verdict on the ratings agencies is that they earned three to four times more for subprime paper and sold their souls for the fee, and he calls the whole arrangement the biggest fraud in human history. He then

bought Moody's anyway, and explains why, which illustrates fairly completely how he separates moral judgement from position-taking.

His regulatory conclusion matches what he says about capitalism generally. The question is never whether to regulate, because unregulated capitalism runs to booms and busts. The only question is how much. Too much kills the golden goose, too little returns you to the original problem, and no formula exists, only an iterative process of learning from experience.

MARGINALIA

Nuggets worth keeping

Things that fit no single theme but recur, or are simply the most useful sentences in 923,000 words.

- **On narrative.** The private credit group went from all-bullish to all-bearish with no change in fundamentals. He treats the urge to pile onto the newest narrative as a tradeable constant.
- **On stories.** Investors love stories. Without one, nobody cares. That is his explanation for why wireless and cable languish whatever their cash flow.
- **On thesis clouds.** When a company sits under a cloud, a bad call cannot happen. Identical guidance gets shrugged off at a beloved company and punished at a feared one.
- **On paradigm shifts.** One of the hardest things a person goes through. The MLP investors, the 1929 bankers and the pre-crisis Wall Street executives all shared it: a paradigm that stopped being true before they stopped believing it.



The Bedtime Story Bunker

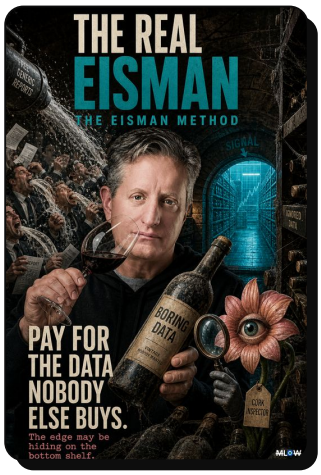
IN GOOD TIMES PEOPLE CARE ABOUT STORIES. IN BAD TIMES THEY CARE ABOUT BALANCE SHEETS

- **On the diversification illusion.** With tech near half the S&P, owning the index is not diversification. The bond sleeve does not save you either, since he cites 15% of existing corporate debt and 50% of 2026 new issuance as AI-related.
- **On indexing.** Know what you own when you buy an index fund. A 20% single-day drop in UnitedHealth barely moved an index that finished the day up.
- **On captured regulators.** Real, but cyclical. Pre-crisis bank regulators were as captured as possible. After the crisis they got teeth, and even a friendlier administration comes nowhere near returning to 2008 leverage.
- **On Long-Term Capital Management.** Greenspan should have let it collapse. People would have learned better lessons.
- **On Ted Williams.** He rereads The Science of Hitting as an investing text. The line he wrote down: swing at strikes. A good hitter on a pitch over the plate beats a great hitter reaching for a bad one in a tough spot.
- **On the market as economist.** He endorses Verrone's line that the market is his favourite economist, along with Verrone's caution that your market call need not resemble your economic call.
- **On fighting the government.** Delivered deadpan after an AI company was shut down over a jailbreak: it is not a great business strategy.
- **On hedging.** If you genuinely want to hedge, the only real answer is out-of-the-money index puts. He is long-term bullish and does not advocate it.
- **On money market funds.** Use one that holds only short-term Treasuries. You lose deposit insurance but hold government debt instead, which amounts to the same protection.
- **On admitting ignorance.** Stated plainly during the AI depreciation debate: sometimes it is just okay to admit that you do not know.

BEHIND THE PAYWALL

The premium tier, decoded

Versions one and two could only count the paid episodes from the Substack archive and guess at their contents. This edition reads them. Some private-feed items are simply the public episode released a day early, so the genuinely exclusive count is 19, running from January to September 2026. They add roughly 155,000 words to the corpus, and they are not offcuts.



The Data Sommelier
PAY FOR THE DATA NOBODY ELSE BUYS

Two things separate the tier from the free feed. The first is length and form: this is where the uninterrupted lectures live, with no guest and no news to get through. The second is candour about himself. The portfolio episode names all 16 positions and the reasoning behind each, and the Big Short episode is the only place he audits the film that made him famous, scene by scene.

A Conspiracy of Credit, the two-part masterclass

The centrepiece, and the fullest statement of the thesis the public feed only circles. His argument runs in three steps. The United States has not had a credit-cycle recession since 2008. The post-crisis regime forced banks to delever and to stop making the riskiest loans, so that lending migrated to private credit. And privacy in that market functions as a synonym for secrecy, which means the credit built up over seventeen years is both concentrated and unobservable.

What is striking is where it lands. Given that framing, the conclusion is softer than expected: a bad credit cycle with real losses, not a systemic event. Part two drops the argument entirely and teaches the bond market from first principles, on the premise that every industry keeps a mafia whose lingo keeps outsiders out, and that underneath the jargon fixed income is common sense plus arithmetic.

Where the tier goes that the feed cannot

Boris Peaker on biotech runs 73 minutes, the longest episode in the corpus, and argues the investment map is drawn by economics rather than science: large firms can now build anything small ones can, so the real structure is a division of labour where small firms carry drugs to the finish and large firms buy them. Peter Hoffman supplies the production side of Hollywood's margin collapse, and Ben Zipursky explains why the social media suits are pleaded as product defect rather than publishing, to route around Section 230.

The sector work with no public equivalent

Brad Safalow returns for 71 minutes on the residential brokerage war, where commissions have barely moved and the real fight is over control of the MLS, plus for-profit education, which both men treat as uninvestable on the long side. Kathleen Kelly and Nancy O'Flynn make the bearish case on oil, arguing the market mistook wartime distortion for tightness. Wolfgang Munchau argues Europe's stagnation is structural, and Eisman leaves calling it pretty hopeless.

The positions he only explains here

The Glass House follow-up is the clearest example of the tier's function. He is a disclosed shareholder, rescheduling has just changed the economics, and he walks the arithmetic in public numbers: a low-cost grower capped near 200 dollars a pound in California against roughly 800 in other states. The portfolio episode does the same for the whole book.

September: the craft lectures and the hardest bear

The tier added a two-part lecture on analysing bank stocks, from leverage and loan-loss accounting to deposits, valuation and the mark-to-market mechanics that sank Silicon Valley Bank, and it is where he retires his merger thesis as a trade. Ed Zitron, the show's most complete AI bear, argues across 70 minutes that the whole

ecosystem leans on two loss-making labs, and Eisman calls the dependence nerve-wracking. Lakshmi Ganapathi returns with shorts on FICO, DoorDash and AeroVironment.

What the paid episodes change about the public record

- **The portfolio section of this report was wrong before now.** Reconstructing holdings from passing public mentions produced a list of 19 longs including names he does not own. The real book is 16, and he had already sold Alphabet, Meta and Oracle.
- **The consumer argument resolves behind the paywall.** In the paid Ganapathi episode both sides give ground and meet: he keeps the bank credit data intact but stops treating it as a verdict on the consumer, and she concedes the stress has not surfaced in credit yet. No public episode reaches that settlement.
- **The Big Short corrections are on the record here.** He holds that the film invents on the surface and is right underneath, names the taxi argument with his wife as invention, and reverses his own long-standing view that Steve Carell overplayed the anger, on the strength of a document rather than a memory.
- **Publishing moved paid-first in 2026.** Three of the eighteen private-feed items are simply the public episode a day early, which is a distribution change rather than extra content, and worth knowing before anyone counts the tier by episode number.

One caution for anyone using this section as a buying guide. The tier is where he is least hedged, which makes it the most useful and the most dated. The oil call carries its own six to nine month clock, the cannabis case depends on a rescheduling process still running, and the portfolio is a snapshot he says would change on four named conditions. Read the dates.

> *“Almost all the growth in lending since 2008 has been in private credit behind a veil of privacy, which means secrecy.”*
>
> A CONSPIRACY OF CREDIT, PART 1, 13 MAY 2026

Outside and before the podcast

Subprime Goes to College (2010)

His second-most-famous call, and the one that most directly prefigures the podcast's moral register. He presented it at the Ira Sohn conference on 26 May 2010: a 48-page bear case on for-profit education, covering Apollo Group, ITT Educational, Corinthian Colleges and Education Management. The argument ran that these companies drew up to 90% of revenue from federal Title IV loans, posted terrible graduation and default rates, and functioned as marketing machines dressed as universities. He framed it by saying he thought he would never again find an industry as socially destructive as subprime, and had been proven wrong. He testified before the Senate HELP committee. ITT and Corinthian eventually went to zero. Brad Safalow now invokes ITT on the podcast as the template for spotting the next one.

The public record since

He has remained a fixture on CNBC, appearing on Fast Money and Squawk Box, and on Bloomberg Television, and the podcast's positions track his televised ones closely. Recent examples: pushing back on Michael Burry's market-top call as premature, warning that the market goes straight down if a hyperscaler cuts capital spending, and the August 2026 Achilles heel argument about OpenAI and Anthropic concentration. In September 2024 he publicly withdrew an earlier prediction of a Trump win and called the election a toss-up, a small but characteristic instance of retracting a call rather than defending it.

Reading his own myth

He stays consistently deflationary about the Big Short legend. He points out what the film compressed or invented, notes that his New Century short cost 40% a year to borrow, describes running the swap book and the equity book together with prices arriving an hour apart, and shows open irritation at the industry habit of predicting the end of the world. His line on the genre, that people just love to predict the end of the world, is aimed squarely at the audience that came to him for exactly that.

What the corpus leaves open

Each dossier ends with the questions its episode failed to settle. Collected across 92 interviews and lectures, they cluster into five arguments the show has framed carefully and cannot yet close. These are the places where the next year of episodes will either vindicate the method or embarrass it.

1. Does the AI spend earn its return

- The question he has refused to answer since June 2025, and dates to 2027 or 2028
- Resolution test he accepts from Gary Marcus: whether tokens can be priced profitably once the subsidy ends
- The dependency he named in August 2026: two private companies, Anthropic and OpenAI, continuing to buy compute
- What a hyperscaler capex cut would do, which he says arrives too late to trade once it prints
- Narrowed in September 2026 to one company: whether OpenAI can close a gap in which, in the June quarter, revenue rose about 1 billion dollars and costs about 3 billion, and what Anthropic's filing shows about revenue once the token subsidy ended

2. Is private credit a cycle or a crisis

- The dated test: software refinancings in 2027, negotiated against valuations that have already fallen
- Whether buyout equity beneath the loans is itself borrowed, the Liesman insight he admits he lacked
- Whether opacity alone can cause the panic without real losses ever appearing
- The life insurance triangle, where he holds the thesis and concedes no credit losses have surfaced

3. Has the consumer actually cracked

- Ganapathi's second-half-2026 call, accepted as direction and refused as date
- Whether spending cracks before credit metrics, her claim and his adopted canary
- Whether bank credit quality still leads, after he revised that rule in July 2026
- How long a top-decile-driven economy can absorb a market correction

4. Do the frameworks still hold

- The 5% ten-year line, set on 18 September 2026 after 4.5% failed, with a correction called probably imminent if the yield holds above it
- Whether regional banks ever merge, now a thesis he keeps for its logic and no longer invests on
- Whether index concentration makes the eventual correction violent, as he predicts, or merely fast
- Whether software is structurally impaired or simply early, the call he refuses to make until the data arrives

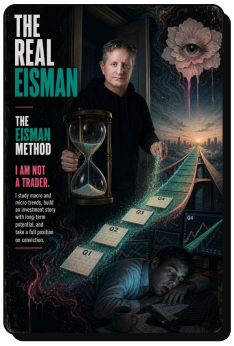
The fifth cluster is the one he cannot test, and he says so. Asked repeatedly to name the next black swan, he answers that the request misunderstands the term. The corpus is consistent about this: it forecasts mechanisms and refuses dates, which is exactly why the dated tests above are worth holding him to.

THE METHOD, ILLUSTRATED

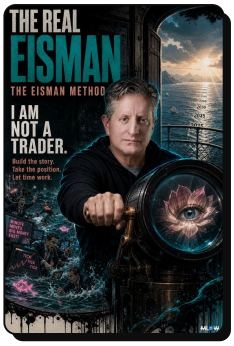
12 rules, 50 posters

Every rule in The Eisman method, drawn as a poster. Poster art by MLow.

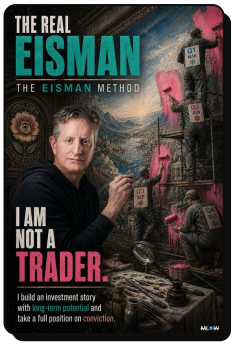
01 He is not a trader



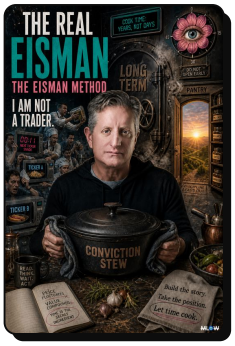
The Sandman



The Lighthouse

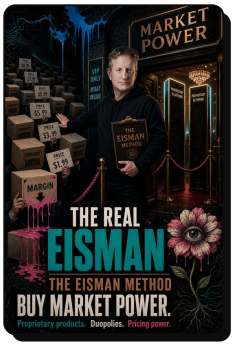


The Fresco Conservator

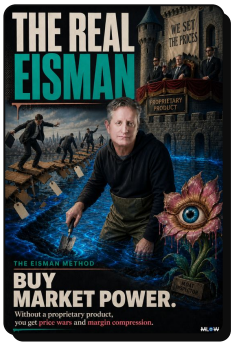


Conviction Stew

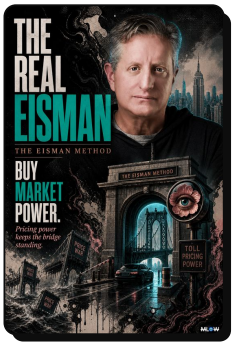
02 Buy market power



The Nightclub



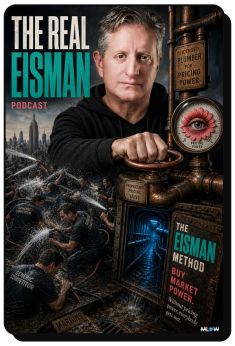
Moat Maintenance



The Toll Bridge

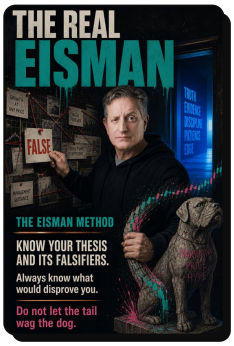


The Only Tollbooth in Town

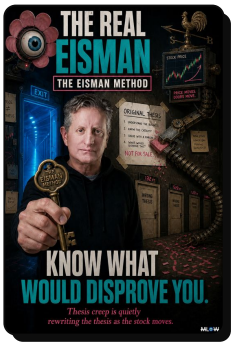


The Pricing Power Plumber

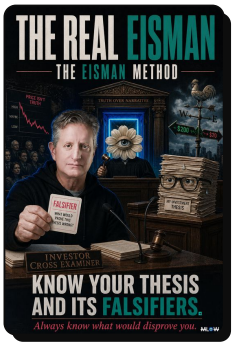
03 Know your thesis and its falsifiers



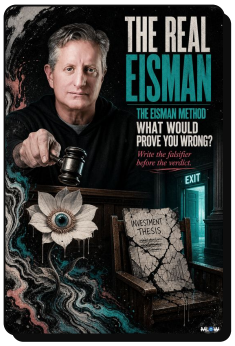
The Thesis Detective



The Escape Room



Cross-Examination

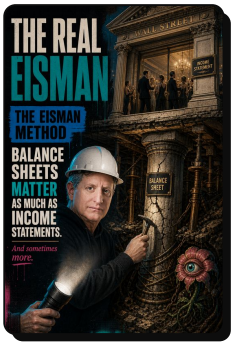


The Courtroom



The Optometrist

04 Balance sheets matter as much as income statements



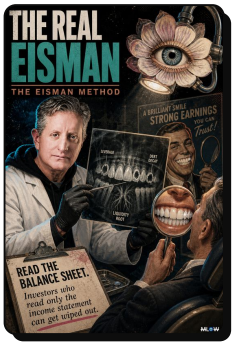
The Inspector



The X-Ray



The Submarine



The Financial Dentist

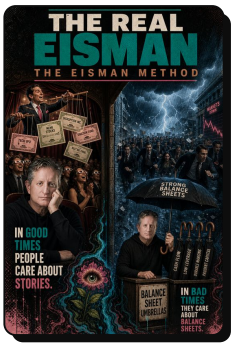


The Magician

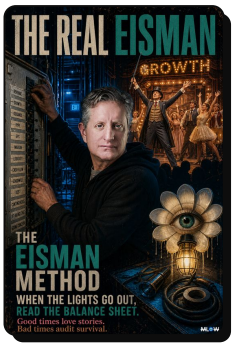
05 In good times people care about stories. In bad times they care about balance sheets



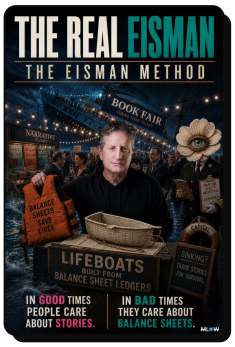
The Weather Forecast



Umbrellas



Backstage



The Lifeboat Stand



The Bedtime Story Bunker

06 All my best ideas are stolen



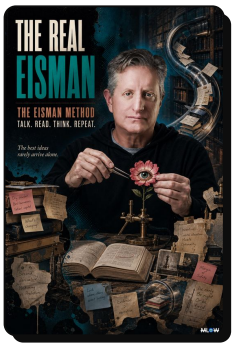
The Heist



The Laundromat



The Beekeeper

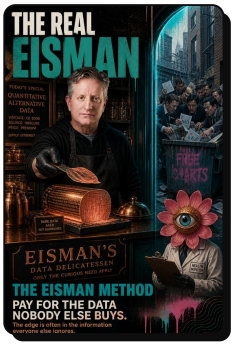


Talk, Read, Think

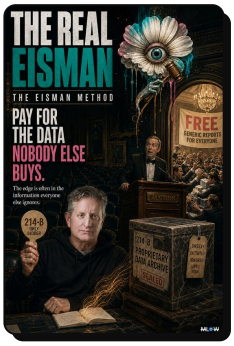


The Pawnshop

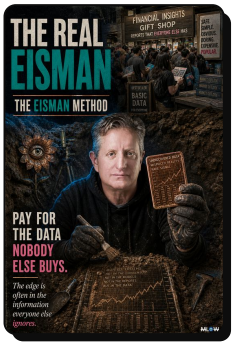
07 Pay for the data nobody else buys



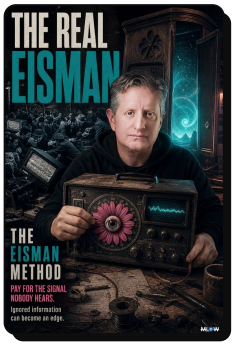
The Delicatessen



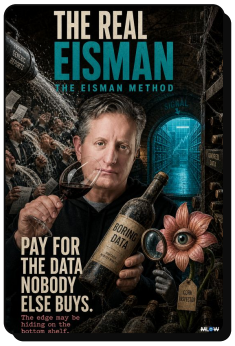
The Auction



The Dig

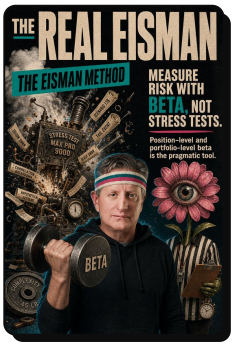


The Radio

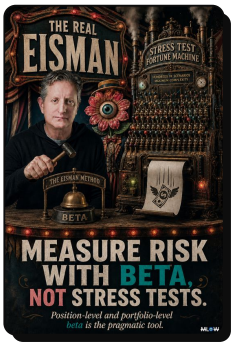


The Data Sommelier

08 Measure risk with beta, not stress tests



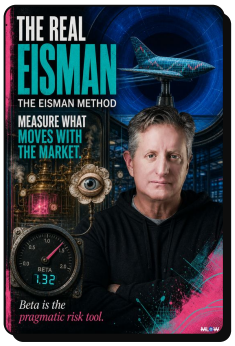
Beta Fitness



The Carnival



Air Traffic Control



The Wind Tunnel

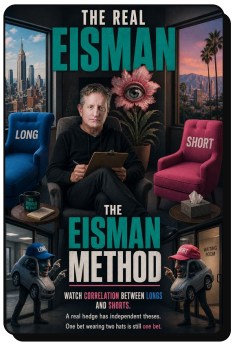


The Tailor

09 Watch correlation between longs and shorts



The Swim Coach



Couples Therapy



The Electrician

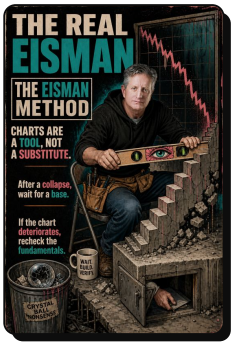


The Conductor

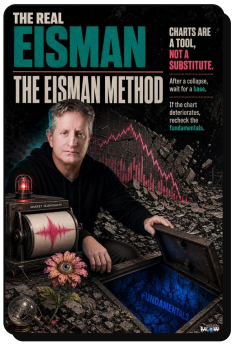


The Elevator

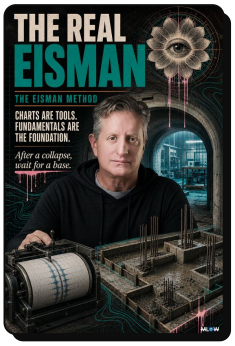
10 Charts are a tool, not a substitute



The Carpenter



The Seismologist



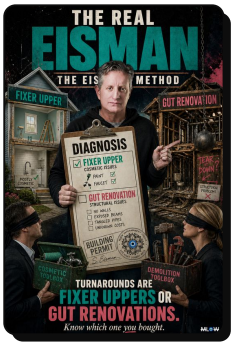
The Foundation Lab

11 Do not invest overseas

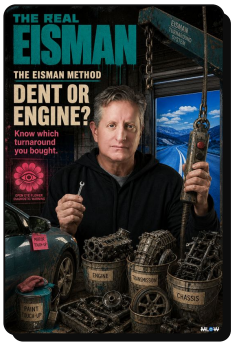


Customs

12 Turnarounds are fixer-uppers or gut renovations



The Game Show



The Garage

APPENDIX A

Episode index

All 152 episodes in the public feed, oldest first.

DATE	EP	TITLE	GUESTS
2025-06-05		Does China Own Apple? With Patrick McGee	Patrick McGee
2025-06-07		Stablecoin and Instability with Trump and Musk - The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-06-08		A Skeptic's Guide to Cryptocurrency and Stablecoins	Rahul Jindal
2025-06-09		Safe to Stay Invested? Decoding 2025 Stock Charts	Todd Sohn
2025-06-14		Market Resilience Amid Multiple Challenges - The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-06-16		Are We Building an AI Future We Can't Power?	Sami Badri
2025-06-21		Earnings, Geopolitics, and Sectors - The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-06-23		Is Capitalism Flawed? Fixing and Regulating Free Markets	John Cassidy
2025-06-28		Bullish Signs Continue - The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-06-30		How CEOs Build Empires, Or Blow Them Up	Glenn Schorr, Gerard Cassidy, Dwight Collins
2025-07-03		Jobs Shock, Bank Buyback Boom & AI Talent Wars | The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-07-07		Don't Get Fooled Again: Pulitzer Winner Warns of Wall Street's Dark Side	Gretchen Morgenson
2025-07-12		Big Beautiful Bill, Write-Off Revolution & Tariff Tempest | The Friday Market Wrap!	Dan Clifton
2025-07-14		Why the Market's Surging Despite the Headlines	Chris Verrone
2025-07-19		Earnings Season Kickoff, Bank Earnings & Nvidia China Greenlight | The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-07-21		The Secrets of the Short Seller: How the Pros Spot Trouble	Lakshmi Ganapathi
2025-07-26		Meme Stock Resurgence: Warning Signs or Just Noise? - The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-07-28		The Secrets of the Short Seller Part 2: The Blueprint for Strategy & Survival	Brad Safalow
2025-08-02		How Tariff Deals, Pharma Shocks, & Mega Mergers Redefined the Market - The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-08-04		Venture Capital Revealed: Behind the Schemes They Haven’t Told You	Stu Elman
2025-08-08		Tariffs Are Back, Apple's Big Bet, and AI's Real Impact - The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-08-11		Steve Eisman Shares the Real Story Behind Predicting the 2008 Crash	Melissa Lee
2025-08-16		The U.S. Sets an Unprecedented AI Chip Agreement with China | The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-08-18	21	Industrial Sector Explained: Data Center Growth & Rise of Vertiv | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep. 21	Steve Tusa
2025-08-22		Powell Says Nothing & Markets Cheer, Amazon Wins & Target Loses | The Friday Market Wrap!	

DATE	EP	TITLE	GUESTS
2025-08-25	22	Tesla vs Waymo: Who Will Win the Robotaxi Race? | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep. 22	Itay Michaeli
2025-08-30		Trump vs The Fed, U.S. Takes 10% Stake in Intel, Cracker Barrel Cracks | The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-09-01	23	Steve Eisman Answers YOUR Investing Questions | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 23	
2025-09-05		Google Wins Antitrust Case, Is AI The Next Bubble? | The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-09-08	24	Steve Eisman's Masterclass on Financial Literacy | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 24	
2025-09-12		Oracle's Massive AI Forecast, Hot IPOs Explained | The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-09-15	25	Trump's Battle with the Fed Explained | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 25	Rob Kaplan
2025-09-20		Are Stablecoins the Next Big Thing? Luigi Mangione Terror Charges Dropped | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-09-22	26	Breaking Down the United Healthcare Disaster: What's REALLY Going On? | Real Eisman Playbook Ep. 26	Michael Ha
2025-09-26		The Wild West of Crypto: Chaos, Shenanigans, & The AI Revolution | The Friday Market Wrap!	
2025-09-29	27	The AI Revolution: Winners, Losers, & The Future of Tech | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 27	Dan Ives
2025-10-03		U.S. Consumers Are Collapsing: Cars, Credit, & the Chaos Ahead | The Weekly Wrap	Lakshmi Ganapathi
2025-10-06	28	Inside the AI Chip War: From Nvidia's Dominance to Intel's Turmoil | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 28	Stacy Rasgon
2025-10-10		AI's Real Life Impact: Inside the Human Cost of the Tech Boom | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-10-13	29	Inside America's Economic Divide: AI, Tariffs, & The Fed | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 29	Steve Liesman
2025-10-17		The Bank Stock Rout: Separating Facts From Fiction | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-10-20		The Next Revolution: AI, Advertising, and the Collapse of Old Media	Craig Moffett, Michael Nathanson
2025-10-24		The K-Shaped Reality: AI Booms While Housing & Tesla Struggle | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-10-26		Inside the Data Center Boom: Understanding the Massive Infrastructure That Supports AI	Nick Del Deo
2025-10-27		Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Crash of 1929 & The Parallels We See Today | The Real Eisman Playbook	Andrew Ross Sorkin
2025-10-31		The AI Boom Rolls On: AI Partnerships Pay Off as Stocks Soar & Meta, Google & Microsoft Go All-In	
2025-11-03		Inside the Cannabis Comeback: How One Company is Beating a Broken Market | The Real Eisman Playbook	Kyle Kazan, Mark Vendetti, Graham Farrar, John Dorsey
2025-11-09		Cracks Beneath the AI Boom: Is the U.S. Economy Heading For a Downturn? | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-11-10	33	The Private Credit Panic: Why Wall Street's Big Winners are Now Losing | Real Eisman Playbook Ep 33	Glenn Schorr

DATE	EP	TITLE	GUESTS
2025-11-14		The Shutdown Ends, Burry’s New AI Warning & Disney Stumbles | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-11-17	34	Inside Publishing’s Big Shakeup: AI, TikTok & the Battle Ahead | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 34	Regina Brooks, Jennifer Weiss, Anthony Ziccardi
2025-11-21		NVIDIA’S Explosive Growth Can’t Hide the Market’s AI Panic | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-11-24	35	Why It’s So Difficult For Companies to Go Public: A CFO Explains the Process | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 35	Amy Butte
2025-11-28		Google Surges Past OpenAI and AI Faces a Bigger Crisis That Could Break the Boom | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-12-01	36	Steve Eisman Reflects on 2008, The Big Short & Today’s K-Shaped Economy | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 36	Ivy Zelman
2025-12-05		The Housing Market is Broken: Why Homes Are Unaffordable & What It Takes to Fix It | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-12-08	37	Inside the Industrial Comeback & AI’s Power Crisis with Nigel Coe | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 37	Nigel Coe
2025-12-12		Netflix & Paramount’s WBD Fight Heats Up + Oracle Falls as AI Doubts Grow | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-12-16	38	Steve Eisman's Masterclass on the 2008 Financial Crisis (Part One) | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 38	
2025-12-19		Steve Eisman's 2025 Wrap Up: 4 Themes Defining the Market Today | The Weekly Wrap	
2025-12-23	39	Steve Eisman's Masterclass on the 2008 Financial Crisis (Part Two) | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 39	
2026-01-02		Steve Eisman Reacts to Scenes From The Big Short	
2026-01-05	40	2026 Predictions with Dan Ives and Chris Verrone | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 40	Chris Verrone, Dan Ives
2026-01-09		5 Long-Term Themes You Need to Understand For 2026 | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-01-12	41	The Broken US Healthcare System is Failing Millions of Americans with Warris Bokhari | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 41	Warris Bokhari
2026-01-16		Why Bank Earnings Are Essential to Understanding the Market in 2026 | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-01-19	42	Gary Marcus on the Massive Problems Facing AI & LLM Scaling | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 42	Gary Marcus
2026-01-23		The “Lone Wolf” Effect: Trump, Burry & a Market on Edge | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-01-26	43	The Mystery of Stablecoins, Visa, & Fiserv’s Collapse with Ken Suchoski | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 43	Ken Suchoski
2026-01-30		Silver Goes Crazy, United Healthcare is Falling, & AI’s CapEx is Exploding | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-02-02	44	Jason Trennert on Populism, Policy & a Distorted Market System | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 44	Jason Trennert
2026-02-06		Crypto & Silver Collapse, Software Gets Obliterated, & Two Stock Recommendations | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-02-09	45	Consumer VibeCession & Private Credit Risk with Lakshmi Ganapathi | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 45	Lakshmi Ganapathi
2026-02-13		AI Panic Spreads, Health Insurers Crack & Retail Keeps Buying | The Weekly Wrap	

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2026-02-16	46	Daniel Guetta on the Guts of AI, Agentic AI & Why LLMs Hallucinate | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 46	Daniel Guetta
2026-02-20		Flight to Safety Begins, Private Credit Cracks & the Software Bloodbath Continues | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-02-23	47	George Noble on Gold's Rise, Crypto Doubts & Tesla's Struggles | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 47	George Noble
2026-02-27		Trump Tariff Turmoil, Private Credit Risk Grows, & AI's Software Fears | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-03-02	48	The Next Financial Crisis? Private Equity, Private Credit & Life Insurance | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 48	Tom Gober
2026-03-06		Iran War Volatility, Private Credit Fears Grow, & Solar Continues to Crash | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-03-09	49	Private Credit Cracks, The AI "Boogeyman" & Why Crypto is for Boomers | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 49	Glenn Schorr, Dwight Collins
2026-03-13		The Iran War Crisis: Ex-CIA Analyst Helima Croft on Oil Shock & Energy Risk | The Weekly Wrap	Helima Croft
2026-03-16	50	Mark Cuban Shares His Plan For Fixing Drug Prices in America | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 50	Mark Cuban
2026-03-20		Private Credit Risks Explained, Oil Surges Above $100 | The Weekly Wrap	Mark Cuban
2026-03-23	51	The Only Health Insurance Stock You Can Own with Michael Ha | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 51	Michael Ha
2026-03-27		The Iran War is Masking Economic Problems: Why Housing is So Expensive | The Weekly Wrap	Phillippe Lord
2026-03-30	52	Inside the Iran War with Steven Cook: What's REALLY Happening? | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 52	Steven Cook
2026-04-02		The Private Credit Reckoning is Coming: Executives Are Mistaking Luck For Genius | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-04-06	53	Is Private Credit the Next Systemic Crisis? Steve Liesman Weighs In | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 53	Steve Liesman
2026-04-10		Q1 Market Recap: How Private Credit, AI, & War Have Dominated 2026 So Far | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-04-13	54	Catching a Falling Knife: The Truth About Software Stocks Today | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 54	Rob Oliver
2026-04-14	55	John Spencer on What the Headlines Get Wrong About the Iran War | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 55	John Spencer
2026-04-17		Bank Earnings Are In: Here's What They're REALLY Saying About the U.S. Economy | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-04-20	56	Market Patterns Work and Jeffrey Hirsch Explains Why | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 56	Jeffrey Hirsch
2026-04-24		Is a Recession Coming? What 100+ Companies Are Telling Us | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-04-27	57	Apollo's Private Credit Exposure: Chris Edson Weighs In | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 57	Chris Edson
2026-05-01		Earnings Keep the Market Strong Despite Signs of Consumer Weakness | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-05-04	58	Is a Market Melt-Up Coming? Why Tech & Semis Are Dominating Again | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 58	Chris Verrone, Todd Sohn

DATE	EP	TITLE	GUESTS
2026-05-08		S&P Hits New Highs as Tech Earnings Crush Recession Fears | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-05-11	59	FICO’s Monopoly is Fading & Consumers Are the Winners w/ Kelsey Zhu | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 59	Kelsey Zhu
2026-05-13		Conspiracy of Credit Part 1	
2026-05-14		A Conspiracy Of Credit Master Class: Part 2	
2026-05-15		Why this Market “Melt-Up” is Making Me Nervous | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-05-18	60	Why Energy Stocks Are Down When They Should Be Up with Bob Brackett | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 60	Bob Brackett
2026-05-22		Walmart & Target Signal Consumer Stress as the 10-Year Yield Hits 4.6% | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-05-25	61	How Silicon Valley Took Over the Defense Industry with Peter Arment | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 61	Peter Arment
2026-05-27		Inside the Hidden Consumer Crisis with Lakshmi Ganapathi	
2026-05-29		The SpaceX IPO: Science Fiction or Serious Investment? | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-06-01	62	Is AI a Bubble? Gary Marcus on What Could Break the Story | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 62	Gary Marcus
2026-06-05		SpaceX's Exploding Capex, AI Addiction Lawsuits, and the Reality of "TokenMaxxing" | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-06-08	63	The AI Semiconductor Boom and What Could End It with Stacy Rasgon | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 63	Stacy Rasgon
2026-06-12		Google Raises $85 Billion and the Market Finally Wakes Up | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-06-15	64	Is Private Equity Destroying the Life Insurance Industry? | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 64	Tom Gallagher
2026-06-17		The Lawsuits That Could Change Social Media Forever w/ Ben Zipursky	
2026-06-18		Anthropic Gets Shut Down By the Government and the AI Story Gets More Complicated | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-06-22	65	The Real State of the American Consumer w/ Three Evercore Analysts | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 65	Michael Binetti, David Palmer, Greg Melich
2026-06-24		Why Cannabis Rescheduling Changes Everything for Glass House Brands	
2026-06-26		The Q2 2026 Report Card: Who Won, Who Lost, and Why | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-06-29	66	The Market's Biggest Warning Signs Right Now with Todd Sohn | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 66	Todd Sohn
2026-07-01		Steve Eisman Reveals His Personal Portfolio: Every Position Explained	
2026-07-06	67	Who Wins the Midterms & What It Means for Markets with Dan Clifton | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 67	Dan Clifton
2026-07-08		The Bearish Case for Oil and Gold with Queen Anne's Gate Capital	
2026-07-10		Why the Entire Market Is Now a Single Bet on AI | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-07-13	68	AI Dominates Economy and Markets with Torsten Slok | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 68	Torsten Slok

DATE	EP	TITLE	GUESTS
2026-07-15		Beyond Ozempic: The Next Wave of Biotech Winners with Boris Peaker	
2026-07-17		Bank Earnings Just Gave the Market a Much Needed Confidence Boost | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-07-21	69	AI Has a Power Problem: Why the U.S. Power Grid Can't Keep Up | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 69	Ben Kallo
2026-07-22		Payments Industry - Fear and Reality	
2026-07-24		Google's Negative Cash Flow and the AI Capex Reckoning | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-07-27	70	The AI Revolution: Who Wins, Who Loses & the SaaSpocalypse | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 70	Dan Ives, Gil Luria
2026-07-29		The Real Estate Brokerage War, For-Profit Education, & the Art of the Short with Brad Safalow	
2026-07-31		The AI Debate Gets More Complicated: Microsoft Has a Win, Meta Stumbles | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-08-03	71	250 Years of American Capitalism: Hamilton, the GFC, & the AI Boom | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 71	Adrian Wooldridge
2026-08-05		Streaming Hits Hollywood Hard: Here's Why with Producer Peter Hoffman	
2026-08-07		SpaceX Disappoints, AI's Free Cash Flow Shrinks, Meta Struggles | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-08-10	72	Private Credit's Clock is Ticking w/ Glenn Schorr & Ken Worthington | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 72	Glenn Schorr, Ken Worthington
2026-08-12		Why the Iran War Is Stuck & What Comes Next with Steven Cook	
2026-08-14		AI’s Achilles’ Heel: Why Everything Hinges on Anthropic & OpenAI | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-08-17	73	The AI Trade, Rising Rates, and Why the Market Is Still Standing | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 73	Jason Trennert, Chris Verrone
2026-08-19		Why Europe Can't Fix Itself & Why It's Getting Worse with Wolfgang Munchau	
2026-08-26		The Juiciest Corporate Scandals with Becca Platsky	
2026-09-02		The Art of the Short with Lakshmi Ganapathi: FICO, DoorDash, and AeroVironment	
2026-09-04		Is OpenAI the Achilles’ Heel of the US Economy? | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-09-07	74	P&C Stocks Worth Owning: The AI Hedge with Ryan Tunis | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 74	
2026-09-09		Inside AI’s Fragile Ecosystem with Ed Zitron	
2026-09-11		AI Terminator Fears Grow & Rates Breach 4.9% | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-09-14	75	The Big Short Partners Reunite: Rates, AI, Gold and Two Stock Picks | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 75	
2026-09-16		How to Analyze Bank Stocks (Part 1): Leverage, Accounting, and Loan Losses	
2026-09-18		Why Dario Amodei and Sam Altman Are Faking the AI Doomsday Crisis | The Weekly Wrap	
2026-09-21	76	Stock Picking in Difficult Times with George Noble | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 76	

DATE	EP	TITLE	GUESTS
2026-09-23		How to Analyze Banks (Part 2): Deposits, Valuations, and Silicon Valley	
2026-09-25		The Enron-Era Tricks Are Back in AI: How These Companies Are Hiding Their Debt | The Weekly Wrap	

APPENDIX B

Guest index

Brad Safalow (recurring)

PAA Research | Short selling, for-profit education, brokerage

Gave the four Ps framework and the rule that every great short rallies hard several times on the way down.

Chris Verrone (recurring)

Strategas | Technical analysis and market structure

Source of the line Eisman repeats: the market is my favourite economist.

Dan Clifton (recurring)

Strategas | Policy and politics

The first guest on the show. Returns for tariffs, the tax bill and the midterms.

Dan Ives (recurring)

Wedbush Securities | Technology

The resident bull. Eisman uses him as a deliberate counterweight.

Dwight Collins (recurring)

Autonomous Research | Financial services

Part of the CEO ranking panel and the private credit panels.

Gary Marcus (recurring)

Cognitive scientist, NYU emeritus | LLM limits and the AI bear case

Argues scaling alone will not reach general intelligence. Eisman treats this as the deepest risk to the AI trade.

Glenn Schorr (recurring)

Evercore ISI | Banks, brokers, alternative asset managers

The house voice on private credit mechanics and BDC structure.

Lakshmi Ganapathi (recurring)

Unicus Research | Short selling, consumer credit, subprime auto

Publishes short research. Calls hundreds of dealers and installers to build a thesis.

Michael Ha (recurring)

Baird | Health insurance

The UnitedHealth teardown and the Molina recovery timeline.

Steven Cook (recurring)

Council on Foreign Relations | Middle East and the Iran war

Two appearances as the war moves from opening strikes to stalemate.

Tom Gober (recurring)

Former life insurance examiner | Private equity and life insurance

Source of the captive reinsurance argument Eisman calls a potential systemic problem.

Wolfgang Munchau (recurring)

Eurointelligence | Europe

Author of Kaput. Argues Europe cannot fix itself.

Adrian Wooldridge

Bloomberg Opinion | Economic history

Episode 71. Two hundred and fifty years of American capitalism.

Amy Butte

Navan | IPOs and market structure

November 2025. CFO of Navan, and CFO of the NYSE for its own 2006 IPO, on why going public is hard.

Andrew Ross Sorkin

CNBC and The New York Times | The Crash of 1929

On his book about 1929 and what rhymes today.

Anthony Ziccardi

Publishing | Book publishing

November 2025. A publisher's view of AI and TikTok reshaping the trade.

Becca Platsky

Investigative reporter | Corporate scandals

Premium episode, August 2026.

Ben Kallo

Baird | Sustainable energy and mobility

July 2026. The companies electrifying the grid that AI needs.

Ben Zipursky

Fordham Law School | Tort law

Premium episode on the lawsuits that could reshape social media.

Bob Brackett

Bernstein | Energy and mining

Episode 60. Why energy stocks lag when they should lead.

Boris Peaker

Biotech analyst | Biotech

Premium episode. The next wave of winners beyond Ozempic.

Chris Edson

Credit analyst | Private credit origination

Episode 57. Apollo's exposure, from someone watching what gets originated.

Craig Fuller

FreightWaves | Logistics

Called the collapse in Chinese export volumes almost to the percentage point.

Craig Moffett

MoffettNathanson | Telecom and cable

October 2025. Old media's wreckage: cable versus fiber, Verizon, and AI advertising.

Daniel Guetta

Columbia Business School | The mechanics of AI

Episode 46. How LLMs work, agentic AI and why models hallucinate.

David Palmer

Evercore | Restaurants and food

June 2026. The protein-obsessed eater and the hollowed-out middle.

Ed Zitron

Writer and podcaster | AI industry economics

September 2026 paid episode. The most thoroughgoing AI bear on the show, on how dependent the ecosystem is on two labs.

George Noble

Noble Capital | Gold, crypto scepticism, Tesla

Episode 47. Discloses a short position in Strategy.

Gerard Cassidy

RBC Capital Markets | Banks

Part of the CEO ranking panel.

Gil Luria

D.A. Davidson | Technology

July 2026. The measured counterpart in the AI winners and losers debate.

Graham Farrar

Glass House Brands | Cannabis

November 2025. Co-founder on growing at greenhouse scale.

Greg Melich

Evercore | Big box retail

June 2026. Walmart as the one enormous winner.

Gretchen Morgenson

NBC News, formerly The New York Times | Investigative reporting

Pulitzer winner. On the crisis, for-profit education and private equity.

Helima Croft

RBC Capital Markets, formerly CIA | Commodities and Middle East risk

Oil shock and energy risk as the Iran war escalates.

Itay Michaeli

TD Cowen | Autos

Autos analyst on the vehicle market, EVs and autonomy.

Ivy Zelman

Zelman and Associates | Housing

On affordability and why builder stocks deserve caution.

Jason Trennert

Strategas | Strategy and policy

Episode 44. Populism, policy and a distorted market system.

Jeffrey Hirsch

Stock Trader's Almanac | Seasonality

Episode 56. Why market patterns work.

Jennifer Weiss

Literary agency | Book publishing

November 2025. The platform now precedes the book.

John Cassidy

The New Yorker | The history of capitalism

Author of Capitalism and its Critics. Prompted the regulation debate Eisman returns to.

John Dorsey

Glass House Brands | Cannabis

November 2025. Part of the first management team interviewed on the show.

John Spencer

Modern War Institute, West Point | Urban warfare

Episode 55. What the headlines get wrong about the Iran war.

Jonathan DeCourcy

Glass House Brands | Cannabis, investor relations

June 2026 paid episode. Head of IR and a former sell-side analyst, on what rescheduling changes.

Kathleen Kelly

Queen Anne's Gate Capital | Commodities

July 2026 paid episode. The bearish case for oil and gold.

Kelsey Zhu

Sell-side analyst | Credit scoring

Episode 59. FICO's eroding monopoly. Eisman discloses he is short the stock.

Ken Suchoski

Autonomous Research | Payments

Episode 43. Stablecoins, Visa and the Fiserv collapse.

Ken Worthington

J.P. Morgan | Brokers and asset managers

August 2026. More positive on private markets than the host.

Kyle Kazan

Glass House Brands | Cannabis

November 2025. CEO of the California grower that makes money in a broken market.

Mark Cuban

Cost Plus Drugs | Drug pricing and PBMs

Episode 50. Argues the delivery system, not research cost, drives US drug prices.

Mark Vendetti

Glass House Brands | Cannabis

November 2025. CFO on unit economics in a federally illegal industry.

Melissa Lee

CNBC | Markets media

Interviewed Eisman on 2025-08-11 in a role reversal episode.

Michael Binetti

Evercore | Retail

June 2026. One of three Evercore analysts on the K-shaped consumer.

Michael Nathanson

MoffettNathanson | Media

October 2025. Whether AI-generated advertising ends the agency business.

Nancy O'Flynn

Queen Anne's Gate Capital | Commodities

July 2026 paid episode. The bearish case for oil and gold.

Nick Del Deo

MoffettNathanson | Digital infrastructure

October 2025. Maps the data center landscape from first principles.

Nigel Coe

Wolfe Research | Industrials

Episode 37. The industrial comeback and the AI power crisis.

Patrick McGee

Financial Times | Apple and China

Author of Apple in China. The very first episode.

Peter Arment

Baird | Aerospace and defence

Episode 61. How Silicon Valley took over the defence industry.

Peter Hoffman

Film producer | Hollywood and streaming

Premium episode on how streaming hit the studios.

Phillippe Lord

Meritage Homes | Homebuilding

March 2026. CEO ground-level view of why housing is so expensive.

Porter Collins

FrontPoint Partners, formerly | Macro and markets, the Big Short team

September 2026. Returning Big Short partner in the reunion episode.

Rahul Jindal

Autonomous Research | Stablecoins

The early primer episode on what a stablecoin actually is.

Regina Brooks

Literary agency | Book publishing

November 2025. How publishing changed over 20 years and what AI does next.

Rob Kaplan

Goldman Sachs | The Fed, banks and the economy

Goldman vice chairman and former Dallas Fed president. Inside the room during political pressure.

Rob Oliver

Baird | Software

April 2026. How software lost half its valuation to AI fear before the numbers moved.

Ryan Tunis

Cantor Fitzgerald | Property and casualty insurance

September 2026. The show's first property and casualty episode, pitched as the AI hedge.

Sami Badri

Cisco | Technology, investor relations

A former sell-side analyst now running IR, walked through the whole tech landscape.

Stacy Rasgon

Bernstein | Semiconductors

Episode 63. Agrees on the mechanism that would end the boom, disagrees on the timing.

Steve Liesman

CNBC | Economics

Episode 53. Is private credit systemic?

Steve Tusa

JP Morgan | Industrials

Industrials analyst. The GE bear call and what it taught about complexity.

Stu Elman

RRE Ventures | Venture capital

August 2025. Co-founder of RRE Ventures on the mechanics and the illiquidity nobody discusses.

Todd Sohn

Strategas | Technical analysis and ETF flows

Episode 66. The market's biggest warning signs.

Tom Gallagher

Evercore | Insurance

June 2026. The second opinion on private equity in life insurance.

Torsten Slok

Apollo Global Management | Economics

Episode 68. The definitive breakdown of the K shape into wealth, wages and inflation.

Vincent Daniel

FrontPoint Partners, formerly | Financials, the Big Short team

September 2026. Returning Big Short partner in the reunion episode on rates, AI and gold.

Warris Bokhari

Claimable | Healthcare

Episode 41. Why the US healthcare system fails millions.

APPENDIX C

Episode synopses

Every one of the 152 public episodes, summarised from the transcripts: what was discussed and what can be learned.

Does China Own Apple? With Patrick McGee

2025-06-05 | DEEP DIVE | 56 MIN | WITH PATRICK MCGEE

The launch episode, and a statement of method. Eisman spends an hour on how Apple physically makes things, and arrives at an argument about national security rather than about the stock.

DISCUSSED

- Apple's near-bankruptcy in spring 1996, closer than the standard Jobs story admits
- The shift from Apple owning factories on three continents to roughly nine countries in 2000 and then almost entirely China
- Tim Cook's contribution framed as manufacturing genius rather than product innovation
- How Apple bought the tooling, designed the machines and trained the workforce, running factories it did not own
- The Chinese suppliers Luxshare, Goertek and BYD displacing Taiwanese firms inside the supply chain
- Xi Jinping's 2013 pressure on Apple and Apple's counter-argument that it contributes to indigenous innovation
- Why moving to India fails, since the component ecosystem itself sits in China

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Manufacturing know-how is a transferable asset, and transferring it is harder to reverse than transferring money
- A supply chain can become a strategic encirclement. McGee's Go analogy is that you win by removing your opponent's moves, not by checkmate
- Concentration risk hides inside companies that look diversified. Components come from many countries but are assembled in one
- When a company has no good options, saying so plainly is more useful than proposing a fix

  Business ties unbreakable, political ties untenable. The situation is not in equilibrium, and nobody knows how it breaks.

Stablecoin and Instability with Trump and Musk - The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-06-07 | WEEKLY WRAP | 19 MIN

An early wrap that sets the template: index stats, a walk through the week's news, then a mailbag answer that turns into a framework. Here the framework is his complacency warning.

DISCUSSED

- Steel tariffs doubled to 50%, and the US and China each accusing the other of reneging
- Tesla registrations in France down 67% year over year
- Private equity monetisations stalling as the IPO window stays shut, with institutions seeking secondary exits
- Meta's twenty-year nuclear deal with Constellation Energy as the start of a trend
- The Fed finally lifting the Wells Fargo asset cap after seven years
- Circle's IPO at 31 dollars trading to 107 within two days

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Markets correct on the possibility of a recession, then rally back until an actual recession arrives
- His World War One analogy: nobody wanted the war, but reciprocal treaties triggered it. Trade can work the same way
- Bitcoin trades opposite its own stated thesis, rising with NASDAQ rather than against fiat risk
- Two contradictory headlines can follow the same jobs print, which is a reason to read the data yourself

He compares the moment to 2007, when the economy looked fine while the underlying credit was already rotten, while explicitly declining to predict calamity.

A Skeptic's Guide to Cryptocurrency and Stablecoins

2025-06-08 | DEEP DIVE | 64 MIN | WITH RAHUL JINDAL

Eisman opens by calling himself a crypto skeptic rather than a hater, then hands a fintech strategist his single objection and lets him answer it at length.

DISCUSSED

- The correlation between Bitcoin and NASDAQ split into three eras, before 2019, the pandemic, and after the crypto winter
- The separation between a coin as an asset and the underlying technology as payment rails
- Why ubiquity and liquidity, not technology, decide which coins matter
- Exactly how a stablecoin works: dollars in, treasuries held in custody, one-to-one backing, no capital appreciation
- Why network fees rather than the coin are where value would accrue
- Visa Plus and Visa Direct as the interoperability layer challengers have to beat
- The regulatory split, with most assets heading to the CFTC as commodities

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A payment technology has to beat the incumbent on the whole job, not on one fee line. The network fee is about 12 basis points of a roughly 3% merchant cost, so attacking it is not worth the build
- Remittances, not retail payments, is where stablecoins have a real opening
- Vertical payment businesses like Toast build a moat by solving an industry's whole back office, which is harder to commoditise
- Eisman's pattern recognition: every few years someone pitches disintermediating Visa and Mastercard, and returns later working with them

He discloses owning Visa for years and calls it the best business model he has seen.

Safe to Stay Invested? Decoding 2025 Stock Charts

2025-06-09 | DEEP DIVE | 63 MIN | WITH TODD SOHN

A working tutorial in technical analysis, with Eisman pressing on whether charts are a philosophy or a tool. The answer he accepts is a tool, and he adopts it.

DISCUSSED

- What a technical strategist actually does: trend, momentum, sentiment and intermarket relationships
- Why head and shoulders patterns are mostly head fakes
- Base building after a collapse, and the UnitedHealth counterexample where a base broke lower
- The equal-weight index as a health check on breadth
- Percentage of S&P stocks at one-month highs as a durability measure
- Consumer discretionary versus staples as an economic barometer
- Levered ETFs at roughly 100 billion dollars, twelve times larger long than short at the January peak

- Why long-duration bonds failed to work after the Fed began cutting, breaking a pattern back to 1975
- Private equity and private credit stocks failing to recover with the rest of financials

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Sentiment is a contrarian tool. When every metric aligns bullish, plan the exit
- Index concentration masks internal deterioration, so look through to breadth
- Active managers face a structural problem: risk limits stop them owning enough of the largest names
- The charts flagged trouble in private credit stocks months before the news did

Sohn reads the private asset managers as distributive across the board, and Eisman connects it to a closed IPO window and impatient institutions.

Market Resilience Amid Multiple Challenges - The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-06-14 | WEEKLY WRAP | 16 MIN

A quiet week that Eisman uses for the most important mailbag answer of the early run, on whether incompetence causes crashes.

DISCUSSED

- Chinese exports to the US down 35% in May, matching a logistics guest's earlier forecast
- Rare earth monopolisation as China's equalizer in trade talks
- Warner Brothers splitting in two, with Netflix at 520 billion against Warner's 26 billion
- Apple's developer conference passing without a meaningful AI announcement
- Israel striking Iran as the episode is recorded

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- How he actually detected the housing bubble: a Moody's securitisation database showing early delinquencies month by month, read like a Rosetta Stone
- Incompetence does not cause bubbles. If it did we could screen for it. Minsky's rational irrationality does
- Chuck Prince's dancing line explains why executives cannot act against their own incentives
- On regulation, the question is never whether but how much, and there is no formula, only iteration

Incentives trump ethics almost every time. The maxim he returns to for the next fourteen months.

Are We Building an AI Future We Can't Power?

2025-06-16 | DEEP DIVE | 61 MIN | WITH SAMI BADRI

A structural tour of the data centre stack with Cisco's head of investor relations, framed as a trip back to 2015 to see what changed.

DISCUSSED

- The 2015 landscape before trillion-dollar market caps, when public cloud was still displacing enterprise data centres
- How CPUs and GPUs differ in practical terms, using a spreadsheet analogy of rows and columns
- The networking layer, NVLink aggregation, and why the interconnect matters as much as the chip
- That much enterprise data is stored but not usable without reformatting
- Cisco's own position across switching, security, observability and collaboration

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The constraint on AI is shifting from chips to power and interconnect
- If people who cannot code can now produce software, the moat around software companies may be thinner than assumed. Eisman flags this in June 2025, well before the software selloff he later covers

- Hardware may outperform software precisely because software's defensibility is now in question

  He says plainly that he is struggling with the software moat question, an early sighting of what becomes the SaaSpocalypse thesis.

Earnings, Geopolitics, and Sectors - The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-06-21 | WEEKLY WRAP | 17 MIN

With earnings season over, he explains the rhythm of the market calendar, then uses the empty week to lay out his first full statement on private credit.

DISCUSSED

- Why the weeks between earnings seasons trade on macro themes alone
- The Iran conflict driving headline-to-headline trading
- Renewable incentives being cut, with Enphase down from 340 dollars to 35 and First Solar from 285 to 140
- Homebuilders losing the benefit of mortgage rate buy-downs, with Lennar down from 185 to 105
- The explosive growth in business development corporations and private credit funds

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- His causal model for credit: in 2008 the credit blowup caused the recession, which is unusual. Normally a recession comes first and exposes bad credit
- He expects the normal order this time, so private credit will reveal mistakes rather than cause them
- The reason he will not call private credit a bubble is the absence of any credit-quality data, in direct contrast to the securitisation data he had in 2006
- Solar is a policy-dependent trade, and he does not expect a rally while the incentives are gone

  He names a trade war as the only thing he can see causing a recession, a view he holds for most of 2025.

Is Capitalism Flawed? Fixing and Regulating Free Markets

2025-06-23 | DEEP DIVE | 67 MIN | WITH JOHN CASSIDY

A book conversation that doubles as Eisman's fullest statement of his own political economy, conducted with a critic of capitalism he clearly respects.

DISCUSSED

- Why Cassidy traced criticism of capitalism back to its origins rather than starting after the Cold War
- Left and right converging on anti-globalisation, which Cassidy calls a crisis of legitimacy
- Mercantile capitalism and the monopoly power of the East India Company at both ends of the trade
- Marxian declining-rate-of-profit theory and why it failed
- Keynes's demand formula and why it was designed to save the system rather than replace it
- Minsky on instability as an internal product of stable periods
- Eisman's own claim that risk-weighted assets, not the repeal of Glass-Steagall, enabled the leverage behind 2008

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The useful debate is not free markets against socialism but where on the spectrum to sit, since both extremes are unserious
- Capitalism's flaws come from people, not from design, so they recur rather than get fixed
- Regulatory capture is real but cyclical, and post-crisis regimes do get teeth
- Populist economic nationalism can be politically coherent while remaining economically incoherent

Eisman argues that even capitalism's critics concede the counterfactual, which he later uses against listeners who read the K-shaped economy fatalistically.

Bullish Signs Continue - The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-06-28 | WEEKLY WRAP | 18 MIN

Both indices hit 52-week highs and Eisman explains the round trip from the February peak through the April 8 low. The answer becomes one of his standing mental models.

DISCUSSED

- The year reviewed: all-time highs in February, a sharp correction to April 8, then a rally back
- Nvidia's 69% revenue growth as proof the AI story is early
- Tech and tech-related stocks passing 40% of the index, a concentration no other country approaches
- Mastercard and Fiserv launching a stablecoin, with Visa expected to follow
- Nike rallying 15% on green shoots despite weak fundamentals
- Zohran Mamdani winning the Democratic primary, hitting New York real estate names

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Markets price the ultimate outcome immediately, then wait to see if it arrives. The error in April was expecting tariffs to hit the economy instantly
- Regulatory capture is real but moves in waves rather than one direction
- Buy the dip is a religion he largely subscribes to, with one named exception: a genuine trade war
- New entrants usually fail against Visa and Mastercard because the incumbents already own trusted global networks

He states the belief that anchors his bullishness: the US economy is more dynamic than at any time in his lifetime.

How CEOs Build Empires, Or Blow Them Up

2025-06-30 | DEEP DIVE | 68 MIN | WITH GLENN SCHORR, GERARD CASSIDY, DWIGHT COLLINS

A three-analyst panel naming good and bad chief executives in financial services, with roughly a century of combined coverage in the room. The most quotable episode of the early run.

DISCUSSED

- Jamie Dimon's record of fixing Bank One, then JP Morgan, then Chase in sequence
- The accountability and transparency the panel calls shocking in the best sense
- John Kanas selling North Fork to Capital One in 2005, before the blowup
- Citigroup trading at three times book while JP Morgan sat at 75% of book in 2000
- The recurring anatomy of failed banks: concentrated risk, balance sheets growing too fast, no controls, high-risk lending
- Texas banks in the 1980s, Northeast banks in the 1990s, Washington Mutual and Wachovia in 2008
- Lloyd Blankfein named as the most overrated
- Brian Moynihan offered as the rare bad-to-good turnaround
- Marianne Lake flagged as the likely Dimon successor

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Good chief executives build teams, hold them accountable, and go against the grain while absorbing criticism for it
- Bad ones share a specific fingerprint, and it is a balance sheet fingerprint rather than a personality one
- Avoiding dilutive acquisitions and buying cheap in distress is a marker of the best operators

- Growth in tangible book value per share over ten to fifteen years is the scoreboard that survives cycles
- Great leaders produce successors, which is itself a test of the leader

  Eisman's own summary elsewhere: a chief executive who stays too long becomes good, mediocre and bad in sequence.

Jobs Shock, Bank Buyback Boom & AI Talent Wars | The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-07-03 | WEEKLY WRAP | 20 MIN

A technical wrap that teaches bank capital from first principles, prompted by the annual stress test results.

DISCUSSED

- Payrolls at 147,000 against 106,000 expected, ending hope of a summer rate cut
- The ten-year yield stuck in the same range since October 2022, which he calls directionless
- Meta poaching OpenAI talent with very large signing bonuses
- Foxconn recalling Chinese engineers from Indian iPhone plants, stalling Apple's diversification
- Stress capital buffers falling across the board, with Goldman down nearly 300 basis points

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Capital ratios divide common equity by risk-weighted assets, not by assets, and the stress capital buffer is the binding constraint on large banks
- Regulators should not ratchet the test forever, because enough deleveraging makes banking uneconomic
- His defence of calling Hank Greenberg a bad chief executive: AIG was his largest short in 2005, and Greenberg built both the powerhouse and the decentralised structure that sank it
- Fifteen years to merge 200 operating systems is the real cost of a decentralised empire

  For the first time since the crisis, he says, regulators are turning friendlier to banks, while stressing this is nothing like pre-2008 leverage.

Don't Get Fooled Again: Pulitzer Winner Warns of Wall Street's Dark Side

2025-07-07 | DEEP DIVE | 59 MIN | WITH GRETCHEN MORGENSON

Two people who were reporting and shorting the same companies in the 2000s compare notes. The register is moral as much as analytical.

DISCUSSED

- Her 2002 Pulitzer for exposing conflicted Wall Street analysts during the dot-com era
- Her recurring theme: practices that harm many people and benefit a small group on the inside
- Household International, Enron, WorldCom and the road to Sarbanes-Oxley
- AIG's disputes with Goldman over credit default swap pricing, and how circular the marks became
- Fabrice Tourre as a junior salesman who became the face of a firm-level problem
- How little changed after 2008 despite trillions in losses and mass foreclosure
- Private equity bankruptcies beginning as the rate and IPO environment turns against the model
- Private equity firms taking on pension liabilities, leaving retirees dependent on them

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Incentives ran the length of the chain. Countrywide loan officers earned two to three times more for a subprime loan than a prime one
- State-based insurance regulation is a structural weakness, since a national insurer answers to whichever state it is domiciled in
- Eisman's discipline in his own words: he would not short the planet without data, and the private-equity-into-insurance story is compelling but currently dataless

He tells her that explaining how finance actually works to ordinary people could not be more crucial, which is effectively the podcast's mission statement.

Big Beautiful Bill, Write-Off Revolution & Tariff Tempest | The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-07-12 | WEEKLY WRAP | 35 MIN | WITH DAN CLIFTON

A wrap that hands most of its runtime to a policy analyst, because a 900-page bill had just become law. The most investment-relevant policy episode of 2025.

DISCUSSED

- Tariff threats against fourteen countries, plus copper at 50% and Brazil at 50%, with the market ignoring all of it
- The five themes in the bill: permanent individual tax cuts, the president's campaign promises, business investment incentives, spending cuts and a five trillion dollar debt ceiling rise
- 100% immediate expensing for factories built in America, and for capital goods, made permanent
- R&D expensing restored for domestic research
- Medicaid growth slowed rather than cut, with effects starting in 2028
- Orphan drug carve-outs from inflation-reduction price controls

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Clifton's framing that Eisman adopts: the bill sterilises the tariffs rather than stimulating growth. Read the two together or you misjudge the deficit
- The Congressional Budget Office scores the bill at 3.4 trillion added and the tariffs at 2.8 trillion raised, leaving the deficit near 6.2% of GDP rather than exploding
- America has entered austerity for the first time in thirty years, measured by interest cost against tax revenue
- Policy changes create two distinct winner sets: those who sell the goods and those who buy and expense them

Eisman's own aside on conspiracy theories: the important conspiracies are the unspoken ones that develop over time, like an entire sector's ethos of lending badly.

Why the Market's Surging Despite the Headlines

2025-07-14 | DEEP DIVE | 66 MIN | WITH CHRIS VERRONE

A market strategist walks through why the year confounded everyone, and Eisman uses him to test his own worry that the market has priced trade risk at zero.

DISCUSSED

- Equity inflows in the 99th percentile of all history going into January, a sentiment warning
- The 65-day rally off the April low ranking fourth best in history, alongside 2009, 2020 and 1982
- Credit conditions described as remarkably benign
- Deregulation as a reason to prefer Goldman over Apollo and Blackstone, since regulation protects incumbents and deregulation helps challengers
- Homebuilders correlating tightly with regional banks
- Gold sentiment described as excessive
- Bitcoin surviving three separate 90% drawdowns

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Having the headlines in advance would have lost you money, which is the argument for listening to price rather than predicting news

- The market is consistently smarter than any individual, and the best response is to listen
- Anything that survives three 90% drawdowns is a survivor, whatever it eventually becomes
- Verrone's line that Eisman adopts permanently: the market is my favourite economist

Eisman names his precise discomfort: he thinks the US economy is great, and worries the market is treating trade-war probability as zero.

Earnings Season Kickoff, Bank Earnings & Nvidia China Greenlight | The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-07-19 | WEEKLY WRAP | 28 MIN

He opens by disclosing a breast cancer diagnosis, deliberately, to make men aware the disease is not confined to women. Then he teaches bank valuation and works through earnings.

DISCUSSED

- The diagnosis, caught early, with treatment expected over several months
- An oncologist squash partner spotting a skin irritation he had ignored for months
- Return on tangible common equity and price to tangible book as the two metrics that drive bank valuation
- JP Morgan, Goldman and BlackRock earnings, with advisory revenue up 71% signalling an M&A recovery
- Progressive's premiums up 18%, which he calls remarkable at that size

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A bank with a higher return on tangible common equity earns a higher multiple of tangible book. Those two numbers explain most bank valuation
- Why he invests only in the United States: tech is 31% of the S&P alone, and over 50% including tech-adjacent names, which no other market approaches
- His own education arc. He joined Neuberger knowing financials, spent years learning technology and industrials, and that study changed his view of the whole economy

He tells men to get unexplained breast symptoms checked, and credits his friend with probably saving his life.

The Secrets of the Short Seller: How the Pros Spot Trouble

2025-07-21 | DEEP DIVE | 50 MIN | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

The first of two consecutive short-selling masterclasses. A boutique researcher walks through winners, losers and the rules she now refuses to break.

DISCUSSED

- An airline short built on a Freedom of Information Act request and a whistleblowing mechanic
- Stellantis from 20 dollars to 9, built on calls to 100 to 300 dealerships
- How stimulus cheques turned subprime borrowers into paper-prime borrowers, then reversed
- Negative equity freezing the trade-in market and stranding dealer inventory
- SolarEdge and Enphase advertising sub-1% failure rates while installers reported nearer 40%
- California's NEM 3.0 stretching solar payback from seven years to twenty
- Reddit and DraftKings as losses, both cult stocks
- Carvana covered at 4 dollars, then rising above 300

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Never short a cult, because cultists care about things you consider irrelevant and buy on them
- Never short purely on valuation, and never short a stock at a 52-week high. Wait for one missed earnings
- Never short a roll-up before its anniversary, since acquisition accretion masks the problem for about a year

- It is always the management. Investigate every board member, where they worked and why they left
- Watch receivables, warranty expense and liabilities. The balance sheet tells the story
- Eisman's ranking: a pure microeconomic short is best, one with macro or political overlay second, a politically dependent short last

Her partner's test for whether a thesis will work: the fundamentals may be bad, but does anybody care?

Meme Stock Resurgence: Warning Signs or Just Noise? - The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-07-26 | WEEKLY WRAP | 27 MIN

A 113-company earnings dump, used to illustrate why identical industries earn wildly different multiples, and to announce the masterclass series.

DISCUSSED

- The Japan deal at 15% rather than the threatened 25%, plus a 550 billion dollar investment fund
- Verizon and AT&T trading below their year-2000 levels despite 180 to 200 billion dollar market caps
- T-Mobile at 22 times earnings against AT&T at 12 and Verizon at 9
- Everyone in cable and wireless attacking everyone else's business, leaving Charter without growth
- GE Vernova at 86 times 2025 earnings, justified by scarcity since only two companies make gas turbines
- Tesla earnings down 23% and revenue down 12%
- Meme stocks under 5 dollars spiking on social buzz and short squeezes

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Multiples reflect story and growth, not industry. Three wireless companies with similar assets trade at wildly different valuations
- Electrical power is the binding constraint on AI, and removing solar subsidies raised the value of gas turbines
- Scarcity value is a legitimate reason for a rich multiple when only two suppliers exist worldwide
- Tesla taught Chinese manufacturers to build electric vehicles, and they now build them better and cheaper

He announces the financial literacy and 2008 crisis lectures, and asks listeners to send topics they want covered.

The Secrets of the Short Seller Part 2: The Blueprint for Strategy & Survival

2025-07-28 | DEEP DIVE | 63 MIN | WITH BRAD SAFALOW

The second short-selling masterclass, and the more structural of the two. Safalow supplies a market-structure framework before discussing a single company.

DISCUSSED

- The four Ps: passives, processors meaning quants and algos, pods, and positioning
- How multi-strategy pod risk management forces violent unwinds on a 3% to 5% drawdown
- Gamma squeezes, and why dealers must buy the underlying as calls are bought
- Fresh Pet: store saturation near 28,000 of a 32,000 to 35,000 addressable base, rising acquisition costs, no third-party study of the product's benefit
- Trupanion and the insurance rate spiral, with premiums up 400% to 700% over a decade yet loss ratios still above target
- Kinsale compared to ITT Educational, both revered financially, both serving customers other providers refuse

- Shutterstock and title insurers as set-and-forget shorts

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Every great short rallies 50% to 100% against the trend three to five times on the way down, which is the hardest part to survive
- Rank short types by durability: secularly challenged first, then fad, then cyclical, then fraud, because frauds persist for a decade
- Carry both kinds. High-maintenance shorts are war, set-and-forget shorts on quiet decline often deliver the better return on time
- Where passive ownership dominates, valuation is nearly irrelevant and flows decide the price
- The IKEA effect is real in research. A thousand pages of work on one name does not make the position right

Safalow's short ideas have generated about 27% annual alpha since inception, yet he notes Pepsi alone produced roughly 200% over five years as a simple secular short.

How Tariff Deals, Pharma Shocks, & Mega Mergers Redefined the Market - The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-08-02 | WEEKLY WRAP | 25 MIN

Tariff diplomacy dominates, and a weak payroll print with a large downward revision changes the Fed conversation.

DISCUSSED

- The EU deal at 15%, which he reads as Europe mostly caving, with Germany most exposed as the largest exporter
- India threatened at 25% plus penalties over Russian oil purchases
- July payrolls at 73,000 against 104,000 expected, with June revised from 147,000 down to 14,000
- PayPal down from nearly 300 dollars in 2021 to 67, with payment volume growth slowing
- Microsoft revenue up 18% at a four trillion dollar market cap
- Meta showing AI translating into better monetisation

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A four trillion dollar company growing revenue 18% would normally be astonishing, and only looks ordinary beside Nvidia's 69%
- Payments outside the Visa and Mastercard duopoly is a brutal business where everyone attacks everyone
- His sell discipline stated plainly: hold while the thesis is intact, largely ignore valuation, and sell when the story changes rather than when the multiple moves

He previews the venture capital episode by flagging a claim he says is not written about anywhere: venture entered a depression in 2022.

Venture Capital Revealed: Behind the Schemes They Haven't Told You

2025-08-04 | DEEP DIVE | 54 MIN | WITH STU ELMAN

A co-founder of RRE Ventures describes a venture depression that began in 2022 and, he argues, is largely absent from public coverage.

DISCUSSED

- Founding a fund in 1994, the month Netscape shipped
- How cloud removed the fixed costs of servers, racks and licences that once made a pivot impossible
- The 2017 to 2021 period, which his partners judged worse than 2000 on valuation
- Vanilla term sheets with no board seat as a marker of the top

- Pay-to-play recapitalisations diluting non-participating investors roughly ten to one
- Why venture firms die slowly rather than quickly, continuing to claim they are in business while deploying almost nothing
- Tokenisation of real estate cash flows as his next area of study

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Venture accounting lets firms carry marks that public markets would have repriced, so distress stays hidden longer
- The sector is bifurcated. AI, crypto and blockchain attract capital while everything else stays frozen
- Illiquidity is the through-line connecting venture, private equity and private credit. Getting in is easy and getting out is the problem
- Both venture and private equity are broadening from institutional to retail investors, which is when the public starts to care

Eisman uses this episode repeatedly afterwards as the first sighting of the exit problem he later tracks through private credit.

Tariffs Are Back, Apple's Big Bet, and AI's Real Impact - The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-08-08 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

Recorded from the road. Sector tariffs arrive, and Eisman applies real scepticism to a headline investment promise.

DISCUSSED

- Switzerland threatened at 39% and improving its offer, India raised from 25% to 50%
- Pharma tariffs threatened to escalate to 150% then 250% to force domestic factory building
- 100% semiconductor tariffs, waived for companies building in the United States
- Apple pledging another 100 billion dollars, reaching 600 billion over four years
- Vertex down 20% on a failed pain drug despite fine revenue and earnings
- Eli Lilly down 14% despite beating and raising, on disappointing obesity pill data
- Super Micro down 18% while Arista rose on more proprietary products

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Effective total tariff rate heading to roughly 13% to 14%, per his go-to policy analyst
- In pharma and biotech the pipeline matters more than current earnings, which is why beats can be punished
- Investment pledges deserve arithmetic. Apple invests around 55 billion a year in China, so the promised US figure needs context before it is taken at face value
- Proprietary products defend margins. Commodity servers do not

He says the president appears to take corporate investment announcements at face value when more scepticism might be appropriate.

Steve Eisman Shares the Real Story Behind Predicting the 2008 Crash

2025-08-11 | DEEP DIVE | 64 MIN | WITH MELISSA LEE

The role reverses and CNBC's Melissa Lee interviews him. The most complete first-person account of his career and the Big Short trade in the whole run.

DISCUSSED

- Why he is structurally bullish: after 2014 he studied technology and industrials and revised his view of the economy

- His Oppenheimer coverage spanning investment banks, Fannie, Freddie, Sallie Mae, credit cards and the subprime lenders
- Turning negative on subprime lenders in early 1998
- Shorting New Century, Countrywide and Washington Mutual as equities, with borrow costs as high as 25%
- Moving into credit default swaps because the equity shorts were illiquid and expensive
- The single metric he cared most about in a securitisation: the share of no-doc and low-doc loans
- Visiting Aames Financial in the 1990s and finding the chairman personally on the loan committee
- Why what happened to Greece cannot happen to the United States while treasuries have no alternative

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- He describes living The Man Who Shot Liberty Valance, a candid note on being credited for a call
- Reserve currency status alone is not the protection. The banking system's plumbing runs on treasuries, and no alternative exists yet
- He owns Apple unhedged while acknowledging it is fully captive to US and China relations, an honest statement of a position held despite a known risk

Asked about the industry's hunger to call the next crisis, he suggests people want a movie made about them.

The U.S. Sets an Unprecedented AI Chip Agreement with China | The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-08-16 | WEEKLY WRAP | 27 MIN

An end-of-quarter reflection that doubles as his clearest statement of how he reads an earnings season.

DISCUSSED

- Nvidia permitted to sell certain chips into China under an unprecedented arrangement
- UnitedHealth halved from its 2024 peak above 600 dollars, with Berkshire disclosing a new position
- Arista beating strongly while Cisco beat only slightly
- The MLP collapse as a case study in paradigm shifts

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- His earnings-season method: he is not a trader, and uses quarterly reports as a thesis check rather than a trading trigger
- Revenue is harder to manage than earnings, so a revenue miss is the more serious red flag, especially for growth stocks
- Decide in advance which numbers matter, and listen to conference calls for what is not said
- Paradigm shifts are hard to see because management and investors are both too invested, financially and emotionally, to read the signs
- Balance sheets matter as much as income statements, which the MLP investors learned the hard way

He ranks AI stories by how proprietary the product is, which is why he separates Nvidia and Arista from Super Micro and Dell.

Industrial Sector Explained: Data Center Growth & Rise of Vertiv | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep. 21

2025-08-18 | DEEP DIVE | 60 MIN | WITH STEVE TUSA

JP Morgan's industrial analyst, best known for years of scepticism on GE, on how data centres turned a thematically dull sector into a historic investment cycle.

DISCUSSED

- Data centres upgraded from a ferocious to a historic investment cycle
- The scale check: data centres are only about 5% of US private non-residential construction, so the growth rate matters more than the base
- Hyperscaler capex of 300 to 400 billion a year plus utility capex in the hundreds of billions
- Vertiv with roughly 80% data centre exposure, more than Nvidia by revenue share
- Cooling demand rising exponentially as chip density climbs from about 100 kilowatts toward 200 and beyond
- A 300 gigawatt US data centre pipeline of which only about 35% is funded
- GE Vernova still losing a billion dollars in wind while power demand carries the rest

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The AI trade extends well past chips into transformers, distribution and grid equipment
- New chip architectures every couple of years push hyperscalers toward outsourced thermal design rather than in-house teams
- Autos and process industries are not participating, so the capex cycle is narrower than it appears
- Tusa's old GE critique: the balance sheet sat in financial services while the earnings were reported from the industrial side, and the sell-side incentive structure discouraged asking about it

Peacock today, feather duster tomorrow, peacock again. Tusa's line for the cyclicality of industrial reputations.

Powell Says Nothing & Markets Cheer, Amazon Wins & Target Loses | The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-08-22 | WEEKLY WRAP | 18 MIN

He opens by explaining exactly how he makes the show, then uses retail market caps to show how completely the sector reordered itself.

DISCUSSED

- His process: he starts writing Monday, builds a script through the week, and writes every word himself
- Palantir down 20% from its high while still up over 100% on the year
- Amazon at 2.4 trillion, Walmart at 810 billion, Costco at 434 billion and Target at only 45 billion
- Target reporting badly and naming an insider chief executive, disappointing the street
- Home Depot reaffirming weak guidance, with sales up 3% and earnings down 2%

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Seasonal rules like selling in May are mostly noise. He shows the arithmetic of having sold on 30 May and missing a 9% to 13% move
- Monthly Fed pronouncements matter little unless the Fed turns genuinely aggressive. Everything else is tinkering
- His Jim Cramer point about 2008: the crisis was never about rates, it was about the financial system, and rate cuts cannot fix a broken system
- The existing-home market is frozen because owners refinanced at 3% to 4% and will not sell into a 6.5% market while they still have jobs

Target's market cap was once roughly three times its current level, which he offers as a caution about assuming today's leaders are permanent.

Tesla vs Waymo: Who Will Win the Robotaxi Race? | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep. 22

2025-08-25 | DEEP DIVE | 66 MIN | WITH ITAY MICHAELI

TD Cowen's auto analyst on why Tesla earnings fell about 57% from the 2022 peak while the stock stayed flat, and whether autonomy can justify the gap.

DISCUSSED

- Over-earning in 2022 at roughly 4 dollars a share and 25% gross margin, off a single ageing platform
- Why a vehicle remains an emotional purchase, so software updates do not substitute for redesigns
- Chinese manufacturers matching then exceeding Tesla on speed of development
- EV penetration around 7.5% of new sales, with a pull-forward expected before credits expire
- Waymo at over 250,000 weekly fully autonomous rides against Tesla's very limited service
- Why solving autonomy in Manhattan differs completely from solving it at 3am in a quiet suburb
- GM as his top overall pick, Aptiv as top supplier

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A metric can be right for the wrong reason. Growth over market was read as pure secular EV demand when mix and trim were doing much of the work
- Design variety expands demand. Two vehicles on one platform can sell to buyers who would reject either alone
- Tesla's case now rests on autonomy and cheaper product rather than on current deliveries

Eisman stays on the sidelines and says so, offering his own purchase of a Tesla as the barometer for autonomy actually working.

Trump vs The Fed, U.S. Takes 10% Stake in Intel, Cracker Barrel Cracks | The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-08-30 | WEEKLY WRAP | 37 MIN

A long wrap covering an attempt to remove a Fed governor, a government equity stake in Intel, and a full ranking of sector performance.

DISCUSSED

- Mortgage fraud allegations against Fed Governor Lisa Cook and the attempt to fire her for cause
- The US taking a 10% equity stake in Intel via Chips Act funds, with the commerce secretary signalling more such deals
- Semiconductors leading all subsectors, followed by real estate management on CoStar and CBRE
- Diversified financials up 10%, with Goldman up 31%
- Food staples and retail lagging, with Target down 28%
- Salesforce and Adobe falling in a bull market where tech outperformed

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- His test for industrial policy is symmetry. Ask how you would feel when the other party holds the same equity stake and steers the company toward its agenda
- Defensive stocks keep underperforming while the economy holds up, so their weakness is information about growth
- Subsector analysis reveals what sector analysis hides. AI is already producing losers inside the winning sector
- When iconic software names fall during a tech rally, the market is pricing a moat problem rather than a cycle

He admits he raised Cracker Barrel's logo reversal purely so he could say Cracker Barrel cracked.

Steve Eisman Answers YOUR Investing Questions | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 23

2025-09-01 | DEEP DIVE | 47 MIN

A scripted mailbag episode that turns into the most personal statement of method in the run, covering what he reads, how he researches and why he sleeps better investing only in America.

DISCUSSED

- Why he avoids business books and reads history, psychology and politics instead
- Richard Posner as his formative influence, having read roughly 35 of the judge's 40 books
- How Posner's 1974 antitrust book taught him that ideas matter and that disciplines can be reframed
- The pre-Dodd-Frank alphabet soup of regulators and how banks played them against each other
- Quantitative easing inflating the Fed balance sheet with debatable effect on the real economy
- Holding cash, and how his view changed as his confidence in the economy grew
- The MLP collapse revisited, including a call where management could not answer a cost-of-capital question

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- His research loop: form a thesis from fundamental work, then pay for outside data that can confirm or destroy it. He paid for the Moody's securitisation database precisely for that
- Leverage without capital retention is dangerous, the specific flaw that broke the MLPs
- He recommends the CFA course over any book for anyone wanting to run money
- Having predicted the end of the world once, he is in no hurry to predict it again, and sees no evidence for it

His closing advice is about sleep. He once woke at 3am to check a global portfolio and could never get back to sleep. Investing as a passion is fine, as a preoccupation it is a signal to change your style.

Google Wins Antitrust Case, Is AI The Next Bubble? | The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-09-05 | WEEKLY WRAP | 18 MIN

He opens with a correction to his own error, then works through Google's antitrust win and the first serious articulation of his AI bubble worry.

DISCUSSED

- Correcting himself: the Fed was created by the Federal Reserve Act of 1913, not a constitutional amendment
- An appeals court rejecting the emergency-powers basis for tariffs, with a Supreme Court appeal expected
- Google winning the antitrust case outright, which he attributes partly to AI competition making search look less dominant
- Two of the three overhangs on Apple clearing at once
- Buffett opposing the Kraft Heinz breakup while Berkshire holds 27.5%
- Salesforce beating but guiding weakly, down almost 6%, and flat over five years despite being up nearly 6,000% since 2004
- Lululemon missing a shift in silhouettes

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Correcting a factual error on air, promptly and without hedging, is part of how the show builds trust
- The AI worry stated cleanly: if scaling ever-larger models is losing steam and returns disappoint, investment slows and a painful digestion period follows, as in 2001

- Retailers eventually miss a fashion inflection, and they all do, which is the structural risk in the sector

He notes reports that the newest model release was not much better than its predecessor, the first appearance of the scaling question that becomes his central AI risk.

Steve Eisman's Masterclass on Financial Literacy | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 24

2025-09-08 | MASTERCLASS | 71 MIN

A formal solo lecture in eight parts, and the single most useful episode for a non-professional investor. His stated aim is to teach the language of investing, which he calls the entrance fee to the club.

DISCUSSED

- Market corrections, and why his own answer differs completely from 2007 when he told people to go to cash
- Why he believes another crisis of that kind is unlikely after Dodd-Frank deleveraging, while a recession is always possible
- Long-term investing: buy the indices, use SPY for lower risk tolerance and add QQQ for more, invest on a schedule and do not market time
- Thesis creep explained through a worked Capital One example
- Shorting, short squeezes, and why forced covering by risk managers makes them worse
- Valuation methods by sector: price to earnings, EV to EBITDA, price to tangible book for balance-sheet-dependent financials
- Sector weights, and how reclassifying Meta, Google and Amazon would lift tech from 31% to over 40%
- How interest rates hit growth stocks hardest through the discount rate in a discounted cash flow

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Thesis creep is the bane of every investor. When the thesis breaks, you were wrong, and holding on because the stock is now cheaper is a different decision pretending to be the same one
- He does not much like discounted cash flow because it needs too many variables, while admitting it is in principle correct
- Safety sectors still exist but several are less safe than they were, since cable and traditional media stopped being defensive
- Most professionals fail to beat the averages over long periods, which is the honest case for indexing

Every profession is a club with its own language, and mastery of that language is the entrance fee. That is his stated purpose for the whole series.

Oracle's Massive AI Forecast, Hot IPOs Explained | The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-09-12 | WEEKLY WRAP | 27 MIN

Oracle misses on both lines and the stock takes off, because the backlog number rewrites the story. He then grades the new IPO class.

DISCUSSED

- Oracle missing earnings and revenue, then disclosing remaining performance obligations of 455 billion, up 359%
- How that backlog converts into forward infrastructure revenue guidance
- CoreWeave described as the strongest story of the recent IPO vintage
- Circle's revenue being interest earned on the treasuries backing its coins, making it highly rate-sensitive
- Buy now pay later names with intense retail followings and untested credit

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A backlog can matter more than the quarter. Investors bought the obligation schedule and ignored two misses
- A business whose earnings track short-term rates does not deserve a technology multiple
- Buy now pay later credit has never been tested by a recession, and he expects investors to exit the whole group when recession fears return
- The market's default assumption has flipped. Once a new thing had to prove itself, now it is assumed to be the next big thing until disproved

He walks through beta as a portfolio tool while explicitly refusing to advise a listener to add leverage through it.

Trump's Battle with the Fed Explained | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 25

2025-09-15 | DEEP DIVE | 52 MIN | WITH ROB KAPLAN

A former Dallas Fed president, now Goldman vice chairman, on what actually happens inside Fed meetings during political pressure. Eisman calls himself a professional critic and Kaplan the man in the room.

DISCUSSED

- Growth at 1.25% to 1.5%, with unemployment low only because labour supply has fallen
- Tariffs as a short-run headwind even if they eventually raise growth
- Whether political pressure is discussed at Fed meetings, which Kaplan says it is not
- Kaplan's dissent on aggressive forward guidance during COVID, when he argued the neutral rate would drift up
- Why he would not build an operation that is only competitive behind a tariff moat
- Consolidation among roughly 4,150 US banks, only about 80 of which hold more than 20 billion in assets

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Doing the deal is the easy part. Integration is where mergers are won or lost
- Large banks hold a widening structural advantage in technology spending and deposit gathering, which is the argument for regional consolidation
- When an entire group disagrees with you, the first thought should be that you are wrong. Kaplan's point is that occasionally you still are not
- Eisman's own long-standing call for a regional bank M&A wave gets its fullest airing here

Eisman's framing of the difference between them: he was an analyst and fund manager, which makes him a professional critic, while Kaplan was in the room where it happens.

Are Stablecoins the Next Big Thing? Luigi Mangione Terror Charges Dropped | The Weekly Wrap

2025-09-20 | WEEKLY WRAP | 23 MIN

A solo wrap built around a stablecoin primer: the opportunity is real in cross-border payments, but consumer payments are a fortress stablecoins probably cannot storm. He opens on the Mangione ruling and the Kirk assassination, arguing markets stay peaceful because everyone accepts a final arbiter.

DISCUSSED

- A New York judge dismissing state terrorism charges against Luigi Mangione, with murder and weapons charges remaining
- The Charlie Kirk assassination as evidence of how polarized discourse has become, contrasted with market Reddit rage that never turns violent
- Circle going public June 4, 2025 at 31 and trading at 140, which put stablecoins on everyone's radar
- Cross-border payments routing through three to five banks, the process stablecoins could streamline first

- Why consumer payments resist disruption: the merchant pays the 2.5 to 3% fee, Visa and Mastercard take only about 15 basis points, and rewards lock consumers in
- Tether as the sector's reputational risk: the largest stablecoin company, not US-based and unregulated
- Mailbag on valuing loss-making tech with DCF supplemented by price to sales

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A payment system where the consumer pays nothing upfront is nearly impossible to disrupt on price; you have to bribe consumers away from rewards they already get free
- Attack the clunky corridor first. Cross-border and remittances, not consumer checkout, is where stablecoins can win
- How companies are valued within a sector is set by consensus, what he calls the mafia; accept the terms of debate or do not play, but do not argue with them
- An unregulated offshore giant can damage the reputation of its regulated US competitors; Tether risk is Circle risk

His answer to why market rage never turns violent: unlike politics, the market is a final arbiter everyone concedes makes the final decision.

Breaking Down the United Healthcare Disaster: What's REALLY Going On? | Real Eisman Playbook Ep. 26

2025-09-22 | DEEP DIVE | 56 MIN | WITH MICHAEL HA

Baird's managed care analyst, who was in the auditorium at UnitedHealth's investor day when Brian Thompson was murdered, walks through how the most hated company in the world went from PR noise to genuine fundamental cracks. The core of the bear case is Optum Health, the crown jewel, being structurally impaired by V28 risk model changes the company still has not offset.

DISCUSSED

- The timeline: Thompson murdered in December at the investor day, the stock falling from about 600 to around 440 by February on PR alone, recovering to 600, then breaking on first quarter results in April
- UnitedHealthcare's three insurance pillars: Medicare Advantage, Medicaid and commercial, with Medicare Advantage the biggest earnings driver
- Optum Health as the crown jewel: converting 90% of roughly 10 million Medicare Advantage members at 10 to 15% margins could double enterprise earnings over a decade
- The V28 risk model revisions phasing in equally across 2024 to 2026, which removed thousands of ICD-10 codes that mapped to payable condition categories
- The disclosure problem: a roughly 3.3 billion dollar gain from selling stakes in Optum businesses, about 3 dollars of 27 dollars in 2024 EPS, mentioned only vaguely in the 10-K
- Baird's underperform: bull case of 257 against a stock at 305, on a 14 to 15 times multiple he calls the new normal versus the old 20 times

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Separate PR noise from fundamental cracks. The first 20 to 25% drawdown was noise; the April quarter was not
- Optimized clinic models have no slack. When reimbursement rules change, tightly staffed value-based care has very limited offsets, which is why the South Florida models disappeared
- When a company's entire year of earnings growth comes from a gain on sale disclosed as a vague line item, treat management confidence with suspicion
- Eisman's own rule surfaces again: without dramatically improved disclosure, the stock is very difficult to recommend regardless of valuation

Ha's bull case implies 15% downside, and after marketing across the country he has found a definitive zero healthcare investors positive on the name.

The Wild West of Crypto: Chaos, Shenanigans, & The AI Revolution | The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-09-26 | WEEKLY WRAP | 27 MIN

Framed by his upcoming Andrew Ross Sorkin interview on 1929, he argues crypto today rhymes with the unregulated shenanigans and leverage of that era. He then maps the AI trade into themes of winners and losers and flags a tiring market under the surface.

DISCUSSED

- Monday's crypto selloff of about 10% in some coins on no news, traced to the offshore structure of trading
- Binance handling roughly 40% plus of global crypto spot volume after migrating from China to Japan to Malta to the Cayman Islands, which he calls a big bunch of red flags
- Market breadth deteriorating: less than 60% of the S&P 500 above its 50-day moving average near all-time highs
- AI hardware winners: Nvidia, Broadcom, Arista Networks, Amphenol, maybe Cisco, and CoreWeave, the data center manager public since March
- The consensus that AI guts consultants and traditional software: Gartner down 49% and Accenture down 32% this year
- Morgan Stanley's estimate of 2.9 trillion dollars in data center spending through 2028, 1.4 trillion funded by hyperscaler cash flow and the rest by debt of every flavor
- Nvidia's new vendor financing making an otherwise healthy funding story less clean

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- History rhymes too often. The 1929 mix of no regulation, manipulation and crazy leverage maps directly onto offshore crypto today
- US-regulated crypto firms hold the high ground on leverage limits, which makes them safer and less competitive at the same time
- A market at highs with shrinking breadth is consolidating at best and tiring at worst
- That half of the AI buildout is funded from operating cash flow of large famous companies is what keeps the story healthy; watch the other half
- Too little regulation gives you a casino, too much stalls the system; his job is measuring the odds between them

The AI Revolution: Winners, Losers, & The Future of Tech | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 27

2025-09-29 | DEEP DIVE | 59 MIN | WITH DAN IVES

Wedbush's resident tech bull calls this a fourth industrial revolution and an unprecedented capex buildout, and Eisman lets him run through the whole board: Apple, Tesla, Palantir, Nvidia and the derivative plays. Two bulls, but Eisman keeps forcing the how questions under each thesis.

DISCUSSED

- The ATCO saga: Ives named chairman on Monday, a 250 million dollar private placement to buy Worldcoin, the stock riding from 145 to 80 to 40 and back up
- Apple's elephant in the room: no AI story until it doubles down on the Gemini partnership, despite a roughly 8.5 out of 10 iPhone cycle
- Hyperscaler capex adding up to 300 to 350 billion dollars, and Nvidia growing revenue 55% year over year at a 4 trillion dollar market cap

- Power as the biggest constraint on the buildout, with his thesis of small nuclear reactors powering data centers
- Palantir as Karp being the Musk of the enterprise: software behind every three-letter agency now moving commercial
- Tesla versus Waymo on autonomy: Waymo's cars costing 200,000 to 230,000 dollars in five cities against Tesla's scale at 30,000 dollars per vehicle
- Second, third and fourth derivative plays: MongoDB, Snowflake, GE Vernova, Nebius, and Spotify in his top 30 as a consumer AI monetization bet

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The AI trade moves in derivatives: once the buildout layer is priced, follow the breadcrumbs to data mining, power and consumer use cases
- Enterprise is where AI spending is today; the consumer wave is the next leg, which is how names like Spotify sneak into an AI list
- Scale is the autonomy argument: whoever produces millions of cheap autonomous vehicles owns the market and everyone else pays rent
- Ives got vicious institutional email for his early Palantir call, a reminder that the most profitable calls often draw the most abuse first

Eisman opens by contrasting their outfits, his stayed sport jacket against the tech analyst's Wild West look, then congratulates Ives on the ATCO chairmanship mid-episode.

U.S. Consumers Are Collapsing: Cars, Credit, & the Chaos Ahead | The Weekly Wrap

2025-10-03 | WEEKLY WRAP | 38 MIN | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

A wrap with a returning guest: Lakshmi Ganapathi of Unicus Research lays out the case that the prime consumer was a stimulus-era illusion now unwinding through auto loans and credit cards. Eisman frames it with his math showing the US economy barely grows once AI capex is stripped out.

DISCUSSED

- The government shutdown that the market completely ignored, with the S&P and Nasdaq at all-time highs
- His GDP arithmetic: 29.18 trillion in 2024, 1.8% expected growth of about 530 billion, against roughly 400 billion of AI infrastructure spend, leaving under 50 basis points of growth for everything else
- Stimulus checks inflating credit scores so subprime borrowers looked prime, meaning ABS pools labeled prime hold effectively subprime auto loans
- The used car market bifurcating: only older cars under about 10,000 dollars moving, with dealers and banks modifying loans to avoid taking losses
- Credit card debt up roughly 50% from third quarter 2020, about 400 billion dollars of additional balances, while issuers cut credit lines as student loan defaults drop scores 100 to 200 points
- Her warnings on meme stock Opendoor, and the abuse she gets from retail holders for making them

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A credit score is a snapshot, not a truth. Government transfers can make a borrower look prime long enough to get a loan he cannot service
- Watch what securitization data says about the consumer monthly; it leads the official statistics
- When the only used cars that move cost under 10,000 dollars, the consumer is telling you something the headline GDP number is not
- Retail investors trusting a famous fund manager's endorsement is not diligence; her Opendoor warnings are aimed exactly at that reflex

Asked what critics say, she reports being called dumb and accused of shorting Opendoor, then explains compliance bars her from trading her own calls at all.

Inside the AI Chip War: From Nvidia’s Dominance to Intel’s Turmoil | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 28

2025-10-06 | DEEP DIVE | 62 MIN | WITH STACY RASGON

Bernstein's semiconductor analyst, 18 years on the beat since three weeks after Bear Stearns failed, walks the whole chip landscape: an AI trade that is ripping while everything else is lackluster. The throughline is that a digestion period is a 100% certainty eventually, just not now, not next year, and maybe not 2027.

DISCUSSED

- The Nvidia origin story of this cycle: ChatGPT in November 2022, then the May 2023 earnings call he titled the big bang
- Why a capex digestion phase is inevitable but invisible on the horizon, with Jensen Huang and Broadcom's Hock Tan pointing past 2027
- AMD's data center GPU business at 5 billion dollars from zero, impressive but small against Nvidia's roughly 100 billion, and the bull case of 5% of a claimed 500 billion TAM
- The China argument: export bans forcing Huawei to build purportedly leading-edge chips at SMIC, risking a robust competitor that eventually exports
- Reported proposals for a one-to-one rule pairing every foreign chip purchase with a US-made one, plus possible tariffs on semiconductors inside devices, roughly 500 dollars of chips in a 1,000 dollar smartphone
- Intel's collapse: Gelsinger's build-it-and-they-will-come foundry losing about 13 billion dollars last year, and the outlandish February 2022 target of 120 billion in revenue by 2026
- Why he likes Lip-Bu Tan's underpromise-and-overdeliver approach while refusing to call the turnaround

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Hyperscaler capex has always built and digested in cycles; the question is never whether digestion comes, only when, and betting on the date has been a losing trade for three years
- Reasoning models and agentic AI multiply compute per query, which is the demand-side answer to the digestion worry
- Export controls cut both ways: restricting sales to China forces China to become creative, in every sense of that word
- A TAM speech is not a business. Every internet company promised 2% of a trillion; watch shipped revenue instead
- A CEO who enters a turnaround declaring everything already fixed is telling you the turnaround has not started

On whether Lip-Bu Tan can save Intel: he is doing absolutely the right things, and the honest answer is call me in three or four years.

AI’s Real Life Impact: Inside the Human Cost of the Tech Boom | The Weekly Wrap

2025-10-10 | WEEKLY WRAP | 21 MIN

A mailbag-heavy wrap anchored by a letter from a listener named Max, whose daily experience with clumsy AI tools punctures the euphoric capex narrative. He repeats his tale of two economies math and calls the Fifth Third purchase of Comerica the start of his regional bank M&A wave.

DISCUSSED

- The week's headlines: the AMD deal with OpenAI, gold crossing 4,000 dollars an ounce for the first time, and the government still shut down

- Fifth Third buying Comerica at about 80 dollars, only 10 dollars above its 1998 price, which he reads as the Trump administration encouraging regional bank consolidation
- His estimate that 1.8% GDP growth this year is almost entirely large-cap AI capex, leaving the rest of the economy barely growing
- Max's letter: AI tools that are clumsy, imagine things and create more work, while employees are more or less forced to use them
- Housing advice from the mailbag: illiquid, seven-year or longer cycles, and hidden costs from closing fees to insurance
- Retirement allocation: taking required minimum distributions at 73 and buying treasuries or high-grade corporates rather than selling appreciated index funds and paying roughly 30% capital gains

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The AI capex frenzy must eventually generate strong returns on investment; right now it is so early that anyone can literally say anything
- One frustrated employee's letter is a better check on the euphoric AI narrative than another sell-side report
- Never sell an appreciated asset and pay 30% tax to buy a 6% bond fund; fund bond purchases from money already being forced out, like RMDs
- Match stock sales with equal gains and losses; taxes are the hidden factor that hurts otherwise good decisions

He puts a listener named Max at the center of the episode, working double time to clean up after the AI tools his employer forces on him.

Inside America’s Economic Divide: AI, Tariffs, & The Fed | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 29

2025-10-13 | DEEP DIVE | 55 MIN | WITH STEVE LIESMAN

CNBC's senior economics reporter pushes back on Eisman's framing, insisting the market and the economy are different questions, then works through the K-shaped economy, tariffs and Fed history. The episode ends far from the ticker, in Liesman's stories from 1990s Russia, where nobody understood what a price was.

DISCUSSED

- Eisman's twitch: 1.8% growth on 29.18 trillion of GDP is about 530 billion, roughly matching the 400 billion plus of hyperscaler AI spend, so the economy ex-AI is flat
- Josh Brown's line that the momentum will continue as long as the momentum continues, and the parallel to Henry Blodget, who was right about the internet changing the world and wrong for investors anyway
- Auto loans as the last bill a stressed consumer skips, and why used car weakness therefore matters
- Tariff damage papered over by AI: Orvis closing stores and laying off, fly-fishing importers hit on both the import tariff and metal content
- Greenspan running Fed communication through a single reporter, John Barry, before the FOMC statement arrived around 1994
- His years covering Russia: the US government paying accounting firms millions to write Russia a universal legal code, and oil output reversing a 20-year decline within two years of privatization

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Do not conflate the market and the economy; they are separate pies divided on different logic and different clocks
- A technology can change the world, create dynastic wealth and still lose money for the investors who bought the story at the top, the Blodget lesson

- Watch the payment hierarchy: when the car loan, the bill people pay first, comes under stress, the consumer is genuinely stretched
- Markets are not natural. Liesman's Russia stories show the price mechanism is a learned institution, not an instinct

  The missile factory director asked for 200 million dollars to make rifles; asked how he knew it was a good business, he answered that before the revolution, Russians created great rifles.

The Bank Stock Rout: Separating Facts From Fiction | The Weekly Wrap

2025-10-17 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

Bank earnings kick off the season against a backdrop of tariff whiplash, and he argues the credit scare is a normal cycle, not 2008. The distinction he draws is between visible commercial deterioration and the kind that actually causes a recession.

DISCUSSED

- Trump's Friday threat of 100% tariffs on China sending NASDAQ down 3%, unwound by a Monday Truth Social post saying it will all be fine
- JPMorgan's $170 million loss on the Tricolor fraud bankruptcy, which he calls tiny for a bank that size
- Commercial non-accrual loans up 33% year over year at JPMorgan and 119% at Citi, with no problems at Wells Fargo
- Jamie Dimon's phrase too small to succeed, and why Dodd-Frank and soaring technology costs favour the big banks
- Fifth Third buying Comerica two weeks earlier at around $80 per share
- Progressive as the champion that emerges in a mature industry by passing efficiency to customers as better pricing

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Quarterly reports exist to check the thesis; buy, sell and hold are all three investment decisions, and doing nothing takes as much guts as trading
- Some commercial credit deterioration is normal; real deterioration arrives with the recession, not before it
- Regional and community banks must merge to carry regulatory and technology costs or go the way of the dodo
- In mature industries, reclassified as cyclical or safety sectors, the companies that keep taking share are the ones that convert efficiency into price

  His earnings-season image: industries report like herds in the Sahara, and the banks come first like the gazelles.

The Next Revolution: AI, Advertising, and the Collapse of Old Media

2025-10-20 | DEEP DIVE | 60 MIN | WITH CRAIG MOFFETT, MICHAEL NATHANSON

Two analysts from one of Eisman's favourite research boutiques cover the wreckage of old media: Apple's reprieve in the Google antitrust case, the cable-versus-fiber stalemate, Verizon firing its CEO, and AI ads that may end the agency business. The closing debate is whether AI revenue can ever justify the infrastructure spend.

DISCUSSED

- The Google payments to Apple, $20 billion a year at roughly 100% margin and about 20% of Apple's operating income, ruled illegal and then left intact at the remedy stage
- Why the judge blinked: district judges hate being overturned, and AI's arrival gave him an easy out

- Cable versus fiber as technically interchangeable networks, with bears betting 80% of the country gets overbuilt
- Fiber overbuilds costing roughly $4,000 per connected home, funded by private equity money pouring in
- Verizon firing its CEO and installing board member Dan Schulman, 67, who Eisman says did not do a good job running PayPal
- Meta producing a fully finished TV ad from just a brand logo, with the 15 most effective versions A/B tested by the end of the day
- Paramount under David Ellison, the Bari Weiss hire as a pitch to Washington, and the case for streaming consolidation

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Disruption starts at the bottom, per Clay Christensen: AI ads first empower small brands that could never afford an agency, then the technology climbs
- The AI capex bull case is a company paying nearly the full salary of a $125,000 employee for a bot; the bear case is four competitors driving the bot's price below what the infrastructure needs
- When there is no counterfactual you can dream any dream; the honest position on AI returns is humility
- A regulated industry's structure can be the story: legacy Bell-system norms explain why Verizon reached for a 67-year-old insider

The verdict on who has to justify the entire AI buildout: it is really on Sam Altman's shoulders to prove this makes sense.

The K-Shaped Reality: AI Booms While Housing & Tesla Struggle | The Weekly Wrap

2025-10-24 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

He splits 89 reporting companies into two economies: AI and everything else. The AI side prints spectacular numbers while Tesla, managed care and housing-adjacent names deteriorate, the K-shaped economy in one earnings week.

DISCUSSED

- Apple hitting an all-time high on iPhone 17 sales up about 14% versus the 16, market cap just below $4 trillion
- GE Vernova, the turbine maker feeding AI's insatiable electricity demand, up around 80% this year
- Amphenol's third quarter: sales up 53% in total and 41% organically, EPS up 87% year over year
- Tesla revenue up 6% only because buyers rushed the expiring $7,500 EV credit; net income down 37% to $1.4 billion with zero guidance
- The FICO price war after the FHFA required lenders to accept VantageScore, with the credit bureaus striking back
- Molina reporting $1.84 versus $3.90 expected on exchange medical costs, cutting 2025 guidance by 26%

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A K-shaped economy shows up in earnings before it shows up in macro data: sort the reports into AI and everything else and the split is stark
- Revenue pulled forward by an expiring subsidy is not growth; Musk gave no December-quarter guidance because he could not
- Starting a price war is one thing; starting one against the three companies that supply your competition (the bureaus behind VantageScore) is another
- A safety stock can be turbocharged into a growth stock when its end market explodes, as Amphenol shows

He notes the date: October 24, exactly 96 years after the 1929 crash began, teeing up the Sorkin interview.

Inside the Data Center Boom: Understanding the Massive Infrastructure That Supports AI

2025-10-26 | DEEP DIVE | 60 MIN | WITH NICK DEL DEO

MoffettNathanson's digital infrastructure analyst maps the data center landscape from first principles: who the hyperscalers are, why most of the buildout happens in private markets, and what a GPU is actually worth. Unusually for a coverage universe, most of the space he analyses is not publicly traded at all.

DISCUSSED

- Why only Digital Realty and Equinix remain public: the capital required and years of negative cash flow spooked public shareholders
- A data center defined as a warehouse for computers, with the four hyperscalers being Amazon, Microsoft, Google and Meta
- The REIT problem: paying out cash flow as dividends forces constant trips to the capital markets to fund growth
- Equinix as the connectivity hub, with cloud on-ramps he compares to on-ramps to the Jersey Turnpike
- Bitcoin miners repurposing power-rich, latency-insensitive sites for high performance computing
- GPU economics: CoreWeave depreciates chips over six years, and its OpenAI deal runs five years with two one-year renewals
- Cogent's conversion of the old Sprint network into a wavelengths business against Lumen and Zayo

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Judge an AI infrastructure deal on its unit economics, not on a headline multiple of spend
- Tight power supply is the industry's pricing stick; lifting the constraint helps volumes but pushes returns back toward the cost of capital
- The economic life of a GPU is genuinely unknown, and the most sophisticated buyer signing a five-plus-two year lease is the best evidence available
- Hyperscalers will build in oddball markets that third-party developers avoid, because developers fear the re-leasing risk 10 to 15 years out

When Del Deo mentions Bitcoin miners pivoting to high performance computing, Eisman replies that the sentence was definitely in English but he is not quite sure he understood it.

Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Crash of 1929 & The Parallels We See Today | The Real Eisman Playbook

2025-10-27 | DEEP DIVE | 54 MIN | WITH ANDREW ROSS SORKIN

Sorkin spent eight years in archives, some boxes never indexed, reconstructing 1929 with the room-where-it-happened detail he brought to 2008, except everyone in this book is dead. The conversation keeps circling one theme: elites who believed they ruled the world did not see the paradigm shift coming.

DISCUSSED

- Why he wrote it: Americans have only a vague idea that something very bad happened in 1929
- Stock pools as normalized pump and dump, run by the era's biggest names, who circulated written circulars about it; he compares it to the Davos guest list colluding today
- Jack Morgan knowing he was not his father and installing Thomas Lamont, a former journalist, as the real power behind the scenes
- Ferdinand Pecora, the little-known lawyer from Queens on $250 a week, whose hearings shamed the uber-WASPs though nobody went to jail
- The Fed of 1929 seeing too much speculation but fearing for its own existence if it raised rates, then failing to flood the system with liquidity in 1930 to 1933

- Eisman's own 2008 mistake: assuming the government knew how bad it was, disproved by the scene where officials learn AIG is in trouble and have no idea

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The crash formula is credit plus leverage plus FOMO, and the policy failure is hesitating on the front end and withholding liquidity on the back end
- The hardest thing a person lives through is a paradigm shift; masters-of-the-universe confidence is precisely what blinds them
- Never assume the authorities have read the research; in both 1929 and 2008 the people in charge understood less than the market's analysts
- Humility can be strategy: Jack Morgan's genius was knowing he needed someone else to play his father's role

Eisman's framing: Too Big to Fail was Lord of the Rings, and Sorkin has now written the prequel, in the wrong order, so he never has to write a sequel.

The AI Boom Rolls On: AI Partnerships Pay Off as Stocks Soar & Meta, Google & Microsoft Go All-In

2025-10-31 | DEEP DIVE | 22 MIN

A Halloween wrap where every AI partnership announcement makes a stock soar and the big three all raise capex, yet the market punishes Meta and rewards Google for the same behaviour. His explanation is return on invested capital: cloud businesses earn on AI spending now, Meta has to build products first.

DISCUSSED

- The US-China agreement landing as only a one-year truce after markets hit all-time highs on the outline of a deal
- The Fed's second 25 basis point cut, with Powell warning a December cut may not happen
- Nvidia reaching $5 trillion in market cap while Apple and Microsoft breach $4 trillion; Europe's largest stock is not even at $500 billion
- The announcement effect: PayPal as a ChatGPT payment engine, Nvidia's $1 billion Nokia stake for 6G, and Qualcomm's Humain deal, where he flags Humain hedging across Nvidia, AMD and Qualcomm
- 2025 capex: Meta in the low $70 billions, Microsoft $80 billion, Google above $90 billion; all three beat, yet Meta fell 7% and Microsoft 4% while Google rose 7%
- Fiserv down over 40% in a day after new management said the company had been masking its problems
- UnitedHealth's Optum Health margin at 1% versus 8.3% a year ago, and Eli Lilly's $7.02 against a $5.69 estimate

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Identical capex headlines get opposite receptions because ROIC differs: cloud AI spending generates revenue today, product-building AI spending is a promise
- In a mania, any partnership announcement is greeted with joy, but read the capacity numbers; the details still matter
- Payments is a dangerous space because things change fast, and a company can mask deterioration for years before it surfaces all at once
- Peacock today, feather duster tomorrow: Chipotle shows how quickly the hottest stock in a sector loses the crown

His offer to the market: if anyone is listening, he is happy to become the spokesperson for anyone in AI, maybe his stock will soar.

Inside the Cannabis Comeback: How One Company is Beating a Broken Market | The Real Eisman Playbook

2025-11-03 | DEEP DIVE | 49 MIN | WITH KYLE KAZAN, MARK VENDETTI, GRAHAM FARRAR, JOHN DORSEY

A first for the show: interviewing company management, Glass House Brands, a sub-billion-dollar California cannabis grower that actually makes money in an industry left for dead. Eisman discloses he is a recent shareholder and frames the position as speculative, prompted by Trump's Truth Social posts on cannabis.

DISCUSSED

- The setup: the 2018 boom priced in Biden-era legalization that never came, leaving the sector starved and oversupplied
- Second quarter profitability: 53% gross margin, roughly 18% EBITDA margin, and normalized returns on equity in the mid to high teens
- Production costs around $100 per unit in California, the lowest-price and most competitive market in the country
- The ICE raid on their farm and hiring Julie Myers Wood, the former Bush-era ICE director, to make the workforce audit-proof
- Federal Schedule I status and what rescheduling would change
- Trump's two Truth Social posts on medical cannabis and his public support for Florida's Amendment 3 adult-use measure, against DeSantis
- The asset: about 165 acres with 120 acres of greenhouse, only two of five greenhouses productive so far, and export prices five to six times California's

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Look at sectors everyone has abandoned when the political weather shifts; Eisman's model is FanDuel and DraftKings before sports betting normalized
- Winning in the most competitive, lowest-priced market is transferable; the inverse is not, like training at altitude
- In a broken industry the survivor is the cost leader, not the best story
- Management quality shows in crisis response: their answer to an ICE raid was to hire the former ICE director and invite scrutiny

Farrar's line on expansion once other markets open: it is going to be like throwing a knife into a pillow.

Cracks Beneath the AI Boom: Is the U.S. Economy Heading For a Downturn? | The Weekly Wrap

2025-11-09 | WEEKLY WRAP | 28 MIN

With the government shutdown blacking out official statistics, private data points to a cooling labour market and the K-shaped economy sharpens: the top 10% of households drive nearly half of consumer spending. He argues that makes the economy unusually exposed to a stock market correction.

DISCUSSED

- The Challenger report showing the most announced October job cuts in over 20 years, sending stocks down and bonds up on Thursday
- Cap-weighted indices masking narrowness: the S&P 500 up roughly 16% and NASDAQ up about 23%, flattered by the largest names
- The Mamdani effect on New York property: SL Green already down 25% this year and talk of Wall Street firms eyeing Dallas
- Arista growing EPS 25% and still falling, because in-line guidance is not enough at over 40 times 2026 earnings

- Apollo beating on revenue and earnings yet down about 20% this year on private credit worries after Tricolor and First Brands
- FICO guiding fiscal 2026 to $38.17 against a $39.19 consensus after raising score prices from $5 toward $10, with the FHFA pushing an alternative

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When official data goes dark, markets trade on single private data points, which amplifies volatility
- Concentrated consumer spending means the wealth effect runs in reverse: a big market correction could take the whole economy with it
- At 40 times forward earnings, beating estimates is table stakes; only raised guidance keeps the stock up
- A monopolist that raises prices too far invites both customer revolt and its regulator to sponsor a competitor, which is how FICO got greedy

He closes with a financial literacy explainer of the money multiplier, walking a $100,000 deposit through the banking system: it sounds like magic, but that is how we want it to work.

The Private Credit Panic: Why Wall Street's Big Winners are Now Losing | Real Eisman Playbook Ep 33

2025-11-10 | DEEP DIVE | 62 MIN | WITH GLENN SCHORR

Evercore's Glenn Schorr, who covers what Eisman calls the good, the bad and the ugly of finance, explains why the alternative asset managers are having a terrible year in a bull market. The core puzzle: secular growth stories keep raising record money while their stocks fall, and either the tight high-yield market or the falling manager stocks has to be wrong.

DISCUSSED

- Blackstone down 15%, Apollo down 25%, KKR down 21% and Blue Owl down 33% in 2025 despite record fundraising
- The contradiction of Goldman at $800 and tightening high-yield spreads while private credit stocks get shot
- Private equity mechanics: seven to ten year fund lives and a good outcome of 2 to 2.5 times invested capital
- Why Apollo takes the credit-fear beating: roughly half its balance sheet is its own insurance book
- Praise for Jane Fraser breaking eggs at Citi after 15 years of mess, exiting hobbies and 2%-share consumer markets
- Tokenization, which Eisman says not one in two million people can explain in plain English
- The decline of traditional asset managers: more mutual funds than stocks, then index funds and ETFs at 5 to 15 basis points

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Technology eventually comes for every industry; for asset management it arrived as the index fund and the ETF
- When two markets price the same risk differently, one of them has to give; watch the disagreement, not either signal alone
- Traditional managers got fat and happy in the hay days and let the alternatives build private markets uncontested; not one invested in it
- A back book of legacy products can drag on a firm for a decade even while new businesses hum

On what Goldman would be had it skipped consumer and just raised funds 10 years ago: don't shoot me David if you're watching this, but we'd call them Morgan Stanley.

The Shutdown Ends, Burry's New AI Warning & Disney Stumbles | The Weekly Wrap

2025-11-14 | WEEKLY WRAP | 19 MIN

Eisman opens by telling newer viewers about his breast cancer diagnosis and chemotherapy, then walks through the end of the shutdown and takes on Michael Burry's depreciation argument. The through line is that in this tape, high-flyers cannot disappoint on any metric, actual or perceived.

DISCUSSED

- Eight Democratic senators crossing over on Monday to end the shutdown, with funding only through January 20
- Burry's claim that stretched depreciation schedules will overstate Meta's earnings by 21% and Oracle's by 27% by 2028
- Fitch data showing more subprime borrowers at least 60 days delinquent, another sign of the strained low-end consumer
- CoreWeave's Q3 revenue of roughly 1.44 billion, up 134%, against a consensus of no profits until 2027 and a 47 times 2027 PE
- Paramount's 17 billion market cap versus Netflix at 475 billion, with the Warner Brothers dance ongoing
- A hot stablecoin name at roughly 70 times 2026 earnings, where the real question is who wins dominant market share

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Even granting Burry's math, a depreciation argument does not change cash flows; the debate is about the quality of reported earnings, not solvency
- At 47 times earnings two years out, a company cannot disappoint in any way; the multiple prices in perfection
- David and Goliath can fully swap places in an industry; Paramount versus Netflix proves scale advantages migrate
- In payments and stablecoins, market share, not this quarter's numbers, decides who deserves the multiple

He announces mid-chemotherapy hair loss, says he is starting to wear a hat, and moves on to the shutdown in the same breath.

Inside Publishing's Big Shakeup: AI, TikTok & the Battle Ahead | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 34

2025-11-17 | DEEP DIVE | 62 MIN | WITH REGINA BROOKS, JENNIFER WEISS, ANTHONY ZICCARDI

An episode born from a conversation with his wife Valerie: two literary agents and a publisher on how book publishing changed over 20 years and what AI does next. The verdict is that the platform now precedes the book, and publishing is recalibrating the way music already has.

DISCUSSED

- Why a nonfiction author now needs social media numbers before a deal, even the world's leading expert on an important topic
- Romantasy readers driving deluxe print editions with etched end papers and maps after starting in self-published ebooks
- Hybrid publishing's 70/30 profit split versus the traditional 10 to 12% royalty on cover price
- Eisman's ChatGPT test: essays on morality in the voices of Alasdair MacIntyre and Richard Posner, produced in 30 seconds
- No decade-scale cultural phenomenon in publishing in five years, nothing like Oprah's club or Harry Potter
- Agents as fiduciaries weighing a modest advance against a real marketing commitment

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Distribution flipped: audiences are built first and monetized through books, the reverse of the old order
- Publishing is tracking the music industry, where content margins collapsed and the money moved to community and events around the person
- AI raises the bar rather than abolishing it; plot, pacing and characterization arriving together is the concert that is hard to mimic
- People increasingly buy books because of the author, not the content; the individual is the brand

The ChatGPT essays blew him out of the water: work that would have taken him a month of rereading arrived in 30 seconds, and he calls them excellent.

NVIDIA'S Explosive Growth Can't Hide the Market's AI Panic | The Weekly Wrap

2025-11-21 | WEEKLY WRAP | 24 MIN

Nvidia posts accelerating 62% revenue growth at a 4.4 trillion market cap and the market still cannot hold its nerve. Eisman spends the week on why great numbers no longer calm an AI-anxious tape, leaning on Niall Ferguson's railroad analogy.

DISCUSSED

- Nvidia's EPS of $1.30 versus $1.25 expected and revenue of 57 billion, up 62% versus last year and accelerating from 56%, all without China
- Emotional trading: corrections Monday and Tuesday, a Wednesday rally, then a fade after the after-hours pop
- Ferguson's parallel to the railroad crashes of 1873 and 1893, when overlapping lines competed returns away
- Target down 4% on EPS with a new CEO refusing to say when sales turn, the stock down 39% this year
- Tricolor, then First Brands, and now another credit blowup in the sequence he is tracking
- A mailbag question from his high school classmate Mark on whether 2 and 20 is fair or sustainable
- His FrontPoint years, 2004 to 2011, investing in Indian banks and real estate

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The railroad pitfalls map to AI: it may prove an upgrade of Google rather than a miracle, and overlapping LLMs may compete returns down
- When the largest company on earth accelerates growth and the market still sells off, the anxiety is about the cycle, not the company
- Two and twenty creates asymmetric incentives; the manager shares the upside and bears none of the downside
- Emerging-market bull runs with insane IPO multiples read the same in every country; he made and lost money in India and learned humility

Nvidia sang an operatic aria whose music the market at first seemed to really enjoy, and then the anxiety returned anyway.

Why It's So Difficult For Companies to Go Public: A CFO Explains the Process | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 35

2025-11-24 | DEEP DIVE | 50 MIN | WITH AMY BUTTE

Amy Butte, CFO of newly public travel platform Navan and CFO of the New York Stock Exchange for its 2006 IPO, dismantles the idea that going public is hire some bankers, bing bang boom. The real work is building financial processes reliable enough to repeat without mistakes, and it takes years.

DISCUSSED

- Becoming NYSE CFO in January 2004 and getting the IPO done in March 2006, a two-year rebuild
- Her admission that the Exchange's financial process was a plug, which is what auditors actually care about
- The four things going public buys: a branding event, forced maturation, easier capital access and acquisition currency
- Taxes as golf putting: a third of your score, and nobody practices it until it hurts
- Navan's claim of running on less than a tenth of the customer support staffing of an Amex GBT, thanks to AI
- The roadshow from the other side: portfolio managers mapping the company onto their own investment thesis
- Hiring smart non-coders to build on Navan's AI framework for its next-generation product, Edge

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Auditors care about one thing: do you have a process that produces reliable numbers over and over without mistakes
- Not every company needs every benefit of being public; NYSE needed maturation and currency, not branding
- IPO pricing is a matching problem; the question is how the story fits each buyer's existing thesis, not whether the story is good
- AI-era operating leverage shows up first in support headcount ratios, not in the product itself

The sign-off: Eisman wishes her luck with the company, and Butte answers with best of luck to you and your health.

Google Surges Past OpenAI and AI Faces a Bigger Crisis That Could Break the Boom | The Weekly Wrap

2025-11-28 | WEEKLY WRAP | 24 MIN

A Thanksgiving-week rally erases the prior week's AI correction while the competitive ground shifts under OpenAI. Eisman introduces his binding constraint framework, borrowed from bank stress tests, and argues the constraint on AI is electric power.

DISCUSSED

- The market recovering last week's 2% to 3% losses on dovish Fed governor comments, back near all-time highs
- Dell's quarter: EPS up 17%, revenue up 11% but a slight miss, and a 31.5 billion Q4 sales guide versus 27.6 billion expected
- Gemini 3 leapfrogging ChatGPT, with Sam Altman's memo admitting we have some work to do and expecting rough vibes
- The binding constraint concept from the Fed's annual bank stress test, transplanted to AI
- Texas power math: proposed projects equal to consumption of over 150 million homes on an ERCOT grid serving 30 million
- A European viewer's twice-rejected permit application for a simple consumer product, with a 30-page business plan

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Every industry has a binding constraint that governs everything else; for banks it is stress-test capital, for AI it is power
- The second railroad catches up: OpenAI's lead looked structural until Gemini 3, and perceived moats in AI are measured in months

- Novel power solutions, nuclear included, are becoming part of the AI investment case rather than a footnote
- Europe's sclerosis is procedural; no one says no, they just never say yes, and capital goes elsewhere

His correction of the week: the US produces roughly 4,200 terawatt hours, not terawatts, and he stands corrected.

Steve Eisman Reflects on 2008, The Big Short & Today's K-Shaped Economy | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 36

2025-12-01 | DEEP DIVE | 74 MIN | WITH IVY ZELMAN

A recorded October 29 event at Case Western Reserve University, hosted by housing analyst Ivy Zelman, where Eisman retells the financial crisis for a hundred students and fields their questions on today's market. The crisis story he tells is a debt story, not an equity story, ending in what he calls the biggest fraud in human history.

DISCUSSED

- His path from Harvard Law and a federal clerkship to Wall Street
- Credit default swaps tying bank balance sheets into a spiderweb, and AIG's roughly 50 to 70 billion of swaps sold to the street
- Underwriting standards loosening from 2002 until the 2006 standard was can you breathe
- Zelman blaming Greenspan's 2004 endorsement of ARMs for the option-ARM and negative-am era
- Citigroup levered about 35 to 1 pre-crisis versus about 10 to 1 now, which he calls the distance from Pluto to the sun
- Silicon Valley Bank as a rates and business-model failure, not a capital problem
- A student pressing him on AI driving roughly half of GDP growth, which he thinks understates it

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The crisis lived on the debt side of planet Earth; equity investors watching stocks missed where the risk sat
- When results keep beating expectations year after year, standards loosen; prosperity itself degrades underwriting
- Bank leverage, not bank size, is the systemic variable, and on that measure today's banks are basically safe
- He no longer considers housing an investment; matching inflation is the best case
- Sell-side rewards writing and speaking; buy-side is a quieter skill of just picking stocks and making money

His sole contribution to The Big Short: overruling his wife's pleading to tell Adam McKay the cab line should be schmuck, not asshole. Schmuck is in the movie.

The Housing Market is Broken: Why Homes Are Unaffordable & What It Takes to Fix It | The Weekly Wrap

2025-12-05 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

After dismissing the Fed-cut rally as tinkering, Eisman devotes the wrap to housing: affordability is the most stretched in decades and nothing that fails to attack local supply rules deserves to be taken seriously. He closes with a primer on active ETFs versus mutual funds.

DISCUSSED

- The S&P 500 up 3.7% and Nasdaq up 4.9% in the holiday week, recovering the AI correction as Fed governors bless a December cut
- Bitcoin down from 125,000 in late September, barely participating in the equity rally

- Salesforce's mixed quarter under the AI Grim Reaper, rescued by better Q4 revenue guidance for a 4% Thursday pop
- Public builders' share of new homes at about 50%, double the 25% of 2001
- Entry-level buyers needing 60% of income for the monthly payment, worse than before the financial crisis and beaten only by the late 1970s
- Property taxes and insurance rising from 5% to 7% of income since 2000
- His fix list: cut local regulation, impact fees and permit times, allow smaller homes, and have Washington threaten state and local funding

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A 25 basis point cut here and there is tinkering; the market cares, but in the long run it does not matter
- Housing affordability is a local supply problem; federal gestures that skip zoning and permitting cannot begin to solve it
- America still builds homes one at a time on site while Sweden builds in factories; the production model itself is antique
- All else equal the actively managed ETF beats the mutual fund on taxes, disclosure and cost, but stock picking trumps structure

His test for any housing plan: until the federal government threatens to cut off state and local funds over supply rules, the problem is not even beginning to be dealt with.

Inside the Industrial Comeback & AI’s Power Crisis with Nigel Coe | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 37

2025-12-08 | DEEP DIVE | 47 MIN | WITH NIGEL COE

Wolfe Research's industrials analyst maps a sector split in two: pockets of fast growth wherever a company touches the data center, and no growth anywhere else. The conversation lands on power as the binding constraint on AI, with data centers migrating to wherever they can plug in.

DISCUSSED

- His coverage as the successor companies of the old GE and ITT conglomerates: aerospace and defense, electrical equipment, HVAC, industrial automation
- Eaton lagging because legacy businesses drag; its class eight truck units down roughly mid-teens this year
- Honeywell breaking up after Elliott Management pushed to spin out aerospace, its biggest division
- Data centers built by 2028 that may not get plugged in, so siting shifts to Texas and the Midwest where power exists
- Gas turbines, the large ones producing 400 megawatts, back in demand after the market was left for dead in the renewables shift
- 3M as a classic CEO-change margin story under Bill Brown after years of PFAS liabilities
- The ISM Index sub-50 for three years, now about 48; his housing-inflection picks are Lennox International and Stanley Black & Decker

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The best industrial stories of his career have been CEO-change margin-improvement stories, not end-market calls
- Flexibility beats consistency: his most impactful sell at 250 became one of his better buys after upgrading around 90
- Short cycle industrials have been stagnant for three years; the 2026 question is whether investors will pay up for cyclicality before the Fed eases

- After stocks run 100% to 300%, the question shifts from the story to how much more multiple expansion is possible

Eisman's compressed version of the power problem: they'll get this stuff built by 2028, the question is whether they can plug it in.

Netflix & Paramount’s WBD Fight Heats Up + Oracle Falls as AI Doubts Grow | The Weekly Wrap

2025-12-12 | WEEKLY WRAP | 24 MIN

Oracle disappoints and the Warner Brothers fight turns hostile, and Eisman uses both to sketch the emerging risks to the AI trade. His bet on the media brawl: the odds favor Paramount, and Netflix shareholders should be nervous.

DISCUSSED

- The Fed cutting 25 basis points on a 10 to 3 vote, with Powell signaling future cuts will be tougher and his chairmanship ending
- Oracle at the center of the AI debate because, unlike Google, it cannot fund AI demand from cash flow
- Netflix's announced purchase of Warner Brothers, and Jeff Bewkes's 2010 Albanian army dismissal of Netflix
- Paramount's higher hostile bid, backstopped by a syndicate including Jared Kushner's private equity firm
- One commentator's estimate that big tech needs 2 trillion in AI revenue by 2030 to justify the capex
- 2025 GDP growth of about 2% coming almost entirely from hyperscaler AI capex
- Home Depot guiding 2026 EPS growth of 0 to 4% against expectations of 5%

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Warner Brothers has been bought and sold many times and only the executives ever benefited; culture, not price, is the risk in this deal
- The longer a regulatory delay runs, the more management gets distracted, which itself changes the odds
- If scaling ever-larger models loses efficacy, hyperscalers slow chip purchases and the whole virtuous cycle reverses
- Strip hyperscaler capex out of 2025 and there is no GDP growth at all, which is how much the economy leans on one trade

A listener named Sebastian, a software engineer, reports he can no longer conceive of doing his job without AI, and that the senior engineers are the most eager adopters.

Steve Eisman's Masterclass on the 2008 Financial Crisis (Part One) | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 38

2025-12-16 | MASTERCLASS | 44 MIN

Part one of a two-part lecture on the financial crisis, covering the first two of four interlocking causes: too much leverage and the subprime blowup. Eisman builds it from first principles, starting with why a bank cannot function without leverage, then narrates his own short from the inside.

DISCUSSED

- The four causes: leverage, a large asset class blowing up, systemic institutions owning it, and derivatives tying balance sheets together
- The bank thought experiment: 1 billion in equity, a 1% ROA, and why ROE equals ROA times leverage
- Subprime's history from the first pure-play IPO in 1992 (the Money Store, Aames Financial) through 20 billion of loans in 1993
- By 2006, roughly 600 billion in annual volume, about 20% of the US mortgage market, on collapsed underwriting

- Monthly securitization data from the ratings agencies as the tool that let him watch credit deteriorate in real time
- Why he shorted securitizations rather than stocks: borrow cost on names like New Century ran as high as 20% a year
- The March and April 2007 head fake, when tax refunds made credit data look temporarily better

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Banks are the one business where the cost of goods sold, loan losses, is unknown at the point of sale
- Leverage is like the porridge in Goldilocks: too little and banks cannot recycle deposits, too much and the system breaks
- An entire generation of bank CEOs mistook leverage for genius; a $50 million paycheck is proof against self-doubt
- Knowing the seasonal pattern in consumer credit let him add to shorts into the 2007 rally instead of covering
- Once the buyer strike hit, the chain was mechanical: no securitization sales, no loan purchases, no refinancing, soaring defaults

He ends on a deliberate cliffhanger: by late summer 2007 the crisis was already inevitable, and the reason why is part two.

Steve Eisman's 2025 Wrap Up: 4 Themes Defining the Market Today | The Weekly Wrap

2025-12-19 | WEEKLY WRAP | 31 MIN

The year-end review: an S&P up 16% and NASDAQ up 20%, a 19% tariff drawdown, and a 37% rally off the April bottom. He organizes the whole year around four themes and then reads them out of the performance of all 11 S&P sectors.

DISCUSSED

- The timeline: up about 1% by February 19, Liberation Day tariffs April 2, down 19% through April 8, then the AI-led recovery
- The four themes: the K-shaped economy, AI revolution or bubble, private credit fears, and consumer affordability
- Nvidia's third quarter revenue growing more than 60% as the one number that settles whether AI demand is real
- Power as the structural constraint on AI growth, with LLM scaling doubts as the intellectual one
- Tricolor and First Brands as private credit warnings even though neither loan originated in private credit
- GE Vernova up over 100% on gas turbines while housing-tied Carrier fell 22%
- Staples up only 2%, with Clorox, Campbell, and Kimberly Clark down 36%, 32%, and 28%

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Unlike subprime, where monthly securitization data let anyone watch credit rot, private credit offers no data, so no firm conclusion is possible
- Defensive stocks did not just lag the AI story; tariffs squeezed margins while consumers pulled back, a double hit
- A sector table tells the theme story better than the index: the same AI trade explains both the winners and the losers
- Cash can work for you without risk, his closing point for retail investors after a euphoric year

Steve Eisman's Masterclass on the 2008 Financial Crisis (Part Two) | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 39

2025-12-23 | MASTERCLASS | 43 MIN

Part two covers the final causes, Wall Street's own subprime holdings and credit default swaps, then runs from the September 2008 collapse through Dodd-Frank, Silicon Valley Bank, and his predictions for the Trump-era regulatory turn. The ending is a reversal: the man who shorted the banks now argues for a bank merger wave.

DISCUSSED

- Why Wall Street kept the excess paper: 600 billion of annual origination produced more securitizations than investors could absorb, so firms bought their own AAA product
- Credit default swaps explained through a GE example, and AIG having sold about 80 billion of CDS when it hit trouble
- The September 2008 sequence: Fannie and Freddie seized September 7, Lehman down September 14, Bank of America taking Merrill, AIG two days later
- Clayton Mortgage checking roughly 10% samples of loan files, about 500 files per billion-dollar pool, as underwriting went to hell
- Dodd-Frank creating the vice chair of financial supervision, the first head bank regulator the US ever had
- Silicon Valley Bank as a mark-to-market and concentrated-deposit failure, not a capital failure, and regulators fighting the last war anyway
- JP Morgan's deposit share rising from 7.4% in 2008 to over 12% as compliance and technology costs made the big bigger

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Incentives trump ethics every time; securitization heads knew the loans would blow up and planned to buy the paper back for pennies
- Every crisis in history combines leverage, a blown-up asset class, and concentrated ownership; derivatives were 2008's only genuinely new ingredient
- Unrealized bond losses hide in book value until the bonds are sold, which is exactly the accounting that let SVB's problem build
- Regulation aimed at safety concentrated the industry: only large banks can afford compliance and technology, so deposits migrate to them
- He has changed his mind: the system now needs many bank mergers so more banks can afford the technology arms race

On the securitization bankers who said the loans were legal: after these meetings, I felt like I needed to take a shower.

Steve Eisman Reacts to Scenes From The Big Short

2026-01-02 | DEEP DIVE | 35 MIN

Eisman walks through the scenes of The Big Short one by one and separates what happened from what the screenwriters invented. The film gets the emotional truth right even where it invents dialogue, and he ends by conceding that the angriest version of himself on screen was the accurate one.

DISCUSSED

- Mark Baum being Eisman with the name changed, Ryan Gosling's Jared Vennett being Greg Lippmann of Deutsche Bank, and Vincent Daniel, Porter Collins and Danny Moses keeping their real names
- His single contribution to the script, telling Adam McKay that he would have said schmuck rather than a harsher word, which made the final cut without a credit
- The taxi argument with his wife never happening, but capturing the real anxiety of shorting the entire US housing market while Wall Street called them lunatics

- The Las Vegas securitization conference in January 2007 with roughly 5,000 people at the Venetian, where they met everyone to test whether they were wrong
- Credit default swap pricing being quoted by the dealer rather than shown on a screen, which he calls corrupt, and why subprime bond prices rose while defaults soared
- Morgan Stanley's internal hedge fund being long the paper and taking a write-off of at least 10 billion in the fall of 2007, one year ahead of the general collapse
- The 2015 release of his Financial Crisis Inquiry Commission interview transcript, which changed his own verdict on Steve Carell's portrayal

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Go meet the other side of your trade before you size it up. The Vegas trip was a search for disconfirming evidence, and it came back showing the consensus was delusional
- A market where the dealer quotes the price and no screen contradicts him is not a market you can trust to mark your position honestly
- Prices can move against the fundamentals for a long time. Defaults were spiking while the bonds went up, and the position had to survive that gap
- When an institution is on the other side using its own capital, that is information. Morgan Stanley's write-off pre-announced the crisis a year early
- Memory sands down conviction. His own contemporaneous transcript was angrier than his recollection of himself

He closes on the same note the film does, that ordinary people pay for Wall Street's mistakes, and says being proved right about it makes him sad rather than superior.

2026 Predictions with Dan Ives and Chris Verrone | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 40

2026-01-05 | DEEP DIVE | 67 MIN | WITH DAN IVES, CHRIS VERRONE

The resident bull and the market strategist review the whiplash of 2025 and set up 2026. Verrone's discipline anchors it: as long as banks are working and credit is calm, the trend is up, whatever the narrative of the month says.

DISCUSSED

- The 2025 narrative churn: DeepSeek in January, tariffs in April, ChatGPT eating Google's lunch, then Google eating everyone's
- Verrone's sentiment composite hitting the second percentile after Liberation Day, then a 25% three-month rally nobody believed
- Eaton flat since roughly April 2024 as investors sort real AI plays from companies that just say AI on calls
- The memory super cycle: Samsung and SK Hynix as the trade Asian investors already own
- Housing at a decision point, with D.R. Horton sitting on critical support and needing to turn up now if 2026 is the year
- Bank of America at 55, with Verrone calling 75 a conservative target and defending Brian Moynihan's record
- Private credit growing from 2 trillion in 2020 to 3 trillion today, with First Brands and Tricolor as public-credit canaries

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Watch banks and credit, not narratives; both stayed calm through every 2025 panic and the trend never actually broke
- Saying AI 30 times on a conference call does not make you an AI play; the market is now separating winners from pretenders

- Valuation-centric investors have had to rewrite their resumes repeatedly for missing Mag Seven names, the argument for trend-following in transformational stories
- If housing stocks are going to work in 2026, they must move before the fundamentals confirm, because they are anticipatory
- The consensus risk list for 2026: power constraints, LLM scaling doubts, and a 10-year yield move back toward 4.5% that would spook speculative names

Eisman accepts the bull case with two exceptions he keeps repeating: energy always takes longer than people think, and the LLM scaling question is the serious one.

5 Long-Term Themes You Need to Understand For 2026 | The Weekly Wrap

2026-01-09 | WEEKLY WRAP | 27 MIN

With earnings season a week away, he zooms out to five structural themes that explain how the market itself has changed, all downstream of one fact: tech dominance. The history of S&P sector weights becomes an argument about why the consumer no longer moves the index.

DISCUSSED

- The US taking Maduro and his wife out of Venezuela, arraigned in New York federal court, and the market treating it as a non-event
- 2025 closing with the S&P up 16% and NASDAQ up 21%
- Info tech at 35% of the S&P, versus 28% at the end of 2020 and 21% at the end of 2015
- The 2018 defanging: Facebook, Apple, Amazon, Netflix, and Google reshuffled and the communication services sector created
- Embedded unrealized tax gains in tech as a force that overrides almost every sell decision, retail and institutional alike
- A listener question on PayPal: from a COVID-era high of 289 in August 2021 to 58 at the end of 2025, an 80% decline
- The coming week: bank earnings start, plus an interview with Warris Bokhari of Claimable on health insurance denials

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The consumer drives 70% of the economy but no longer reliably moves the market; tech does, and the two facts coexist
- Embedded tax gains create structural buy-and-hold pressure: nobody sells winners unless the rug is truly pulled
- Beating a 35%-tech index year after year is structurally hard for any manager who will not concentrate the same way
- A stock that soared because of a temporary regime, like payments during COVID, can fall 80% without ever being a scandal

The Broken US Healthcare System is Failing Millions of Americans with Warris Bokhari | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 41

2026-01-12 | DEEP DIVE | 80 MIN | WITH WARRIS BOKHARI

No stocks this week. A British-trained ICU doctor turned Anthem executive, now CEO of Claimable, walks Eisman through why American health insurance denies care, why providers cannot fight back, and why he built a company to appeal denials. Eisman frames it with the Mangione trial: the murder was wrong, and the system is still broken.

DISCUSSED

- Bokhari's route: son of two disabled parents in England, anesthesia and ICU training, then biotech, GE, Apple, Anthem, and Amazon
- The four-part system, commercial insurance, Medicare, Medicaid, and the ACA, and why all four have problems
- Defining deviancy down: mass claim denial, once the villainy of the movie The Rainmaker, now standard practice most patients never appeal
- Sutter Health as the consolidation case study: buy the regional practices, promise nothing changes, then raise prices on a captive network
- ACA-era rules that barred doctors from owning hospitals and enriched PBMs, entrenching the corporate side of medicine
- Bokhari's own CVS denial of an asthma medication he has taken since 2007, answered with an angry letter to CEO David Joiner
- Elizabeth Potter, the Austin breast surgeon called out of surgery by UnitedHealth to be told her patient was denied
- Hospitals running 1.5% to 3.5% margins while EMTALA, signed by Reagan, forces them to eat the cost of the uninsured

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Denial economics depend on inertia: most people never appeal, so denying everything is profitable even when appeals usually win
- Consolidation is the system's survival strategy on both sides; monopoly hospital systems and vertically integrated insurers price against each other and the patient pays
- Regulation intended to expand coverage handed structural advantages to insurers and PBMs by prohibiting provider ownership of hospitals
- A denial overturned in a day can still be a catastrophe; the patient whose vision never came back won her appeal

Bokhari closes with his medical school professor's eulogy: he did not try to make the world perfect, he tried to make his corner of it a little more perfect.

Why Bank Earnings Are Essential to Understanding the Market in 2026 | The Weekly Wrap

2026-01-16 | WEEKLY WRAP | 27 MIN

Prompted by viewer questions, he pulls back the camera and ties the four themes of 2025 to the five structural themes of 2026 in one framework, then grades the first week of bank earnings. The verdict: fundamentals fine, credit benign, valuations at their ceiling.

DISCUSSED

- The four 2025 themes: the K-shaped economy, AI revolution or bubble, private credit fears, and affordability
- The five structural themes, from tech dominance to index funds taking 60% of equity flows
- The Justice Department opening a criminal investigation into Fed Chairman Powell, which the market read as an attack on Fed independence
- JPMorgan revenue up 7% with stable credit in both commercial and consumer; investment banking fees down 4% on M&A deals slipping into 2026
- No signs of credit deterioration in any category across the reporting banks
- Goldman near three times tangible book versus 1.3 times two years ago, levels last seen before the financial crisis
- Citi valued above tangible book even though its return on tangible common equity never reaches 10%

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Higher return on tangible common equity earns a higher price to tangible book, but bank valuations move within a range, and the range is now at peak
- With 60% of flows passive, index funds buy their holdings automatically; when a recession or an AI capex slowdown comes, the same machinery will make the correction fast and furious
- The stock market has become unmoored from everyday life; 70% of GDP is consumer driven, yet consumer stocks move the market less every year
- Fed independence is a market variable, not just a political one: it underpins the dollar and interest rates

He frames the whole wrap as connecting the dots: one lens through which a year of themes and a decade of structure become a single coherent story.

Gary Marcus on the Massive Problems Facing AI & LLM Scaling | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 42

2026-01-19 | DEEP DIVE | 58 MIN | WITH GARY MARCUS

The leading LLM skeptic explains why scaling has hit diminishing returns and why hallucination is built into how the models work, not a bug awaiting a patch. Eisman treats this as the deepest risk to the AI trade: if Marcus is right, the capex boom rests on a technology that cannot deliver what it promises.

DISCUSSED

- Marcus's credentials: an MIT dissertation on neural networks and a 2001 book, The Algebraic Mind, that anticipated hallucinations
- System 1 versus system 2 thinking: LLMs do fast pattern matching but have never managed slow deliberative reasoning
- A tracker of fabricated legal citations finding roughly 300 court cases of lawyers filing made-up references, then 600 three months later
- GPT-5's launch on August 7, 2025, sold as doing anything a PhD can do and picked apart by the public within about an hour
- The novelty problem: models break outside their training distribution, which he compares to LTCM and the Russian bond collapse
- If scale is all that matters, Google wins with its own tensor processing units; OpenAI next needs roughly a hundred billion dollar check that maybe five people in the world can write
- Models trained on every chess rulebook and millions of games still make illegal moves, the case for world models and foundational research

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Hallucination follows from the architecture: statistical blurring works on average but can never guarantee any particular fact
- Claims that one model beats another are task-dependent; there is no definitive ranking, only intuitions from different users doing different things
- Models fail hardest on novelty, and markets are where novelty does the most damage
- When critics from opposite ends, Marcus and Ilya Sutskever, converge on the view that scaling alone is a dead end, investors should listen

The chess example lands hardest: after reading every rulebook and seeing millions of games, the models still make illegal moves, which Marcus calls just damning.

The “Lone Wolf” Effect: Trump, Burry & a Market on Edge | The Weekly Wrap

2026-01-23 | WEEKLY WRAP | 21 MIN

A shortened wrap, current through Wednesday, built around a new theme he calls lone wolves: contrarian outsiders whose once-dismissed positions now move markets, from Trump on Greenland to Michael Burry on chip depreciation. Tariff escalation and rising yields leave the market on edge.

DISCUSSED

- Escalating tariffs on eight European countries to pressure Denmark over Greenland, starting at 10% in February and rising to 25% in June
- 85% of Greenlanders opposing US annexation, turning the dispute into a contest of credibility and ego that is very difficult to handicap
- Nvidia's Rubin chip shipping later this year, barely a year after Blackwell began shipping in late 2024
- Burry's argument that hyperscalers stretched semiconductor depreciation from 3 to 5 years out to 5 to 6, inflating earnings by billions
- Private equity's monetization problem: companies bought at zero rates are hard to exit with rates significantly higher
- The 10-year Treasury jumping to 4.3%, pushing mortgage rates back above 6% and hurting homebuilders most
- A mailbag question on why index investing would make any market pullback more severe

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A chip generation that turns over in about a year makes 5 to 6 year depreciation schedules hard to defend; Rubin's arrival strengthens Burry's math
- When a conflict becomes about credibility and ego rather than economics, it stops being possible to handicap, and that is itself the risk
- Passive flows buy stocks automatically in index weight on the way up and will sell the same mechanical way on the way down
- Lone wolves matter most at the moment their contrarian positions start gaining adherents

  His aside that sometimes lone wolves join into packs and create their own society with their own rules, his description of private equity.

The Mystery of Stablecoins, Visa, & Fiserv’s Collapse with Ken Suchoski | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 43

2026-01-26 | DEEP DIVE | 61 MIN | WITH KEN SUCHOSKI

The Autonomous Research payments analyst walks the sector from newest to oldest: stablecoins and Circle, then PayPal, Block and Toast, then Visa, Mastercard and the legacy processors. The backdrop is a brutal year in which only two of the 32 payment companies in his screen beat the S&P 500.

DISCUSSED

- What a stablecoin actually is: Circle mints USDC against very short US treasuries, about two weeks of average duration
- Why Autonomous was negative on Circle at the IPO: roughly 75 times EBITDA for a reserve return rate that tracks the Fed funds rate, so rate cuts hurt
- Stablecoins' real edge in cross-border payments: 24/7 settlement with no cutoff times or weekends, against a correspondent banking system that still holds about 90% of the market
- The anatomy of a card swipe, from merchant acquirer to network routing to the issuing bank's approve-or-decline decision
- Fiserv down 71% on the year, with Clover on one side and issuer processing for banks on the other

- Block as two businesses: Square at about 40% of gross profit and Cash App, a neobank for the unbanked, at 60%
- PayPal's premium pricing under pressure when merchants get Apple Pay free through Stripe

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A stablecoin issuer is really an asset manager; its earnings are short-term interest rates in disguise and deserve to be valued that way
- Biometric authentication is a uniquely strong password with a fatal flaw: once someone steals your face or thumbprint, you cannot change it
- Lower starting valuations mechanically improve prospective returns; after a terrible year, that is the bull case for quality payment names
- Sector carnage does not indict every franchise: both men would still own Visa and Mastercard

The year-end scoreboard read aloud like casualties: Fiserv down 71, Bill down 36, Block down 30, PayPal down 27. Eisman's verdict: it's like a minefield.

Silver Goes Crazy, United Healthcare is Falling, & AI’s CapEx is Exploding | The Weekly Wrap

2026-01-30 | WEEKLY WRAP | 26 MIN

Silver jumps roughly 60% in a single month while the VIX sits at 17, so complacent equity bulls now live side by side with investors betting on the dollar's demise. He works through a heavy earnings week in which AI capex begins to cut both ways.

DISCUSSED

- Silver surging from $72 an ounce at the end of 2025 to about $115, with gold breaching the $5,000 barrier
- The bedrock assumption of commodity trading breaking down as silver traders demand physical delivery
- The Fed holding rates steady despite pressure from President Trump, citing a stronger economy
- UnitedHealth's real problem: a change in Medicare compensation created a 6% pricing gap and left Optum Health barely profitable in the fourth quarter
- GE Vernova orders of $22.2 billion, up 65%, as one of only three companies in the world making large gas turbines
- Tesla revenue down 3% and autos down 11%, largely irrelevant at a 200 times 2026 PE built on robotaxi promises
- Bank leverage then and now: Citi at 33 to 1 before the financial crisis, roughly 40 to 1 with off-balance sheet items, versus 14 to 1 today

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When traders start demanding physical delivery, a commodity market's core assumption fails and the squeeze feeds on itself
- Only an actual recession, not fear of one, will break retail's buy-the-dip conditioning
- Short-tailed insurance can be repriced quickly and fixed; a regulatory change to Medicare compensation is structural damage that cannot
- A market that is simultaneously complacent (VIX at 17) and apocalyptic (gold and silver soaring) is telling you two incompatible stories at once

His flat approval of the central bank under political fire: the Fed showed some backbone.

Jason Trennert on Populism, Policy & a Distorted Market System | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 44

2026-02-02 | DEEP DIVE | 52 MIN | WITH JASON TRENNERT

A conversation between two old friends that opens with Trennert's multiple myeloma diagnosis and his search for a kidney donor, then turns to populism distorting markets, above all the price of money. Trennert expects a strong 2026 economy but sees a Fed that has become a participant in the game instead of its referee.

DISCUSSED

- The diagnosis arriving two weeks before he was to start as assistant Treasury secretary for financial markets; dialysis three times a week while he waits for a matching kidney
- The One Big Beautiful Bill injecting roughly $150 billion of tax refunds and stimulus into 2026, plus supply-side provisions behind it
- Why populist price-setting is a bad idea everywhere, including setting the price of money and blocking buybacks
- The Fed as active participant rather than referee: Trennert would have let Silicon Valley Bank go down
- Private equity secondaries always trading at a discount to par, never at the marks
- Retail and meme stock power, from Carvana's run from $4 to over $400 to his skepticism of Opendoor
- Prediction markets going mainstream: CME's FanDuel deal reaching effectively 50 states within weeks, and Polymarket, a significant Trump family holding, partnering with ICE

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The secondary market is the tell on private equity marks: if the holdings were really worth par, sellers would not have to exit at a discount
- Suppressing the price of money is price-fixing like any other; the escape valve is higher inflation, a weaker currency, or both
- Online virality lets stocks be manipulated faster than ever, true or not, and erodes the whole idea of long-term investing
- Unregulated prediction markets are, in Trennert's words, as ripe for insider trading as anything he can think of; regulation is coming

A self-described rock-ribbed Republican, weeks from joining the Treasury, arguing the Fed should have let Silicon Valley Bank fail.

Crypto & Silver Collapse, Software Gets Obliterated, & Two Stock Recommendations | The Weekly Wrap

2026-02-06 | WEEKLY WRAP | 28 MIN

He opens with a personal announcement, his cancer treatments are over, and thanks his wife Valerie Feigen, then covers a rout: silver and crypto collapsing, software stocks obliterated by AI fear, and hyperscaler capex now punished instead of rewarded. He also lays out theses for two stocks he just bought, Charter Communications and Meritage Homes.

DISCUSSED

- Silver's violent round trip after its run to $115, and a sharp crypto decline with one major name down over 75% from its peak and 29% in a week
- ServiceNow reporting genuinely great numbers and falling 10% anyway, dragging all of software; Anthropic's new model releases feeding the fear that AI kills software franchises
- The Charter thesis: roughly $121 of estimated 2029 free cash flow per share, an implied 54% yield, less than two times free cash flow, with the cash going to buybacks

- Waymo raising $16 billion at a $126 billion valuation, an awkward comp for Tesla's $1.6 trillion robotaxi-and-robotics story
- Palantir growing fourth quarter revenue 70% and guiding 2026 to $7.2 billion versus a $6.3 billion consensus
- Eli Lilly winning the weight loss wars: EPS of $7.54 versus $6.67 expected and 25% revenue growth guidance
- Amazon guiding 2026 capex to $200 billion versus a $146 billion estimate and falling 7% after hours; last year the same announcement would have lifted the stock

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When a great quarter sinks a stock 10%, the market is repricing the category's future, not the quarter; software is now guilty until proven innocent
- A free cash flow yield above 20% signals suspected bankruptcy; when the balance sheet says otherwise, that gap is the opportunity
- Narratives flip without warning: identical capex announcements that lifted hyperscalers last year now sink them
- A stock at more than 30 times earnings after doubling in a year cannot afford any disappointment; AMD proved it with a 17% drop

The wrap pauses for gratitude: hundreds of viewer emails through months of treatment, and a thank-you to Valerie Feigen, without whom the podcast would be impossible.

Consumer VibeCession & Private Credit Risk with Lakshmi Ganapathi | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 45

2026-02-09 | DEEP DIVE | 49 MIN | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

The Unicus Research short seller argues the US consumer is in a vibe-cession: credit data looks fine while invisible costs in insurance, car repair and health care crush households whose wages have not kept up. She expects the cracks to appear in consumer spending in the second half of 2026, before they ever reach the credit statistics.

DISCUSSED

- The disconnect: Michigan consumer sentiment at a multi-decade low while bank credit metrics stay benign
- Earners of $100,000 to $150,000 cascading down into the lower leg of the K-shaped economy
- Car repair costs up roughly 45 to 50%, breaking the old rule that consumers could safely borrow to a 30% debt-to-income ratio
- 19% of buy now pay later users forgetting payments across Klarna, Affirm and PayPal, with BNPL now covering rent and DoorDash
- Lenders quietly extending auto loans rather than repossessing, including a reported 100-month car loan on a depreciating asset
- The yen carry trade in plain terms: borrow cheap in Japan, buy dollar bonds, credit and equities
- Private credit's opacity, with First Brands as the case where nobody saw the problem until it was too late

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Credit is now cut silently in real time: BNPL firms underwrite at the point of sale and decline cards without ever saying why
- Loan term extension masks deterioration; a repossession avoided is a default deferred, invisible to CPI and credit data alike
- Watch spending, not credit metrics; stretched consumers cut expenses before they miss payments, so spending cracks first
- Even a short shop has untouchables: her Carvana rule is no shorting the cult

- A correct short can still moonshot; her GE Vernova call caught the wind write-off, then watched the stock ride the AI power wave from about 250 to 700

The episode's coinage: not a recession but a vibe-cession, a silent squeeze that shows up in how people feel long before it shows up in the data.

AI Panic Spreads, Health Insurers Crack & Retail Keeps Buying | The Weekly Wrap

2026-02-13 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

AI fear has escaped the software group and now torches a new sector every day, while retail keeps buying every dip. He closes with a two-stock lesson in cheap versus broken: Charter yes, PayPal no.

DISCUSSED

- December retail sales flat against expectations of 0.4% growth, another sign of a mixed consumer
- Altruist's AI tax planning tool knocking Raymond James down 9%, LPL 8% and Schwab 7% in a day
- CBRE and JLL both down 12%, then CH Robinson down 15%, as AI fears hit real estate services and logistics
- Molina's results showing health insurance problems are widespread, not confined to UnitedHealth
- T-Mobile beating on EPS but losing its discounter role to a newly aggressive Verizon
- A mailbag on measuring portfolio risk through the betas of individual holdings
- Charter's 94 billion in long-term debt against a 30 billion market cap, defended anyway

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Buying the dip works until an actual widespread recession arrives, and not before
- Even profitable hyperscalers like Google will have no cash flow this year because of AI capex
- In a panic regime investors shoot first and rarely ask questions, so a group burned by bad news can stay rejected
- A portfolio of high-beta stocks can be effectively 121% invested without any margin; beta is how you see it
- Cheap is not the test. Charter is an improving story with rising cash flow; PayPal is losing share with no obvious fix

His running refrain for the week: every day is an AI adventure.

Daniel Guetta on the Guts of AI, Agentic AI & Why LLMs Hallucinate | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 46

2026-02-16 | DEEP DIVE | 63 MIN | WITH DANIEL GUETTA

A deliberate second opinion after Gary Marcus: a Columbia professor who worked at Amazon and Palantir explains LLMs from the inside, embeddings, agents and hallucination included. Guetta agrees LLMs will not reach general intelligence but argues it does not matter, because the products are good enough to disrupt anyway.

DISCUSSED

- The top four hyperscalers set to spend roughly 650 billion dollars on AI infrastructure
- How deep learning in the mid 2010s let models capture the meaning of text as a list of numbers
- The Sandy Koufax example: a model answers by finding the words around your question in embedding space
- Agentic AI as a chatbot given tools, able to book a hotel or send an email on its own
- Why companies whose moat is control of a database, such as commercial real estate data, are vulnerable
- His Good Will Hunting analogy for what models know versus what they understand

- Models as statistical parrots of their training data, which is why they hallucinate

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The first job for a company adopting AI is a fertile environment: IT systems a computer can actually operate
- These are calculations and statistics, not magic; understanding the mechanism removes both the awe and the panic
- AGI is the wrong bar. Good-enough agentic products can still shake insurance brokers and wealth managers
- Eisman's timeline: whether the spending earns its return will not be known this year, perhaps not until 2027 or 2028

Eisman sides more with Guetta than Marcus, then immediately concedes the only question that matters, returns on the hundreds of billions, is unanswerable for years.

Flight to Safety Begins, Private Credit Cracks & the Software Bloodbath Continues | The Weekly Wrap

2026-02-20 | WEEKLY WRAP | 25 MIN

The index is flat but the hood is off: software down 20% this year, staples up 13%, a flight to safety with no fundamental improvement behind it. He also flags a brewing life insurance story he will spend the next fortnight unpacking.

DISCUSSED

- S&P info tech down 4% and the software subsector down 20% for the year, while staples are up 13%
- Homebuilder TPH acquired by Sumitomo Forestry for $47 a share, a 29% premium at 1.3 times tangible book
- His Meritage thesis getting outside affirmation from the TPH deal math
- Walmart's rare stumble: $2.80 EPS guidance against a $2.96 estimate, 4% same store sales, and still a 50 times PE
- Payments consolidating to two long-term investments, Mastercard and Visa, everything else a trading vehicle
- Mailbag questions on what a recession does to markets and on private equity owned insurers like Athene
- A coming interview with a forensic accountant and former life insurance examiner on hidden risk in the sector

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Watch rotation, not the index level; a flat tape can hide a genuine flight to safety
- Staples rallied without their fundamentals improving at all, which is what a pure safety bid looks like
- Recession and recovery recalibrate an economy; weak balance sheets fail, the Fed cuts, and the survivors emerge healthier
- When e-commerce has devastated a sector, investors pay 50 times earnings for anything still working

He teases the life insurance story as increasing investment risk plus hidden leverage, a very important story to tell.

George Noble on Gold's Rise, Crypto Doubts & Tesla's Struggles | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 47

2026-02-23 | DEEP DIVE | 55 MIN | WITH GEORGE NOBLE

An old-fashioned buyside stock jockey, at it since 1981, bullish on gold, energy and materials and bearish on tech, crypto and Tesla. Eisman lets him run, then pushes back on the gold thesis while agreeing completely on crypto.

DISCUSSED

- Noble's Fidelity years: launching the Overseas Fund in December 1984 and returning 79% in 1985
- Both men on the short side in 2008, both redeemed heavily because they did not gate; 'I was the ATM'
- His call that R is for rotation, not recession: out of tech, into energy, materials, gold and silver
- Fiat debasement and the risk of a global Liz Truss moment, echoing the UK gilt collapse of autumn 2022
- Tesla's 2025 consensus EPS falling from $8 three years ago to about $1.70, with the stock flat for five years
- Gross versus net revenue recognition, illustrated with a ticket reseller reporting $120 instead of $20
- An engineer's view that OpenAI underprices badly: the $20 a month product does what the $200 one does

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Eisman will not short anything that involves a cult, Tesla included, however bad the numbers
- When a discussion is all chart and narrative with no fundamentals, you are no longer analyzing a business
- As long as there is no alternative to treasuries, betting on the demise of the dollar has failed for 40 years
- Crypto was sold as digital gold but trades with tech in every crisis; it is speculation about speculation

Noble's line that young people now have FanDuel and prediction markets, so Bitcoin is for old people; Eisman thought it captured something real.

Trump Tariff Turmoil, Private Credit Risk Grows, & AI's Software Fears | The Weekly Wrap

2026-02-27 | WEEKLY WRAP | 27 MIN

The Supreme Court kills the IEEPA tariffs and Trump rebuilds them within a weekend, so the market barely blinks. The real story is Blue Owl freezing redemptions, which turns private credit from an institutional curiosity into everyone's problem.

DISCUSSED

- The Supreme Court striking down the IEEPA tariffs; Trump answering with a temporary 15% tariff under Section 122 plus new Section 301 investigations
- Bessent's claim that the reworked tariffs leave 2026 revenue virtually unchanged
- Blue Owl freezing redemptions while selling 1.4 billion in loans at roughly par to CalPERS, OMERS, British Columbia Investment Management and a fourth buyer
- Retail money, 401k plans and policyholder-backed insurers now inside private credit, which is why the freeze matters
- Another AI fear week: CrowdStrike down 10%, Visa and Mastercard hit, IBM down 13% on an Anthropic product aimed at its COBOL franchise
- First Solar down 15% as commercial solar cracks; Enphase down from $340 in COVID to $46
- Mailbags on why tariff news did not sink the market and what edge institutions really have over retail

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- His three risks to watch: whether AI spending earns a return, private credit's overexposure to software, and the private equity, private credit, life insurance triangle
- Private credit sold only to institutions was nobody's problem; sold to retail and insurers, it is everybody's
- The private credit model has never been stress tested with valuation doubts, liquidity pressure and a sector disruption hitting at once
- For most retail investors the honest answer on edge is that indices beat active managers anyway

He breaks his own format to flag the coming Tom Gober episode up front, calling it truly worth checking out.

The Next Financial Crisis? Private Equity, Private Credit & Life Insurance | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 48

2026-03-02 | DEEP DIVE | 52 MIN | WITH TOM GOBER

A forensic accountant and former Mississippi insurance examiner walks through how private equity turned life insurers into captive buyers of their own credit paper, then hid the leverage offshore through captive reinsurance. Eisman's verdict: nobody is looking, and it rhymes with the years before the financial crisis.

DISCUSSED

- Why insurance is regulated state by state while banks answer to the Fed, and how companies play states off each other
- Five industry-friendly states, Vermont, South Carolina, Delaware, Arizona and Iowa, granting permitted practices outside statutory accounting
- Captive reinsurers as special purpose vehicles with no building and no employees, absorbing liabilities under looser rules
- Deferring commissions already paid over 25 years, underfunding future death claims
- Athene sharply increasing its exposure to affiliated private credit investments
- One company taking reserve credit for 7 billion laid off to three captives whose assets, when visible, fell well short
- Why sell-side coverage misses it: Apollo and KKR are covered by asset manager analysts who never read statutory filings

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When an insurer buys credit paper from its own private equity parent, there is no arms-length pricing and every incentive to hide risk
- Offshore captive reinsurance is leverage you cannot see; the industry is far more levered than it looks
- A credit bull market postpones the reckoning without repairing it; the risk compounds quietly
- Regulators act after blowups, not before, exactly as before the great financial crisis
- The people bearing the risk are policyholders and annuity owners, who have no idea

Eisman's closing image: a slow boiling frog that one day is just going to explode.

Iran War Volatility, Private Credit Fears Grow, & Solar Continues to Crash | The Weekly Wrap

2026-03-06 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

The US and Israel bomb Iran and kill Khamenei, and the market closes flat; the narratives that actually move stocks are private credit fraud and forced markdowns. Bitcoin fails the hedge test yet again.

DISCUSSED

- The weekend strike on Iran killing Ayatollah Khamenei and much of the leadership, with oil, gold and silver up and Bitcoin down
- UK private lender Market Financial Solutions, a 2.4 billion loan book, liquidated amid apparent double pledging of assets
- Barclays, Apollo, Jefferies and Wells Fargo among the exposed; the third lending fraud in six months after Tricolor and First Brands
- TCPC marking a 25 million loan from par to zero, three months after valuing it at 100 cents on the dollar
- CMS threatening Elevance with a Medicare Advantage enrollment freeze over risk adjustment data submitted 2015 through 2023
- A viewer asking whether he is short the life insurance names; he says simply that he is not
- A preview of the Glenn Schorr and Dwight Collins financial services panel

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- In a genuine crisis Bitcoin correlates with tech stocks; it has never once acted as the hedge it claims to be
- Credit problems emerge where the growth was: subprime mortgages before the GFC, private credit now
- Frauds like double pledging are discoverable; they grow because private lenders skip the due diligence
- Ganapathi's line stands for the whole sector: getting in was easy, getting out is a whole different story

Elevance allegedly submitted its data corrections to CMS on a USB flash drive, every year, that CMS could not open.

Private Credit Cracks, The AI "Boogeyman" & Why Crypto is for Boomers | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 49

2026-03-09 | DEEP DIVE | 53 MIN | WITH GLENN SCHORR, DWIGHT COLLINS

Depth and breadth: Evercore's Glenn Schorr, who covers the alternative managers, and Autonomous sales head Dwight Collins on the private credit panic. Schorr's contrarian core is that the equity market is pricing a credit cycle the credit market itself cannot see.

DISCUSSED

- Blue Owl stocks down 30% to 50% this year, and the canceled fund merger that offered holders roughly 80 cents on the dollar
- Private credit at 1.8 trillion, with direct lending concentrated in software because that is where five years of growth went
- The distinction between direct lending and the rest of the pie: real estate credit, infrastructure debt, investment grade asset-backed finance
- Insurance brokers down 10% to 12% in a day on a Spanish AI insurance app approved on OpenAI's platform
- Bank M&A running slower and thinner than hoped, without the 30% premiums of the early 2000s
- Stablecoins as a threat to the 29% of US deposits that pay zero interest, and the banks' federal guarantee objection
- Software buyouts financed with roughly 75% equity and 25% debt

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Credit spreads at all-time tights and private equity stocks obliterated cannot both be right; watch which one blinks
- A 75% equity cushion means a great deal must go wrong before the private credit loan itself is impaired
- Retail is walking away from direct lending before any actual losses appear, trying to move first
- Bank CEOs still like being bank CEOs, which is why the long-predicted M&A wave keeps underdelivering
- The old conclusion holds: Visa and Mastercard are the only long-term investments in payments, the rest are trades

Schorr's screen paradox: high yield spreads tighter than ever, every bank CEO upbeat, every broker cheering the capital markets cycle, and the private market stocks getting pummeled. Can all those things coexist?

The Iran War Crisis: Ex-CIA Analyst Helima Croft on Oil Shock & Energy Risk | The Weekly Wrap

2026-03-13 | WEEKLY WRAP | 41 MIN | WITH HELIMA CROFT

With war on, traditional equity analysis is suspended; the market trades every Iran headline, and oil breaching $100 on Monday swooned stocks until Trump told CBS the war would end soon. The wrap then hands off to RBC's Helima Croft, a former CIA analyst, on why the administration misjudged the oil risk and what a shutdown does to supply.

DISCUSSED

- Oil breaching $100 on Monday and collapsing as Trump told CBS News the war would be over soon
- Croft's read that Washington extrapolated from Venezuela, where installing Delcy Rodriguez kept goals manageable, and from the June 12-day war that markets faded
- Why restarts are not a light switch: Aramco could come back fast, Iraq's creaky infrastructure could not, and LNG liquefaction takes long to cycle
- Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline to the Red Sea as the oil market's main comfort if Hormuz stays shut
- Croft's CIA start on December 1, 2001 and Iraq as her formative bias
- Storage hitting tank tops if the shutdown drags on

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- In geopolitical crises the market stops discounting cash flows and trades only the events creating the uncertainty
- Policy makers anchor on their last two crises; both precedents here argued for a muted oil response, and both may mislead
- Supply that shuts down does not restart on command, so the duration of a closure matters more than the closure itself
- Mission creep is the real war risk: objectives change, and the adversary gets a vote on the timeline and the cost

Eisman retires the chemo hat on air, his hair growing back, and reveals its provenance: he bought it at The Gap.

Mark Cuban Shares His Plan For Fixing Drug Prices in America | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 50

2026-03-16 | DEEP DIVE | 51 MIN | WITH MARK CUBAN

Mark Cuban explains why US drug prices are a delivery-system problem, not a research-cost problem, and how Cost Plus attacks it with one transparent price of wholesale plus 15% for everyone. The third episode in Eisman's healthcare series, after Michael Ha on insurance and Warris Bokhari on claim denials.

DISCUSSED

- The PBM scheme: wholesale acquisition cost equals retail, rebates of roughly 400 on a 1,000 drug get pocketed by PBMs, not consumers
- Formularies as pay-to-play, with insurer-owned PBMs telling pharma companies that working with Cuban means being cut off
- Deductibles as the real barrier: a $1,500 deductible you cannot afford means you have no insurance, which turns providers into subprime lenders
- Medical loss ratios gamed through vertical integration, with the biggest insurer running 2,600 subsidiaries and shifting profit pocket to pocket
- Cost Plus Wellness contracts published free at costpluswellness.com, with no insurance company in Cuban's own employee plan
- Cuban's own portfolio: mostly cash, waiting Buffett-style for the tide to go out on meme-like and AI-labeled names

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The US is the only country with PBMs, and their rebate economics are a core reason drug prices are higher here than anywhere else
- Different prices for the same drug depending on insurance is the disease; one published price for all is the cure Cuban is betting on

- When patients cannot pay deductibles, hospitals lend money they know they will never collect, so credit risk hides inside healthcare delivery
- The interests of health insurers are structurally unaligned with patients, which no amount of regulation-tinkering fixes

Cuban's distilled lesson from Shark Tank and the Mavericks is simply: be nice, and your business does better.

Private Credit Risks Explained, Oil Surges Above $100 | The Weekly Wrap

2026-03-20 | WEEKLY WRAP | 29 MIN

With Hormuz still closed, oil above $100 and the S&P down 4% for the year, Eisman uses the fog of war to deliver a primer on private credit, the opaque lending machine now cracking in public. He runs through a list of fresh warnings, from Carlyle's Project Potomac to SoFi's breached securitization triggers.

DISCUSSED

- Straits of Hormuz closed, China back-channeling passage for Chinese-flagged ships, and Mnuchin denying rumors of federal oil-market intervention
- The 10-year Treasury yield rising from 4.0% to 4.3% since the war began, the opposite of the usual flight to safety
- Private credit's structure: 80% of direct lending funds private equity buyouts, with an estimated 25% of loans to software companies bought from 2018 through 2022
- AI eroding software business models as the sector's concentrated risk
- Carlyle's Project Potomac, a collateralized fund obligation pooling LP stakes from multiple funds so new investors buy out old ones
- MFS Investment Management as the third lending fraud after Tricolor and First Brands, plus Canada's subprime lender GoEasy
- SoFi's 2025 securitization breaching its cumulative net loss trigger, cutting off SoFi's excess spread and threatening its funding model

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- He dismisses government-intervention conspiracy theories with a simple test: if it were happening, it would leak, and it never has
- Private credit stays invisible until problems develop precisely because it is private; the information vacuum is the risk
- When a securitization trigger breaches, the lender's economics vanish first, and losing securitization investors can shut off lending entirely
- Redemption limits and creative structures like CFOs are signs that money wants out faster than the assets can pay it

A viewer letter about the Cuban interview lets him restate the whole PBM scheme in two minutes, a wrap-as-classroom move.

The Only Health Insurance Stock You Can Own with Michael Ha | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 51

2026-03-23 | DEEP DIVE | 59 MIN | WITH MICHAEL HA

Baird's Michael Ha returns to survey a managed care sector in wrenching decline: risk adjustment crackdowns, flat Medicare Advantage rates, and a sicker Medicaid pool. The core puzzle Eisman poses is why a vertically integrated oligopoly cannot extract any rent at all, and Ha's answer is that it was never actually integrated.

DISCUSSED

- Risk adjustment as a revenue multiplier, where coding sicker members lifts the benchmark rate and drops straight to earnings
- Medicare Advantage rate notices coming in flat for 2027 when everyone expected roughly 5%, echoing the margin destruction of 2024 and 2025
- Medicaid redetermination leaving Molina with a sicker pool, and the 24-to-36-month actuarial lag before state rates catch up
- United Healthcare's 2,000-plus subsidiaries and databases that do not speak to each other
- PBMs surviving rebate reform through fee-based revenue levers most investors do not understand
- Ha's pick ALHC as the one name he loves, and European investors sitting on hundreds of millions in unrealized losses
- Breakup tail risk rising from about 1% to perhaps 5% or 10% as Congress stirs

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Vertical integration built by acquisition is not integration; these companies are conglomerates of parts that cannot talk to each other, which is why the oligopoly earns no excess rent
- When healthy members drop off a pool, rates set on the old population become inadequate everywhere at once
- Government-administered pricing repricing on a two-to-three-year lag defines when the recovery trade works: too early is simply wrong
- Eisman's bottom line is that it is mostly too early to buy the sector, selectivity or not

Ha opens by wishing Eisman well on his health and calling the show the best financial podcast in the world, before an hour of unrelieved sector gloom.

The Iran War is Masking Economic Problems: Why Housing is So Expensive | The Weekly Wrap

2026-03-27 | WEEKLY WRAP | 54 MIN | WITH PHILLIPPE LORD

A week of headline whiplash, with Trump postponing bombing for five days, a 15-point plan floated and Iran rejecting it while demanding control of Hormuz. Eisman then cuts to the CEO of Meritage Homes, a stock he recommended, for a ground-level look at why houses cost so much and how builders manage capital.

DISCUSSED

- Monday futures down 100 basis points, then up over 200 on Trump's bombing pause, closing up 1.15% after Iran denied any talks
- The theory that Trump's delays are setting up a US move on Kharg Island, the key to Iran's economy
- The country underbuilt since the Great Recession, with builders slow to bring lots and supply back
- Median new home prices above half a million dollars, and Meritage's focus on delivering product below that line
- Meritage at roughly a 5 billion market cap versus Lennar around 20 billion and DHI up to 45 billion, and why the big three earn higher price-to-book multiples
- Off-balance-sheet land banking, its drag on margins, and bringing land on book only when ready to build

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Affordability is a supply problem years in the making; pent-up demand met a decade of underbuilding
- Land is the builder's real balance sheet decision: optioned land costs margin but frees working capital, and it is all math on the IRR
- Scale earns builders a valuation premium through higher returns on equity, so the mid-caps trade cheap to book
- In a headline-driven market, single-stock work like housing is where actual analysis still pays

The CEO's summary of land banking: no free lunch, just capital efficiency.

Inside the Iran War with Steven Cook: What's REALLY Happening? | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 52

2026-03-30 | DEEP DIVE | 44 MIN | WITH STEVEN COOK

With the war in its fourth week and the only variable that moves markets, Eisman brings in the Council on Foreign Relations' Steven Cook to separate fact from fiction. Cook's forecast is a messy stalemate: the regime survives, the Gulf rearms, and victory stays unclear.

DISCUSSED

- Israel's four objectives: regime change, the missile program, the nuclear program, and the proxies, with heavy damage to the middle two
- Trump's deliberately vague war aims, his 4-to-6-week claim now entering week four as energy prices bite
- Israel folded into CENTCOM after the Abraham Accords, forcing even Qatar to work with it
- A Saudi-hosted gathering of 18 foreign ministers issuing tough statements on Iran, with criticism of Israel almost an afterthought
- The regime killing an upward estimate of 30,000 of its own civilians in December and January, and why Cook still expects Iranians to be heard from
- An Iranian strike missing Dimona by about 12 miles, and Israeli confidence that the enriched uranium is buried beyond reach under rubble

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Vague war aims are a dealmaker's choice: they preserve maneuverability at the cost of criticism
- Regimes look resilient until they are not; the Iranian revolution unfolded over 15 to 18 months, so quiet streets today prove little
- The adversary sets its own timeline and prices its resistance to deter the next intervention, not just to survive this one
- Any negotiated end requires verifiable limits on the nuclear program, or the whole war is for naught

Eisman, mid-interview, accidentally welcomes his guest to the Middle East Laybook, then asks Cook to translate JCPOA the way Cook endures financial jargon.

The Private Credit Reckoning is Coming: Executives Are Mistaking Luck For Genius | The Weekly Wrap

2026-04-02 | WEEKLY WRAP | 23 MIN

A shortened Good Friday week closes a tough first quarter, S&P down 4.6% and Nasdaq down 7.1%, and Eisman draws his sharpest historical parallel yet: private credit executives sound like pre-2008 Wall Street, mistaking a benign cycle for their own genius. The difference is that this time the arrogance does not even have leverage behind it.

DISCUSSED

- Q1 ending with the S&P down 4.6% and Nasdaq down 7.1% on war, AI fears and private credit
- Trump threatening Iran's energy infrastructure and Kharg Island unless the straits reopen
- A Wall Street Journal piece finding software exposure in direct lending well above the 25% estimate, thanks to what he calls data massaging in sector classification
- Hedge fund idea dinners breeding herd trades, visible in gold falling while oil and rates rise, which he says makes no sense
- Pre-crisis Wall Street pay built on ROE and net income, so an entire generation mistook leverage for genius
- A viewer question on GameStop: 6.3 billion cash against 4.1 billion debt on a 10 billion market cap, and why he rejects Michael Burry's buy-something thesis

- BDCs versus private funds: the 1980 structure trades SEC registration, two-to-one leverage limits and 90% payout for retail access

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Rising rates during a crisis signal that inflation fear has displaced the flight to safety
- When funds classify software borrowers as healthcare companies because of their customers, believe the exposure is higher than reported
- Executives who have never seen a default cycle radiate the same certainty as 2007 bank CEOs; lack of a track record through a downturn is itself the risk
- Buying a stock because management might acquire something good someday is a pipe dream, not a thesis

His GameStop verdict on the Burry argument: buy a stock because they could buy something worthwhile at a good price? Good luck with that.

Is Private Credit the Next Systemic Crisis? Steve Liesman Weighs In | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 53

2026-04-06 | DEEP DIVE | 49 MIN | WITH STEVE LIESMAN

CNBC's Steve Liesman, recorded just after a huge war-headline rally on March 31, lays out four simultaneous stories: tariffs, AI job losses, private credit and the oil shock, any one of which would normally fill an analyst's plate. The most useful thread is his case that private credit's danger lies less in its size than in nobody knowing who holds what.

DISCUSSED

- Four concurrent macro stories, each consequential on its own, with oil the most important and the least forecastable
- The unforecastable resilience of the US economy, which contains an oil economy the size of Saudi Arabia inside it
- Fed turmoil: Warsh nominated with possible delays, Powell maybe staying, Cook before the Supreme Court, and Kansas City hawks floating policy action to anchor inflation expectations
- Why raising rates against an exogenous oil shock troubles Eisman
- Liesman's point that private equity may borrow to fund its own equity checks, so true leverage in buyouts is unknowable
- Banks levered 12 to 1 versus private credit's 2 to 1, and whether the boom is a sign Dodd-Frank pushed lending too far outside banks
- Bank of America card data showing the lower-end consumer hurting, with oil the insult to injury

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Opacity itself is the systemic risk: small known losses calm markets, small unknown losses panic everyone who might be holding the bag
- If equity beneath private credit loans is itself borrowed, headline loan-to-value ratios understate the leverage in the system
- A central bank facing an exogenous supply shock has no good move; watching inflation expectations is all it can do
- The K-shaped economy shows up first in bank card data, and the low end that thrived during COVID is now the pressure point

Eisman describes his week: he starts writing more bad news on private credit on Monday and has to add a fresh sentence every single morning.

Q1 Market Recap: How Private Credit, AI, & War Have Dominated 2026 So Far | The Weekly Wrap

2026-04-10 | WEEKLY WRAP | 25 MIN

A quarter-end wrap dominated by the Iran ceasefire whiplash and redemption runs at the big private credit funds. He closes the quarter with a sector scorecard and a primer on why private equity grew so large in the first place.

DISCUSSED

- Trump's two-week Iran ceasefire after threatening to destroy Iran's infrastructure; oil fell over 15% and the S&P closed up 2.5%
- Vance calling the ceasefire a fragile truce, with Iran keeping the Strait of Hormuz closed and disputing whether Lebanon is covered
- Blue Owl's OCIC receiving redemption requests of 21.9% and its $3.3 billion tech fund OTIC 41%, both capped at 5%
- Carlyle's $7 billion CTAC fund getting a 16% redemption notice; Moody's turning negative on OCIC and the whole BDC industry
- Energy at only 4% of the S&P 500 despite the US energy sector matching the size of the entire Saudi economy
- Utilities and consumer staples up 7% plus as safety plays in a down quarter
- Meritage Homes revisited: recommended in January near tangible book value around $74, with a valuation range of 50% to 1.5 times tangible book

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Redemption requests above 20% at funds that cap withdrawals at 5% are the clearest stress signal private credit has produced yet
- Software modeling reduces to seats times price per seat, and AI now puts both assumptions at risk
- A homebuilder bought at or below tangible book value tends to work over time because profitability compounds book value
- Nobody could have stopped the subprime crisis by mid-2007; the environment had to change in 2005, when underwriting first rotted and everyone was paid on volume

  His answer to whether commentators could have averted 2008: with lenders, Wall Street and the raters all paid by volume, a bunch of podcasters complaining about underwriting would not have been listened to.

Catching a Falling Knife: The Truth About Software Stocks Today | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 54

2026-04-13 | DEEP DIVE | 59 MIN | WITH ROB OLIVER

Baird software analyst Rob Oliver explains how a group built on sticky systems of record and decades of pricing power lost half its valuation to AI fear before anything bad showed up in the numbers. Eisman's verdict: the group is cheap for the first time in its history, and that is not a reason to buy it.

DISCUSSED

- Why software was great for decades: systems of record, brutal change management, pricing power, and survival through the client-server and cloud transitions
- Valuations cut by more than half, leaving software at a huge discount to the S&P for maybe the first time ever
- The seat-based revenue model, with both seat growth and price per seat now in doubt
- Oliver calling this a golden age of creation, with anyone able to build software and an explosion in domain creation visible at Cloudflare
- Whether proprietary-database companies like Moody's or S&P are the best-protected position

- Only one company in his coverage reporting on a GAAP basis, which astonishes Eisman
- Private equity's software holdings, bought at big multiples, now worth less whatever the checks say

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Software investors do not care about valuation; they buy revenue growth, so cheapness reads as a symptom rather than an opportunity
- You cannot disprove a negative, and a stock fighting one has no floor until real data arrives
- Disruption timelines run long; the iPhone took years to kill the yellow cab, and the AI hit to software revenue could take three to four quarters to even start showing
- Eisman's own sticking point is pricing power: when the cost of creating software collapses, revenue growth estimates must come down, and until he knows how far, he will not buy

Oliver's cocktail-party summary of his own coverage group: nobody loves software right now.

John Spencer on What the Headlines Get Wrong About the Iran War | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 55

2026-04-14 | DEEP DIVE | 68 MIN | WITH JOHN SPENCER

Urban warfare scholar John Spencer cuts through five weeks of contradictory headlines on the Iran war, arguing the US and Israel are systematically achieving four defined goals without seeking regime change. The market takeaway is that a demonstration of American military prowess this complete changes the calculus in Beijing as much as Tehran.

DISCUSSED

- The four US goals: no nuclear capability, no ballistic missile program, no exported power, and pressure on the regime's ability to survive, without regime change as an objective
- Intelligence penetration including tapping Tehran's highway cameras as sensors to track the supreme leader
- B-2 bombers flying from Missouri, roughly 18 hours each way, with seven sent toward the Middle East and six toward Guam as deception
- The pilot rescue completed without a single death or injury
- A Foreign Policy editor's headline claiming Trump is losing the war, which Spencer rebuts
- Iran lobbing missiles at Turkey, Cyprus and Azerbaijan, validating the case for the operation to every neighbor
- Twenty years ago an entire corps attacking Baghdad had one drone; the technology gap since then explains what is now possible

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Strikes on the Basij and regime communications target the ability to suppress the population, not just military hardware; wars are won by threatening what a regime values most, its survival
- Russia and China are taking notes: their equipment just failed the comparison test, and Xi has to rethink Taiwan with a military that has not fought in decades
- Deception still decides operations; Sun Tzu's rule held for the B-2 raid
- Spencer expects the war to end in more global stability, not less, which is the bullish reading markets keep missing

Eisman's summary of the raid geography: basically the state of Missouri bombed Iran.

Bank Earnings Are In: Here’s What They’re REALLY Saying About the U.S. Economy | The Weekly Wrap

2026-04-17 | WEEKLY WRAP | 28 MIN

With Iran talks collapsed and the US blockading the Strait of Hormuz, he reads the big banks' credit data as the best available window on the economy. The banks say the consumer is fine; the anxiety lives everywhere else.

DISCUSSED

- The US blocking the Strait of Hormuz for economic pressure after weekend talks fell apart, with oil briefly above $100
- Using consumer and commercial non-accruing loans, from disclosures like JP Morgan's 28-page supplement, as the cleanest read on credit quality
- 17 years of benign credit since the financial crisis, and whether the good times are ending
- Goldman's quarter: advisory up 89%, tax rate of 13% versus the usual 21%, no operating leverage, and fixed income trading down 10% while every other major bank traded well
- Why lending-centric banks earn less: Goldman, JP Morgan and Morgan Stanley return above 20% while Wells and Bank of America sit at 14% to 16%
- A mailbag explainer on credit spreads as the market's fear gauge
- Why he avoids giving trade ideas: taxes of 30% plus mean a trade has to be very good to beat holding

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Lending is brutally competitive against banks and non-banks alike, which is why net interest margins have declined for years and diversified banks out-earn lenders
- Widening credit spreads signal worry, but they are not by themselves a verdict on credit quality
- The software fear list is so long, replacement, internalization, dead pricing power, that no clarity is possible for at least a year; predicting the bottom of a group with a broken narrative is brutal
- When expectations are high, a good quarter still sends the stock down, as Goldman showed

Market Patterns Work and Jeffrey Hirsch Explains Why | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 56

2026-04-20 | DEEP DIVE | 50 MIN | WITH JEFFREY HIRSCH

Jeffrey Hirsch, keeper of the Stock Trader's Almanac his father Yale started in 1966, walks through sixty years of seasonal patterns and which ones still work. The premise is simple: people have patterns, people buy stocks, and even the algorithms are written by people.

DISCUSSED

- The Almanac's family history: Yale Hirsch, ex-songwriter, launching the book in 1966 out of Indicator Digest in Palisades Park, New Jersey
- The midterm election pattern: volatility bottoming around September or October of the midterm year, then rallying through April
- The January barometer, which still works, versus the September reverse barometer, retired to the indicator graveyard
- Using MACD only to confirm a seasonal entry or exit, work refined with David Aronson around 2008
- Bitcoin's failed patterns: it trades like leveraged Nasdaq, so Hirsch asks why not just buy a 2x ETF
- Sell in May, but buy in October, his correction to the old saw
- A tongue-in-cheek 5-year taco trade cycle: Trump shocks the world in Q1, then negotiates it better through year-end

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Seasonality is not a standalone signal; pair it with a fundamental or technical reason and use momentum to time the entry
- Keep a graveyard for both losing stocks and dead indicators; if you do not profit from your mistakes, somebody else will
- Black swans are by definition unforeseeable; anyone asking a forecaster to name the next one has missed the point
- Patterns persist because they encode how people react to war and inflation, and those reactions change slower than the news

Hirsch describing the pre-Excel workflow: lead pages stacked as high as himself in his father's office closet, added up on an adding machine and drawn on graph paper.

Is a Recession Coming? What 100+ Companies Are Telling Us | The Weekly Wrap

2026-04-24 | WEEKLY WRAP | 34 MIN

A big earnings week from industrials to homebuilders becomes his recession dashboard, and the data mostly says slowdown, not collapse. The quiet bombshell is regulatory: FICO's decades-old monopoly on consumer credit scoring just cracked.

DISCUSSED

- The FHFA letting Fannie and Freddie accept VantageScore loans immediately, ending FICO's decades-long lock on consumer lending
- Blackstone's BCRED, at 81 billion the industry's largest private credit fund, reporting weak new share sales
- Airlines still ordering planes despite war worries, with orders up roughly 87%
- GEV, which he owns: gas turbines and electrification equipment as one of the best AI stories, since US electrical production barely grew before 2020
- D.R. Horton earnings down 13% but in line, and Meritage EPS down 51% while orders fell only 5%; both rallied on rock-bottom expectations
- A practitioner's argument that B2B software internalization is overstated, citing total cost of ownership and gyms running on exercise.com
- His closing case that stock-based compensation is a real expense, since the same companies deduct it from their taxes

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When expectations are low enough, bad-but-in-line results make stocks rally; homebuilders proved it this week
- A monopoly's value can end with one regulator's announcement; watch the FHFA, not just FICO's earnings
- Building software internally is easy; maintaining, patching, and staying compliant is the expensive part AI does not remove
- User acquisition, not code, is the bottleneck for consumer startups; the VC money flows straight to Google and Meta

On non-GAAP reporting: paying people in stock and refusing to count the expense is, to him, just ridiculous.

Apollo's Private Credit Exposure: Chris Edson Weighs In | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 57

2026-04-27 | DEEP DIVE | 49 MIN | WITH CHRIS EDSON

Apollo's global head of originations, Chris Edson, describes a lender with 16 platforms and 4,000 employees that looks nothing like the buyout-shop caricature of private equity. Eisman comes away holding his view that a software credit cycle is coming, but concluding Apollo's exposure to it is small.

DISCUSSED

- Apollo's 16 origination platforms across fleet finance, equipment, real estate and more, including PK Air Finance, the aircraft lending business bought from GE Capital
- Athene alignment: Apollo owns the insurer and holds $35 billion of its own capital in it as first loss
- Less than 5% of Apollo's capital sitting in redeemable retail vehicles, versus far higher shares at rivals like Blue Owl
- Why Apollo mostly avoided software lending: its roots are value and collateral, and software loans are a dollar and a dream
- Edson's answer on transparency: Athene's regulatory filings list every loan, counterparty and amount
- CFOs de-risking borrowing after COVID, the Russia war, the regional bank crisis, liberation day and now Iran
- Edson's 8-year-old daughter's Junie B. Jones math game, built in seconds with Claude, as his own demonstration of why software moats are in question

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Underwriting advantage starts with scale: the widest funnel of opportunities plus diversification and duration matching, liabilities never shorter than assets
- Owning the balance sheet solves the principal-agent problem; a manager that is first loss on its own insurer is aligned in a way fee-only managers are not
- An AI test for any software credit: no moat, no proprietary data, quickly installed means quickly replaced
- Honoring only a 5% redemption cap may be contractually fair, but the industry's treatment of exiting investors will define its reputation

Eisman's distillation of why Apollo skipped software lending: software companies are not value and not collateral; you are buying a dollar and a dream.

Earnings Keep the Market Strong Despite Signs of Consumer Weakness | The Weekly Wrap

2026-05-01 | WEEKLY WRAP | 31 MIN

He opens with a transparent post-mortem on Charter, his January pick, down 25% in a day, and explains why he added to the position anyway. The rest of the week's mega-cap earnings say cloud and AI capex remain the market's engine while the consumer sends mixed signals.

DISCUSSED

- Charter losing 120,000 broadband subscribers versus a 100,000 estimate, dropping the stock 25% and leaving his January recommendation at $223 down 22% for the year
- His convergence thesis: Charter sells cable plus mobile for $100 a month against 180 to 200 at competitors, so he added to the position
- Ares' outside consultant grading ARCC's software book 85% low risk, with the problematic 15% equal to 3.3% of the portfolio, about 1 billion; he questions the categories
- Visa's net revenue up 17%, the biggest increase since 2022, with payment volume up 9%
- Microsoft down despite Azure growing 39%, because 39% was only one point better than expected
- Amazon's AWS accelerating to 28% growth from 24% last quarter

- Caterpillar's construction industries unit up 38% on AI capex, and Apple beating overall while iPhone missed for the second time in three quarters

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When you recommend a stock publicly, own the bad quarter in public too; transparency means restating the thesis, not deleting it
- The low-cost provider tends to win a convergence war, which is why one awful subscriber print does not kill the story
- At AI-era valuations, meeting expectations is not enough; Microsoft fell on a beat because the beat was too small
- Visa remains as good a single read on the consumer as any company reporting

He teases the Founders Club: mailing-list subscribers get founder status when the new project goes live, while Monday and Friday episodes stay free.

Is a Market Melt-Up Coming? Why Tech & Semis Are Dominating Again | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 58

2026-05-04 | DEEP DIVE | 39 MIN | WITH CHRIS VERRONE, TODD SOHN

The Strategas duo return to read the price action after the war swoon, and their verdict is deja vu: same dates as last year's tariff scare, same V-shaped recovery, same leadership. Verrone raises his odds of a 1999-style melt-up while Sohn warns that passive investors now own far more semiconductor exposure than they realize.

DISCUSSED

- The parallel between last year's tariff swoon (February 29 to April 9) and this year's war decline, with the low on March 31 and the Nasdaq down 7% before recovering
- Leadership snapping right back to AI names, industrials and banks once the market turned
- Gold underwhelming through the entire war, having jumped from safe haven to risk asset before a January blow-off
- Semis now 17% of the S&P 500 and half the tech sector, while software has shrunk to single digits
- Wells Fargo's net interest margin down 13 basis points sequentially, which Eisman calls a culture of ruining the quarter like clockwork
- GE plane orders up roughly 80% as a non-recession indicator, with transports breaking out just as street economists raised recession odds
- Energy oversold within a long-term uptrend; Eisman says he is thinking about adding, not trimming

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Put the newspaper away and follow the price action; had you known the headlines in advance, you would not have predicted new highs either time
- When defensive groups get their moment and give it back within two weeks, the market is telling you it does not want to be defensive
- Index investors' diet has quietly become semi-heavy; diversification now means deliberately looking outside the S&P's mega cap weights
- Transports breaking out while economists raise recession odds is the tell to trust the market over the forecasts

Verrone's closing message is to raise your odds of a melt-up, with the memory move back into the same old stocks echoing 1999.

S&P Hits New Highs as Tech Earnings Crush Recession Fears | The Weekly Wrap

2026-05-08 | WEEKLY WRAP | 30 MIN

With first quarter results nearly all printed, he cross-checks the recession question from the earnings side and finds the same answer the bank credit data gave: not imminent. He also announces the May 15 launch of the Premium subscription, opening with a two-hour masterclass on private credit and the toxic bonds of 2008.

DISCUSSED

- The Real Eisman Playbook Premium launching May 15 with the three-part masterclass A Conspiracy of Credit
- GameStop's deal to buy eBay, with a prominent holder selling his entire position over the debt it requires
- Palantir down 22% this year on AI fears yet still at a 100 times 2026 PE; EPS of 33 cents versus 13, up 154%, on revenue of 1.63 billion
- Diamondback raising oil and gas production targets on higher prices, with second quarter EPS expected to grow over 100%
- PayPal as a structurally problematic payments company squeezed by Apple and Google Pay
- McDonald's growing EPS 6% with 3.8% same-store sales while Shake Shack broke even and fell 30%
- Whirlpool's disaster quarter: a 56 cent loss versus $1.70 last year, with guidance slashed to $3 to $3.50

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Recession checks should triangulate: bank credit quality two weeks ago and now revenue, earnings and margins all point the same way
- In a bifurcated consumer, scale and value win; the same week can produce a McDonald's beat and a Shake Shack collapse
- Software is guilty until proven innocent on AI; even a good Palantir quarter cannot rescue a 100 times multiple
- Housing-related names remain the market's dead zone, and earnings keep confirming it

His preview of the FICO episode: raising scoring prices 1,500% in five years is one of the most egregious monopolistic acts he has ever seen.

FICO's Monopoly is Fading & Consumers Are the Winners w/ Kelsey Zhu | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 59

2026-05-11 | DEEP DIVE | 74 MIN | WITH KELSEY ZHU

The Autonomous financial information services analyst walks through how FICO turned a 60 cent mortgage credit pull into a $10 one and enraged the entire lending ecosystem, which is now rallying behind VantageScore. The back half is a masterclass in what makes an information services moat defensible, from Verisk's loss-cost monopoly to FactSet's shrinking end market.

DISCUSSED

- Mortgage scoring mechanics: 60 cents per pull times three bureaus times three lenders, with five or six pulls per completed mortgage
- FICO pricing rising from 60 cents a pull in 2022 to $10, an increase of more than 1,000%
- VantageScore already validated for mortgage underwriting while FICO 10-T is not, giving lenders a live alternative
- Widespread confusion among lenders and investors over how to even model FICO's pricing grid and success fee
- Verisk as a near-monopoly in property and casualty loss-cost data, serving an insurance vertical built on 30-year relationships

- MSCI benefiting from the shift to passive while FactSet suffers from it, since an index needs no analysts
- Zhu's underperform on FICO: management insists it will lose no share, and she thinks estimates are far too high

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A monopoly that antagonizes every customer at once manufactures its own competition; the whole lending ecosystem now wants FICO to fail
- Vertical culture determines pricing power: mortgage players eagerly trial new products while insurance carriers stay loyal for decades
- AI is a cost tailwind, not a threat, for data companies with proprietary moats; the market currently prices the whole sector the other way
- Narratives swing further than fundamentals: two years ago investors asked if score pricing could reach $50, now they ask if it goes to $1

Zhu on cocktail parties: admit you are an equity research analyst and there are usually no follow-up questions.

Conspiracy of Credit Part 1

2026-05-13 | DEEP DIVE | 20 MIN

Part one of a three part lecture on private credit. Eisman argues we are in the early stage of the first real credit cycle since 2008, that almost all post crisis loan growth moved outside the regulated banks and behind a veil of secrecy, and that the concentrated bet on software is the rotten core. He expects losses and possibly a recession, but not a systemic repeat, because the banks are well capitalized.

DISCUSSED

- The Fed forcing banks to delever and to stop making riskier loans after the crisis, which pushed loan growth into private credit and curtailed bank lending to private equity
- The banks finding a workaround by lending to the funds instead, with recent data showing roughly 300 billion of bank leverage extended to private credit
- Public BDCs being levered at two to one while other private credit vehicles go higher, and an unknown amount of the underlying equity being borrowed too
- Blue Owl disclosing first quarter 2026 redemption requests of 21.9% of assets in its roughly 36 billion flagship OCIC fund, with the smaller 3.3 billion OTIC also hit
- Retail private credit funds capping quarterly redemptions at 5% to 7% and receiving requests above the cap all year
- Sizing the problem against 2006, when 600 billion of subprime was resecuritized into CDOs many times over, versus a roughly 1.8 trillion private credit industry with little resecuritization
- A Wall Street Journal analysis on March 30 showing private credit labelled software loans by end industry, so healthcare software counted as healthcare, hiding true software exposure above the estimated 25% of direct lending

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Equity is subordinate to debt on the same assets, so equity investors who ignore the credit markets are ignoring the thing that will price them
- Markets are clearing mechanisms. When risk is hidden it cannot be priced, and unpriceable risk turns into panic rather than an orderly repricing
- Rating agencies are referees, not regulators, and they are always late. When downgrades start arriving, the damage is already done
- Concentration is the real risk multiplier. Herd behaviour put a quarter or more of direct lending into one bet, so one wrong assumption hits everyone at once
- Relabelling exposure does not reduce it. Check how a lender classifies loans before you accept its industry breakdown

His line for the whole lecture: even expensive, well paid cows prefer to join the herd.

A Conspiracy Of Credit Master Class: Part 2

2026-05-14 | MASTERCLASS | 26 MIN

The middle lecture is a fixed income primer built on one claim, that the bond market's complexity is mostly lingo defending insiders. Eisman teaches the terms, the price and yield relationship, the treasury curve, the power of the rating agencies and the four Cs of credit analysis, so that part three's account of subprime securitization lands.

DISCUSSED

- Why bond prices rise when rates fall, and why every bond is priced off the treasury yield curve as the risk free benchmark
- The curve's shape following lender risk, since thirty year money costs more than overnight money because things go wrong over time
- Treasuries remaining the least risky and most liquid bonds regardless of Moody's and S&P no longer rating the United States triple A
- Rating agencies not merely influencing bond prices but setting them, as the only subjective input in an otherwise mathematical market, which large institutions trade ahead of
- The four Cs of credit analysis, cash flow, collateral, covenants and character, with covenants treated as contract law rather than math
- Tax treatment across treasuries, municipals and corporates, and the near total absence of liquidity in a private loan
- Amortizing versus non amortizing bonds, using a five year 7% bond at par paying 70 dollars a year against a self amortizing residential mortgage

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Learning an industry's lingo is most of the work of understanding it. Jargon is a gate, not a description of real complexity
- In fixed income the rating is the price. Understand who assigns it and how slowly they change it before you trust the mark
- Covenants decide who gets what when the borrower fails, so a credit view that stops at the numbers is incomplete
- Liquidity is a feature markets manufacture. A private loan without a market leaves you contractually stuck for the full term
- Distressed debt is an institutional game requiring lawyers, covenant fluency and often a board seat. It is not a retail asset class

His image for the asset class: if the stock market is a slot machine, distressed debt is the craps table in the private room of the most exclusive casino.

Why this Market “Melt-Up” is Making Me Nervous | The Weekly Wrap

2026-05-15 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

Premium goes live with the Conspiracy of Credit masterclass, and he uses the wrap to defend disclosing his FICO short: being short is an opinion backed by research, not a bias. The week's earnings reinforce the split between hardware winners and everything touching software or private credit.

DISCUSSED

- The Premium launch: weekly bonus episodes, a community board and the three-part fixed income masterclass, with part three on toxic GFC mortgage bonds dropping May 20

- FSK, a $3 billion BDC down 27% this year and cut to junk by Moody's in March, with KKR injecting 150 million of equity and spending another 150 million buying shares
- Toast cut in half from its summer high of 49 on competition and AI fears, down 17% on weak EBITDA guidance
- Bill raising guidance while cutting up to 30% of its workforce as it leans on AI
- Cisco delivering 10% EPS growth and 12% revenue growth, vindicating its claim that AI is a real tailwind
- His response to listeners who called his FICO short a bias, and the coming Bob Brackett energy interview

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When a sponsor has to inject equity into its own credit fund and buy out exiting investors, read it as a signal about the asset class, not generosity
- A workforce cut framed as an AI strategy can lift a stock short term, but it is still a shrinking-cost story, not a growth story
- The GFC parallel to private credit has a limit: banks are well capitalized this time, so expect losses and perhaps a recession rather than systemic collapse
- Having a position and having a bias are different things; research-driven conviction expressed via a short is still just an opinion

  On disclosing his FICO short: I am short because of my research, and I am not trying to convince anyone to join me.

Why Energy Stocks Are Down When They Should Be Up with Bob Brackett | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 60

2026-05-18 | DEEP DIVE | 78 MIN | WITH BOB BRACKETT

Bernstein's energy and mining analyst explains the paradox of the moment: the closing of the strait has removed roughly 20% of world oil production, yet prices stay contained because the market keeps betting the war ends soon. Along the way he maps the whole energy stack, from E&Ps to toll-booth midstream to refiners, and makes the case for treating these as trading vehicles, not growth holdings.

DISCUSSED

- Energy at only 4% of the S&P 500, so generalists buy Exxon and move on; Exxon outperformed in January and February then fell after the invasion
- The UAE dropping out of OPEC this year and what it means for the cartel's long-run grip
- Exxon and Chevron each returning 30 to 50 billion dollars a year through dividends and buybacks
- Why commodity company yields should be compared to TIPS, not treasuries, since the assets are inflation protected
- EOG as a great company that is almost transparently great and therefore usually expensive, versus Diamondback as the more attractive stock after levering up for acquisitions
- Cheniere trading near an 8% free cash flow yield against 5% for S&P midstream peers, with a pass-through model that takes no price risk
- Gas-heavy producers versus oil producers, and refiners capturing margin while selling cigarettes and lottery tickets along the way

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Buy deep cyclicals when the commodity has collapsed and nobody will touch them, and sell when everyone is excited; never the reverse
- War destroys inventories as well as supply, so restocking should keep oil production strong for a year or two even if peace arrives
- A pass-through LNG model with no geopolitical or price risk can be the best risk-adjusted return in the sector without ever being the biggest gainer

- These are value and trading vehicles; growth investors do not belong in them, by Eisman's own closing admission

A technical failure killed the video at the 45-minute mark, so Eisman opens by asking listeners to stay for the audio-only back half.

Walmart & Target Signal Consumer Stress as the 10-Year Yield Hits 4.6% | The Weekly Wrap

2026-05-22 | WEEKLY WRAP | 21 MIN

Hot CPI and PPI prints push the 10-year yield to 4.6%, through the 4.5% level he calls his Rubicon, and he explains why that made him lighten up on stocks. A mailbag question also produces his most detailed account yet of how his fund actually closed the Big Short trades in 2008.

DISCUSSED

- Trump threatening to resume bombing Iran, sending oil higher and pressuring rates
- The 10-year at 4.6% versus his 4.5% Rubicon, with upcoming inflation data unlikely to help
- NextEra buying Dominion Energy in an all-stock utility merger aimed at data center power demand, including the world's largest data center market
- Intuit growing revenue 10%, its slowest since 2024, laying off 17% of its workforce and falling to down 50% for the year
- Nvidia's EPS of $1.87, up 95%, with margins still expanding
- Home Depot and Lowe's both stuck at 0.6% same-store sales growth, confirming no housing pickup
- A mailbag answer on private equity owned software: with ServiceNow down 50% in a year, the 2027 refinancing wall means sponsors must pony up equity or hand over the keys

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Have a line in the sand for rates and act when it breaks; his is 4.5% on the 10-year, and he lightened up rather than rationalize
- Tight credit spreads do not mean corporate and sovereign creditworthiness have converged; the technicals are doing the work
- Private credit's software problem is a 2027 event, not a today event, because that is when the refinancing forces a mark
- Exiting a great trade is its own decision: he covered the Big Short positions in spring 2008 because a government bailout, not the fundamentals, had become the risk

The mailbag reveal: covering meant calling the swap desks at Goldman Sachs and Deutsche Bank and accepting their prices, and what they did on their end is not something I thought about much.

How Silicon Valley Took Over the Defense Industry with Peter Arment | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 61

2026-05-25 | DEEP DIVE | 68 MIN | WITH PETER ARMENT

Baird's aerospace and defense analyst traces the industry from the 1993 Last Supper, when the Pentagon forced 60 primes to merge into a handful, to today, when venture-backed drone and space companies are unwinding that consolidation. The primes remain profitable but too big to pivot, and the share shift is running toward cheaper, faster, purpose-built systems.

DISCUSSED

- The Last Supper dinner at the Pentagon on July 21, 1993, under Defense Secretary Les Aspin, which collapsed roughly 60 prime contractors
- The wave of venture capital and private equity money that entered defense between 2020 and 2024

- Lockheed Martin's F-35 at a nominal 80 million dollars each, with the program more than a third through its total buy at 156 aircraft a year
- Taiwan's dilemma: the shortest distance to China is about 117 miles, which favors affordable drones over expensive fighters
- Boeing's economics of spending billions to lose billions to make billions, with the 787 costing double the plan and post-dilution free cash flow potential cut from about $40 to $20 per share
- A private equity rollup that consolidated the niche space supply chain the primes had outsourced
- Curtiss-Wright and BWX Technologies as nuclear plays, with Curtiss-Wright serving license extensions across the 94 US reactors and growing mid-teens

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Forced consolidation created primes too big to pivot; a trillion-dollar defense budget now increasingly flows to nimble newcomers
- In defense, the threat geometry sets the product: when the adversary is 117 miles away, cheap drones beat exquisite platforms
- Avoid airframe makers at the start of an R&D cycle, because cost overruns are a feature of the model, not an accident
- Aftermarket nuclear exposure is the quiet compounder: regulated license extensions on an installed base are recurring revenue with a growth kicker

Eisman's closing verdict: not much to do in the primes, but Curtiss-Wright and BWX are the two names he is going to work on himself.

Inside the Hidden Consumer Crisis with Lakshmi Ganapathi

2026-05-27 | DEEP DIVE | 32 MIN | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

Ganapathi argues the clean bank credit data is the problem rather than the reassurance, because extend and pretend keeps stressed borrowers marked as current. She and Eisman then map the same denial onto private credit's software book and finish on her short book.

DISCUSSED

- Flat nonaccruals on both consumer and commercial books across every bank, with Jamie Dimon saying there are no issues so far
- Extend and pretend keeping borrowers current on minimum payments, which lets lenders avoid marking to market and raising provisions because a provision is itself a panic signal
- Buy now pay later reaching roughly 45 million users, with 29% using it for groceries against 14% two years earlier, and 13% using it to pay rent
- Banks funding private credit through warehouse lines and direct lending, which then funds buy now pay later books through forward flow agreements
- MUFG looking to move 2 billion off its book through a synthetic risk transfer to insurance companies, moving risk in name only
- The private credit maturity wall arriving slowly, with roughly 11% refinancing next year and 20% after, against software marks down more than half
- Her short book, FICO on VantageScore share gains and banks building internal models, plus AutoZone and Dorman on invoice factoring, GPI in used cars, Wingstop and DoorDash on affordability

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Benign data is not the same as a benign situation. Ask what accounting choice is producing the clean number before you trust it
- The lender always breaks first and the consumer shows up as the second order effect, so watching consumer data for the first crack means watching the wrong series

- Track what a credit product is being used for, not just how much of it there is. Groceries and rent on installment plans is a distress signal a balance total hides
- A monopoly ends when a credible second option appears and the customers start building their own replacement, which is the FICO thesis in one line
- Risk transfer is not risk removal. Synthetic transfers move the exposure to insurers rather than retiring it

Eisman concedes the bank numbers are the numbers, then accepts they may be measuring something other than the consumer's actual health.

The SpaceX IPO: Science Fiction or Serious Investment? | The Weekly Wrap

2026-05-29 | WEEKLY WRAP | 21 MIN

He dissects the SpaceX S-1 ahead of the June 12 IPO and finds the numbers far less bold than the story: decelerating growth, a 1.9 billion dollar quarterly loss, and only one profitable division. He pairs it with a new recurring theme, that technology's business model builds dependence while subsidizing user costs, and AI tokens are next.

DISCUSSED

- Nasdaq rewriting its index rules so SpaceX can join with only about a 5% float, on a potential 1.75 to 2 trillion dollar valuation
- SpaceX 1Q26 numbers: revenue of 4.7 billion, up 15% versus 33% growth in 2025, with a 1.9 billion loss
- The segment split: connectivity at 3.3 billion is the only profitable division, while space revenue of 619 million fell 28%
- Salesforce beating on adjusted EPS of 3.88 while GAAP EPS was $2.42, a gap he attributes to stock-based comp he considers ridiculous to exclude
- The subsidized-addiction theme: like Uber Eats, AI token costs have been subsidized, and agentic AI is where the real bill arrives
- A mailbag on ratings agencies: Moody's and S&P up roughly 24% against a market that doubled, because 2020 and 2021 pulled a decade of debt issuance forward
- His answer to the ethical question of owning Moody's given the agencies' AAA stamps in 2008

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When an exchange changes its rules to accommodate one company, the deck is being stacked for the launch; read the S-1, not the mythology
- A 15% growth, money-losing company at a near 2 trillion dollar valuation prices in multi-planetary dreams, not the connectivity business that actually earns money
- Adjusted EPS that excludes stock-based comp is a choice, not a fact; the GAAP gap tells you how big the choice is
- Oligopolies can underperform for years for cyclical reasons, issuance droughts, without the moat being impaired; that can be the entry

On SpaceX versus bank stocks: the words we would like to expand our net interest margin just do not generate the same energy as multi-planetary exploration.

Is AI a Bubble? Gary Marcus on What Could Break the Story | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 62

2026-06-01 | DEEP DIVE | 50 MIN | WITH GARY MARCUS

Gary Marcus returns to argue that scaling stopped paying off in December 2024 and that the industry keeps promising more data will fix problems it has never solved. Eisman plays the reluctant bull: he shorted subprime, but he cannot short a story whose biggest company just grew revenue 85%.

DISCUSSED

- Marcus's 25-year thesis: distribution shift identified in 1998, hallucinations flagged in 2001, still unsolved
- Companies privately conceding around December 2024 that bigger models stopped delivering expected returns
- CPUs making a comeback (Intel included) because agents need CPU time alongside GPUs, and the case for medium models plus symbolic AI
- Token economics: all-you-can-eat pricing at slim or negative margins, with agents deepening losses just as the labs want to IPO
- One company spending 180 billion on infrastructure, which both call lunacy driven by FOMO
- A Sequoia-based estimate of how much revenue the industry collectively needs to justify the spend
- Nvidia's revenue accelerating from 65% to 85% growth over two quarters

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- What broke subprime was the end buyer refusing the paper; the AI equivalent would be customers refusing token-based pricing once the buffet closes
- LLMs are next-word predictors building a model of how people talk, which makes them superb mimics and unreliable generalizers
- Unlike a spreadsheet on your laptop, every LLM query has an incremental cloud cost, and that cost structure shapes the whole industry
- Marcus frames the AI trade as a bet with a low but nonzero probability of paying off, and Eisman accepts the framing

Eisman admits he could not make the short argument he made on subprime right now, because the biggest company on planet Earth just reported 85% revenue growth.

SpaceX's Exploding Capex, AI Addiction Lawsuits, and the Reality of "TokenMaxxing" | The Weekly Wrap

2026-06-05 | WEEKLY WRAP | 25 MIN

He defends last week's tongue-in-cheek SpaceX takedown by contrasting today's meme-driven IPOs with the institutional dog-and-pony shows he sat through, then turns to business models built on addiction. Kalshi, he argues, has taken gambling out of regulated rooms and put it everywhere, including classrooms.

DISCUSSED

- The SpaceX valuation assuming conquest of a $28.5 trillion TAM, most of it in AI, where Grok is not yet a world-class product
- Kalshi and near-miss psychology: a gambler who almost wins bets again, and more often
- Crypto losing its mojo just as Kalshi exploded
- Nvidia entering the PC market with a chip in Windows machines from Microsoft, Dell, HP, and Lenovo; over 30 laptops and 10 desktops planned
- S&P 500 up over 10% and Nasdaq up 15% for the year, with financials the notable laggard
- Partners Group's evergreen Global Value fund receiving 9.8% redemption requests against a 5% quarterly cap
- Mailbag: own versus rent in a housing market locked by 3 to 4% COVID mortgages against 7% new ones

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Redemption gates spreading from private credit to private equity vehicles signal investors questioning the entire alternatives space
- A locked housing market inflates prices artificially: scarce inventory, not strong demand, holds them up
- Buy a home below what you can afford so the hidden costs (taxes, maintenance) do not break you, and assume you will merely break even
- IPOs once priced in room for investors; meme-era offerings price for the sellers

His housing advice to a high school class: own a home if you want one, but never assume it will make you money.

The AI Semiconductor Boom and What Could End It with Stacy Rasgon | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 63

2026-06-08 | DEEP DIVE | 58 MIN | WITH STACY RASGON

Eisman says semis are now what financials were in 2008, the center of the universe, and brings back Bernstein's Stacy Rasgon seven months after his last appearance to explain why the boom is accelerating rather than peaking. The one thing that ends it, both agree, is disappointing returns on AI itself, and Rasgon thinks it is far too early for that.

DISCUSSED

- Nvidia resegmenting its data center business into hyperscale and non-hyperscale customers
- The GB300 NVL72 rack: 72 GPUs plus 36 ARM-based Grace CPUs, with agentic AI driving CPU demand per rack higher
- Rental prices on even old compute rising because demand outruns exponentially growing supply
- Intel: 18A yields near zero at this stage, foundry rumors around Apple, and packaging demand as the real positive
- The big five equipment makers: Applied Materials, Lam Research, KLA, ASML, and Tokyo Electron
- AI capex at roughly 75% of GDP growth last year, a share Rasgon compares to the railroad buildout
- China powering data centers with coal plants at will while the US struggles to add grid capacity, down to restarting Three Mile Island

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Investors in a supply-constrained boom chase bottlenecks, which is why memory and CPU stocks (SanDisk, Micron and peers) have beaten Nvidia itself this year
- Even in a mania, multiples can contract: the CPU names' earnings rose faster than their stocks
- If AI returns disappoint there is nowhere to hide, in semis or out; the buildout is carrying the whole economy
- Depreciation of old GPUs only matters in a demand collapse, at which point, as Rasgon puts it, everyone is screwed anyway

Eisman opens by explaining he saw the financial crisis coming because finance was the center of the universe and it was his sector; today the center of the universe is semiconductors.

Google Raises $85 Billion and the Market Finally Wakes Up | The Weekly Wrap

2026-06-12 | WEEKLY WRAP | 25 MIN

A real correction arrives: Broadcom's soft AI numbers plus strong jobs data push the S&P down 2.64% and Nasdaq down 4.18% on Friday. The deeper story is that hyperscalers have become capital-intensive hardware companies now asking public shareholders, not free cash flow, to fund a trillion dollars of capex.

DISCUSSED

- Google's $85 billion raise, plus SoftBank, Supermicro, and Oracle adding $20 billion, running his tally of equity demands to $360 billion
- Hyperscaler AI capex going from about 400 billion last year to close to 1 trillion this year
- The moat question: Gemini on top one week, Anthropic the next, despite the spend
- OpenAI's S-1 after raising $122 billion at an $852 billion valuation, making a $100 billion IPO plausible
- Apple's WWDC and how abandoning the LLM race now looks like a great decision

- Private equity technology deals down 70% in Q1 to $20 billion, holding periods stretching past 7 years, $4 trillion unmonetized
- The 10-year yield back above 4.5% after employment numbers took Fed cuts off the table

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- It is one thing to own AI stocks when the companies foot the capex bill, another when they raise the money from public shareholders
- Sameness across managers increases the risk that everyone underperforms at once; herd positioning is itself a risk factor
- If your active manager is hugging an index, just buy the index; pay up only for genuine stock picking
- Massive spend with no durable model differentiation is the signature of an industry without moats

His verdict on manager crowding into the same trades: this is way past FOMO, this is required uniformity in order to stay in business.

Is Private Equity Destroying the Life Insurance Industry? | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 64

2026-06-15 | DEEP DIVE | 48 MIN | WITH TOM GALLAGHER

After Tom Gober's alarming take on private equity in life insurance, Eisman seeks a second opinion from Tom Gallagher, the Evercore analyst he has known for decades. Gallagher is broadly comfortable: the big alternative insurers take somewhat more risk for an extra 100 basis points, but not an insane amount, and Eisman is surprised by the answer.

DISCUSSED

- The lineage from Apollo's 2012 annuity acquisition through Athene, taken public and then private again
- The player map: Apollo biggest, KKR's Global Atlantic second, Carlyle with 10% of a Corebridge piece alongside a Japanese insurer, Blackstone taking minority stakes
- Gallagher's bond-by-bond eye test of the top 30 to 40 private credit positions in alternative insurers' books
- Regulators accommodating offshore reinsurance because punitive rules would push companies out of their jurisdictions entirely
- Past blowups: 20-year liabilities hedged with three-month options, and secondary guarantee universal life priced for mid-single-digit lapses that ran at 1%
- Apollo's net interest margin squeezed by the roll-off of low-cost liabilities plus Fed cuts
- The Corebridge-Equitable merger as a scale play in commodity fixed annuities, and Lincoln's roughly 9.5% preferred due out in 2027

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Traditional life insurers run a zero-loss expectation model, so conservative that an extra 100 basis points of yield need not signal recklessness
- In a commodity product the only way to win is scale, which is the entire logic of annuity consolidation
- Decades of long-tail blowups, from long-term care to variable annuities, explain why these stocks sell at three to five times earnings and why the discount persists
- At three to five times earnings, buying back your own stock beats any M&A deal, yet the companies still will not go beyond about 8% of market cap a year

Eisman deliberately staged a second opinion against his own earlier guest, and admits he expected the trusted veteran to be more scared than he was.

The Lawsuits That Could Change Social Media Forever w/ Ben Zipursky

2026-06-17 | DEEP DIVE | 50 MIN | WITH BEN ZIPURSKY

Eisman brings a Fordham tort professor on to work out whether the wave of addiction lawsuits against Meta and Google can survive Section 230. Zipursky explains how plaintiffs reframe the claim as defective product design rather than harmful content, and why he thinks the strongest looking theory is also the weakest on the law.

DISCUSSED

- Section 230C of the Communications Decency Act and how broadly courts have read it, including the Sixth Circuit protecting the operator of a gossip site over user submitted defamation
- The Los Angeles verdict against Meta, roughly 6 million dollars, with one plaintiff among 1,800 in that filing alone and scores of similar suits nationwide
- The New Mexico case split into a consumer fraud jury phase and an injunctive phase heard by a judge, since injunctions do not usually go to a jury
- What the injunction actually asks for, namely that Meta redesign its algorithms to be less addictive
- Zipursky's negative view of the public nuisance theory, the same theory he is publishing against in the opioid context, which he calls made up but scary enough to force settlements
- The product liability route, traced back through the collapse of the privity rule and the exploding Coke bottle line of cases, where a defect is enough without proving negligence
- The complete absence of appellate rulings so far, with only two tried cases and every one of them heading up on appeal

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The legal question that decides the money is framing. Content claims die under Section 230, design defect claims survive it
- A theory can be strong as leverage and weak as law. Public nuisance settles cases precisely because defendants will not risk it going to verdict
- Two trial verdicts are not a trend. Until an appellate court rules, nothing about the exposure is settled
- Common law does move, and it moves through exactly this kind of repeated litigation, so slow legislatures are not the only route to a rule change
- Watch state legislatures alongside the courts. Zipursky thinks statutory regulation of social media is politically achievable where other tech regulation is not

The tort professor turns out to be more optimistic about legislation than about the lawsuits he is being asked to handicap.

Anthropic Gets Shut Down By the Government and the AI Story Gets More Complicated | The Weekly Wrap

2026-06-18 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

A short Juneteenth week with two shocks: an Iran memorandum of understanding that the market overcelebrated, and the US government issuing an export control directive that effectively shuts down Anthropic's Fable 5 and Mythos 5 models. He then lays out his fullest side-by-side of the AI bull and bear cases yet.

DISCUSSED

- The Iran deal being only an MOU to negotiate for 60 days, with the Strait of Hormuz open in the interim; oil fell 5%
- Anthropic classified a supply chain risk after limiting DoD usage, then barred from giving foreign nationals, including its own employees, access to Fable 5 and Mythos 5
- Kevin Warsh's first Fed meeting: rates unchanged, cuts ruled out, hikes not

- The bear case ledger: shareholders now fund capex, and 1 trillion of annual spend has produced no visible moats
- The airlines versus TransDigm analogy: hyperscalers as capital-hungry airlines, their suppliers as the great businesses
- Europe's top five (ASML, then Roche, LVMH, Novartis, Nestle at 260 to 330 billion) against US top five market caps of 2.7 to 5.1 trillion
- Premium interviews with law professor Ben Zipursky on social media addiction suits and with cannabis company Glass House Brands after rescheduling

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Watch the difference between a treaty and a memorandum of understanding; markets priced a peace that has not been negotiated
- When an industry turns capital intensive, look for its TransDigm: the suppliers, not the platforms, may own the pricing power
- Europe is not a hedge against a US recession; its large caps depend on the US economy and carry almost no tech exposure
- Addiction-model lawsuits hinge on intent: algorithms designed to addict, not merely engaging products

The week's strangest headline delivered deadpan: the government's export directive shuts down the most sophisticated models of a leading AI lab, and the AI story gets more complicated.

The Real State of the American Consumer w/ Three Evercore Analysts | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 65

2026-06-22 | DEEP DIVE | 69 MIN | WITH MICHAEL BINETTI, DAVID PALMER, GREG MELICH

Eisman calls in reinforcements: three Evercore analysts covering retail, restaurants and food, and big box, for a full anatomy of the K-shaped consumer. The verdict is a hollowed-out middle, a protein-obsessed eater, and one enormous winner in Walmart.

DISCUSSED

- Restaurant spending splitting into equal thirds across under 50,000, 50,000 to 100,000, and over 100,000 income cohorts
- The barbell in retail: Ralph Lauren and Coach fine at the top, off-price killing it on value, an ocean of struggle in the middle despite the best tax refund season since COVID
- Binetti's Murderer's Row of broken stocks: Lululemon, Ulta, Gap, Kohl's, Canada Goose
- Nike's rushed direct-to-consumer push, which cost it shelf intelligence and let competitors seize on product weakness
- Team protein: LongHorn running 10 to 11% same-store sales while Olive Garden, Domino's, and Wendy's struggle
- Legacy food companies (Smucker's, Kellogg's, Kraft Heinz, Campbell) skewed away from protein in a GLP-1 world
- Home Depot and Lowe's stuck behind a locked housing market, with pro the only growth avenue, and Walmart's same-day delivery of nearly anything

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Walmart's strength is a warning, not just a stock story: it is winning because the middle-income consumer is trading down
- A brand that goes direct-to-consumer too fast stops seeing why shoppers pick up the competitor's shoe, and loses the market's early warning system
- GLP-1 drugs are quietly repricing the entire food aisle; the losers are the non-protein legacy brands with no end in sight
- Experiential retail like the Polo Bar keeps an aspirational brand alive off the shelf

- Housing will not unlock through prices: supply scarcity keeps them rising even with sales terrible

Eisman reads out the list of broken retail stocks and christens it Murderer's Row.

Why Cannabis Rescheduling Changes Everything for Glass House Brands

2026-06-24 | DEEP DIVE | 41 MIN | WITH JONATHAN DECOURCY

Medical cannabis moved from Schedule I to Schedule III in late April, and Eisman brings back Glass House Brands to work out what that unlocks. The answer is geography: the same pound that fetches 200 dollars in California sells for 800 in other medical states and more in Europe, with almost no added cost beyond shipping. Eisman owns the stock and says so repeatedly while insisting he is not selling it to anyone.

DISCUSSED

- Medical cannabis reclassified from Schedule I to Schedule III on April 23, with an expedited DEA hearing on recreational set for June 29 and a mid July deadline
- Glass House producing at roughly 100 dollars per pound and selling into California wholesale at about 200, against 800 to 1,000 per pound in other US medical markets
- First quarter revenue of 40.5 million, roughly 80% wholesale and the rest from 11 retail stores
- Capacity of about 1.4 million pounds of biomass with the current build out and one greenhouse still vacant, against roughly 700,000 pounds in a normal prior year
- Europe as a near empty field, with Germany already a multi billion dollar medical market and almost no European cultivation
- The exchange listing problem, with the stock stuck on CBOE Canada and US over the counter, blocking institutional ownership, and precedents where Curaleaf and TerrAscend uplisted to the TSX on a small non Schedule I revenue line
- Cannabis and wine farms failing in California, creating land Glass House can buy and convert

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When a regulatory cage opens, the low cost producer captures the most, because the price gap between markets falls straight to margin
- A listing venue is part of the thesis. A stock institutions legally cannot buy carries a discount that disappears the day they can
- Ask what a company can do tomorrow that it could not do yesterday. That question separates real regulatory change from headlines
- Disclose your position before you teach the story, then let the listener discount you accordingly

DeCourcy opens by joking that the interview may well be about him getting people to buy the stock, and Eisman lets it stand.

The Q2 2026 Report Card: Who Won, Who Lost, and Why | The Weekly Wrap

2026-06-26 | WEEKLY WRAP | 23 MIN

An early second-quarter report card before he leaves on holiday: a powerful rally off the Q1 bottom, with the S&P up 15% and Nasdaq up 23% for the quarter. Under the surface, investors are chasing scarcity in semiconductors while fleeing anything AI threatens to eat, from software to consulting.

DISCUSSED

- SanDisk and Micron both up over 200% in the second quarter alone as investors play capex-driven scarcity
- Software carnage: Salesforce down 18%, Adobe down 19%, Intuit down 39%
- Accenture's ugly quarter: revenue up 3%, bookings down 3%, contracts slipping to fiscal 27, the stock down 18% Friday and over 50% for the year
- Three Accenture acquisitions announced in one day, which he reads as buying stuff to hide weakness

- Premium subscriptions moving to Substack with a bonus month for existing members
- Glass House Brands listing on the NYSE June 30 under ticker GLAS after medical cannabis rescheduling to schedule three
- His history lesson on Alan Greenspan ignoring unpayable subprime mortgages, versus Kevin Warsh's close-to-the-vest style

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When capex is unstoppable, the market pays for whatever is scarce; the AI report card is really a scarcity report card
- Clustered acquisitions announced into weak results are a red flag, not a growth story
- Companies are spending more on AI and hiring consultants to help, while cutting everything else; net-net the consultants still lose
- Markets are amoral: they do not care about a social safety net, only about dynamism, which is the whole US versus Europe investment case

His epitaph for Greenspan: he saw borrowers who could not pay, decided legal meant acceptable, and history will not be kind to him.

The Market's Biggest Warning Signs Right Now with Todd Sohn | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 66

2026-06-29 | DEEP DIVE | 50 MIN | WITH TODD SOHN

A chart-by-chart tour with Strategas's chief chartist that keeps arriving at the same place: every flow in the market is a tech flow. Eisman's closing warning is that an index holder is no longer diversified, and if the one theme reverses there will be no place to hide.

DISCUSSED

- Reading RSI momentum on the semiconductor ETF SOXX, and why overbought is a guideline, not a rule
- The boom in leveraged ETFs, including single-stock two-times products that did not exist until 2022
- Tech at nearly 40% of the S&P 500, and well over 50% once Google and Amazon are added back in
- Flows pouring into tech ETFs while cyclicals and defensives sit moribund; industrials get money only through the power story
- No flows into financials, which Sohn reads as unease and, contrarily, as bullish
- REITs at roughly 2% of the S&P, an index of about 30 stocks, too small for a portfolio manager to care
- Bitcoin's chart described as rough, with money leaving both gold and Bitcoin ETFs and young traders decamping to Kalshi

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Owning the index no longer means owning diversification; market-cap weighting has quietly concentrated most funds in the same handful of names
- Charts are a summary device: a hundred of them can reconstruct a month of news, and they tell you fastest when you are wrong
- Within tech the winners are the groups without AI capital-intensity exposure, semis and tech equipment, while Meta, Oracle, Microsoft and Amazon charts have gone soft
- An asset that migrates from counterculture to traditional finance can lose the very audience that drove it; Bitcoin's absorption into TradFi was, in Eisman's word, death

Sohn's parting instruction is pay attention to what you own; Eisman's is darker: if this stuff ever reverses, there will be no place to hide.

Steve Eisman Reveals His Personal Portfolio: Every Position Explained

2026-07-01 | DEEP DIVE | 36 MIN

Eisman answers a recurring subscriber request and walks his 16 long positions one by one, sorted into five themes: AI, power and infrastructure, value, great franchises, and unique stories. He explains his method first, buy a story, size it fully, check it every quarter, sell when the thesis breaks, and then names the four conditions that would make him tear the whole thing up.

DISCUSSED

- Sixteen longs across five themes, with seven of them tech or AI adjacent, which he defends by noting infotech is 37% of the S&P 500 and closer to 50% once Google and Amazon are counted
- His guess that at least 50% of all AI spending traces back to Anthropic and OpenAI, both of which lose billions and depend on venture funding, with over 50% of Oracle's data center backlog tied to OpenAI
- The Wall Street Journal report that OpenAI may slash prices, which he reads as evidence AI has little or no moat, since the industry already undercharges for tokens
- Arista falling 14% for not raising guidance enough, and his admission that failing to also buy the cheaper Cisco was a mistake
- Trimming Microsoft over the AI software debate and possible capital raising, noting Chris Hohn sold his entire position
- GE Vernova at 45 times 2026 earnings and Quanta at 50 times, both defended on order backlogs that give years of earnings visibility
- Charter as a cheap turnaround bundling cable and mobile at 100 dollars against 180 to 200 for rivals, plus Meritage Homes bought near tangible book, both admittedly badly timed
- A Glass House valuation exercise producing 40, 49 and 58 dollars per share across three EBITDA margin scenarios against a 13 dollar stock

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Concentration is a decision, not an accident. Count your AI exposure against the index weight before calling it aggressive
- The discipline that protects a long hold is studying the sell case every quarter, not conviction
- Expensive is acceptable when the backlog is long. A business booking orders that fill in years has visibility a multiple cannot see
- Write down in advance what would change your mind. He names four triggers, including the 10 year holding above 4.5% for more than a few weeks
- When both sides of a debate are so passionate they cannot tolerate each other, treat that heat as a bubble signal

He warns that today's buy the dip reflex belongs to investors too young to have invested through the flat 1970s.

Who Wins the Midterms & What It Means for Markets with Dan Clifton | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 67

2026-07-06 | DEEP DIVE | 45 MIN | WITH DAN CLIFTON

The show's first-ever guest returns to handicap the midterms: Democrats likely take the House, the Senate is a 50/50 coin flip, and everything traces back to April 2025, when tariffs turned Trump's economic approval negative for the first time. Clifton then maps how Fed personnel, the 2028 field and the data center backlash all hang off that political arithmetic.

DISCUSSED

- How the April 3, 2025 tariff announcement, the day before Clifton's first appearance, flipped Trump's approval on the economy negative for the first time

- Four political parties in Washington, two inside each formal party, and why a Democratic Congress would choose accomplishment over ambition
- Senate math: Democratic pickup chances in four states, a looming nomination error in Michigan, and a prestigious former governor running in New Hampshire
- Powell holding his seat through the midterms so a Democratic Senate would force Trump to appoint a mainstream economist rather than a MAGA loyalist
- Kevin Warsh's focus on shrinking the Fed's 6 trillion dollar balance sheet by about 1 trillion over time
- Data centers as the new fracking: Loudoun County, Virginia data centers paying 40% of the education bill, cutting property taxes about $2,500 a year against a $20 electricity increase
- 2028 handicapping: Newsom the messy-field Democratic frontrunner; Vance leading Republicans with Rubio and DeSantis alive, and Trump encouraging Vance rather than reining him in

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Central bank succession is a political chess game: a chair can protect institutional independence simply by timing his own departure around Senate control
- Frontrunner status three years out is nearly worthless; the early leader is rarely the nominee
- Local fiscal math can defuse a national backlash: where data centers visibly cut property taxes, the politics flip
- Presidents historically muzzle ambitious vice presidents; Trump's encouragement of Vance breaks a pattern running from Reagan-Bush through Clinton-Gore
- Large-cap defense stocks have badly underperformed while defense tech has not, a signal of where the new procurement model is heading

Clifton's thesis in five words: data centers are the new fracking, opposed by the same environmental money.

The Bearish Case for Oil and Gold with Queen Anne's Gate Capital

2026-07-08 | DEEP DIVE | 39 MIN | WITH KATHLEEN KELLY, NANCY O'FLYNN

Kelly and O'Flynn argue the war disguised a huge and growing oil surplus, and that when the fog lifts prices fall hard. Kelly says the 20s are reachable, with 40 to 50 the likelier landing zone. O'Flynn explains why gold sold off during exactly the crisis it was supposed to hedge, and neither guest nor host can find a reason to own crypto.

DISCUSSED

- Kelly's view that oil was at 50 and heading to 40 before the war, and that surpluses are larger now, making the 20s reachable
- Roughly 5 million barrels per day of new supply arriving next year against demand growth of maybe 2.5 million even on generous assumptions
- The UAE adding about 1.5 million barrels now that it sits outside OPEC, plus China pulling back its own demand
- Record US exports of distillate and jet fuel propping up apparent demand, with demand itself calculated as a residual plug
- The Strait of Hormuz mattering far less than assumed, with Saudi and UAE bypass routes running and Iraq, the most exposed producer, claiming two week restart capability
- Gold running from 2,500 to 5,200 over last year in anticipation of catastrophe, then selling off when the catastrophe arrived and holders needed cash
- Both guests preferring silver to gold, and Eisman noting he has never owned gold in his life

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Oil demand is a residual, backed out from supply, refining runs and net trade. Treat it as an estimate with a plug inside it

- A crowded consensus is its own risk. When you cannot find a bear anywhere, the bullish news is already in the price
- A war can hide a surplus. Disruption headlines suppress the inventory signal until the shooting stops
- Cheaper oil is not automatically disinflationary in a country where electricity, not oil, drives the energy bill

Eisman notes crypto falls on the very days it is supposed to rise, with roughly 75% correlation to the Nasdaq, and O'Flynn suggests young traders left crypto for prediction markets.

Why the Entire Market Is Now a Single Bet on AI | The Weekly Wrap

2026-07-10 | WEEKLY WRAP | 23 MIN

A holiday-week wrap that Eisman uses to step back and structure the AI debate itself, arguing that stocks and bonds have collapsed into one trade. He maps the argument onto his subprime experience: theses develop over time, and the job now is to understand this one well enough to measure its risk.

DISCUSSED

- Iranian attacks on shipping in the Strait of Hormuz, and a premium deep dive flagging the UAE pipeline opening in 2027 that would make the strait matter less
- Torsten Slok's estimate that AI data center and energy spending contributes about 1 percentage point of GDP growth, roughly half the total
- AI token pricing: subscriptions that never covered token costs, corporations grading employees on usage volume, and what happens as subsidies fade
- Chinese AI models as a cheap alternative, raising the possibility of a full-blown price war
- The parallel to May 2007, when a tip about a Morgan Stanley internal subprime fund launched a year-long treasure hunt into Wall Street's balance sheet exposure
- Nike flat after a disappointing call, plus Circle and stablecoin news
- A mailbag on reading: no business books, tons of history, historical fiction like Colleen McCullough's First Man in Rome, and comic books

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Diversification has quietly ceased to exist when the stock and bond markets are both expressions of the same AI trade
- Investment arguments are built in stages, not delivered whole; the subprime thesis took over a year of digging after the first clue
- Subsidized pricing manufactures demand; the real test of AI economics arrives when customers pay the true token cost
- Broad, seemingly unrelated reading is an investing edge: history and even dystopian fiction teach that leaders act irrationally and anything is possible

On why his cynicism was right in the GFC when everyone laughed: being well-read is my superpower.

AI Dominates Economy and Markets with Torsten Slok | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 68

2026-07-13 | DEEP DIVE | 57 MIN | WITH TORSTEN SLOK

Apollo's chief economist decomposes US growth into three unusual engines, with AI spending alone providing about half of it, and shows the K-shaped economy running through wealth, wages and inflation at once. The conversation ends where Eisman wants it: the 60/40 portfolio is now AI-indexed on both sides, so the story had better work.

DISCUSSED

- GDP growth of about 2% split into roughly 1 point from AI data center and energy spending, 0.3 from the industrial renaissance, and 0.9 from big beautiful bill tax refunds

- Housing and autos stalling because the rate-sensitive economy no longer drives growth, leaving rates high for longer
- The K shape measured three ways: wealth, Atlanta Fed wage growth by income level, and New York Fed inflation exposure for low-income households
- The software maturity wall: 2021 and 2022 vintage debt with 7-year maturities coming due in 2028 and 2029, before the AI disruption debate even starts
- US dynamism at possibly an all-time high, with strong job creation among young people despite the layoff headlines
- Federal debt at about 100% of GDP heading toward 175%, and why China avoids weaponizing its Treasury holdings
- Europe described as sclerotic, waking up on defense but needing strategic financing to compete

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Growth built on one sector is fragile in a specific way: no single sector, even housing, has contributed a full GDP point in decades
- Tax-refund stimulus creates its own cliff; strip it out and the 2027 growth base falls below 2%
- A refinancing wall can kill leveraged software companies on macro grounds alone, whatever AI does to their terminal value
- Bond allocations no longer hedge equity AI exposure, because data center debt issuance has AI-indexed the credit market too
- A creditor rarely crashes its best customer; China's Treasury restraint is self-interest, not goodwill

Eisman's closing verdict: this AI story better work, because if it does not, the losses will be mammoth.

Beyond Ozempic: The Next Wave of Biotech Winners with Boris Peaker

2026-07-15 | DEEP DIVE | 74 MIN | WITH BORIS PEAKER

Eisman admits he has never really invested in biotech and spends 74 minutes being taught the sector from the ground up by Jones Trading analyst Boris Peaker. Peaker explains why the pharma and biotech distinction has collapsed, why Phase 1 success so often dies in Phase 3, and where the economics actually reward innovation. The verdict on the business model is blunt: most biotechs exist to be bought.

DISCUSSED

- The historical split between pharma making small molecules and biotech making complex biologics, dating to Genentech in the late 1970s, now effectively gone
- Why Phase 1 results mislead, with carefully curated patients giving way to broad populations where diet, adherence and drug interactions introduce variability
- Grapefruit blocking a liver enzyme pathway and disrupting many drugs, offered as the everyday example of uncontrolled patient behavior
- Trial cost drivers including university administrative overhead of 30% to 40% on top of study payments, plus screening, imaging and diagnostics
- Oncology as the commercially favored field because efficacy reads out fast and safety tolerance is higher for terminal patients
- Revolution's pancreatic cancer drug extending median survival from about 6 months to about 13, which Peaker calls scientifically impressive and Eisman calls still only 13 months
- Antibiotics as commercially unattractive because a new one is held back as a drug of last resort, and aging as unfundable because the FDA demands a functional endpoint
- B cell depletion and immune reset, with a German lupus study keeping B cells undetectable for three to four months and seeing autoantibodies fail to return

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Better science does not mean a better business. Antibiotics prove that a genuinely needed drug can have no commercial model
- Ask what the endpoint is before believing a therapeutic area is investable. No measurable functional endpoint means no approval path
- Early stage trial data is a filtered sample. The curation that makes Phase 1 look good is exactly what Phase 3 removes
- In a sector where the exit is acquisition, the question is not can this company commercialize, but will a large buyer want to

Peaker wants to see oncology survival curves plotted next to life insurance actuarial tables, so the real remaining gap is visible.

Bank Earnings Just Gave the Market a Much Needed Confidence Boost | The Weekly Wrap

2026-07-17 | WEEKLY WRAP | 26 MIN

Bank earnings come in with benign credit across the board, which Eisman treats as the single best concurrent read on the US economy. Around that anchor he works through Circle's competitive problem, an IBM pre-announcement that rattles software, and a mailbag that turns into a guided tour of his 11,000-comic collection.

DISCUSSED

- Large-bank credit trends flat year over year and versus the first quarter; banks trading at 1.3 to 2.1 times tangible book on returns of 13% to 18%
- Circle's bank charter weighed against the bigger news of a Visa and Mastercard stablecoin consortium; the stock's round trip from a $31 IPO in June 2025 to nearly 270 to about 63
- IBM pre-announcing a disastrous quarter with grim implications for the software sector, while PayPal is reported possibly for sale
- UnitedHealth beating and raising on flat revenue, with industry-wide price increases doing the work
- GE Aerospace earning $2.02 versus a $1.86 estimate on revenue of 12.63 billion, up 24%, and the stock falling anyway
- A mailbag on Bank of New York: a trust bank he has never found worth the attention, and a confession that he owns no banks right now
- Twenty-one graphic novel recommendations, heavy on Brian Michael Bendis, plus David Gemmell's Lord of the Silver Bow for The Odyssey's movie week

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Bank results are a concurrent indicator with the broadest credit exposure in the economy; when they are benign, the predicted crisis is not here yet
- Creating a stablecoin is easy; breaking into the payments system is the hard part, which is why a Visa and Mastercard consortium outweighs a bank charter
- A beat means nothing without the pre-positioning: GE Aerospace's excellent quarter still sent the stock down
- The most important post-GFC story is how resilient the US economy has become, seventeen years of predicted crises that never arrived

The premium tease quotes Boris Peaker's biggest AI hope for biotech: cutting the probability that a large clinical trial fails.

AI Has a Power Problem: Why the U.S. Power Grid Can't Keep Up | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 69

2026-07-21 | DEEP DIVE | 47 MIN | WITH BEN KALLO

Baird's sustainable energy and mobility analyst covers the ring just outside the semiconductor center of the universe: the companies electrifying the grid that AI needs. The theme throughout is physical constraint, since turbines, permits and labor all move on timescales the AI buildout does not respect.

DISCUSSED

- Grid strain predating the data center wave: Midtown Manhattan office towers already getting curtailment notices banning air conditioning from 12 to 4 on hot days
- The US adding on the order of 30 gigawatts of power a year, the equivalent of a couple of cities, much of it data center driven
- GE Vernova's gas turbines: an order booked this quarter is not installed at a utility until 2030 or 2031, giving visibility deep into the 2030s, with nuclear not material to earnings until at least 2035
- Tesla's megapack battery business growing over 30% a year from plants in California, Texas and Shanghai, and Kallo's bet that SpaceX buys Tesla relatively soon
- Rivian's R2, a roughly $40,000 to $45,000 smaller SUV that Kallo drove at launch and thinks out-styles the saturated Model Y
- Residential solar's brutal economics, door-to-door sales with $10,000 customer acquisition costs, against utility-scale; First Solar and Nextracker discussed, with tariffs souring him on most of the group
- Air permits for nitrogen and sulfur oxides taking six months at the state and local level even as federal CO2 concern disappears

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- The binding constraint on AI is physical: turbines, transformers, permits and skilled labor cannot be scaled at software speed
- Long-lead-time equipment makers enjoy a rare kind of earnings visibility; GE Vernova can see its backlog well into the next decade
- Hyperscalers still honor their own CO2 targets even where regulators no longer care, which keeps clean generation in the mix
- Labor supply may be the last bottleneck standing: the open question is whether the US can staff everything it has decided to build

Kallo, on Musk consolidating control, predicts SpaceX will buy Tesla and soon; Eisman stays a skeptic on the robotaxi promise, noting Elon has been making it for 10 years.

Payments Industry - Fear and Reality

2026-07-22 | DEEP DIVE | 44 MIN | WITH KEN SUCHOSKI

Investors have marked down the entire payments complex on fear of agentic AI, and Suchoski's research says the fear runs far ahead of the facts. Agents today mostly do discovery and comparison while humans still press pay, and any agentic commerce that scales will almost certainly run over the existing card rails. Eisman's takeaway is that Visa and MasterCard are the only long term holdings in the group.

DISCUSSED

- Suchoski's framework of delegation levels, from a recurring subscription at the low end to full agent execution, with today's activity concentrated in search and comparison
- Consumer protections, habit and rewards as the reason card rails are sticky, and the requirement that any new rail replicate chargeback protection before adoption
- Payments being used as a source of funds, shorted to finance positions in faster growing AI exposed names rather than on company specific bearishness

- Bitcoin falling from roughly 120,000 near its October peak to about 65,000, dragging stablecoin volumes that are mostly tied to digital asset trading
- The stablecoin bull case shifting away from Circle, with cross border B2B still logically compelling but adoption Eisman calls glacial
- Visa and MasterCard partnering with stablecoin issuers to let wallet holders spend over the existing network, leveraging distribution rather than defending against it
- PayPal's premium pricing surviving after rivals matched its checkout experience, and Toast hit twice as both a payments and a software name plus rising memory chip costs

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Separate the psychology from the mechanics. A sector can be repriced on a fear whose evidence has not arrived
- A new payment rail must clear the two sided adoption problem and match incumbent fraud protection. Technical superiority alone moves nobody
- Short selling is not always a bearish opinion. Sometimes a group is sold simply to fund a better idea elsewhere
- In a hard industry, own the toll collectors and treat everything else as a trade

On stablecoins Eisman answers the logic with a demand for proof: great thesis, show me the money.

Google's Negative Cash Flow and the AI Capex Reckoning | The Weekly Wrap

2026-07-24 | WEEKLY WRAP | 23 MIN

Earnings week shows investors finally punishing ever-mounting AI capex while rewarding almost nothing. Eisman works through his own book, the Equifax read-across to his FICO short, Moody's, and ServiceNow, whose fine quarter loses to the SaaSpocalypse narrative anyway.

DISCUSSED

- US and Iran trading blows over the weekend as the war grinds on
- Equifax results as a window on the FICO short: the Workforce Solutions division, EWS, is really a software business now caught in the SaaSpocalypse debate over AI-powered verification
- Moody's earning $4.68, up 31%, with the 2026 multiple now below 30 times; he keeps owning the duopoly and dismisses the AI-disruption fear
- ServiceNow: EPS up 10%, revenue of 4 billion up 24%, no visible AI damage, stock down almost 4% and off 38% for the year
- A mailbag on Bank of New York and why he owns no bank stocks at the moment despite the group's 30%-plus run
- A tutorial on funding shorts: shorting a stock you expect to go nowhere to finance a long you love
- Charter reporting Friday, one day after the wrap records

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When a narrative hardens, fundamentals stop mattering in the short run; fighting the AI narrative is like fighting a ghost
- A quality franchise going sideways is a valuation reset in disguise: Moody's flat since fall 2024 is the cheapest it has been in years
- Shorts are not always directional bets; a funding short converts a mediocre stock into capital for a better idea
- Watch what investors punish, not what companies report: identical beats now get opposite reactions depending on capex exposure

The ServiceNow line of the week: the irony is that it keeps executing well, but fighting the AI narrative is like fighting a ghost.

The AI Revolution: Who Wins, Who Loses & the SaaSpocalypse | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 70

2026-07-27 | DEEP DIVE | 54 MIN | WITH DAN IVES, GIL LURIA

Two full-stack tech analysts, the perma-bull newly out on his own and the more measured Davidson voice, argue out how the AI debate turned two-sided in a single year. Even the bulls now concede the live questions: return on the data center spend, whether moats exist, and which incumbents AI eats.

DISCUSSED

- The two master debates: will the data center buildout earn a return on its capital, and do the model companies have any moat
- The Oracle object lesson: backlog jumping from 150 to 450 billion in a day, revealed as one OpenAI deal, from a customer that on September 11, 2025 had little revenue and 1.1 trillion dollars of additional commitments
- Open source as the quiet threat: Linux and Apache precedents, frontier models for mission-critical work, free models for everything else
- Google graded a distant second in consumer chat and third in enterprise AI, a bureaucracy losing inventors like Noam Shazeer to OpenAI
- Gil's winners and losers: Microsoft insurmountable via data centers plus Outlook, Salesforce a loser that stopped investing and just raises prices
- Cybersecurity budgets expected to double in two to three years because every AI agent expands the attack surface
- Data center moratoriums framed as a gift to China, and AI's self-inflicted PR problem over job-loss rhetoric and electricity bills

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A backlog is only as good as its counterparty; one undercapitalized customer can be most of a headline number
- Moats may sit in the capex layer, not the model layer: the hyperscaler data center footprint is a barrier even if frontier models commoditize
- The doom narrative can be a competitive weapon; incumbents lobbying for safety regulation are also raising rivals' costs
- Wealth in a platform shift accrues across the whole supply chain, so the moat question at the top may matter less than it seems
- In fast regimes, updating is the discipline: these analysts expect to change their own opinions many times by fall

The panel's message to OpenAI and Anthropic on the wipe-out-white-collar-jobs rhetoric: knock it off, and per Ives, they have been told.

The Real Estate Brokerage War, For-Profit Education, & the Art of the Short with Brad Safalow

2026-07-29 | DEEP DIVE | 71 MIN | WITH BRAD SAFALOW

Safalow walks the residential brokerage ecosystem after the commission settlement, where Compass is trying to route listings around the MLS and Zillow keeps executing while the stock gets re-rated. He then argues the for-profit education group is a structural short, and updates three shorts he pitched a year earlier. Eisman closes by grading each idea himself.

DISCUSSED

- The MLS as the backbone of residential real estate, roughly 500 of them nationally, and Compass partnering with regional MLSs to build a national equivalent it can steer

- State pushback on private listings, with Washington's ban going into effect and Connecticut proposing rules on what a private listing may be
- The commission structure holding at 5 to 5.2 percent nationally, split about 2.5 percent each side, with brokers passing roughly 80 percent back to the agent
- Zillow as a recommendation that has been, in Safalow's words, a disaster for him personally even though the company has not missed a number
- For-profit education stocks rallying hard on a Trump win and then facing the One Big Beautiful Bill Act, which kills the Grad Plus program that let graduate students borrow up to cost of attendance
- Ghost students, where AI chatbots enroll at schools to harvest aid, plus a shrinking high school population and collapsing cost of educational content
- Three short updates: Trupanion's aging pet book raising claims costs, Fresh Pet's human grade marketing retreat against Farmer's Dog while Costco went from zero to over 10 percent of revenue between 2022 and 2025, and Kinsale trading at three and a half to four times book with estimates Safalow thinks are 40 to 60 percent too high

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A stock can be right on fundamentals and still lose you money through multiple compression. Safalow's Zillow call never missed a number and still went against him
- When an industry's distribution layer is under attack, watch the states, not the incumbents. Legislatures moved on private listings faster than the brokerages did
- Aging books kill subscription insurance. Once growth stops, the average pet gets older every year and the loss ratio follows
- An insurer that never hires from outside its own ecosystem builds culture and blind spots at the same rate
- Marketing claims that cannot survive inspection, like human grade pet food that is not human grade, are a preview of the share loss

Safalow discloses he is short Google in his personal account, directly to a host who owns it, and Eisman waves it off and keeps going.

The AI Debate Gets More Complicated: Microsoft Has a Win, Meta Stumbles | The Weekly Wrap

2026-07-31 | WEEKLY WRAP | 27 MIN

Eisman opens by capitulating on Charter, then walks through an earnings week that split the AI trade in two: Microsoft and Amazon win, Meta burns cash, and credit markets start charging the smaller players real money. He refuses to call the AI endgame, arguing the facts change too fast for anyone to predict it.

DISCUSSED

- Giving up on Charter after 172,000 second-quarter broadband losses, two bad quarters after his January recommendation
- Meta's free cash flow shrinking to 784 million on 28% revenue growth and 55% expense growth, with capex guidance narrowed to 130 to 145 billion
- Amazon Web Services revenue growth jumping to 37%, sending the stock up over 7% after hours
- The SOX semiconductor index down 23% from its June 22nd peak
- CoreWeave raising 2.6 billion of debt priced above 9%, while Google borrows cheaply
- Situational Awareness, the 20 billion hedge fund founded by former OpenAI employee Leopold Aschenbrenner, seeking fresh capital after margin losses
- A mailbag on the K-shaped economy and the wealth takeoff since the mid-1800s Industrial Revolution

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Admit the mistake and move on; two bad quarters in a row on the core metric outweigh a cheap valuation
- A credit cycle is forming inside AI: fixed income investors now discriminate between hyperscalers that can repay and newer borrowers that might not
- Anyone who claims to confidently predict the AI outcome is kidding themselves; the moats exist, but the story rewrites itself weekly
- Even a correct thesis dies on leverage; margin turned a tech correction into a forced capital raise

He opens on Charter without hedging: bottom line, I give up. Simply put, I made a mistake.

250 Years of American Capitalism: Hamilton, the GFC, & the AI Boom | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 71

2026-08-03 | DEEP DIVE | 52 MIN | WITH ADRIAN WOOLDRIDGE

For the 250th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence, Eisman interviews Adrian Wooldridge, co-author with the late Alan Greenspan of Capitalism in America, on why the United States out-industrialized everyone. The episode ends in a genuine disagreement: Wooldridge reports that Greenspan blamed the GFC mostly on Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac, and Eisman blames the leverage Greenspan himself allowed into the banks.

DISCUSSED

- How Wooldridge, an Oxford academic turned Economist writer, came to co-author the book with Greenspan
- Hamilton versus Jefferson, and Hamilton's infant-industry tariff argument later copied by Germany
- Why creative destruction ran hotter in America: a massive internal market, a culture wired for ambition, and a constitution that constrains government
- The Hoover-to-FDR handover taking roughly six months in the middle of the Depression, leaving the country effectively without a government
- Greenspan's view that finance had become untethered from the economy, self-serving and absorbing too much talent
- Greenspan writing the GFC section solo and blaming Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac, which Eisman rejects in his closing thoughts

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Protectionism has a real historical win on its record; infant-industry tariffs helped build dominant American and German industries, which complicates the modern tariff debate
- America's edge is cultural churn: rich European families persist for centuries while American wealth turns over, and the mess is the dynamism
- Where a clever Frenchman writes philosophy and a clever Brit builds a country house, the American expression of genius is building a company, and that keeps regenerating
- The optimist's caveats are political: instability, creeping corporatism, and concentration that innovation does not need

Eisman presses on the GFC chapter, learns Greenspan wrote it alone, and tells the co-author on air that Greenspan got his own crisis wrong.

Streaming Hits Hollywood Hard: Here's Why with Producer Peter Hoffman

2026-08-05 | DEEP DIVE | 43 MIN | WITH PETER HOFFMAN

Hoffman, who produced Terminator 2, Basic Instinct and Total Recall, explains how independents once financed films on presales and why that machinery is gone. Eisman frames it as a margin story: a high margin syndication business traded itself for a lower margin streaming business. Hoffman also recounts the tax indictment that pushed him out of the industry and the film business out of New Orleans.

DISCUSSED

- Eisman's framing that incumbents happily sold old shows to Netflix and funded their own competitor, quoting the line about capitalists and the rope
- Netflix earnings per share growth slowing to 11 percent from 47 percent in the second quarter of 2025, with the stock down 25 percent on the year
- Disney's stock sitting where it was in late 2014, roughly 12 years of nothing, and AMC falling from 80 dollars to about 10 over a decade
- The major players named as Netflix, Disney, Amazon, Google through YouTube and Paramount, with Prime Video only about 2 percent of Amazon revenue and YouTube about 15 percent of Google
- The presale model that let international independents finance films outside the studio talent oligopoly, and why Apple can simply write the check for Neuromancer after Hoffman spent nearly 15 years failing to
- Hoffman stopping a James Cameron production 30 days over schedule and telling the director's lawyer he could not remove his name, after which Cameron never spoke to him again
- The New Orleans film tax credit indictment, after which the local business fell from about 1.2 billion dollars to 200 million in a year and moved to Georgia, now roughly 2 billion

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Selling your library to a distributor is selling the distributor your future. The syndication cash felt free until Netflix used it to fund originals
- Streaming is a maturing business, not a growth business. Compare the growth rate to the multiple before assuming the transition is bearable
- Prosecutors can destroy an industry cluster without winning a case. The raised eyebrow moved 1 billion dollars of production to another state
- Nobody can predict which films work. Hoffman's example is Angel Heart, which he and Eisman both rate highly and which underperformed anyway
- When financing depends on presaleable talent rather than material, the range of films that can exist narrows to what the buyer already recognizes

Eisman warns up front that technical problems degraded the audio and video, and runs the episode anyway.

SpaceX Disappoints, AI's Free Cash Flow Shrinks, Meta Struggles | The Weekly Wrap

2026-08-07 | WEEKLY WRAP | 21 MIN

A short pre-break wrap built around a correlation lesson: the Situational Awareness blowup shows what happens when every long and every short in a portfolio is the same bet. He then tours earnings where AI capex keeps eating free cash flow, and closes with his ten TV recommendations.

DISCUSSED

- His auto-versus-horse-carriage portfolio parable: a thesis can be right in hindsight and still ruin you, because fully correlated longs and shorts amplify every scare
- SpaceX reporting revenue of 7.8 billion, up 92%, but capex jumping to 18.4 billion from 10.1 billion, with Musk calling for more; the stock still below its 130 IPO price
- Gallop Capital's 10 billion private credit fund seeing redemptions fall below the 5% quarterly cap after 8.5% the prior quarter

- His view that private credit's real test arrives when software loan refinancings start next year
- Arista beating the whisper number versus AMD, up 246% on EPS but down on in-line guidance
- A top-ten TV list, from The Sandman and The Americans to Taylor Sheridan's Lioness

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Diversification means uncorrelated positions, not just longs against shorts; if the longs and shorts are mirror images, there is no hedge
- Being right over five years is worthless if margin forces you out in five weeks; survival horizon matters more than thesis quality
- He holds long-term winners like Arista precisely because trading them quarter to quarter is, in his words, an impossible endeavor
- Calm redemption numbers do not end a credit story; the private credit verdict waits on next year's refinancings

He grades his own record twice in one episode, then hands out TV picks like a mailbag victory lap before a two-week break.

Private Credit's Clock is Ticking w/ Glenn Schorr & Ken Worthington | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 72

2026-08-10 | DEEP DIVE | 51 MIN | WITH GLENN SCHORR, KEN WORTHINGTON

Two sell-side veterans, Glenn Schorr of Evercore and Ken Worthington of J.P. Morgan, join Eisman on the day Microsoft's blowout lifted the market and a levered hedge fund got liquidated. Both are more positive on private markets than the host, who keeps his doubts and gets Worthington to concede he has no real thesis for owning Bitcoin.

DISCUSSED

- Recorded July 30th: Microsoft up double digits, Meta down 10% on 28% revenue growth against 55% expense growth, and a 20 billion fund liquidated the same day
- Private equity monetization times stretching out, with KKR the exception, posting record monetizations
- Sponsors handing back the keys when lenders demand fresh equity to roll financings, and software refinancings hitting early next year at lower valuations
- J.P. Morgan internal studies finding AI agents managing money are wrong the majority of the time, telling investors what prompts suggest they want to hear
- Stablecoins as a settlement layer for the spread of 24/7 trading that back offices cannot support
- Worthington's thesis that blockchains and tokens proliferate together, and Eisman's response that none of it explains Bitcoin
- Investment banks humming: equity trading revenue up about 68% on volume up only 9 to 10%, with margin balances up about 50%

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Watch the gap between volume and revenue; trading profits are coming from margin balances and volatility, not activity, and that mix is fragile
- Disagreement is the trader's friend: Schorr's rule is that trading is bad when everyone agrees and good when they do not
- When everything in the investment banks is humming and estimates only go up, that comfort itself is the warning
- The private credit reckoning has a date: software refinancings next year, negotiated against valuations that have already fallen

Eisman grants Worthington every premise about blockchains proliferating, then asks flatly: what's that got to do with Bitcoin?

Why the Iran War Is Stuck & What Comes Next with Steven Cook

2026-08-12 | DEEP DIVE | 41 MIN | WITH STEVEN COOK

Cook returns to explain why a war that opened with a stunning tactical success has settled into stalemate. The Iranian regime absorbed the decapitation of its leadership, dispersed its missiles and kept firing at Gulf states, and the president backed off once the Strait closed. Cook then tours Syria, Lebanon, Turkey and the region's shifting read on Israel.

DISCUSSED

- Israel killing 40 of Iran's top leaders in the first minutes of Operation Rising Lion, which Cook says destroyed any chance of the president finding a regime figure to work with
- Iran spending the nine months after the June 2025 Operation Midnight Hammer decentralizing missiles and command and control, so damage did not stop the launches
- Iranian strikes on Gulf partners including the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Oman, hitting Dubai Airport, data centers and Amazon web services facilities
- The Strait of Hormuz blockade as the moment the president got cold feet, with the call off coming in early April and the Strait still closed at recording on July 28
- The verification problem, with Eisman asking why anyone would believe an Iranian promise to surrender nuclear fuel, and Cook conceding the same doubt that dogged the 2015 deal
- A Lebanon framework agreement under United States auspices, with Israeli withdrawal from two villages handed to the Lebanese armed forces and a monitoring mechanism aimed at dismantling Hezbollah
- Cook's account of Saudi social change, from seeing no women in Riyadh in 2002 to women everywhere now, and the UAE gratitude for Israeli personnel operating Iron Dome and Iron Beam batteries on its soil

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A regime that values survival above the economy cannot be coerced by economic pain. Iran's leadership accepted food on credit and no internet as the price of staying in power
- Decapitation forecloses negotiation. Killing the people you would have to deal with removes the off ramp along with the target
- Dispersal beats hardening. Nine months of decentralizing command and control preserved the ability to fire under sustained bombardment
- Diplomatic normalization usually predates the ceremony. Israeli missions operated in the Gulf for years before the accords put names on them
- Public opinion runs on a different clock than governments. Gulf leaders wanted a short war precisely because a long one would be watched on phones

Cook forecasts that if they speak again in three or four months, the picture will look the same, and Eisman tells him he will be back regardless.

AI’s Achilles’ Heel: Why Everything Hinges on Anthropic & OpenAI | The Weekly Wrap

2026-08-14 | WEEKLY WRAP | 30 MIN

With earnings quiet, Eisman steps back and names the single point of failure in the AI trade: if Anthropic and OpenAI ever pull back on compute purchases, the entire chain goes into reverse. He pairs that with a shorting lesson, that even a correct bear case a year early is worthless, and declares Bitcoin no longer cool.

DISCUSSED

- Nvidia partnering with six large asset managers on a 500 billion financing push treating compute infrastructure like commercial real estate or toll roads
- The emerging hyperscaler winners, Microsoft, Google, and Amazon, versus Oracle with debt barely above junk and a struggling Meta

- The streaming history lesson: incumbents chose margin over growth against Netflix, and it cost them everything
- Bitcoin losing young traders to prediction markets, with eToro revenue down 30% on collapsing crypto trading and the stock down 14%
- DraftKings facing what he calls the Blockbuster fate as prediction markets encroach
- A premium two-part masterclass on analyzing banks coming after Labor Day, with Substack pricing rising to 20 dollars a month on September 7th

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Map the dependency chain, not the narrative; the AI trade's real risk is concentrated in two private companies' willingness to keep buying compute
- Timing is everything in shorting: a bear case that arrives a year late is indistinguishable from a wrong one, and a year is an eternity for markets
- Defending an existing high-margin business against a lower-margin future is how incumbents die; they preserve margin and lose the market
- Being early to an asset class guarantees nothing; adapting does

His epitaph for crypto's cultural moment: Bitcoin is no longer the cool toy, prediction markets are, just ask DraftKings.

The AI Trade, Rising Rates, and Why the Market Is Still Standing | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 73

2026-08-17 | DEEP DIVE | 45 MIN | WITH JASON TRENNERT, CHRIS VERRONE

Strategas founder Jason Trennert and strategist Chris Verrone survey a tumultuous year, war, tariffs, an AI capex debate, and a hedge fund blowup, and conclude the market's internals keep improving anyway. Their surprise admission: the 4.5% ten-year yield they long treated as the equity market's breaking point came and went, so the true threshold must be significantly higher.

DISCUSSED

- Market internals strengthening through the churn: 50% of the S&P above its 200-day average on June 2nd versus 75% now
- The hunt for the rate of interest that pulls money out of equities, after their 4.5% call on the ten-year failed to bite
- Traditional asset managers, State Street, T. Rowe, Invesco, leading while private equity stocks lag, an industry Trennert calls the biggest beneficiary of near-zero rates
- Private equity monetization timeframes stretching to about seven years
- Bank stocks at new highs worldwide while private credit worries build, which Verrone finds out of step with any historical crisis setup
- Private credit framed as a regulatory arbitrage born of Dodd-Frank pushing lending out of the banks
- The end of Fed forward guidance under Kevin Warsh, and why spoon-fed markets now face more volatility

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Breadth beats headlines: when internals improve while the index churns, corrections keep resolving upward
- Hold a threshold loosely; when the market absorbs the level you feared, the honest move is raising the estimate, not repeating it
- Every claimed crisis has a tell, and world-wide bank stocks at new highs is not what the verge of a big problem looks like
- Forward guidance was a subsidy to media and hedge funds alike; its removal brings volatility that good companies will survive and lazy positioning will not

Verrone's line on the pattern of tops: leaders roll over only when they rally, fail to make new highs, and fail; and we haven't seen that yet.

Why Europe Can't Fix Itself & Why It's Getting Worse with Wolfgang Munchau

2026-08-19 | DEEP DIVE | 46 MIN | WITH WOLFGANG MUNCHAU

Munchau, author of Kaput, returns a year later to report that Europe has gotten worse, not better. His diagnosis is that Germany stopped innovating around the 1990s, built everything on a car industry now losing to China, and chose to regulate technologies it never participated in. Eisman says out loud that the conversation is depressing, because a culture problem has no policy fix.

DISCUSSED

- German productivity flat for eight years, with Munchau dating the turning point to 2018 and noting industry actually fell over the period
- The car industry as the trickle-down engine of the whole German economy, feeding suppliers and the financial system, now losing to China with no diversification strategy
- GDPR as the first of the big regulations and the source of the cookie banners, framed as arrogance in regulating an industry Europe does not participate in
- Where European tech actually exists: the UK as the most active AI investor with spinoffs around the DeepMind orbit, a small Munich scene, a Paris scene, and almost nothing in Italy or Spain
- Munchau's answer for why America has big tech, which is the capital market rather than tax breaks
- Energy management as complex optimization, with coal running longer than planned in Germany because nuclear was switched off, and British housing stock too drafty and uninsulated for easy retrofit
- Debt piling up everywhere because growth is absent, taxes are maxed, France cannot touch pensions, Germany cannot touch welfare, and defense spending has to rise anyway

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Regulating an industry you do not compete in buys you rules and no leverage
- A single dominant sector is a trickle-down engine on the way up and a single point of failure on the way down
- Capital markets, not tax policy, are the precondition for scale technology companies
- Decline reaches a tipping point slowly. Anger and far right support are the visible measure of a system that has stopped working
- Gridlock is structural when no executive exists. A confederacy that refuses to federalize cannot decide, whatever its leaders intend

Munchau's analogy lands hard: imagine the United States with a Congress and no president, then make it worse.

The Juiciest Corporate Scandals with Becca Platsky

2026-08-26 | DEEP DIVE | 45 MIN | WITH BECCA PLATSKY

Platsky, a CPA who hosts Corporate Gossip, trades fraud stories with Eisman across Frank and JPMorgan, Paramount and the Ellisons, prediction markets and FIFA. The two disagree on the nature of fraudsters, with Platsky arguing anyone can slip and Eisman insisting people who commit fraud were always doing it. The episode ends on his oldest grievance, that nobody was ever prosecuted for 2008.

DISCUSSED

- Charlie Javice and Frank, pitched as 400,000 users with socials, incomes, schools, emails, addresses and phone numbers, after other name brand banks passed and JPMorgan bought
- The court ruling that JPMorgan's due diligence was not on trial, and Eisman's agreement that being deceived is not a defense for the deceiver

- The JPMorgan executive who ran that diligence, once in the conversation to succeed Jamie Dimon, since demoted
- Paramount's late-stage governance, described as executives propping up an incapacitated leader, and the Ellison family now using the company to pursue Warner Bros Discovery
- Eisman's own view that Paramount and Warner Bros should merge so Netflix does not own the whole business, against Platsky's concern about Larry Ellison also owning TikTok alongside CBS and CNN
- Prediction market abuse, including a teleprompter technician betting on which words Trump would say, and the CFTC's unsettled posture toward Polymarket's innovation defense
- FIFA sponsorship money flowing to executives, with Chuck Blazer keeping an 8,000 dollar a month Trump Tower apartment for himself and a 6,000 dollar one for his cats and parents

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Shorting a fraud is a solvency race. A fraud can persist longer than a short position can survive
- The gap between the CNBC appearance and the earnings report is where the story usually is
- Insider trading migrates to whatever venue lacks a regulator. Event contracts recreated the problem with none of the enforcement
- Whistleblowing is a real option with a real price. Both hosts say it can blow up your life
- Missing laws are rarely the problem. In 2008 the statutes existed, the investigation never started

Platsky asks what listeners can actually do and Eisman has no answer beyond screaming, then tells her to keep her circle small and useful.

The Art of the Short with Lakshmi Ganapathi: FICO, DoorDash, and AeroVironment

2026-09-02 | DEEP DIVE | 38 MIN | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

Ganapathi explains how she hunts for shorts, then walks through three: FICO, AeroVironment and DoorDash. Eisman, still short FICO, sorts them into a structural short, a business model short and a consumer credit short.

DISCUSSED

- Her screen: cocky management, rising ad spend and debt, debt-funded buybacks, and products or warranties that fail customers
- FICO's price increases of about 1,600% over four to five years, which pushed FHFA head Bill Pulte to back VantageScore
- Her reading that FICO management went from calling Vantage share about 2% to citing roughly 20 to 25% within two quarters
- A FICO price target under 500 against a share price a little over 1,000
- AeroVironment as a roll-up that bought another roll-up, BlueHalo, selling drones at 50,000 dollars plus while Ukrainian and other rivals sell for 5,000 or less
- DoorDash's five or six European lawsuits over Deliveroo, including a French criminal conviction of two former general managers
- DoorDash volume leaning on buy now, pay later credit, which would vanish if consumer credit tightens

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A monopoly can break when management raises price so far that customers and regulators organize against it
- Management statements that shift tenfold in two quarters signal a company caught off guard
- A good short thesis can still be untradeable if the stock is too volatile to hold
- Consumer demand financed by fragile credit is only as durable as that credit

Eisman admits he is tempted to short AeroVironment but fears the agita of holding a stock that volatile.

Is OpenAI the Achilles' Heel of the US Economy? | The Weekly Wrap

2026-09-04 | WEEKLY WRAP | 24 MIN

With the ten-year near 4.8%, Eisman argues AI capex now carries US growth and that OpenAI, not Nvidia or the hyperscalers, is the weak link. He is not making a major call yet, but he names safety ETFs for a possible reallocation.

DISCUSSED

- War in Iran pushing oil up and the ten-year to almost 4.8%
- AI capex as the main driver of GDP growth, large enough that a halt would mean near-immediate recession
- Nvidia's circular financing, including its potential Perplexity investment and a recent Poolside investment
- OpenAI's June quarter: revenue of 6.7 billion, up only 18%, against costs of 12.3 billion, up 3 billion; Anthropic above 11 billion, up over 100%
- Oracle's BBB minus rating and 600 billion backlog, about half from OpenAI, recalling its 2025 jump from 230 to 330 on the backlog
- Safety ETFs: LVHD, SPLV and KBWP, the property and casualty ETF
- Meta's settlement of about 17 billion with state attorneys general, with commentary from law professor Ben Zipursky

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When one customer is half a supplier's backlog, the supplier's value rests on that customer's solvency
- Revenue growing 1 billion while costs grow 3 billion is a trend, not a rounding error
- A late-cycle worry is often a reallocation question, not a stock picking one
- Every sector contains a safety subsector; in financials it is property and casualty

He says it is not too early to think through what happens if OpenAI fails.

P&C Stocks Worth Owning: The AI Hedge with Ryan Tunis | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 74

2026-09-07 | DEEP DIVE | 43 MIN | WITH RYAN TUNIS

Cantor analyst Ryan Tunis maps property and casualty insurance as a hedge against the AI trade, a sector with its own pricing cycle. The market has softened, so he favours self-help and brokers over buying the whole group.

DISCUSSED

- The four parts of the sector: commercial lines, personal lines, reinsurance and insurance brokers
- New car safety technology cutting accident rates, which lowers auto pricing and shrinks the personal lines market
- Progressive's struggle to sell homeowners insurance outside coastal states without independent agent relationships
- A commercial soft market about a year old, with softening spreading into casualty lines
- Tunis rating Travelers and AIG buy but not Chubb; AIG trades around book value and carries a hard market business mix
- Reinsurance brokers as his top subgroup, while reinsurers' pricing discipline remains in doubt
- Trupanion's roughly 1,000 dollar policies and free cash flow near 2% of revenue; Kinsale's mid-50s loss ratios and low broker pay

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Property and casualty cycles run on their own rhythm, not the economy's

- In a soft market, buying on business mix stops working and self-help stories take over
- Technology that reduces losses can shrink an insurer's addressable market
- A low expense ratio built on paying brokers less can hurt when business returns to the standard market

Eisman leaves more negative on personal lines, which includes Progressive, a stock he holds.

Inside AI’s Fragile Ecosystem with Ed Zitron

2026-09-09 | DEEP DIVE | 70 MIN | WITH ED ZITRON

Ed Zitron, the Substack critic listeners asked for for months, argues AI revenue is tiny next to capex and rests almost entirely on two loss-making labs. Eisman largely agrees and names OpenAI as the problem child.

DISCUSSED

- Microsoft's fiscal 2026 AI revenue of 34.33 billion, per a Bloomberg estimate, with 24.1 billion from OpenAI
- OpenAI losing 20.9 billion on 13.07 billion of revenue in 2025, with a recent quarter operating margin of about minus 183%
- Subscriptions that let users burn about 14,000 dollars of compute for a 200 dollar fee
- OpenAI's 122 billion raise, 110 billion of it from Amazon, SoftBank and Nvidia
- Token maxing, then a turn to cost cutting after Meta pulled its token leaderboard
- OpenAI and Anthropic taking about 90% of available compute, and data center buildouts slowed by local pushback in Texas and Pennsylvania
- Hyperscaler capex of about 650 billion this year, with about 70% of hyperscaler AI revenue from the two labs

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Spending on API tokens is not recurring revenue and should not be annualized
- When a supplier's largest customer is funded by that supplier, underwriters should see a concentration risk
- Undisclosed segment revenue leaves investors guessing about the core economics
- Smart people can run a mania; Wall Street did it with subprime until it blew up

Eisman warns listeners to look past Anthropic's first-half S-1 numbers to second-half revenue after enterprises cut token spend.

AI Terminator Fears Grow & Rates Breach 4.9% | The Weekly Wrap

2026-09-11 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

The ten-year breaks 4.9% on war-driven oil, and Eisman concedes 4.5% was not the market's breaking point. He also dismisses AI extinction talk, doubts Tesla's robotaxi valuation and says FICO's monopoly will break badly.

DISCUSSED

- Oil above 100 dollars and the ten-year above 4.9%, the highest since November 2023
- Bessent's treasury buybacks failing to impress; the ten-year rose from 4.80% to 4.845% that day
- Fed Chair Warsh wanting to shrink a 6.7 trillion balance sheet, with markets pricing about a 60% chance of a September hike
- Tesla at 220 times 2026 earnings of 1.66, down 59% from peak EPS of 4.07, against GM at 6.5 times
- OpenAI cutting prices and claiming a tenfold rise in usage; Qualcomm granting Amazon warrants on 25 million shares at 161.26, worth over 4 billion

- Pulte attacking FICO again as VantageScore opens to all lenders
- GameStop's revenue falling to 790 million from 972 million, with collectibles now bigger than video games

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- A rate threshold is a guess; the market sets the real one
- Falling earnings do not guarantee a falling stock when investors buy a story
- Rising yields can lift gold when the yield rise comes from inflation fear
- Warrants to a customer are not circular financing, but they deserve scrutiny

Asked about gold against a 5% treasury, he takes the treasury: the government is stretched but not yet overstretched.

The Big Short Partners Reunite: Rates, AI, Gold and Two Stock Picks | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 75

2026-09-14 | DEEP DIVE | 50 MIN | WITH PORTER COLLINS, VINCENT DANIEL

Eisman sits down with two of his Big Short partners for a lightning round on Scott Bessent's bond buying, the deficit, gold, AI nerves and why shorting has become harder. The partners make the case for precious metals as the endgame of a debt problem Washington will not fix, and pitch a cannabis long alongside a shared FICO short.

DISCUSSED

- Porter Collins arguing interest expense plus entitlements equal about 110% of tax receipts, leaving printing as the only exit
- Gold as a debt-free central bank asset, with central banks close to holding more gold than Treasuries
- Bessent's long-bond purchases of at least 4 billion dollars, mocked as an attempted Draghi moment
- How a multi-manager fund such as Citadel runs a near-zero net book levered about five to one
- All three being short FICO, and Carvana at 30 to 40 times earnings as a short that has failed for eight years
- A cannabis producer selling at about 200 dollars a pound in California that could earn 50% to 65% EBITDA margins abroad, with progress seen as a 2027 event
- SpaceX's S-1 promises, including asteroid mining, as a sign of how far AI and space narratives have run

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When debt service plus entitlements exceed revenue, markets start pricing monetization, and hard assets benefit
- A market-neutral book can carry high gross leverage because its volatility is engineered low, which hides how much capital is really at work
- A short can be right on the numbers and still lose for years if the stock has a buyer of its paper and a devoted base

The partners credit Eisman's habit of asking how a fund levers its book as the question they now use on their own calls.

How to Analyze Bank Stocks (Part 1): Leverage, Accounting, and Loan Losses

2026-09-16 | MASTERCLASS | 49 MIN

Part one of a paid lecture on bank analysis. Eisman builds from a zero-leverage bank to explain why banking is a low-margin business that only works through leverage, then covers risk-weighted capital and how loan loss reserves drive the stocks.

DISCUSSED

- The identity ROE equals ROA times leverage, shown with a bank earning a fine 1% ROA but a pathetic 1% ROE unlevered
- Deposits treated as debt, and leverage defined as assets divided by equity
- Risk-weighted assets rewarding banks that pile into low-weighted assets, and risk weights resting on loss history that underwriting can change
- Large-bank CET1 ratios falling since the fourth quarter of 2024 as regulators loosen capital rules
- JPMorgan provisions of 8.3 billion and 10.5 billion in the first two quarters of 2020 under CECL, then 611 million in the third
- Non-accruing loans at JPMorgan of 9.4 billion in 2Q26, down 5% year on year, and at Bank of America of 5.8 billion, down 4%
- Michael Burry's point on stretched chip depreciation schedules as an example of judgment hidden in accounting

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Read a bank's returns through leverage: a small change in ROA becomes a large change in ROE
- Capital ratios built on historical loss rates are only as good as current underwriting standards
- A reserve true-up forces guidance down and often marks the contrarian moment to buy
- Watch year-on-year and sequential non-accruals at the four biggest banks for the broadest read on credit

He predicts private credit losses will surface first in investor redemptions, not in bank non-accrual data.

Why Dario Amodei and Sam Altman Are Faking the AI Doomsday Crisis | The Weekly Wrap

2026-09-18 | WEEKLY WRAP | 22 MIN

Oil near 110 dollars pushes the ten-year above 5% and the Fed hikes. Eisman concedes his 4.5% line was wrong, then argues Anthropic and OpenAI talk up AI doom as cover while their business models cannot afford any slowdown.

DISCUSSED

- The Fed raising rates 25 basis points to 3.75% to 4%, defying President Trump, and penciling in another hike this year
- Bessent's long-Treasury buying program rising from 4 billion to 6 billion dollars and working for only one day
- FICO raising prices about 1,600% over five years, with pressure now spreading to credit bureaus and mortgage insurers
- Senators blocking the crypto Clarity Act after the industry spent hundreds of millions on it, a blow to Circle
- OpenAI representing about 300 billion of Oracle's 600 billion plus backlog, and an Anthropic IPO expected within a month or two
- The Kevin Mitnick prison story as a parallel for fear of poorly understood technology
- Mailbag: most S&P sectors correlate with AI; staples and healthcare are only 14% of the index; LVHD, SPLV and KBWP as diversifiers; shorting Nvidia against the box

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- When a rate threshold breaks without a selloff, move the line rather than defend it
- Judge a CEO's warnings against what his financing commitments require him to do
- Diversification from a dominant theme may require going inside sectors, such as property and casualty insurers within financials

He admits outright that his 4.5% ten-year threshold was wrong.

Stock Picking in Difficult Times with George Noble | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 76

2026-09-21 | DEEP DIVE | 48 MIN | WITH GEORGE NOBLE

Former Fidelity portfolio manager George Noble returns to argue the macro has flipped from tailwind to gale: Treasury cannot repress rates on 40 trillion of debt, Japan's yields threaten US demand, and AI returns look weak. He closes by laying out his shorts in SpaceX and Tesla.

DISCUSSED

- Bessent cast as Norman Lamont defending sterling against Soros, with Noble noting Bessent was a junior who did not make that trade
- A regime change away from the post-GFC world where money printing carried no cost, and disdain for fixation on monthly CPI decimals
- Japan's ten-year crossing 4% for the first time in about 30 years, which Noble says should be near 7% given debt to GDP of 240%
- Japanese and Chinese selling of Treasuries while US policy discourages foreign buyers
- An AI ecosystem that depends on OpenAI, framed through related-party and VIE accounting
- SpaceX valued at 1.7 trillion against Noble's estimate of roughly 200 to 500 billion, and Tesla US sales down 26% in July
- Tesla's share price roughly unchanged over five years, and doubts on robotaxis

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Stock picking works best when the macro factors are neutral or behind you; fighting rising rates in rate-sensitive groups is hopeless
- A country's sovereign yield should roughly track its debt burden, as a subprime borrower's rate tracks its credit
- In a momentum mania, avoiding the few overvalued giants and indexing the rest can win when the worm turns

Eisman says Noble may be more negative on AI than he is, judging it on return on investment.

How to Analyze Banks (Part 2): Deposits, Valuations, and Silicon Valley

2026-09-23 | MASTERCLASS | 35 MIN

Part two of the bank lecture uses Silicon Valley Bank to show how a bank can fail with no credit problem, then walks through the bank income statement, valuation and the choice between large and plain-vanilla banks. Eisman ends by explaining why he owns no banks today.

DISCUSSED

- Silicon Valley Bank rising from 50 dollars in 2010 to 760 in November 2021 and failing on 10 March 2023
- SVB's 212 billion in assets sitting below the 250 billion stress-test threshold, with a deposit base drawn entirely from venture capital
- Unrealized bond losses hitting book value but not earnings, and Bank of America's roughly 100 billion of such losses being an earnings problem, not a solvency one
- Net interest income as margin times average earning assets, with loans producing about 70% of interest revenue and Citi's thin deposit franchise hurting its margin
- Goldman re-rating from 1.3 times to about 3 times tangible book
- Bank OZK's 32.6 billion loan book, 50% commercial real estate, trading at one times tangible book
- First Horizon's CEO calling his bank a buyer, not a seller, on the 3Q25 call

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Deposits are only as stable as their diversity; many depositors who are all the same act as one

- A bank that funds long bonds with short money is surfing the curve and can fail without a single bad loan
- Buy banks after recession fears have killed them and lighten up at peak valuations
- An M&A thesis needs a willing seller; impeccable logic does not make a CEO sell

He treats buying large investment banks today as an indirect AI bet and declines to add to his AI risk.

The Enron-Era Tricks Are Back in AI: How These Companies Are Hiding Their Debt | The Weekly Wrap

2026-09-25 | WEEKLY WRAP | 26 MIN

With the ten-year at a multi-year high above 5.10%, Eisman calls 5% the market's Rubicon and a correction probably imminent if yields stay there. The core of the wrap compares off-balance-sheet AI data center financing, above all Meta's Beignet vehicle, to Enron and the GFC's SIVs.

DISCUSSED

- Oil and the ten-year as the only two variables moving the market, with strong data pushing yields above 5.10%
- S&P cutting Oracle to BBB minus, one notch above junk, and troubling news at Blue Owl Capital
- Paramount cleared after a California settlement requiring a CNN oversight board and 30 theatrical films a year; Netflix at a growth wall
- SoftBank borrowing in the junk market to fund an equity investment
- Meta's Louisiana data center financed through Beignet Investor LLC, 20% Meta owned with Blue Owl and Pimco, under a 20-year lease with Meta bearing overruns
- Ernst & Young's critical audit matter on the VIE, which Eisman reads as auditor nervousness
- Meta's Muse agent in household use, and a mailbag correction on the Section 1259 constructive sale rule for shorting against the box

WHAT CAN BE LEARNED

- Disclosure is not the same as sound accounting: Enron disclosed its SPVs and the auditors signed off
- When a company guarantees the lease and bears the overruns, the debt is economically its own wherever it sits
- Read a critical audit matter as a signal of where the auditor is uneasy

He details his own tax-compliant hedge: close the short within 30 days of year end, hold the long 60 more days, and retake the risk in 2027.

APPENDIX D

Interview dossiers

A deeper reconstruction of all 92 interview and lecture episodes: the thesis, where Eisman pushed, the numbers, what moved, and the questions each one leaves open.

Does China Own Apple? With Patrick McGee

2025-06-05 | WITH PATRICK MCGEE

THE THESIS

McGee argues Apple did not merely outsource to China, it built China's electronics capability. Because Apple invents its own custom parts and even the machines that make them, going deep in China meant training suppliers and provincial workforces in experiential know-how, the same tacit knowledge McGee says underpinned the British Industrial Revolution. Manufacturing that spanned roughly nine countries around 2000 accreted into China without anyone at Apple ever deciding it, because China alone made manufacturing the core of national strategy, its way out of the poverty trap and later the middle income trap. Once Xi Jinping attacked Apple and blacklisting became a live threat, Apple had to sell Beijing a counter narrative of contributing to indigenous innovation, locking it in deeper. The result is business ties that are unbreakable and political ties that are untenable, a relationship not in equilibrium.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman mostly extracts rather than disputes, but he forces the sharp framings. He challenges the choice of China over India and gets the answer that only China prioritizes manufacturing as national destiny. He tests the claim that Xi Jinping personally sanctioned the attacks on Apple, and McGee insists nothing like that happens without Xi's clearance. Eisman then lands the summary McGee accepts: Apple exported its intellectual property to China, and did not even sell it, it trained an adversary for free.

THE NUMBERS

- In spring 1996 Apple was days from missing payroll and had hired Harvey Miller's bankruptcy firm, a detail McGee says his book reveals for the first time
- Around 2000 Apple manufacturing was spread across roughly nine countries before consolidating into China
- The Texas Mac Pro line ran 5 to 600 units per day while the iPhone requires about a million per day
- Apple has fallen to about fourth place in China smartphone sales and cannot ship ChatGPT style AI there
- Apple is a roughly 3 trillion dollar company earning about 100 billion dollars a year in profits, with everything located in China
- Senator Levin's 2013 attack on Apple's roughly 2% Irish tax structure missed the bigger export, know-how rather than money
- Facebook and Google are blacklisted in China, making the threat to Apple real rather than idle

WHAT MOVED

No disagreement to resolve, but the conversation hardens into a joint verdict. Eisman ends by rejecting Tim Cook's line that the relationship is mutually symbiotic, both settle on mutually exploitative, with China's gain amounting to a US national security risk, and both concede they cannot say how the non-equilibrium breaks.

IN THE ARC

The book episode that anchors the show's tariff and trade thread: Eisman says his Wolfgang Munchau interview taught him that in trade the details matter, and this is the case study. It feeds directly into the weekly wraps tracking the US China negotiations and the later news that China moved to stop manufacturers shifting production out of the country.

“Apple basically exported its intellectual property to China. They didn't sell it to them. They trained them.”

STEVE EISMAN

“If you're not making Mac Pros in Texas, you're sure as hell not making iPhones anytime soon.”

PATRICK MCGEE

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How does a relationship with unbreakable business ties and untenable political ties actually break?
- Can Apple move meaningful iPhone volume out of China when China is actively blocking supplier relocation?
- Does Apple's AI weakness inside China accelerate its decline there faster than tariffs hurt it outside?

A Skeptic's Guide to Cryptocurrency and Stablecoins

2025-06-08 | WITH RAHUL JINDAL

THE THESIS

Jindal's framework is that digital assets should be judged like payment networks, on ubiquity, liquidity and utility, not on price charts. Bitcoin's supposed lockstep correlation with the S&P and NASDAQ breaks into three distinct periods and is weaker over the full span than recent years suggest, so the risk-on label is not settled. Stablecoins are backed one to one, so there is no capital appreciation in the coin itself; the investable value sits in the networks that collect fees, which is why a Solana style chain becoming the stablecoin rail would make its token the utility play. The realistic wedge for stablecoins is velocity of money, getting funds to the recipient faster and cheaper, which makes remittances, effectively replacing Western Union, the first real market rather than a frontal assault on Visa and Mastercard. Pending legislation will sort the space, with stablecoin issuers tiered by size and most other crypto treated as commodities under the CFTC.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman opens by declaring he can be dangerous on payments but is here to learn on crypto, then spends the episode forcing the utility question. He makes Jindal confirm the Solana logic out loud, then deflates the remittance case with 'that's not the biggest business in the world', which Jindal partly concedes while defending its size. Eisman's strongest push is historical: since Visa and Mastercard went public, every couple of years a technology arrives claiming it will supplant them and every one has failed, and he doubts stablecoins are different. Jindal does not really fight that; he retreats to the remittance and velocity case.

THE NUMBERS

- Bitcoin's correlation to the S&P 500 and NASDAQ splits into three distinct periods and is lower across the full span than recent years imply
- Under the pending stablecoin bill, issuers below 10 billion dollars in market cap can stay state regulated, above that they must apply federally
- Most crypto assets are expected to be treated as commodities regulated by the CFTC, with a carve out for clear securities
- Pre Visa Plus, a Venmo user could not pay a Cash App user at all, Eisman's 500 dollar sushi dinner example of closed loop wallets
- Block's stock has been range bound for years and lost roughly half its valuation after the COVID super app thesis faded
- Jindal saw the 2018 to 2022 fintech deal wave from inside Capital One corporate development before joining Autonomous in 2022

WHAT MOVED

Eisman moves visibly: he buys the verticalized payments thesis on the spot, saying he quite likes companies that conquer a vertical like Toast, and in the following wrap he says this conversation left him less skeptical about Bitcoin. Jindal concedes stablecoins are unlikely to displace Visa and Mastercard, holding onto remittances as the real business. Eisman keeps his core position that he is a stock jockey who has never owned Bitcoin.

IN THE ARC

The foundation episode of the show's crypto scepticism thread. The same week's wrap applies it to Circle's IPO tripling, and later wraps track Mastercard and Fiserv launching a competing stablecoin, exactly the incumbent response this conversation predicted.

> *"On payments, I can be very dangerous. But on crypto and stablecoins, I'm here to learn just like everybody else."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *"Enough people on earth think it's valuable, so it must be valuable."*
>
> RAHUL JINDAL

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can stablecoins actually take the remittance market from Western Union, or does incumbency win there too?
- If the value accrues to the settlement network, which chain becomes the stablecoin rail and captures the fees?
- Does treating most crypto as CFTC regulated commodities settle the asset class or just relabel it?

Safe to Stay Invested? Decoding 2025 Stock Charts

2025-06-09 | WITH TODD SOHN

THE THESIS

Sohn's case is that technical work is probability stacking, not fortune telling: identify the big trends across stocks, bonds, currencies and commodities, confirm them with breadth, and lean against sentiment only when every metric aligns at an extreme. On that framework the April lows are in and this is a structural bull market, because equal weight breadth is healthy, industrials and financials lead, and consolidations keep resolving upward. The tactical tell is how a stock behaves after a base: a consolidation breaking against trend, as UnitedHealth's did, is a sell signal regardless of the fundamental story. The blemish is the private asset managers, whose charts peaked months ago and are distributive across the group, suggesting the market is quietly repricing the private equity and private credit complex.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman opens with the old insult, that he used to call technicians chartists, and forces Sohn to defend why charts matter at all, which produces the remote island answer, an hour of charts recovers a month of news. He drills into levered ETFs until Sohn admits they are only about 100 billion dollars, small against the market. On crypto he presses whether Bitcoin is anything more than a risk-on asset and Sohn holds that it is risk and liquidity, nothing else yet. On the private asset managers Eisman supplies the fundamental cause, years without an IPO or M&A exit and institutions like Harvard trying to get out, and Sohn accepts the charts are reflecting exactly that impatience.

THE NUMBERS

- Levered ETFs hold roughly 100 billion dollars in assets, about 1% of the ETF universe, a new sentiment gauge Sohn watches
- Equal weight versus cap weighted performance is his core health check, and early 2023 style divergence is the warning template

- UnitedHealth's repeated failed bases after bad announcements are the model of a consolidation breaking against trend
- Institutional investors are starting to allocate 1 to 2% to crypto products, partly because long duration bonds no longer work
- Private equity and private credit equities peaked months ago after big runs and are distributive across the whole group, not just two names
- His summary call: the April lows are in, expect summer chop, structural bull intact, with leadership in industrials and financials

WHAT MOVED

Convergence rather than conflict. Eisman accepts the constructive market read, which matches his own no trade war, no problem framework, and Sohn accepts Eisman's fundamental explanation for the private asset manager weakness. Each keeps his method: Sohn will not claim charts predict causes, Eisman will not trade on charts alone.

IN THE ARC

The first of the show's two Strategas technician episodes, paired with Chris Verrone's July market strategy visit. The distributive private asset manager charts become the market echo of the show's running private credit scepticism, which Eisman formalizes in the June 21 wrap: problems in private credit will show up only when a recession arrives.

> *"Charts are the language of Wall Street."*
>
> TODD SOHN

> *"I think the equity is reflecting time to get out of these investments."*
>
> TODD SOHN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Are the distributive private asset manager charts an early credit warning or just an exit drought repricing?
- Do levered ETFs grow from 1% of the ETF universe into a structural amplifier of drawdowns?
- If institutions settle at 1 to 2% crypto allocations, does Bitcoin ever decouple from risk-on liquidity?

Are We Building an AI Future We Can't Power?

2025-06-16 | WITH SAMI BADRI

THE THESIS

Badri's argument is that the tech stack has been rebuilt twice in a decade and investors should map the component parts before picking winners. In 2015 there were no trillion dollar companies, the fight was enterprise private cloud versus the emerging public cloud, and the unit of compute was the Intel CPU plus storage and switching. AI flipped the unit of compute to the GPU, which can crawl billions of rows where a CPU manages about a hundred thousand, and Nvidia extended that advantage by bundling NVLink aggregation and switching so customers without deep engineering benches buy the whole stack. The binding constraints now are networking, power and data readiness, since most corporate data is not usable without reformatting, and that is where Cisco repositions itself: switches, routers, its own AI chips, security and observability, as a key enabler and Nvidia partner rather than a bystander.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman's hardest push is his own thesis rather than an attack on Cisco: if morons like me can write software by asking an AI for it, the moats around the big software companies may be far lower than assumed, cheaper entrants flood in, and hardware keeps outperforming software. Badri calls it a very fair question and does not resolve it. Eisman also prods the company itself, noting Cisco was run by its founder era management for a very long time and asking what has actually changed, drawing out the culture change

claim rather than accepting it.

THE NUMBERS

- In 2015 trillion dollar market caps were essentially unimaginable and the law of large numbers was assumed to bind every S&P company
- A CPU can crawl roughly 100,000 rows and columns while a GPU handles billions, and Google scale systems trillions
- Nvidia effectively requires NVLink aggregators and its switching with its GPUs for LLM training buildouts, bundling the stack
- Much of enterprise data is stored but not usable for AI without reformatting, a hidden drag on adoption
- Cisco reported a good fiscal Q3 with the federal government despite DOGE uncertainty, with some deals pushed into fiscal 2026
- Cisco says it is executing ahead of plan on AI infrastructure and webscale orders while enterprise and public sector rebuild

WHAT MOVED

Nothing decisive moves. Badri holds the line that Cisco is a key AI enabler, Eisman neither buys nor rejects it, and his software moat question is explicitly left open as something he expects to struggle with for years.

IN THE ARC

The show's first sustained AI capex episode, laying the stack level groundwork the later AI and power discussions build on; the title's power question follows the wraps tracking AI companies locking up nuclear energy, like Meta's Constellation deal. Eisman's hardware over software hypothesis resurfaces a month later in the Verrone episode.

> *“People are writing software today who don't know how to write software.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“If morons like me can write software, maybe the moats around some of these software companies are not nearly as high as we think.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Do AI coding tools actually compress software margins, and how would the damage first show up?
- Can Cisco take a real share of AI networking against Nvidia's bundled stack?
- Does power availability become the gating factor on AI capex before chip supply does?

Is Capitalism Flawed? Fixing and Regulating Free Markets

2025-06-23 | WITH JOHN CASSIDY

THE THESIS

Cassidy argues that when Sanders and 2016 Trump attacked the system from left and right simultaneously, the first such convergence since the 1930s, capitalism entered a crisis of legitimacy, and that the complaints driving it, globalization, inequality, financialization and instability, are not post Cold War novelties but intrinsic to capitalism from its mercantile beginnings. That is why his book runs the whole history: Smith wrote to critique mercantile monopoly trade, the Marxians' collapse mechanisms like the declining rate of profit failed, and Keynes saved the system with demand management once 30 to 40% unemployment made survival the question. Minsky supplies the financial instability piece the free market agenda ignored. Today's Trumpism, in his reading, hangs together politically, as its European copies show, but is not an economically coherent philosophy.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The sharpest exchange is on the financial crisis. Eisman argues the popular Glass-Steagall repeal story is wrong and that the real cause was the invention of risk weighted assets, which let banks lever from 10 times to 40 times, and he chides Cassidy for not engaging the debate. Cassidy concedes he does not think Glass-Steagall was central either. Eisman also complicates the Trump critique, arguing Trump is in a weird way honest, publishing his road map and executing it, which Cassidy accepts as true while holding that the program's economics do not cohere.

THE NUMBERS

- The book was conceived in 2016 when Sanders and Trump were attacking the system from both flanks, a convergence Cassidy dates back to the 1930s
- Mercantile firms like the East India Company held monopoly power on both ends, squeezing producers and raising prices at home
- Keynes' C plus I plus G plus X minus M framework became the blueprint for saving a system facing 30 to 40% unemployment
- Eisman: risk weighted assets let banks lever from 10 times to roughly 40 times, his candidate for the true cause of 2008
- Both expect Trump's tariffs to settle around 30%, not 100% and not zero
- Farage's party now leads UK polls, with the AfD and National Front rising, evidence Trumpism travels politically

WHAT MOVED

Real movement on the crisis history: Cassidy concedes Glass-Steagall was not central, effectively accepting Eisman's leverage story as at least co-equal. Both end on shared ground that the question is never whether to regulate capitalism but how much, while Cassidy keeps his verdict that economic nationalism is politically potent and economically incoherent.

IN THE ARC

Second entry in the book review series after Munchau's Kaput, and the theoretical spine for Eisman's own regulation riffs in the wraps, where he argues unregulated capitalism is prone to booms, busts and captured regulators and only experience calibrates the dose. The risk weighted assets point previews a financial literacy lecture he promises to deliver.

> *“It's a sort of crisis of legitimacy of the system when you're getting attacked from both sides.”*
>
> JOHN CASSIDY

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If instability is intrinsic to capitalism, what regulatory dose contains it without killing the golden goose?
- Does the left right convergence against free markets outlast Trump himself?
- Would the 2008 crisis have happened at 10 times leverage, or was risk weighting the whole story?

How CEOs Build Empires , Or Blow Them Up

2025-06-30 | WITH GLENN SCHORR, GERARD CASSIDY, DWIGHT COLLINS

THE THESIS

The panel's collective argument is that in financial services the CEO is the variable that compounds or destroys value, and the patterns repeat. Good CEOs build accountable teams, communicate reasonable goals, hold themselves to public report cards, buy assets non dilutively when they are cheap, and compound tangible book value per share and dividends over decades, with Jamie Dimon, who serially fixed Bank One, JPMorgan and Chase, as the archetype. Bad CEOs share two tells, concentrated loan risk and rapid growth, the combination that killed the Texas banks in the 1980s, the Northeast banks in the 1990s, Washington Mutual and Wachovia. Reputation lags reality badly, as the Citi versus JPMorgan valuation flip since 2000 shows, and great franchises prove themselves by producing the next generation of leaders.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman keeps forcing specificity, making the panel name names and interrogating superlatives, including a demand to justify calling Dimon's accountability shocking. His own contrarian entry is that Lloyd Blankfein was perhaps one of the most overrated CEOs in the industry, lionized in the good times, and the panel's counterexamples of supposedly conservative firms that nearly failed in the crisis reinforce the point that stability reputations were fictions. The panel then flips the script on him, asking which CEO judged badly turned out well, and lands on Brian Moynihan, which Eisman accepts.

THE NUMBERS

- Around 2000 Citigroup traded near 3 times book while JPMorgan traded at about 75% of book, a ranking that later fully inverted
- Dimon's arc: pushed out as Sandy Weill's right hand, fixed Bank One, then JPMorgan, then Chase in succession
- M&T bought Wilmington Trust for pennies on the dollar, the model of a non dilutive seize the moment acquisition
- John Kanas read the cycle and sold North Fork to Capital One in 2005, before the blowup
- Wachovia pushed loan to values to 80 to 90% against the 40 to 50% that had kept losses contained, and it was a disaster
- Marianne Lake ran an entire JPMorgan investor day solo, the panel's evidence she is the heir apparent
- Gerard Cassidy has covered the top 20 banks for over 34 years, back to the Texas bank failures

WHAT MOVED

A consensus panel that sharpens rather than fights: Dimon's supremacy goes unchallenged, Eisman's Blankfein demotion stands without rebuttal, and the panel moves Eisman to accept Moynihan as the redemption case he had not considered. Everyone leaves holding the same two variable model of bank failure, concentration plus rapid growth.

IN THE ARC

A pure banks and management episode that extends the show's banks and the Fed thread from stress test season, and Eisman defends its method weeks later in the mailbag when a viewer challenges his Hank Greenberg verdict. The praise for Marc Rowan's private credit platform build sits in tension with the show's running private credit scepticism.

> *“The companies that focus on creating shareholder value through tangible book value per share growth come out on top all the time.”*
>
> GERARD CASSIDY

> *“Great leaders produce future leaders.”*
>
> GLENN SCHORR

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does JPMorgan's compounding machine survive the handoff from Dimon to a successor?
- Can today's fast growing private credit platforms escape the concentration plus rapid growth failure pattern?
- How should investors price a CEO reputation premium when Citi versus JPMorgan shows it can fully invert?

Don't Get Fooled Again: Pulitzer Winner Warns of Wall Street's Dark Side

2025-07-07 | WITH GRETCHEN MORGENSON

THE THESIS

Morgenson's through line, stated as her theme, is practices that harm the vast array of people while benefiting a small elite on the inside, and she argues the pattern simply migrates: crooked dot com analysts, Enron and WorldCom accounting, AIG, then subprime and derivatives, where leverage turned a housing mania into a systemic collapse. The scandal of 2008, to her, is that despite trillions in investor losses and families' furniture on the curb, nothing changed and nobody was prosecuted. The current iteration is private equity: firms that levered up in a perfect rate and IPO environment are starting to go bankrupt as exits close and rates stay high, pensioners are left on the hook, and the industry has moved retiree obligations from blue chip employers into PE owned insurers regulated only by the states.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman pushes back hardest on the private equity bankruptcy claim, countering that the number of PE portfolio bankruptcies he is told about is very small; Morgenson holds that it is starting and explains the mechanism, the perfect environment those capital structures require is gone. On the insurance story Eisman forces his own standard, data before opinion, and Morgenson concedes the bear case is effectively dataless until it happens, though statutory state filings exist; Eisman then piles on that state by state insurance regulation, with firms domiciled in places like Iowa, is another accident waiting to happen.

THE NUMBERS

- Morgenson won the 2002 Pulitzer for 2001 coverage of crooked Wall Street analysts, the Times' seventh that year alongside six for 9/11
- Her AIG accounting story landed around 2005, before the crisis exposed the firm's credit default swap book
- A PE owned aluminum smelter bankruptcy she investigated took three pension plans down with it
- 2008 produced investor losses in the trillions and no senior Wall Street prosecutions, and no one ever found who decided not to prosecute
- Retirees of Bristol Myers, Lockheed and Coors now depend on Apollo's Athene for their pensions
- Insurers are regulated by their state of domicile rather than any federal body, unlike Fed supervised banks

WHAT MOVED

Partial convergence. Eisman accepts the shape of the private equity dark side story and supplies ammunition on state insurance regulation, but holds that without securitization style monthly data the thesis is unprovable in advance, his subprime method inverted. Morgenson holds that the bankruptcies have begun and adds that her own discipline is the same, she would not short planet Earth without data either.

IN THE ARC

The dark side of capitalism episode trailed in the July 3 wrap, and the investigative complement to the show's private credit scepticism: Sohn's charts showed the private asset managers rolling over, Eisman's June 21 wrap said problems surface only in recession, and Morgenson supplies the pensions and insurance transmission channel. It also revisits the 2008 material that made Eisman's name.

> *“Practices that really harm the vast array of people but benefit a small elite group on the inside. That's my theme.”*
>
> GRETCHEN MORGENSON

> *“I wasn't going to go short planet Earth because I woke up on the wrong side of the bed one day.”*
>
> GRETCHEN MORGENSON

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What dataset would let an investor see private equity credit stress monthly, the way subprime securitizations could be tracked?
- Are pensions transferred to PE owned insurers safe through a real credit cycle?

- If nothing changed after 2008, what would force accountability after the next blowup?

Big Beautiful Bill, Write-Off Revolution & Tariff Tempest , The Friday Market Wrap!

2025-07-12 | WITH DAN CLIFTON

THE THESIS

Clifton's core argument is that the big beautiful bill should be read as sterilization, not stimulus: Trump's April 2 tariff program was bad enough to threaten recession, so the business tax cuts, led by 100% immediate expensing for factories built in America, exist to offset the tariff drag, and Bessent's tariff delays were sequencing designed to let the fiscal offset arrive in time. Scored together rather than separately, tariff revenue and tax cuts leave the deficit roughly flat at about 6.2 to 6.3% of GDP, contradicting both the blowout narrative and the MAGA no problem narrative. The growth kick, roughly a full percentage point, lands in late 2025 and 2026 as companies gear up, replacing the fading IRA and infrastructure impulse, while the healthcare cuts everyone is litigating do not take effect until 2028, echoing how Obamacare's changes lagged its politics.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

This is an explainer, so Eisman probes for mechanism rather than disputing: he makes Clifton repeat the 100% factory write off because it is unheard of, and he forces the macro logic into one sentence, that tariffs alone could cause a recession but the tax cuts offset the price increases, which Clifton affirms. Eisman's own standing caveat, aired in the surrounding wrap, is that trade negotiations are complicated and the trade war risk is binary and impossible to handicap, so the offset only works if the tariffs stay delayed.

THE NUMBERS

- A factory built in America can be written off 100% immediately under the new law
- Scoring tariffs and tax cuts together leaves the deficit at roughly 6.2 to 6.3% of GDP, essentially status quo
- The April 2 tariff program peaked at about 700 billion dollars; current policy sits at about 330 billion
- The bill's healthcare cuts and changes do not take effect until 2028, with a roughly 100 billion dollar emergency fund for hospitals
- Clifton expects about a full percentage point of added growth as a 2025 to 2026 story, replacing the fading IRA and infrastructure impulse
- That same week Trump threatened tariffs on 14 countries plus 50% on copper and Brazil, and the market still made an all time high

WHAT MOVED

Eisman adopts the sterilization framing as the biggest takeaway, agreeing the policy mix is far better than the April 2 mix, while keeping his trade war caveat intact. Clifton gives no ground on his both sides are wrong deficit math.

IN THE ARC

Clifton was the show's first ever guest on tariffs in April, and this return visit converts the wraps' running tariff anxiety into a fiscal framework: it explains why Eisman keeps saying the only real market risk is an actual trade war while staying bullish on everything else. The 2028 healthcare timing note foreshadows the show's later healthcare investigations.

> *“If you build a factory in America, you can write it off 100%.”*
>
> DAN CLIFTON

> *“We always view this more as a sterilization than a growth package.”*
>
> DAN CLIFTON

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does the expensing driven capex arrive before the tariff drag bites, or after?
- What happens to the flat deficit math if tariff revenue is negotiated away or struck down?
- Do the 2028 healthcare cuts become the next Obamacare style political time bomb?

Why the Market's Surging Despite the Headlines

2025-07-14 | WITH CHRIS VERRONE

THE THESIS

Verrone argues the year's round trip proves the market is smarter than the headlines: December and January euphoria, with equity flows in the 99th percentile of history, set up the fall, and the April washout set up one of the great thrusts, the fourth best 65 day rally off a low ever, keeping company with 2009, 2020 and 1982. Breadth, benign credit conditions and cyclical leadership say the tape is not predicting a slowdown, so he leans into the trend rather than fighting it. His sharpest thematic call is that deregulation flips the private markets pecking order: regulation protected incumbents like Apollo and Blackstone, and letting Goldman and the banks back into those arenas hands the advantage to the challengers, which the relative charts are already sensing. He also calls gold bullishness excessive and treats Bitcoin as a maturing survivor of three 90% drawdowns rather than a proven store of value.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman agrees the economy is dynamic but presses his complacency worry, that the market is treating trade war probability as roughly zero when it is not zero, and Verrone does not really dispute it, he just argues the tape gives no evidence of slowdown yet. Eisman demands data behind the excessive gold bullishness call and gets the GLD flow evidence. On Bitcoin Eisman pushes for a thesis beyond price action, and Verrone's honest answer is that he owns it because it trades great, conceding under questioning that April's resilience may have been regulatory news rather than maturation. Eisman also retests his hardware over software idea from the Cisco episode against Verrone's charts.

THE NUMBERS

- Flows into equities reached the 99th percentile of all historical periods around the December to January top
- The rally off the April low was the fourth best 65 trading day run in history, behind or beside 2009, 2020 and 1982, with 1998 fifth
- S&P info tech is 31% of the index and tech like exposure exceeds 50%, unmatched anywhere in the world
- Bitcoin has survived three separate 90% drawdowns since 2008, which almost nothing else has done
- By January 1991, Desert Storm's start, oil was already below its pre invasion level, his template for fading geopolitical oil spikes
- Goldman and the banks re-entering private credit territory is visible in Apollo and Blackstone relative charts rolling over

WHAT MOVED

Eisman concedes the tape's message and the historical company of the thrust, but keeps his one worry, a trade war priced at zero. Verrone concedes nuance on Bitcoin's April behavior and does not contest the complacency point, holding simply that until credit or breadth cracks, the trend deserves the benefit of the doubt.

IN THE ARC

The market strategy bookend to Todd Sohn's June technical episode from the same firm, and both flag the private markets incumbents as losers, Sohn via distributive charts, Verrone via the deregulation reversal, deepening the show's private credit thread. It also answers the viewer conspiracy mailbag about the eerie straight up recovery that Eisman addressed in the wraps.

> *"If you had all the headlines in advance, you could lose money with the best of them."*
>
> CHRIS VERRONE

“Regulation benefits incumbents. Deregulation benefits challengers.”

CHRIS VERRONE

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Is pricing trade war risk at zero market wisdom or the complacency Eisman fears?
- Do banks re-entering private credit actually take share from Apollo and Blackstone, or just compress everyone's returns?
- What would Bitcoin have to do for technicians to call it a store of value rather than a risk-on trade?

The Secrets of the Short Seller: How the Pros Spot Trouble

2025-07-21 | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

THE THESIS

Ganapathi's method is that a good short needs a structural catalyst, not a high multiple: a broken business model, product or scalability problems, and above all bad management, which her firm establishes with investigative research, FOIA requests, whistleblowers, and background work on every board member and executive. The balance sheet confirms the story, ballooning receivables at SolarEdge, rising warranty liabilities, and inventory gluts, which is how Stellantis becomes her current conviction short: a rollup that overproduced more than anyone, misjudged demand, and left dealers stuffed with cars while buyers sit on negative equity trade ins. The discipline is as much about what not to short: never short a cult stock, because cultists buy on things you dismiss, and never short purely on valuation, because nobody cares until there is a catalyst.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman relentlessly forces the how: how she sourced the airline maintenance story, exactly why Stellantis is worse than an industry wide inventory problem, and how Opendoor loses thousands per house while barely renovating. He extracts her worst trade, a cult stock short that ripped about 100 points overnight before collapsing, and makes her admit she broke her own rule. He then codifies the lessons on air, contributing his own long held rule against pure valuation shorts, and supplies the closing test his own partner echoes: fundamentals can be terrible and it will not matter if nobody cares.

THE NUMBERS

- A whistleblower mechanic and FOIA work surfaced an airline CEO telling staff not to ground planes for any reason because it cost money
- She spent a month or two calling essentially every US solar installer and distributor before shorting SolarEdge and Enphase
- California's net metering change broke rooftop solar economics, compounding the residential solar collapse
- Her cult stock short rose about 100 points essentially overnight, then fell 150 within days, ending below where it started
- Stellantis dealerships carry materially more excess inventory than peers like Ford, and buyers face negative equity on trade ins
- A private solar company filed Chapter 11 with about 1 billion dollars of liabilities against roughly 100 to 500 million in assets
- Opendoor put lipstick on a pig, paint and new carpet only, yet still lost thousands of dollars per house sold

WHAT MOVED

Convergence into a shared rulebook: Ganapathi concedes her cult stock short was a mistake against her own rules, Eisman endorses her management first framework and adds his valuation rule, and both land on management as the single most reliable tell in a short. No open disagreement survives the episode.

IN THE ARC

First of the show's back to back short seller episodes trailed in the July 19 wrap, where Eisman framed the question as what makes a good short and what risks shorts carry that longs do not. The solar postmortem mirrors his June 21 wrap on Enphase falling from 340 dollars to 35, and Opendoor touches the show's housing affordability thread.

> *“I don't care if the engine falls out of the plane. You do not ground the plane for any reason.”*
>
> LAKSHMI GANAPATHI, QUOTING THE AIRLINE CEO

> *“The stocks that are good shorts, it's the management. It's always the management.”*
>
> LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How long can Stellantis carry industry worst inventory before the write downs force the catalyst?
- How does a short seller time entry when the fundamentals are bad but nobody cares yet?
- Do retail cult dynamics now permanently raise the risk premium on every fundamentals based short?

The Secrets of the Short Seller Part 2: The Blueprint for Strategy & Survival

2025-07-28 | WITH BRAD SAFALOW

THE THESIS

Safalow argues that modern short selling starts with market structure, not fundamentals. Before touching a thesis he maps his four Ps, passives, processors meaning quant algos, pods, and positioning, because they determine how a stock behaves regardless of valuation: with heavy passive ownership valuation is almost irrelevant and flows rule, and the marginal buyer at 100 times earnings is not a human with a model. Only then does he layer on fundamental decay, like declining revenue per incremental store, rising customer acquisition costs, and share loss to competitors. The environment has also inverted the old playbook: it has been better to short an okay company with secular challenges, like Pepsi, than a horrible company with severe limitations, because the horrible ones get squeezed. The craft is survival, since even shorts that eventually go to zero can rally 50 to 100% first.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

This is a colleagues session, so Eisman presses on mechanics rather than disagreeing. He makes Safalow walk listeners through exactly how a gamma squeeze works, using Trupanion in the low 50s with 20% short interest and stacked call strikes at 55 and 60, and how dealer hedging feeds the spiral. He also forces the uncomfortable performance question: if names like Big Lots and IGT rallied 50 to 100% before going to zero, did Safalow actually capture extraordinary returns by pressing? Safalow concedes the honest answer is only sometimes, because he covers at times when he should not, and risk managers can force covers at the worst moment.

THE NUMBERS

- Safalow's four Ps framework for setup analysis: passives, processors (quant algos), pods, and positioning
- His short ideas have generated 27% annual alpha since the inception of his firm
- Pepsi has been one of the best S&P 500 shorts of the last 5 years, roughly 200% alpha generation
- Average vet bill per accident or illness claim is about 400 to 500 dollars, the core economics behind the pet insurance short debate
- US pet insurance penetration for dogs is around 5.5 to 6%, versus 2 to 3 times that in the UK and almost 40% in Sweden
- Kinsale Insurance: 11 billion market cap cult stock with a loss ratio in the low 60s and combined ratio in the low 80s
- Kinsale carries only about 20 million dollars of capitalized software, roughly 1% of premiums, undercutting its claimed technology edge

WHAT MOVED

No real disagreement to resolve. Eisman endorses the framework throughout, and the movement is in candor: Safalow admits the alpha numbers hide misery, mistimed covers, and forced risk management, and both land on shorting as an essential but brutal tool rather than a hero trade.

IN THE ARC

The second half of the show's short-selling curriculum, following the Lakshmi Ganapathi interview a week earlier, and raw material for the shorting topic in the September financial literacy masterclass. It drops the same week Eisman's wrap covers a fresh meme stock rally in sub 5 dollar names, making the squeeze mechanics discussion unusually timely.

> *“It has been better to be short an okay company with some challenges than a horrible company with severe limitations.”*
>
> BRAD SAFALOW

> *“When you get into one of those and it actually starts working it is extremely gratifying, but there's a lot of misery in the middle too.”*
>
> BRAD SAFALOW

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can a fundamental short thesis still pay when passives and algos, not humans, set the marginal price?
- How should a short seller size positions when squeezes can force covers regardless of conviction?
- Does the okay-company-over-horrible-company rule survive a real bear market, or is it an artifact of this bull cycle?

Venture Capital Revealed: Behind the Schemes They Haven’t Told You

2025-08-04 | WITH STU ELMAN

THE THESIS

Ellman argues that venture capital has been in an unreported depression since 2022. The 2017 to 2021 period was a bubble worse than 2000 on valuation: his firm ran the numbers on its own fund-returning companies and concluded that at 2021 prices those same wins would not have returned the fund, so RRE largely stood aside while others signed vanilla term sheets with no board seats. When the market turned, startups that had raised 12 to 18 months of cash ran out, triggering pay-to-play rounds where investors who decline to double down are washed out, diluted roughly 10 to 1 and converted to common. The reckoning is slow because venture firms die slowly, not quickly: zombie funds keep collecting fees while deploying almost nothing, and the real test is whether the 2017 to 2020 vintage can ever raise successor funds. Meanwhile new investment has narrowed almost entirely to AI, blockchain and crypto, with LP money rotating into debt, distressed and asset-based funds.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman plays the forcing function on definitions and mechanics rather than disputing the thesis. He makes Ellman explain exactly what washed out means in a pay-to-play round, why venture firms die slowly instead of visibly failing, and whether 2021 was really worse than the 2000 bubble Ellman lived through, which Ellman affirms on valuation grounds. His sharpest jab comes at the bubble-era practice of funding companies on vanilla term sheets with no board seat: this sounds like gambling. On tokenization Eisman pushes for a concrete example, and Ellman offers real estate cash flows parsed and sold in pieces, which Eisman immediately maps back to CBOs and CMOs from his own past.

THE NUMBERS

- RRE Ventures was founded in 1994, the same month the Netscape browser was released
- The bubble window Ellman identifies runs 2017 to 2021, with valuations worse than 2000 by his firm's own portfolio analysis

- Startups typically raise 12 to 18 months of cash, which set the fuse for the 2022 to 2023 wash-out rounds
- Pay-to-play punishment: investors who do not re-up get diluted roughly 10 to 1 and put to common
- Bubble-era deals were done on vanilla term sheets with no board seats
- RRE was an early investor in Ripple and DCG, the parent of Grayscale and Paxos
- LP fundraising is rotating out of venture into debt funds, distressed debt funds and asset-based funds

WHAT MOVED

Eisman adopts the thesis wholesale. He repeats it almost verbatim in that week's wrap and again to Melissa Lee the following week: venture capital is emerging from a depression nobody writes about, valuations got obliterated, many funds will fail, and VC accounting lets firms hide it. Ellman holds his one bullish lane, physical AI and tokenization, without resistance.

IN THE ARC

The episode extends the show's K-shaped lens to private markets: AI, blockchain and crypto get funded while everything else sits in depression, mirroring the public market split Eisman tracks between AI winners and the rest. Ellman's tokenization enthusiasm also sets up a live tension with Eisman's standing crypto scepticism, which Eisman notably does not press here.

> *"Venture firms don't die quickly, they die slowly."*
>
> STU ELMAN

> *"This sounds like gambling."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How many of the 2017 to 2020 vintage funds actually fail to raise successors, and over what timeline?
- Does VC accounting opacity mean LPs are still carrying marks that a public market would never accept?
- Is tokenization of building cash flows genuinely new infrastructure, or CBOs and CMOs with a blockchain wrapper?

Steve Eisman Shares the Real Story Behind Predicting the 2008 Crash

2025-08-11 | WITH MELISSA LEE

THE THESIS

With Lee interviewing, the argument is Eisman's own bull case and its origin story. He is long-term bullish because Dodd-Frank forced banks to massively delever, taking a systemic financial crisis off the table, while tech, AI and the resulting electricity buildout feed on each other: info tech is officially 31% of the S&P but roughly 50% once Amazon, Google and Meta are counted, a concentration no other country has. The one risk he cannot handicap is a full trade war with China. On 2008, he reconstructs the reasoning chain: the trade began as equity shorts on New Century, Countrywide and WaMu, but 25% borrow costs forced the move into shorting subprime paper itself, guided by the single most important statistic, the percentage of no-doc and low-doc loans in each securitization. And on US debt, the difference from Greece is that treasuries are the plumbing of the global banking system with no alternative, which buys America the luxury of time.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The roles are reversed, so the pressing comes from Lee. She challenges why he stays steadfastly bullish while Wall Street strategists flip-flop targets in real time, and asks why the world remains preoccupied with predicting the next crisis, drawing out his admission that he enjoyed having a movie made about him. Her sharpest sequence is on Apple: Eisman concedes that 100% of real manufacturing happens in China, that India assembly claims are not true, and that this makes Apple captive to US-China relations. When she asks whether any discount is embedded for that risk, he admits he is not hedged, just long, and that a US-China

trade war could give Apple serious problems.

THE NUMBERS

- The info sector is 31% of the S&P, and roughly 50% including Amazon, Google, Meta and Booking, a concentration unmatched by any country
- Borrow cost on illiquid subprime lender equities like New Century was literally 25%, which pushed the trade into credit
- The key subprime metric was the percentage of no-doc and low-doc loans in each securitization, tracked through Moody's database
- Oppenheimer brought subprime lender Aames Financial public in 1992, the start of Eisman's subprime education
- In the tariff endgame the EU caved to a 15% rate and Switzerland was caving, while Canada, Mexico and China remained unresolved
- Venture capital has been in a depression since 2022 outside AI, crypto and blockchain, per his Ellman interview

WHAT MOVED

Eisman holds the bullish frame but Lee extracts a real concession: the Apple position is unhedged against the one risk he himself calls the only thing that could derail the story, and he acknowledges the tension rather than resolving it, ending with it will be all right.

IN THE ARC

The episode is the show's Rosetta stone, connecting the 2008 origin story to the current playbook: thesis-plus-data discipline, banks defanged by Dodd-Frank, AI dynamism as the new engine, and reserve currency status as the answer to debt doomers. The China trade war worry and the VC depression theme both carry straight over from the surrounding wraps and the Ellman episode.

> *“If you manufacture 100% of the stuff in China, you are completely captive to whatever happens between President Trump and China.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“As long as there's no alternative to treasuries, we could do pretty much what we want.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What would force Eisman to hedge or sell Apple rather than ride the China exposure?
- How close would crypto or Chinese bonds have to get to reserve status before the US loses its luxury of time?
- Can a 50% effective tech concentration in the S&P stay a strength rather than become the next fragility?

Industrial Sector Explained: Data Center Growth & Rise of Vertiv | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep. 21

2025-08-18 | WITH STEVE TUSA

THE THESIS

Tusa argues the data center buildout has gone from a ferocious to a historic investment cycle, but investors must size it honestly: data centers are only about 5% of US private non-res building construction, so the theme is massive as a growth rate, not yet as a share of the economy. The numbers get big when you chain it to power, hyperscaler capex of 300 to 400 billion a year plus hundreds of billions of utility capex, and the physics compounds it, with rack power going from about 100 with Blackwell to 200 and upwards of 500 on next generation chips, making cooling demand exponential. That funnels value to the pure plays, Vertiv at 80% data center exposure and Eaton at 30 to 40% data center plus utility. His contrarian edge is scepticism

on the broadening trade: automation names bid up on reshoring lack actual capex support because autos and process industries are flat, and with the group's valuations stretched there is little that is genuinely attractive.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman repeatedly stops Tusa to force sizing and definitions, making him repeat the 5% of non-res construction figure and define the automation industry before letting the reshoring debate proceed, where Tusa himself supplies the objection that no major capex spender backs the theme. The richest exchange is on GE: Eisman recounts how the balance sheet sat entirely in financial services while earnings sat on the industrial side, and how industrial analysts went cross-eyed when he raised it; Tusa concurs that sell-side incentives discouraged tough questions and that the Alstom deal, adding a D minus to a C minus, sank the company. On GE Vernova, Eisman probes whether the turnaround is durable, and Tusa notes wind is still losing about a billion dollars a year.

THE NUMBERS

- Data centers are only about 5% of total US private non-res building construction
- Hyperscaler data center capex is running 300 to 400 billion dollars a year, with utility capex in the hundreds of billions on top
- The US data center pipeline is 300 gigawatts, and only about 35% of that funnel is hyperscalers
- Rack power density goes from about 100 with Blackwell to 200 and upwards of 500 with next generation chips, making cooling needs exponential
- Vertiv has 80% data center exposure, which Tusa jokes is more revenue exposure than Nvidia's
- GE Vernova is still losing about 1 billion dollars a year in wind
- Tusa upgraded Vertiv at 90 with a 130 target; the stock sits at 145 against a 170 target, and JCI just announced a 5 billion accelerated share repurchase

WHAT MOVED

Convergence rather than conflict. Eisman absorbs Tusa's proprietary-versus-derivative frame and deploys it days later in his wrap, ranking AI plays by how proprietary their products are. Tusa holds his valuation caution, marching Vertiv's multiple assumption down from 23 times and calling the group inch by inch from here.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's core AI capex episode from the picks-and-shovels side, quantifying the electricity bottleneck theme Eisman raises in wraps about GE Vernova and gas turbine scarcity. Tusa's warning that only data center and utility spending is real capex also feeds Eisman's running question about whether AI investment returns will justify the spend.

> *“Peacock today, feather duster tomorrow, peacock again.”*
>
> STEVE TUSA

> *“I always joke around and say it has more data center exposure than Nvidia does.”*
>
> STEVE TUSA

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What happens to Vertiv and Eaton multiples if hyperscaler capex growth merely flattens?
- Can the 65% of the 300 gigawatt pipeline that is not hyperscalers actually get financed and powered?
- Does the reshoring automation trade ever get real capex behind it, or does it deflate first?

Tesla vs Waymo: Who Will Win the Robotaxi Race? | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep. 22

2025-08-25 | WITH ITAY MICHAELI

THE THESIS

Michaeli argues Tesla's earnings collapse, down about 57% from the 2022 peak while the stock sits flat, has a mundane cause: the company over-earned off a single aging platform, the Model 3 and Y, forgot that cars are emotional purchases needing refreshes and lineup breadth, taught China how to build EVs and is now losing share to those students, all while the EV market itself slowed and subsidies die after the third quarter. The bull case therefore rests on autonomy, but he says investors frame it too narrowly: 90% of conversations are about robotaxis, a market anchored to a 60 billion dollar ride share business, while the real prize is consumer-facing autonomy inside the roughly 1.5 trillion dollar US mobility market, where Tesla could hold a multi-year lead. He likes the stock when sentiment is low and catalysts are near, but sets a test: if nothing ships on consumer FSD features within 12 to 15 months, his thesis is disappointed.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman opens by forcing the earnings math, reading Tesla's numbers aloud and demanding to know why earnings are down almost 60% since 2022 before any autonomy talk is allowed. He presses the near-term hole: where do sales go in the fourth and first quarters once credits vanish after a pull-forward. On autonomy he channels scepticism about Tesla operating in dense cities, making Michaeli lay out how Waymo's approach differs from Tesla's and getting him to concede solving 3 a.m. suburban driving is a different problem from Manhattan or San Francisco. He then forces the ranking question: Michaeli's top picks are GM, Aptiv and Visteon, with Tesla deliberately outside the pantheon, and Eisman extracts agreement that Tesla's future rests on how fast AV and new product arrive.

THE NUMBERS

- Tesla's market cap is 1.1 trillion dollars while the stock has been basically flat since 2022
- Tesla earned over 4 dollars per share in 2022; consensus has 2025 earnings down about 57% from that peak, with peak gross margin around 25%
- US EV penetration is about 7.5% of new vehicle sales, ticking north of 8% in July before the credit-driven pull-forward
- The US mobility market is roughly 1.5 trillion dollars against a ride share market of about 60 billion
- Michaeli's test: no consumer FSD feature launches within 12 to 15 months would disappoint his thesis; the rest of the industry is 3 to 4 years behind
- Michaeli's ranking: GM top overall pick, Aptiv top supplier, Visteon top SMid idea, with Tesla ranked separately as an autonomy story

WHAT MOVED

Michaeli holds his catalyst-driven constructive view; Eisman stays unconvinced and says so with his wallet, closing that the only thing that would get him to buy a Tesla is AV itself. Days later in his wrap he goes further: with Waymo at more than 250,000 fully autonomous weekly rides and Tesla's service extremely limited, he remains on the sidelines.

IN THE ARC

The episode extends the show's method of separating narrative from earnings, applying the UnitedHealth-style discipline of asking why profits fell before debating the dream. It also feeds the recurring AI theme from the consumer side: autonomy as the next monetization question where, as with AI capex, the gap between spending, promises and shipped product is the whole debate.

> *"The only thing that's going to get me to buy a Tesla is AV. So, I'll let you know."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *"If you put out great product and a compelling offering, you will be successful."*
>
> ITAY MICHAELI

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does Tesla ship broad consumer FSD features inside Michaeli's 12 to 15 month window?
- Where do Tesla sales settle in the fourth and first quarters once EV credits are gone?

- Can Tesla close the gap with Waymo in dense cities, or does its sensor bet cap it to easier geographies?

Steve Eisman Answers YOUR Investing Questions | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 23

2025-09-01 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

A solo mailbag with a connected argument underneath: durable investing judgment comes from outside the business bookshelf. Eisman reads history, psychology and politics rather than business books, crediting Judge Richard Posner, whose 1974 antitrust book remade an entire legal field, with teaching him that ideas matter and that woven frameworks beat isolated facts. Applied to markets, the method is thesis plus independent data: anecdote said subprime underwriting was rotting, but Moody's securitization database proved it, because the numbers did not lie even when ratings did. The MLP case study carries the structural lesson: when a partnership pays its parent 50% of cash flow, a nominal 12% cost of capital is really about 24%, no pipeline can out-earn that, and balance sheets therefore matter as much as, and sometimes more than, income statements. The through line is knowing your lane, including his own choice to stay in the dynamic US market and protect a good night's sleep.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Solo, so the pressure he airs against himself is limited but real. Asked what could derail his bullishness, he concedes a full-blown trade war with China absolutely could happen and is impossible to handicap. On end-of-the-world predictions he disarms his own legend: having predicted it once, he is in no rush to predict it again and sees no evidence for it. He also flags his own fallibility directly, recalling MLP executives who could not see their paradigm had been blown away even when the math was laid in front of them, the same trap any investor, including him, can fall into.

THE NUMBERS

- Eisman has read roughly 35 to 37 of Posner's about 40 books, and Posner's 1974 antitrust book reoriented the field around consumer protection
- Moody's securitization database, bought by subscription, confirmed the subprime thesis when industry anecdote and ratings said all was fine
- A questioner cites Berkshire holding 348 billion dollars in cash; Eisman says he has changed his mind and no longer sees a reason to hoard cash
- The MLP structure paying the parent 50% of cash flow turns a 12% cost of capital into roughly 24%, an unbeatable hurdle
- The MLP index is only back to its 2015 level after the sector's multi-year decline
- Dodd-Frank eliminated the Office of Thrift Supervision and created a de facto chief bank regulator, the Fed vice chair for supervision
- For aspiring analysts he recommends the three-year CFA course over any book

WHAT MOVED

He announces an explicit change of mind: ten years ago corrections made him nervous enough to consider raising cash, but his confidence in the dynamism of the US economy now makes him stay invested through volatility. He also quietly retires his own doomsayer persona, holding the bullish frame while reserving the China trade war as the one live threat.

IN THE ARC

The episode is the connective tissue between the interview series and the masterclasses, converting the 2008 story from the Melissa Lee episode into teachable method and previewing the balance sheet and shorting topics of the September 8 masterclass. Its Fed-is-stronger-than-any-one-person answer lands mid Lisa Cook firing fight, the banks and Fed theme running through the wraps, though he misstates the Fed's origin as a constitutional amendment and corrects it the following week.

“Balance sheets matter as much and at times more than income statements.”

STEVE EISMAN

“Never underestimate the importance of a good night's sleep.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If a China trade war is the one unhedgeable risk, what would early warning actually look like in the data?
- Does the no-cash-buffer stance survive the first real recession scare of this cycle?
- Which of today's consensus sectors is running on a blown paradigm its executives cannot yet see?

Steve Eisman’s Masterclass on Financial Literacy | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 24

2025-09-08 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

The lecture's organizing claim is that investing is a club whose entrance fee is mastering its language, and the masterclass teaches the grammar across eight topics. The foundation is his post crisis reversal: in 2007 leverage made him tell people to go to cash, but Dodd-Frank forced banks to delever so massively that another financial crisis is unlikely, which is what licenses ordinary investors to buy indices, SPY alone for the risk averse or SPY plus QQQ for more risk, on a fixed schedule with no market timing. Discipline then does the rest of the work: a stock is owned for a thesis, thesis creep, keeping a broken thesis because the stock got cheaper, is the bane of every investor, and shorting requires a different mindset because squeezes can bury a correct case. Valuation is presented as a dialect that varies by sector, PE, EV to EBITDA, price to tangible book for balance sheet dependent financials, pipeline guesses for pharma, and rates transmit to stocks through both the economy and the discount rate, hitting growth stocks hardest through DCF math.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Solo lecture, and he supplies his own objections. Against his index advice he flags concentration: info tech is officially 31% of the S&P but over 40% with Meta, Google and Amazon properly counted, a weighting no other developed market carries, so index buyers own a tech bet whether they know it or not. Against his own authority as a famous short seller he warns that shorting a heavily shorted stock can be dangerous regardless of how good the case is, knowledge he says came from really painful experience. And on valuation method he concedes the awkward point that discounted cash flow is in principle the right way to value stocks even though he refuses to rely on it because too many variables must be modeled.

THE NUMBERS

- Info tech is 31% of the S&P officially, over 40% with Meta, Google and Amazon reclassified, versus Europe's largest sector, financials, at 25%
- Sector weights he teaches: consumer discretionary 10%, industrials 9%, communication services 7%, staples 5%, utilities 3%, energy 3%, real estate 2%, materials 1%
- In 2022 the S&P fell 18% as the Fed raised rates on recession fear, and the recession never came
- Recommended default portfolios: SPY for lower risk tolerance, a combination of SPY and QQQ for higher, bought on a schedule without timing
- Eli Lilly's very high PE is priced off its pipeline, led by the premier weight loss drug Mounjaro or Zepbound, not near-year earnings
- Traditional financials are valued on price to tangible book because they are balance sheet dependent, while payments names like Visa and Mastercard trade on PE
- Utilities trade at high teens PEs and on dividend yield because regulation makes their profits predictable

WHAT MOVED

Nothing to concede in a lecture, but the format itself marks the show's pivot: the same Dodd-Frank argument used in interviews becomes doctrine here, the explicit basis for telling retail listeners to stay invested. He closes by handing the syllabus to the audience, promising future topics chosen from their emails.

IN THE ARC

The first formal masterclass, announced since the July wraps and built from mailbag demand, turning the show's running themes into curriculum: banks and the Fed as the delevered safe core, rates as the valuation transmission channel, and tech concentration as the unexamined risk inside passive investing. It pairs with the September 1 Q&A episode, which handled the topics this lecture deferred.

> *"Every profession creates its own language. Mastery of that language is the entrance fee."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *"Thesis creep is the bane of every investor, and I speak only from very hard experience."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If another financial crisis is off the table, what kind of drawdown would falsify the buy-the-index doctrine?
- How should an index investor think about owning an effective 40% plus tech weighting at all-time highs?
- When rates fall as the Fed cuts, does his DCF logic imply growth stock multiples re-inflate past prior peaks?

Trump's Battle with the Fed Explained | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 25

2025-09-15 | WITH ROB KAPLAN

THE THESIS

Kaplan, ex Dallas Fed president and now Goldman vice chairman, argues the Fed's defense against political pressure is to do the job and ignore the noise: inside meetings the Trump pressure is simply not discussed, and policy will follow an economy growing only 1.25 to 1.5% with a weak job market masked by collapsed labor supply, with tariffs and curtailed immigration as near-term headwinds, so easing comes on the data, not on presidential demand. His credibility rests on having dissented from within: he calls the COVID-era forward guidance committing to zero rates until full employment a mistake, like promising to drive through an intersection while the light turns, because the neutral rate was drifting up. On banking he converges with Eisman: with about 4,150 US banks and only about 80 above 20 billion dollars in assets, technology costs and the 250,000 dollar deposit insurance cap give the largest banks overwhelming advantages, so substantial consolidation is both inevitable and healthy, freeing bank capital to drive GDP growth as debt to GDP passes 100%.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman frames the whole hour as critic versus insider, telling Kaplan he was a professional critic while Kaplan was in the room where it happens, and then keeps demanding the room's contents. He presses directly on what happens at Fed meetings under Trump's pressure, and Kaplan answers flatly that it is not discussed, absolutely not. He pushes Kaplan to compare Yellen and Powell, to explain why some M&A deals like Kraft Heinz curdle while others work, and to defend tariffs against Kaplan's own reported CEO worry, that no one wants to build an operation competitive only because of a tariff moat that could vanish in 5 or 10 years. Finally Eisman lays out his own thesis that US banks need an M&A wave to compete with JP Morgan, and rather than resisting, Kaplan extends it with the 4,150 bank arithmetic.

THE NUMBERS

- US GDP growth is running about 1.25 to 1.5%, with unemployment low mainly because labor supply has collapsed

- Kaplan opposed COVID-era forward guidance committing to zero rates until full employment while the neutral rate drifted up
- There are roughly 4,150 banks in the United States and only about 80 with assets over 20 billion dollars
- Deposit insurance caps at 250,000 dollars, handing the largest banks a structural deposit gathering advantage
- Debt to GDP has gone from the mid 70s percent before COVID to over 100%
- Goldman has grown from roughly 12 to 15 thousand employees when Kaplan first left to about 50,000 today
- Kaplan's CEO caution on tariffs: avoid building operations competitive only because of a tariff moat that may vanish in 5 or 10 years

WHAT MOVED

Real convergence on banks: Eisman proposes the consolidation thesis and Kaplan not only endorses it but supplies the regulatory argument, that lighter cost-benefit regulation plus mergers would free capital for organic GDP growth instead of government spending. On the Fed fight, Eisman's institutional calm is reinforced rather than changed: the insider confirms the pressure campaign does not penetrate the meeting room.

IN THE ARC

The banks and the Fed theme at full volume, airing days after the wraps covered the Lisa Cook firing attempt and the market's bet on September rate cuts, and echoing Eisman's September 1 line that the Fed as an institution is stronger than any one person. The bank consolidation argument also plants a flag the show returns to whenever regional banks, deposit flight or JP Morgan's tech spending come up.

> *"That makes me a professional critic. You, sir, are in the room where it happens."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *"I can tell you what I think's happening at the Fed meeting. It is not being discussed. Absolutely not."*
>
> ROB KAPLAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does the Cook firing fight stay outside the meeting room if the courts let the president reshape the board?
- What regulatory change would actually unlock the bank M&A wave both men say is needed?
- If labor supply, not demand, is holding unemployment down, how fast should the Fed cut into weak growth?

Breaking Down the United Healthcare Disaster: What's REALLY Going On? | Real Eisman Playbook Ep. 26

2025-09-22 | WITH MICHAEL HA

THE THESIS

Ha argues UnitedHealth's collapse came in two distinct phases that investors keep conflating. The first, from the investor day tragedy through February, was pure public relations noise with no fundamental cracks, and the stock's round trip from 600 down to about 440 and back proved it, even as Bill Ackman attacked the company over claims denials. The real break came with the April quarter, when the V28 risk model revisions pushed through by CMS began structurally impairing Optum Health, the crown jewel whose value-based care conversion was supposed to double enterprise earnings over a decade. Because those clinic models are optimized and tightly staffed, there are almost no offsets to find, and none have been found in two years; comparable South Florida clinic models have already disappeared for exactly that reason. Ha, once among the most bullish analysts on the name, is now the most bearish, and his bull case still implies downside.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman keeps forcing the disclosure question. He extracts the detail that 2024's entire earnings growth, roughly 3 dollars of 27, came from selling controlling stakes in Optum businesses, disclosed only as a vague line in the 10-K that analysts had to go fish for. He also probes what management actually says, and Ha admits the pattern is confidence followed by another surprise, twelve months running. Eisman's verdict on air: without dramatically improved disclosure the stock is very difficult to recommend at any valuation.

THE NUMBERS

- The stock fell from about 600 to 440 on PR noise alone, then recovered to 600 before the April quarter broke the story
- V28 risk model revisions phase in over 2024 to 2026 in equal parts, removing thousands of ICD-10 codes that mapped to payable hierarchical condition categories
- Converting 90% of roughly 10 million Medicare Advantage lives to Optum Health at 10 to 15% margins would have doubled enterprise earnings over a decade
- About 3 dollars of 2024's roughly 27 dollars in EPS came from gains on sale, the entire year's growth, disclosed only vaguely in the 10-K
- Ha's bull case of 257 sat about 15% below the 305 share price at recording, even assuming V28 is fully offset
- Ha calls 14 to 15 times earnings the new normal against the old 20 times multiple Optum Health once justified
- Brian Thompson's death forced leadership shifts across divisions before the usual two to three year rotations were complete

WHAT MOVED

Nothing converges. Ha reports a definitive zero investors who are both positive and understand the complexity, and Eisman ends more negative than he started, adding disclosure to his list of reasons to stay away. Ha holds his underperform and says cleaner managed care stories exist for anyone tempted by the multi-year recovery case.

IN THE ARC

The first entry in what becomes the show's multi-part healthcare investigation, teased in the September 20 wrap as a real potential scandal. It plants two recurring Eisman rules: separate PR noise from fundamental cracks, and treat opaque disclosure as its own sell signal. The October 31 wrap circles back when United's Optum Health margin prints 1% against 8.3% a year earlier, confirming the thesis in real time.

> *“It was all really PR noise. There were no fundamental cracks in the story at that time.”*
>
> MICHAEL HA

> *“Unless this company dramatically improves disclosure, I think it is very difficult to recommend the stock.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can Optum Health rebuild clinic unit economics before the final V28 phase-in year ends in 2026?
- Does management survive a strategy built on a crown jewel that regulation has repriced?
- What would count as the dramatically improved disclosure Eisman demands?

The AI Revolution: Winners, Losers, & The Future of Tech | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 27

2025-09-29 | WITH DAN IVES

THE THESIS

Ives argues we are living through a genuine fourth industrial revolution: an unprecedented capex buildout of the next layer of how humans and enterprises interact, with the spending in enterprises today and the consumer wave still to come, sustaining a tech bull market for at least two to three more years. Because the obvious names are crowded, the money is made by following the breadcrumbs into second, third and fourth derivative plays: data infrastructure like MongoDB and Snowflake once the buildout needs data mined, power names like GE Vernova and Nebius, and eventually small nuclear reactors powering data centers. Tesla wins autonomy because it can produce cars at roughly 30,000 dollars at scale while Waymo runs 200 to 230 thousand dollar vehicles in five cities, and Palantir converts unmatched three-letter agency data mining into a commercial AI franchise. Apple's elephant in the room is the absence of an AI strategy, fixable only by doubling down on the Gemini partnership.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman opens by making Ives explain the ATCO affair on air: Ives had just become chairman of a company that raised 250 million dollars at 145 a share to buy Worldcoin, a cryptocurrency tied to Sam Altman's eyeball-scanning authentication device, and the stock spiked severalfold before correcting. Eisman, the house crypto sceptic, makes him walk through how an eyeball scan produces a currency. He also forces the how question on the nuclear thesis, asking what the next data point is, and Ives concedes it has not happened yet and he is reading incremental approvals. On Palantir, Eisman makes Ives recount the hate mail from institutional clients saying he should be fired for recommending it, and on Tesla he presses how a 30,000 dollar car overcomes the robotaxi lead Waymo already has.

THE NUMBERS

- Top hyperscaler capex adds up to roughly 300 to 350 billion dollars
- Nvidia is a 4 trillion dollar market cap company, the biggest on the planet, and just grew revenue 55% year over year
- Waymo vehicles cost about 200 to 230 thousand dollars each and operate in roughly five US cities, against Tesla's roughly 30,000 dollar cars
- ATCO raised 250 million dollars in a private placement at 145 to buy Worldcoin, with Ives as chairman
- AMD's OpenAI deal and the iPhone 17 cycle, which Ives scores about 8.5 out of 10, frame the near-term catalysts
- Palantir works with every three-letter agency in the US plus allied Western governments

WHAT MOVED

Nothing structural moves: both men are bullish on the market and stay there. Ives concedes the nuclear data center thesis is still a thesis without a confirming data point, and that Spotify in his AI 30 is a bet on where AI is going, not where it is. Eisman stays visibly unconvinced on the crypto treasury vehicle and keeps Apple in the penalty box pending a real AI strategy.

IN THE ARC

The show's broadest tour of the AI capex theme, sitting between the weekly wraps where Eisman keeps warning that the expenditures must eventually generate returns. It sets up the Rasgon chip deep dive a week later and the Moffett Nathanson episode where the bot-economics ROI debate gets its sharpest airing, and the ATCO exchange extends the show's running crypto scepticism.

> *“It's going to be Tesla's world. Everyone else is paying rent.”*
>
> DAN IVES

> *“This is a 4 trillion market cap company and it just grew revenue 55% year over year.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What data point would actually confirm the nuclear-powered data center thesis Ives calls his own?
- Can Apple rent an AI strategy through Gemini rather than build one, and will the market accept that?

- How far down the derivative chain can investors safely follow the breadcrumbs before the capex cycle digests?

U.S. Consumers Are Collapsing: Cars, Credit, & the Chaos Ahead | The Weekly Wrap

2025-10-03 | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

THE THESIS

Ganapathy argues the American consumer is far weaker than the credit data suggests because the data itself is an illusion. Pandemic stimulus checks temporarily inflated subprime borrowers' credit scores, so loans written to them, and bundled into asset backed securities as prime, are technically subprime and will behave that way now that the checks are gone. Credit card debt has grown roughly 50% since late 2020, student loan delinquencies are again being reported and knocking 100 to 200 points off scores, and issuers like American Express and Chase are cutting credit lines in response, squeezing the borrower from both sides. In autos that means only older used cars under about 10,000 dollars are really moving, dealers are modifying loans to avoid taking back inventory, and the pain will roll from used cars up into the new car market. Her Open Door warning follows the same logic: retail investors are buying a story, and a company leaning on AI outputs is exposed to hallucinated numbers.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman repeatedly stops her to make the mechanism explicit, restating the prime illusion in plain English: a subprime consumer got a government check, looked prime, took an auto loan, and reverts when the checks stop. He then walks her tier by tier through who gets hurt across older used, newer used and new cars, and asks what abuse she took for the Open Door call, drawing out that she is accused of shorting a stock she does not trade. He does not fully endorse the tapped-out thesis, closing instead with a time-boxed test: we will find out if you are right within six to nine months.

THE NUMBERS

- US GDP was 29.18 trillion dollars in 2024 with 2025 consensus growth of 1.8%, roughly 530 billion dollars
- Big tech AI infrastructure spending of about 400 billion dollars means the economy outside AI is growing less than 50 basis points
- Credit card debt rose nearly 50% from third quarter 2020 to second quarter 2024, about 400 billion dollars of additional debt, excluding buy now pay later
- Reported student loan defaults drop credit scores 100 to 200 points, triggering credit line cuts by card issuers
- Used car demand is concentrated in older cars under about 10,000 dollars

WHAT MOVED

Eisman moves partway: he accepts the consumer is at minimum not increasing spending and that the auto data is a genuine warning, but withholds judgment on collapse, setting a six to nine month clock. Ganapathy holds her full thesis, including the Open Door warning, and insists her motive is protecting retail investors, not a short position.

IN THE ARC

This wrap is where Eisman first runs the GDP-minus-AI-capex arithmetic that becomes his K-shaped economy signature, repeated to Liesman ten days later almost verbatim. Ganapathy's subprime-dressed-as-prime consumer is the bottom leg of the K against the AI boom on top, and her ABS focus echoes the show's recurring use of securitization data as the true consumer health indicator.

> *“The credit score prime was an illusion. Whatever prime loans are sitting in the ABS are technically subprime.”*
>
> LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

“That was very educational, and I think we'll find out if you're right within the next six to nine months.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How much of the prime-labeled ABS collateral actually reverts to subprime behavior now that stimulus effects are gone?
- Does auto loan stress stay contained to older used cars or roll up into new car demand and lender losses?
- Will Open Door's retail shareholder base absorb a fundamental disappointment, and on what timeline?

Inside the AI Chip War: From Nvidia’s Dominance to Intel’s Turmoil | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 28

2025-10-06 | WITH STACY RASGON

THE THESIS

Rasgon frames semiconductors as a tale of two cities: AI numbers that are ripping and a rest-of-semis market that is lackluster, with the whole space carried by a boom that began with ChatGPT in November 2022 and Nvidia's big bang guide in May 2023. A digestion period is a 100% certainty eventually, because hyperscaler capex always built and digested even before AI, but the evidence says it is not this year, not next year, and if Nvidia and Broadcom are right not 2027 either. On China, he argues export controls are self-defeating: refusing to sell Nvidia into China forces Huawei to build purportedly leading edge chips at SMIC, creating first a robust domestic competitor and then potentially a global one, so it is important for Nvidia to be allowed to sell. Intel's collapse was self-inflicted: Pat Gelsinger's build-it-and-they-will-come foundry bet spent money the company did not have on capacity with no customers, and while Lip-Bu Tan is doing absolutely the right things, the hand he was dealt is weak.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman forces the falsifiability question on the AI trade: if digestion is inevitable, what is the sign that tells you it is happening? He also pulls Rasgon into the mechanics of proposed chip tariffs, using a smartphone as the prop, roughly 500 dollars of semiconductors inside a 1,000 dollar phone, to show how a one-to-one US purchase requirement would ripple through devices. On Intel, Eisman offers his own theory that Gelsinger was pandering to Congress to pass the Chips Act; Rasgon rejects the charitable reading, saying Gelsinger genuinely believed his outlandish targets, which is worse.

THE NUMBERS

- Nvidia did roughly 100 billion dollars in AI revenue against AMD's 5 billion, though AMD's 5 billion came from zero the year before
- The AMD bull case is TAM math: 5% of a claimed 500 billion dollar market is 25 billion dollars
- When Nvidia delivered its May 2023 big bang quarter, consensus for the following quarter was only about 7 billion dollars
- Intel's foundry business lost about 13 billion dollars last year
- Gelsinger's February 2022 analyst day targeted 120 billion dollars of revenue by 2026; Intel is doing less than half that
- Floated US policy would require one US-made semiconductor purchased for every foreign one, with higher tariffs otherwise, potentially covering chips inside devices
- A roughly 1,000 dollar smartphone contains about 500 dollars of semiconductors

WHAT MOVED

No one changes position, but the terms sharpen: Rasgon holds that digestion timing is unknowable and refuses to call it, while giving Eisman the framework for what the warning would look like in capex behavior. On Intel both converge on suspended judgment, call me in three or four years, with Rasgon endorsing Lip-Bu Tan's approach while refusing to predict success.

IN THE ARC

The chip-level companion to the Ives episode a week earlier: Ives supplies the revolution narrative, Rasgon supplies the cycle math and the certainty that digestion eventually comes, feeding Eisman's running question of whether AI capex can earn its keep. The China export control argument becomes a recurring Eisman talking point, and the episode sets up the data center infrastructure deep dive with Nick Del Deo three weeks later.

> *“The chances of that at some point happening, it has to be 100%. It's not now.”*
>
> STACY RASGON

> *“In my view he was delusionally optimistic.”*
>
> STACY RASGON

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What observable capex behavior marks the start of the inevitable digestion period?
- Does restricting Nvidia in China create the global Huawei competitor Rasgon fears, and how fast?
- Can Lip-Bu Tan find foundry customers before Intel's balance sheet forces the question?

Inside America’s Economic Divide: AI, Tariffs, & The Fed | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 29

2025-10-13 | WITH STEVE LIESMAN

THE THESIS

Liesman's core move is to separate what Eisman conflates: the market and the economy. The market is in a momentum fervor, as long as investors reward companies for raising AI investment, the investment continues, a loop he compares to the post-2000 period, while the economy underneath is genuinely K-shaped, with tariff-hit industries laying people off and their damage papered over by AI spending. He endorses watching auto loans as the stress gauge because economists know the car payment is the last bill a strapped consumer skips. His deeper argument, drawn from Fed history and his years running the Wall Street Journal's Moscow bureau, is institutional: markets only work inside societies that understand and accept price signals, which is why imposing a universal legal code on 1990s Russia failed while oil privatization worked, and why Fed credibility and communication matter as much as rate decisions.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The pushback runs unusually in both directions. Eisman opens with his twitch: 29.18 trillion of GDP growing 1.8% is about 530 billion dollars, and with 400 billion plus of AI capex the rest of the economy is flat, and Liesman's first two answers are corrections, telling him he is mixing the market up with the economy. Eisman counters with the Henry Blodget story: across the hall at Oppenheimer in the late 90s, Blodget was 1,000% right that the internet would change the world and create dynastic wealth, and investors still got carried out, his standing objection to trillions-in-returns talk from Jensen Huang. On the Fed, Eisman presses that what people brought Greenspan was ethics and fraud and he stood aside; Liesman defends Greenspan as an enigma who improved communication but concedes nothing on the ethics point.

THE NUMBERS

- US GDP of 29.18 trillion dollars in 2024 with consensus 2025 growth of 1.8% implies roughly 530 billion dollars of growth
- Hyperscaler AI spending above 400 billion dollars leaves the economy outside AI essentially flat
- Orvis is closing stores and laying off workers as tariffs hit fishing gear importers on both the import duty and metal content
- The US government paid accounting firms millions of dollars to write a universal legal code for Russia, which failed
- Within two years of privatization, Russian oil companies reversed a 20 year decline in Soviet oil output

- The Fed in 1929 saw excess speculation but would not raise rates for fear the institution would not survive, then failed to flood the system with liquidity in 1930 to 1933

WHAT MOVED

Eisman accepts the market-versus-economy distinction as the better frame for his own K-shaped data but keeps the twitch, and Liesman explicitly validates the K-shaped label for the tariff economy. Neither yields on Greenspan: Eisman holds the ethics indictment, Liesman the institutionalist defense. The shared landing spot is that AI returns are unknowable this early and the Blodget precedent cuts both ways.

IN THE ARC

This is the episode where Eisman's GDP-minus-AI-capex arithmetic, first aired in the October 3 wrap, gets stress-tested by a professional Fed watcher and survives. It deepens the show's banks-and-Fed thread with firsthand Greenspan history and links the AI boom to the show's favorite cautionary structure: a true revolution that still wrecked investors, the same frame Eisman brings to Sorkin's 1929 two weeks later.

> *"The momentum will continue as long as the momentum continues."*
>
> STEVE LIESMAN, QUOTING JOSH BROWN

> *"He repeated that like 100 times, and you know what? He was 1,000% correct."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN, ON HENRY BLODGET'S INTERNET CALL

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How long can market momentum reward AI capex before someone demands proof of returns?
- If the car loan is the last bill consumers skip, how close is that indicator to flashing?
- Would today's Fed act against speculation it can see, or repeat 1929's political paralysis?

The Next Revolution: AI, Advertising, and the Collapse of Old Media

2025-10-20 | WITH CRAIG MOFFETT, MICHAEL NATHANSON

THE THESIS

The pair argue that the market keeps mispricing regulatory and technological risk. Their Apple sell case was never about fear, the world was not scared enough: a judge ruled Google's 20 billion dollars a year of search payments to Apple, 100% margin and about 20% of Apple's operating income, to be illegal monopolist conduct, and only a timid remedy preserved them, leaving Apple with the check but still no AI strategy. In telecom, fiber and cable are technically interchangeable, so the fiber overbuild wave funded by private equity at about 4,000 dollars per connected home is a returns problem, and distressed cable assets will eventually attract the same private equity money. In advertising, AI is a Christensen-style disruption that starts with small brands: Meta can turn a logo into fifteen fully produced, A/B tested ads in an afternoon, which armies of agency people cannot match. On AI capex itself they preach humility: the bull case is companies paying near-salary prices for bots that replace 125,000 dollar employees, the bear case is four competitors driving bot prices below what the infrastructure needs.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman opens by framing the Apple story as fear that receded and Moffett immediately quibbles: investors were not scared to death and should have been. Eisman then presses the after-picture, Apple keeps the 20 billion but still has no discernible AI strategy, and offers his own clerk's-eye theory that the judge took the easy out because district judges hate being overturned. On Verizon he brings personal knowledge, noting new CEO Dan Schulman did not do a good job running PayPal, a stock he knows well, and the guests concede they know very little and are surmising. On AI returns Eisman keeps repeating the show's refrain, it is too early, you can dream any dream, there is no counterfactual, and drives the group to agree the burden of proof sits with Sam Altman.

THE NUMBERS

- Google pays Apple about 20 billion dollars a year, essentially 100% margin and roughly 20% of Apple's operating income, payments a judge ruled illegal before a mild remedy preserved them
- A typical fiber overbuild costs about 4,000 dollars per connected home, roughly 2,300 dollars per home passed
- Cable bears believe about 80% of the country will be overbuilt with fiber
- Meta offers advertisers a fully produced TV ad from just a brand logo, A/B tested the same afternoon, with the 15 most effective versions by day's end
- The AI bot bull case: a company replacing a 125,000 dollar employee should pay up to about 119,000 dollars for the bot
- Verizon replaced its CEO with board member Dan Schulman, 67, formerly of PayPal

WHAT MOVED

Genuine convergence on humility: all three agree nobody can yet answer whether AI revenue supports the infrastructure spend, that near-term ROIC will not be pretty, and that the proof burden is Altman's. The guests hold their sector calls, agencies structurally doomed, cable oversold, streaming consolidation necessary, and Eisman holds Apple accountable for having no AI strategy despite the reprieve.

IN THE ARC

The episode fuses three show threads: AI capex and its returns get their most balanced bull-bear articulation yet, the Apple-Google antitrust saga previewed in the October 10 wrap resolves into a lesson about regulatory risk, and AI-driven job displacement enters the K-shaped economy story through advertising and youth unemployment. The bonus Del Deo data center episode days later extends the same firm's coverage into the infrastructure itself.

> *“Those payments were essentially bribery. It was Google paying Apple not to be in the search business.”*
>
> CRAIG MOFFETT, CITING BEN THOMPSON

> *“It's really on Sam Altman's shoulders to prove this makes sense.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If bot prices get competed down, what level of AI revenue actually supports the infrastructure spend?
- When does private equity start buying distressed cable at the coupon-clipping math Moffett describes?
- Can the agency holding companies survive AI-generated advertising even as a shrunken business?

Inside the Data Center Boom: Understanding the Massive Infrastructure That Supports AI

2025-10-26 | WITH NICK DEL DEO

THE THESIS

Del Deo maps an industry where most of the action has left the public markets: only Digital Realty and Equinix remain listed because the capital required and the years of negative cash flow before payoff spooked public investors, pushing construction to private players and hyperscalers. The landlords are warehouses for computers, power, cooling, security; Equinix's real asset is connectivity, the on-ramp where networks, clouds and enterprises interconnect, so its AI payoff arrives when latency-sensitive apps and private AI deployments proliferate, like Bristol Myers putting a private GPU cluster inside Equinix. GPU economics are the open question, CoreWeave depreciates them over six years and OpenAI signed a five year deal with two one year renewals, so the assets have life but a supply-constrained market flatters returns. His contrarian core: tight power supply is good for operators, because lifting the constraint would push returns back toward the cost of capital, and the hundreds-of-gigawatts demand projections contain heavy double counting.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman plays translator and sceptic at once. He forces plain English throughout, mocking that bitcoin miners repurposing capacity for high performance computing was a sentence definitely in English, and makes Del Deo unpack it. He presses the REIT structure, if you pay out your cash flow, must you constantly raise capital to grow, which Del Deo concedes has been a sore point with investors. He asks straight whether the energy constraint will actually bind, drawing out the double counting point, and on Lumen's pivot-to-growth pitch he demands a verdict, and what do you think, getting the admission that Del Deo is skeptical the legacy decline can be outrun as fast as management claims.

THE NUMBERS

- Only two public data center REITs remain, Digital Realty and Equinix; others like CyrusOne were taken private, one by KKR and GIP
- Hyperscalers are effectively four players, Amazon, Microsoft, Google and Meta, investing in IT infrastructure at globally unmatched scale
- CoreWeave depreciates its GPUs over six years
- OpenAI, arguably the most sophisticated chip user, signed a five year CoreWeave deal with two one year renewal options
- Projections of hundreds of gigawatts of data center demand contain substantial double counting and uncertainty
- Cogent, at roughly a 1.5 billion dollar market cap, bought the old Sprint fiber network and repurposed it to sell wavelengths against Lumen and Zayo

WHAT MOVED

Eisman ends better informed rather than converted, and says so, calling it really informative and inviting a return visit. Del Deo holds his contrarian positions: operators should want power to stay tight, Equinix's AI moment is still ahead of it, legacy telco pivots deserve skepticism, and Cogent is his interesting pick despite admitting he has been wrong on it for a couple of years.

IN THE ARC

A direct extension of the AI capex thread from Ives, Rasgon and the Moffett Nathanson episode, this time from the landlord's side of the boom, and the source of the show's recurring point that data center demand forecasts are double counted. The observation that public markets will not fund negative cash flow buildouts connects to the show's private credit thread: the Morgan Stanley 2.9 trillion dollar funding estimate Eisman cited in the September 26 wrap has to come from somewhere.

> *“A data center is basically a warehouse for computers.”*
>
> NICK DEL DEO

> *“If I were a data center operator, I'd want supply to remain tight, because that's my stick to get better pricing.”*
>
> NICK DEL DEO

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What is the true economic life of a GPU, and what happens to CoreWeave-style models if it is shorter than six years?
- Does abundant power eventually arrive and compress operator returns toward the cost of capital?
- When AI applications finally proliferate, does the value migrate to connectivity hubs like Equinix as Del Deo expects?

Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Crash of 1929 & The Parallels We See Today | The Real Eisman Playbook

2025-10-27 | WITH ANDREW ROSS SORKIN

THE THESIS

Sorkin argues 1929 matters because its mechanics are recurring, not antique: completely unregulated markets, crazy leverage, and elite pump-and-dump pools run so openly that the operators, the era's equivalent of a Davos guest list, mailed each other circulars describing the manipulation. The crash formula he distills is credit, leverage plus FOMO, enabled by a Federal Reserve that saw the speculation but would not raise rates for fear the young institution would be destroyed politically, then compounded the bust by failing to flood the system with liquidity from 1930 to 1933. The aftermath also rhymes: a 250 dollar a week outside lawyer from Queens ran the investigation that exposed the bankers, shined light, and still sent nobody to jail, exactly as after 2008. Built from eight years in archives rather than interviews, the book is his prequel to Too Big to Fail: the same masters-of-the-universe paradigm, shattered the same way.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman's opening challenge is why write about people who are all really dead, which Sorkin answers with the archive method, letters that explain what interviews once did. The sharper exchange runs the other way: Eisman uses the book to indict his own 2008 mistake, he and his team assumed the government knew how bad it was, and Sorkin's AIG scene, where officials in the room are stunned to learn AIG is in trouble, proved they had no clue, which is why he did not short everything that moved. Eisman also keeps interrupting the 1929 narrative with I have heard this before, forcing the parallels, no jail time, captured regulators, political fear at the Fed, to be stated explicitly rather than implied.

THE NUMBERS

- The book took eight years, built from archival letters and library boxes that had never been indexed
- Pool operators circulated written circulars describing their manipulations, some literally handed out on the street
- The congressional investigator hired to examine the bankers was paid 250 dollars a week and sent no one to jail
- The 1929 Fed saw excessive speculation but feared raising rates would destroy the institution, then failed to supply liquidity in 1930 to 1933
- Google-era comparison aside, JP Morgan's Jack Morgan knew he was not his father and installed Thomas Lamont, a former journalist, as the real operator
- In Sorkin's AIG scene, days after Lehman, senior officials did not know AIG was in trouble

WHAT MOVED

Eisman concedes something real and personal: reading the book corrected his model of 2008, the authorities were not knowingly slow, they were genuinely ignorant and out of bandwidth. Sorkin agrees they could not compute it. Both leave holding the parallel: unregulated corners of today's markets, from crypto leverage to private pools of capital, are running the 1929 formula of credit, leverage and FOMO.

IN THE ARC

Previewed in the September 26 wrap where Eisman branded the week shenanigans, chaos and revolutions and tied Binance's domicile-hopping to 1929-style red flags, this episode is the historical anchor for the show's crypto scepticism and its warnings about unregulated leverage. It is also the fifth author interview of the run and pairs naturally with the Liesman episode's Fed history: both ask whether institutions act against manias they can plainly see.

> *“It would be like the guest list at Davos getting together to pump and dump a stock.”*
>
> ANDREW ROSS SORKIN

> *“That was our actual mistake, why we didn't short everything that moved.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Which of today's unregulated corners, crypto leverage or private pools, is running the closest copy of the 1929 formula?

- Would today's Fed tighten against visible speculation, or repeat the political paralysis of 1929?
- If the next crisis comes, does anyone go to jail this time, or does the Pecora pattern repeat again?

Inside the Cannabis Comeback: How One Company is Beating a Broken Market | The Real Eisman Playbook

2025-11-03 | WITH KYLE KAZAN, GRAHAM FARRAR, MARK VENDETTI, JOHN DORSEY

THE THESIS

The Glass House team argues they have already won the hardest game in cannabis: they are profitable as the low-cost greenhouse grower in California, the most competitive, lowest-price, most discerning market in the country, after an industry-wide capital binge circa 2018 ended in overcapacity and years of being left for dead when federal legalization never came. Their production cost of roughly 100 dollars per pound undercuts out-of-state growers whose customers pay sometimes multiples of California prices, and only two of five greenhouses on their 165 acre farm, 120 acres under glass, are productive, so capacity can scale without reinventing anything. The dream scenario is regulatory: Trump has twice posted favorably on medical cannabis and backed Florida's adult-use ballot measure, and any rescheduling or interstate commerce opening lets a proven low-cost operator sell into markets, domestic and eventually export, priced at five to six times California levels. Training at altitude, then throwing a knife into a pillow.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman opens with unusual disclosure discipline: he is a recent shareholder, calls the position fairly speculative, and states on air that he is not there to pump and dump. His pressing is diligence-style: how exactly did you get to a 53% gross margin when almost no cannabis company makes money; what do out-of-state competitors' costs actually look like; and on the dream scenario he forces the arithmetic, if six greenhouses run, do I just multiply revenue by two plus efficiency gains? He also makes management walk through the federal scheduling regime from scratch and recount the ICE raid on their farm, drawing out that they hired the former ICE director Julie Myers Wood to make the workforce auditable rather than fight the enforcement.

THE NUMBERS

- Glass House's market cap is under 1 billion dollars and, unlike most of the industry, it makes money
- Second quarter gross margin was 53% with an EBITDA margin around 18%; Eisman normalizes ROE to the mid to high teens
- Production cost runs at roughly 100 dollars per pound in the lowest-price market in the country
- The farm spans about 165 acres with 120 acres of greenhouse, and only two of five greenhouses are productive today
- Out-of-state customers often pay multiples of California prices, and export markets like Germany and the UK can price at five to six times California
- Trump posted positively on medical cannabis twice on Truth Social and backed Florida's adult-use Amendment 3 against DeSantis
- After the ICE raid, the company hired Julie Myers Wood, ICE director under George W. Bush, to audit its workforce

WHAT MOVED

No adversarial gap to close: Eisman entered as a shareholder and leaves one, but the episode fixes the frame he wants viewers to hold, a profitable operator whose base business works today and whose upside is a regulatory option he refuses to handicap. Management concedes the dream scenario depends entirely on Washington while insisting the California cost position wins under any rules.

IN THE ARC

The show's first management interview and its most explicit conflict-of-interest disclosure, applying the Eisman playbook, unit economics first, policy taken as given, to a left-for-dead sector the way earlier episodes did to banks and healthcare. It also extends the K-shaped economy theme from the supply side: a

real business that grew through a capital drought while AI absorbs every marginal investment dollar elsewhere.

> *“If you can win in California, you can win everywhere else. The inverse is definitely not true.”*
>
> GRAHAM FARRAR

> *“I'm not here to pump and dump. This is a podcast that's dedicated to education.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does rescheduling or interstate commerce actually arrive, and which one unlocks the California export model first?
- Can the roughly 100 dollar per pound cost advantage survive contact with scaled competition in other states?
- How should investors size a position whose base case is modest and whose upside is a binary policy event?

The Private Credit Panic: Why Wall Street’s Big Winners are Now Losing | Real Eisman Playbook Ep 33

2025-11-10 | WITH GLENN SCHORR

THE THESIS

Schorr argues the alternative asset managers are in a question phase, not a broken story. After monster years in 2023 and 2024, investors are giving back gains because they are asking whether this is the beginning of a credit cycle, which would be a problem for firms that manage and lend enormous amounts of credit, and because slow monetizations have left spread-related earnings weak, with Apollo hit hardest since half its balance sheet is its own insurance book. He points at the market's internal contradiction: Goldman near 800 and high-yield spreads tightening daily say credit is fine, while the private credit stocks trade as if a cycle has begun, and one of those views has to give. Underneath, he still believes in the group because long duration liabilities and private markets diversification are what the end LP wants. The traditional managers remain the bad of his good, bad and ugly framework because technology came for them in the form of index funds and ETFs at 5 to 15 basis points, and not one of them thought to build a private markets business.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman opens by forcing the paradox: secular growth stories, record fundraising every quarter, a market at all-time highs, and the stocks are down 15 to 33%, so what is going on. He then makes Schorr explain tokenization in plain English, saying not one in 2 million people can, and questions what tokenizing something like a building's rent rolls actually accomplishes. On Goldman, Eisman delivers the counterfactual that had it skipped the consumer adventure ten years ago, sold the private equity on its balance sheet and just raised funds, it would be much farther along; Schorr's punchline is that we would call that company Morgan Stanley.

THE NUMBERS

- In 2025 Blackstone is down 15%, Apollo down 25%, KKR down 21% and Blue Owl down 33% despite record fundraising
- KKR was up about 80% in 2024 and 30 to 40% the year before, so some giveback was natural
- A classic private equity fund runs roughly 7 to 10 years and targets 2 to 2.5 times multiple of invested capital
- Index funds and ETFs deliver market returns for 5 to 15 basis points, and there are now more ETFs than there are stocks

- Goldman trades near 800 dollars while high-yield spreads tighten daily, a combination Schorr says cannot coexist with a credit cycle
- Jane Fraser's Citi exited consumer businesses where it had roughly 2% market share across 100 countries

WHAT MOVED

Neither side capitulates. Schorr holds his structural bull case on private markets while conceding it is very tough sledding for the traditional managers, and Eisman stays wary that the stocks are signaling something credit markets have not priced. They converge only on the logic that the equity market and the high-yield market cannot both be right.

IN THE ARC

The fullest treatment yet of the show's private credit theme, taped as the wraps track Tricolor, First Brands and other credit accidents that Eisman keeps noting did not originate in private credit. It sets up Chris Verrone's January rule that the bull market lasts as long as banks work and credit stays calm, and complements the year-end wrap where private credit fear is named one of 2025's four themes.

> *“Goldman Sachs can be 800 dollars and high-yield spreads can tighten every day? That doesn't make sense. One of these things has to give.”*
>
> GLENN SCHORR

> *“You know what we'd call them? Morgan Stanley.”*
>
> GLENN SCHORR

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Is the alts selloff the market sniffing out a real credit cycle, or just multiple compression after two euphoric years?
- Which corrects first, tight high-yield spreads or falling private credit stocks?
- Can tokenization create real liquidity in private assets, or does it just relabel the same illiquid cash flows?

Inside Publishing’s Big Shakeup: AI, TikTok & the Battle Ahead | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 34

2025-11-17 | WITH REGINA BROOKS, JENNIFER WEISS, ANTHONY ZICCARDI

THE THESIS

The panel argues publishing has already lived through one revolution and is entering another. Distribution power moved to Amazon and social media, so a platform, measured first in follower counts, now gates entry for nonfiction authors regardless of expertise. The economics fragmented too: traditional deals pay 10 to 12% royalties on cover price while hybrid publishers split profits with authors at ratios like 70 to 30, and formats multiplied, with romantasy readers who started in self-published ebooks now buying deluxe print editions. AI is the next shock, but the panel's case for survival is that the industry's scarce assets are talent picking and community around authors, the same shift music made when albums became low-margin marketing for concerts and readers began buying the person, not just the book.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman tests the platform rule with a hypothetical: the world's leading expert on an important historical topic who has no social media presence, and gets the uncomfortable answer that the numbers now come first. He then confronts the panel with his own experiment, asking ChatGPT for two essays on whether morality is absolute or relative in the voices of Alasdair MacIntyre and Richard Posner, and receiving in 30 seconds work he says would have taken him a month. The panel does not dispute the quality; their defense is that fiction demands plot, pacing and characterization working in concert, which is still hard to mimic.

THE NUMBERS

- Traditional nonfiction royalties run 10 to 12% of cover price, while hybrid publishers offer profit shares around 70% to the author
- Publishers now screen nonfiction proposals on social media numbers; five to seven years ago a speaking circuit or course audience was enough
- Jennifer Weiss reads 100 plus submissions a week looking for plot, pacing and characterization together
- Eisman's ChatGPT prompt returned two polished essays in about 30 seconds on an obscure philosophy question
- The panel cannot name a decade-scale cultural phenomenon moving books, on the order of Oprah's club or Harry Potter, in the last five years
- Romantasy titles that began as self-published ebooks now sell as deluxe editions with etched end papers and maps

WHAT MOVED

Eisman closes convinced that AI is definitely changing the industry, like all industries. The publisher urges embracing change, and both agents hold onto talent picking as the durable human edge, telling authors to stay hopeful. No one disputes the direction of change, only whether curation survives it.

IN THE ARC

The first entry in the show's new series on how industries change, an idea Eisman credits on air to his wife Valerie, and a deliberate look at AI from the demand and diffusion side rather than the capex side that dominates the wraps. It pairs with the Navan episode the following week, where AI appears as a cost weapon inside a business model.

> *“Thirty seconds later, two essays showed up. I couldn't believe it. They were so good.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“We're talent pickers in the end.”*
>
> JENNIFER WEISS

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does the social media platform requirement permanently lock genuine expertise out of nonfiction publishing?
- Can hybrid profit-share models displace the 10 to 12% royalty standard at scale?
- What would a bestseller-making cultural force even look like in a fragmented social media world?

Why It’s So Difficult For Companies to Go Public: A CFO Explains the Process | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 35

2025-11-24 | WITH AMY BUTTE

THE THESIS

Butte argues that an IPO is the end of a multi-year maturation project, not a banking transaction. At the New York Stock Exchange she arrived in January 2004 to find an iconic institution whose financial reporting was a plug rather than a process, and it took until March 2006 to build the repeatable, auditable numbers a public company must produce quarter after quarter. Going public buys four things, a branding event, an acceleration of maturation, easier access to capital, and an acquisition currency, and a company should know which ones it actually needs; the NYSE needed maturation, not brand. At Navan she applies the same discipline to a travel and expense platform whose pitch is that AI collapses the cost structure, running the business with a fraction of the support staff of legacy competitors.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman punctures the folk version of going public, hire some bankers, bing bang boom, and makes Butte walk through why the NYSE took over two years. He then asks what he calls an uncomfortable question about why the deal, priced at 25, traded the way it did, and pushes for the unsaid number on customer

support headcount until Butte draws the disclosure line, repeating that she has not said that publicly while conceding Navan uses less than a tenth of the support staffing of an Amex GBT.

THE NUMBERS

- Butte became NYSE CFO in January 2004 and the IPO did not price until March 2006, over two years of preparation
- Her framework: going public provides a branding event, accelerated maturation, easier access to capital and an acquisition currency
- Navan handles its current business with about 3,000 employees
- Butte estimates Amex GBT has 10 to 20 times Navan's customer support agents, and Navan has said it uses less than a tenth of that staffing
- The Navan IPO priced at 25 dollars
- Audit readiness came down to proving a repeatable process; the old NYSE numbers were a plug

WHAT MOVED

There is no disagreement to resolve. Eisman comes away endorsing the thesis that going public is far harder than investors assume, and Butte holds her disclosure boundaries on the numbers he probes. The episode ends with her wishing him luck with his health during chemotherapy.

IN THE ARC

Extends the industry-transformation series into market plumbing and gives the AI theme a demand-side face: AI as an internal cost advantage rather than capex. It lands in the same month the wraps observe that newly public high flyers on 70 times earnings cannot afford to disappoint on any metric, which is exactly the regime Navan entered at 25 dollars.

> *“Most people just think you hire some bankers, you go public, bing bang boom. That is not what happened.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“It's a little bit of pleasure and it's a lot of pain.”*
>
> AMY BUTTE

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Why did the Navan IPO trade the way it did after pricing at 25, and what does that say about the 2025 IPO window?
- Can AI-light support staffing hold its cost advantage as Navan scales into bigger enterprise accounts?
- Which of Butte's four IPO benefits still justifies being public when private capital is so abundant?

Steve Eisman Reflects on 2008, The Big Short & Today’s K-Shaped Economy | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 36

2025-12-01 | WITH IVY ZELMAN

THE THESIS

In a Case Western student forum moderated by Ivy Zelman, Eisman compresses his crisis account and applies it to today. The 2008 story was a debt story: credit default swaps written between systemically important firms tied their balance sheets into a spiderweb so complicated nobody knew where it began or ended, which is why AIG's 50 to 70 billion of CDS sold to the street forced a bailout. Today those same institutions are safe because deleveraging was so extreme, Citigroup going from at least 35 to 1 to 10 to 1, so the systemic anxiety has migrated to private credit, where he says he has no data showing a problem. On the current market he accepts that AI carries most of GDP growth and concedes the bubble worry has real validity, while dismissing housing as an investment that at best keeps pace with inflation.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The pressure runs in reverse: students press Eisman. One argues the fundamentals are weaker than the tape, with AI at almost 50% of GDP growth, China holding the rare earth cards, inflation and unemployment ticking up and shaky monetary policy, and asks whether an AI bubble is holding everything up; Eisman corrects the number upward, saying he thinks AI's share of growth is more than 50%, and concedes there is a lot of validity to the worry. Zelman also presses her own crisis villain, Greenspan's 2004 endorsement of ARMs plus the rating agencies, alongside Eisman's incentives story.

THE NUMBERS

- AIG sold roughly 50 to 70 billion dollars of credit default swaps to the street, the reason the government bailed it out
- Citigroup was levered at least 35 to 1 before the crisis versus about 10 to 1 afterward, which Eisman calls the distance from Pluto to the sun
- From 2002 through 2006 better-than-expected delinquencies led subprime lenders to loosen every year until the standard was can you breathe
- A student cites AI as almost 50% of GDP growth; Eisman answers that he thinks it is more
- Silicon Valley Bank's model was taking in Silicon Valley deposits and buying Treasuries for the spread, a liquidity story rather than a capital one
- Eisman puts pre-crisis subprime shorting costs and the CDS mechanics in context of trillions in interbank derivative exposure

WHAT MOVED

Eisman gives more explicit ground on the AI bubble question than he does in studio, agreeing the skeptical case has a lot of validity, while holding firm that the banks are safe and that nothing in the data yet condemns private credit. Zelman keeps her Greenspan indictment; the two accounts of 2008 sit side by side rather than merging.

IN THE ARC

The live-audience rehearsal of the two-part 2008 masterclass posted over the following weeks, with the K-shaped economy, private credit and housing affordability themes all surfacing in the Q&A. It also delivers the show's most personal Big Short material, including his single contribution to the movie, the word schmuck.

> *“I don't think housing is an investment anymore.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“It was Greenspan. I blame him and the credit agencies.”*
>
> IVY ZELMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If AI is more than half of GDP growth, what happens to the real economy when that capex normalizes?
- What data could settle whether private credit has a problem before losses actually arrive?
- Does the banks-are-safe case survive a private credit shock that flows back through bank lending to the sector?

Inside the Industrial Comeback & AI’s Power Crisis with Nigel Coe | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 37

2025-12-08 | WITH NIGEL COE

THE THESIS

Coe's argument is that the industrial sector has split in two: pockets of growth and a lot of no growth, and the dividing line is the data center. Anything touching the AI buildout, electrical equipment, HVAC, gas turbines, is growing fast, while short cycle industrials have been stagnant for three years with the ISM stuck below 50. Power is the binding constraint on the whole AI trade, so data centers are migrating to where the

power is, Texas and the Midwest, and the gas turbine market that was supposedly ebbing away to renewables has revived around 400 megawatt machines. Beyond the AI barbell, he argues the best industrial stories of his career are CEO-change margin stories, with 3M under Bill Brown the current case, and that the housing-levered names are the 2026 inflection trade once Fed easing gives visibility.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman presses on why Eaton, traditionally a winner, lagged the electrical equipment trade, extracting that its class 8 truck businesses are down mid-teens and its automation business is flat, so it is not the pure AI play the market wanted. He sharpens the power argument into his own framing, that the stuff gets built by 2028 and the question is whether they can plug it in, which Coe adopts as exactly the binding constraint. He also runs the accountability segment, drawing out Coe's best and worst calls, including the GE underperform at 250 that became an upgrade near 90, and closes with the forcing question: if housing inflects in the second half of 2026, name the two stocks.

THE NUMBERS

- The ISM manufacturing index has been below 50 for 3 years and sits around 48
- Eaton's two class 8 truck businesses are down roughly mid-teens this year while its automation business is flat
- Large gas turbines put out about 400 megawatts each, and the market has revived after years of drift toward wind, solar and batteries
- Coe put an underperform on GE at about 250 and upgraded it at about 90; he calls it his most impactful sell and now one of his better buys
- About 70% of Lennox International's business is tied to residential housing, and about 80% of Stanley Black and Decker's sales are housing linked
- Texas rationed electricity in the 2021 winter storm, a warning for the grid hyperscalers are counting on

WHAT MOVED

The two end aligned: the data center side of the barbell continues, it is too soon to buy consumer and housing exposure until the Fed easing path is visible, and the short cycle recovery is the big unresolved 2026 call. Eisman gets his specificity, Lennox and Stanley Black and Decker as the housing inflection names.

IN THE ARC

The interview that grounds the show's power-as-binding-constraint theme, a framing Eisman borrows from bank stress tests in his wraps, and it explains why GE Vernova is up over 100% in his year-end sector review. The housing discussion ties directly to the affordability theme of the December 5 wrap.

> *"We've got pockets of growth, and then we've got a lot of no growth in the industrial sector right now."*
>
> NIGEL COE

> *"They'll get this stuff built by 2028. The question basically is, can they plug it in?"*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- When does gas turbine supply actually catch up with data center power demand?
- Will the ISM break back above 50 in 2026 and revive the short cycle industrials?
- Does the housing inflection arrive in time for Lennox and Stanley Black and Decker, or is that a 2027 story?

Steve Eisman's Masterclass on the 2008 Financial Crisis (Part One) | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 38

2025-12-16 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

Part one of the lecture argues the crisis had four interlocking causes, too much leverage at systemic institutions, a large asset class that blew up, systemic ownership of that asset class, and derivatives tying balance sheets together, and then builds the first two from the ground up. Banks are unlike other businesses because ROE equals ROA times leverage: with a 1% return on assets a bank needs roughly ten times leverage to earn an adequate return, which is also its social purpose of recycling deposits into loans, so the question is never whether banks should be levered but how much is too much. Through the 2000s ROEs rose simply because leverage rose, and an entire generation of CEOs mistook leverage for genius. Meanwhile securitization removed the funding constraint on subprime lending, volume exploded from 20 billion in 1993 to about 600 billion by 2006 while underwriting collapsed, and when the buyer strike hit in summer 2007 refinancing stopped, loans repriced toward 9%, and the crisis became inevitable.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

No guest challenges him, but he stress-tests his own story twice. First, he insists the anti-leverage moral is wrong as commonly told: we want banks levered so they can recycle deposits, like the porridge it has to be just right, so the failure was calibration and incentives, not leverage itself. Second, he flags the moment his short thesis wobbled, when March and April 2007 credit data improved, and explains why he held: tax refund season always flatters consumer credit, so the rally was an opportunity to add positions rather than a disconfirmation.

THE NUMBERS

- The key identity: ROE equals ROA times leverage, so a 1% ROA bank with no leverage earns a terrible 1% return on equity
- The subprime industry generated only 20 billion in loans in 1993; by 2006 volume was around 600 billion a year, about 20% of the entire US mortgage market
- The first pure subprime mortgage company went public in 1992, era names included the Money Store and Aames Financial
- Borrow costs to short subprime stocks ran as high as 20% annually, which pushed his fund into shorting securitizations instead
- Securitizations published 30, 60 and 90 day delinquency data every month, the disclosure that let him watch credit deteriorate in real time
- When refinancing stopped in 2007, subprime loans repriced to a go-to rate of around 9% that borrowers could not afford

WHAT MOVED

As a lecture it moves toward a single claim: by late summer 2007, with the buyer strike in place, the financial crisis was already inevitable. He ends deliberately on that cliffhanger, deferring why inevitability became global collapse to part two.

IN THE ARC

The financial literacy masterclass strand at full length, formalizing the story he told live at Case Western weeks earlier. It also quietly underwrites his 2025 running argument on private credit: subprime was visible because securitizations disclosed monthly data, and private credit's danger is precisely that no such data exists.

> *“An entire generation of bank CEOs mistook leverage for genius.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“A bank sells you access to its balance sheet for a price.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Where is the just-right leverage level between a bank too timid to serve its purpose and one that endangers the system?

- Would monthly loan-level disclosure like subprime securitizations had make today's private credit risk visible?
- What turned an inevitable subprime blowup into systemic collapse, the question part two exists to answer?

Steve Eisman's Masterclass on the 2008 Financial Crisis (Part Two) | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 39

2025-12-23 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

Part two completes the causal chain. Wall Street, paid entirely on volume, could not sell all the securitizations it was manufacturing, so it kept the excess AAA-rated paper on its own balance sheets, which is why the summer 2007 buyer strike doomed the system: the banks owned the asset class they had been selling, and incentives trump ethics every time. Credit default swaps, most of them written between systemically important firms, tied those balance sheets into a web nobody could map, so Lehman's failure and AIG's 80 billion of sold CDS turned a mortgage problem into a global one. Dodd-Frank then delevered and derisked the banks, creating the first real chief bank regulator, but with unforeseen consequences: compliance and technology costs made the big bigger, JPMorgan's deposit share going from 7.4% to over 12%. Silicon Valley Bank, he argues, was a liquidity and mark-to-market failure, not a capital failure, yet regulators fought the last war and demanded more capital, and the coming Trump-era changes, lighter stress tests and a friendlier vice chair, plus a bank merger wave, are the correction.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

No outside voice pushes, but he confronts his own record and priors. The securitization heads he despised predicted they would buy back blown-up paper for pennies; he notes the irony that the prediction failed in reverse, since Wall Street never got the chance because it already owned the paper. More significantly, he announces a genuine reversal: after years of accepting regulatory hostility to bank M&A, he now believes the system needs many bank mergers so more banks can afford the technology arms race, and he says plainly that this is something he has changed his mind about.

THE NUMBERS

- AIG had sold about 80 billion dollars of credit default swaps when it hit trouble on September 16, 2008
- Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac were seized on September 7, 2008, and Lehman went under on Sunday, September 14
- Clayton Mortgage sampled roughly 10% of loan files, about 500 of the 5,000 mortgages in a typical 1 billion pool of 200,000 dollar loans
- JPMorgan's deposit share has grown from 7.4% in 2008 to over 12% today, his exhibit for the big getting bigger
- In 2022 the S&P fell 18% and Nasdaq 33% as rates rose, the shock that exposed Silicon Valley Bank's mark-to-market losses
- By 2006 subprime origination of 600 billion a year produced more securitizations and CDOs than investors could absorb

WHAT MOVED

The lecture ends with a stated change of mind: Eisman, long comfortable with the post-crisis regime, now argues for a wave of bank mergers and predicts more lenient stress tests, better bank fundamentals and a friendlier regulator in Michelle Bowman replacing Michael Barr.

IN THE ARC

Closes the year and the financial literacy arc, and supplies the analytical spine for his weekly wrap positions: banks are safe because of post-2008 deleveraging, regulators repeat the last war, and the binding constraint metaphor he applies to AI power comes straight from the stress test regime described here.

“Incentives trump ethics every time.”

STEVE EISMAN

“Generals always fight the last war.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If stress tests become more lenient, does the system stay as safe as Eisman insists it now is?
- Does a bank merger wave actually arrive, and would it fix the technology cost problem or just concentrate deposits further?
- Would today's regulators catch a Silicon Valley style liquidity risk any faster than the 2023 ones did?

Steve Eisman Reacts to Scenes From The Big Short

2026-01-02 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

Eisman's claim is that The Big Short compresses and invents on the surface while getting the mechanics and the emotion right underneath. The scenes he calls literary license, the taxi argument with his wife above all, never happened, but they encode a real condition, that shorting the entire housing market against unanimous opposition produced constant anxiety. The scenes he calls accurate are the technical ones, Lippmann teaching them how to short subprime paper, the dealers quoting credit default swap prices off screen, subprime bonds rising while defaults spiked. His conclusion is that the film's least flattering choice, the anger, was the most accurate, and he only accepted this after reading his own 2009 or 2010 testimony released in 2015.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

No guest, so the pushback is against himself. His strongest self correction is on the portrayal: he told everyone the anger was overdone, then read his Financial Crisis Inquiry Commission transcript in the 2015 data dump and reversed on air. He also pushes back on the heroic framing of the trade by describing the Vegas trip as an attempt to find out that they were wrong.

THE NUMBERS

- The cast mapping, with Mark Baum as Eisman, Jared Vennett as Greg Lippmann of Deutsche Bank, and Vincent Daniel, Porter Collins and Danny Moses under their own names
- Roughly 5,000 attendees at the January 2007 securitization conference at the Venetian, including hedge funds, rating agencies, banks and lenders
- Morgan Stanley's internal hedge fund write-off in the fall of 2007 of at least 10 billion dollars, a full year before the general crisis
- The Bear Stearns panel at Deutsche Bank held on the Friday it could not roll its paper, before the market opened, with the JP Morgan sale landing that Monday
- The 2015 Financial Crisis Inquiry Commission document release, which made his own interview transcript publicly searchable
- His one script contribution, changing a single insult to schmuck, which survived into the film with no credit

WHAT MOVED

Nothing shifts on the trade itself, which he has told many times. What moves is his account of himself. He arrives holding that Carell overplayed the anger and leaves holding the opposite, on the strength of a document rather than a memory.

IN THE ARC

The origin story the whole show runs on, and the source of the rules he applies to private credit and to AI capex in later episodes. The dealer quoted credit default swap price is his earliest version of the

transparency complaint he now aims at private credit marks, and the Vegas trip is his template for going to meet the consensus before you bet against it.

> *“Not only were we wrong, but everybody else was delusional.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“Average people are going to be the ones that are going to have to pay for all of this.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If dealer quoted pricing was the corruption he identified in 2007, where is the equivalent unobservable mark today?
- What in the current market would play the role Morgan Stanley's 2007 write-off played, a single institution's loss that pre-announces the cycle?

2026 Predictions with Dan Ives and Chris Verrone | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 40

2026-01-05 | WITH DAN IVES, CHRIS VERRONE

THE THESIS

Verrone's core argument is that one simple test survived a year of narrative whiplash: as long as bank stocks are working and credit is calm, the market trend is up, and both conditions held through deepseek in January, the tariff crash in April and every AI scare since, with 10-year yields remarkably stable underneath. Sentiment, not fundamentals, drove the swings, from euphoria in January to the second percentile at the April low, which is why the 37% rally off the bottom found so few believers. Ives layers on the tech case: it is still early in the AI trade, transformational names punish valuation-centric investors who trim on multiples, and even Apple has finally decided to play ball. Both expect 2026 up with white-knuckle moments, and the real work is sorting genuine AI winners from pretenders now that the label alone no longer carries a stock.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman announces his pushback on the AI trade explicitly, using Eaton, unchanged since about April 2024, to show that a supposed AI darling with legacy businesses is not an AI play at all, and the panel concedes investors are now separating winners from what one guest calls the frauds, since saying AI 30 times on a conference call does not make you an AI play. On private credit he counters the bears: the canaries, First Brands and Tricolor, did not originate in private credit, and the negative case rests on a single number, growth from 2 trillion to 3 trillion, with no loss data behind it. He also insists his two 2026 risks, power timelines and the absence of a federal AI regulatory roadmap, are more serious than the panel's base case allows.

THE NUMBERS

- From February 19 through April 8, 2025 the market fell about 19 to 20% on tariffs, then rallied roughly 37% off the April low
- Strategas's sentiment composite hit the second percentile historically around the April bottom
- Private credit grew from 2 trillion in 2020 to 3 trillion today, the bears' main exhibit and, Eisman argues, their only one
- Verrone calls Bank of America, a 55 dollar stock, conservatively worth 75 next year, with Wells Fargo, Goldman and Morgan Stanley already at new highs
- Eaton has been roughly unchanged since April 2024 despite its AI halo, dragged by legacy truck and automation businesses
- Verrone's added risk: a strong early-2026 economy pushes the 10-year back to 4.5% and triggers de-risking of speculative names

WHAT MOVED

Direction is never in dispute; the risk list is. Eisman signs on to the bull case except for his two named risks, energy and LLM law, Ives accepts the federal roadmap point, and Verrone appends a third risk, rates. Nobody concedes an AI bubble, and the argument ends as a ranking of what could break first.

IN THE ARC

The 2026 season opener, pairing the technician and the tech bull against Eisman's four 2025 themes from the year-end wrap. Verrone's banks-and-credit test is the market-facing twin of the Schorr private credit conversation, and the AI winners-versus-pretenders sorting picks up where the Nvidia and Burry depreciation debates in the November wraps left off.

> *“So long as banks are involved and so long as credit is calm, the trend of the market's probably still up.”*
>
> CHRIS VERRONE

> *“This is a 55 dollar stock today. I don't think it's a 55 dollar stock next year.”*
>
> CHRIS VERRONE

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Which cracks first in 2026: credit calm, power availability, or a 10-year yield back at 4.5%?
- Can a federal AI regulatory roadmap arrive before a state-by-state patchwork chills the trade?
- Does Bank of America reach Verrone's 75, and what would that confirm about the bank-led bull case?

The Broken US Healthcare System is Failing Millions of Americans with Warris Bokhari | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 41

2026-01-12 | WITH WARRIS BOKHARI

THE THESIS

Bokhari, a British-trained ICU doctor turned Anthem executive turned founder of Claimable, argues that all four pillars of American healthcare, commercial insurance, Medicare, Medicaid and the ACA, share one structural disease: the incentives reward denying care, because most patients never appeal even though appeals routinely succeed, sometimes in a day. Regulation entrenched the problem, barring providers from owning hospitals so they can only be bought, and fattening pharmacy benefit managers through rebates, while consolidation on both sides, Sutter Health style hospital monopolies and vertically integrated insurers, ratchets prices. Hospitals running 1.5 to 3.5% margins must treat everyone under EMTALA, so stripping coverage just shifts uninsured patients into emergency rooms the hospitals eat. He calls the whole drift defining deviancy down: denial of medically necessary care has become normal, and his answer is technology aimed at the denial chokepoint itself.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman does not contest the thesis; he disciplines it. He forces the four-part taxonomy at the start, demands names and mechanisms throughout, who Sutter Health is, who David Joyner is, how a monopoly network negotiation actually works, and grounds every abstraction in a case: Bokhari's own inhaler prescription, taken since about 2007, denied by CVS the week before taping; the Austin breast surgeon Elizabeth Potter called out of surgery by UnitedHealth over a denial; the insurer's own employee whose denial was overturned in a day after her vision was already gone. The pressure is toward specificity rather than disagreement.

THE NUMBERS

- Most denied claims are never appealed, and appeals frequently succeed, some overturned within a single day
- Hospital systems run at margins of roughly 1.5 to 3.5%, the difference between making and losing money

- EMTALA, signed under Reagan in the 1980s, forces emergency rooms to treat regardless of insurance, and hospitals cannot balance-bill those patients
- Sutter Health bought up regional California practices, promised no changes, then raised prices insurers could not refuse
- Bokhari's own inhaler, prescribed continuously since about 2007, was denied by CVS the week before taping, prompting his letter to CEO David Joyner
- Surgeon Elizabeth Potter was called out of an operation by UnitedHealth to be told her patient's coverage was effectively denied

WHAT MOVED

There is no adversary to move. Eisman, who opened by saying the episode exists because we are all human beings rather than stock pickers, closes calling the conversation great and very emotional, absorbing the argument that the failure is structural rather than a few bad actors. Bokhari ends on mission, his professor's eulogy, not on valuation.

IN THE ARC

The denials chapter of the show's running healthcare investigation, following Michael Ha's UnitedHealth work and framed by the Mangione trial happening blocks from the studio. It is also the clearest expression of the show's K-shaped economy theme at the human level, deliberately stripped of any stock angle.

> *"We're going to talk about it not because we want to pick stocks, but because we're human beings."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *"He didn't try to make the world perfect. He just tried to make his corner of the world that little bit more perfect."*
>
> WARRIS BOKHARI

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can automated appeals change insurer behavior, or will denial models simply adapt to the counterattack?
- What regulatory change would actually break the provider consolidation ratchet Bokhari describes?
- If the ACA is weakened, can hospitals at 3% margins survive the EMTALA load of newly uninsured patients?

Gary Marcus on the Massive Problems Facing AI & LLM Scaling | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 42

2026-01-19 | WITH GARY MARCUS

THE THESIS

Marcus argues that large language models are statistical blur machines, not systems that build models of the world, and that this flaw is structural, not fixable by scale. Because they only predict which words cluster around other words in training data, they hallucinate constantly and break down on anything novel, from legal citations to bond market shocks to chess, where a model trained on the whole internet still makes illegal moves because it never abstracts the rules. He anticipated these failure modes in his 2001 book The Algebraic Mind, and GPT-5's underwhelming August 2025 debut, after repeated delays and a discarded intermediate model, is his proof that scaling has hit diminishing returns. The industry is therefore speculating hundreds of billions on the bet that a technology that does not work will magically work if made bigger, when what is needed is foundational research into systems that can induce causal world models. AI will transform the world eventually, just not with this technology and not on this timetable.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman mostly plays prosecutor for the bull case, forcing Marcus to translate theory into market mechanics. He extracts the concession that each generation is legitimately better, just not enough better, and pushes

the competitive logic to its end point: if the game is only scale, Google wins hands down because it makes its own tensor chips and can fund the commitments, while OpenAI next needs roughly a 100 billion dollar check that maybe five people in the world can write. Eisman also frames the novelty failure himself, asking whether the core problem is that anything not in the database breaks the model, which Marcus confirms is the central issue even for the newer inference models.

THE NUMBERS

- GPT-5 launched August 7, 2025, billed as able to do anything a PhD can do, and the public found the same hallucinations within about an hour
- An earlier model internally treated as GPT-5 was demoted to GPT-4.5 because it was not good enough to carry the name
- A tracker of fabricated legal citations in court filings found about 300 cases, then about 600 roughly three months later
- Models trained on the entire internet, including the written rules of chess, still make illegal chess moves
- Marcus wrote about hallucination and reasoning failures in The Algebraic Mind in 2001, and the transformer paper underlying LLMs dates to 2017
- OpenAI's next funding round needs roughly a 100 billion dollar check, which maybe five people in the world can write
- Ilya Sutskever, coming from the opposite camp, said in November that scaling alone is played out, converging with Marcus's five-year-old position

WHAT MOVED

No conversion, but a genuine update. Marcus holds his full position that scaling is an intellectual dead end, conceding only that models keep improving modestly. Eisman does not adopt the thesis on air; he calls the interview educational, tells wrap viewers that if Marcus is right the torrid growth in AI may slow with broad market implications, and immediately books Columbia's Daniel Guetta for a second opinion because the stakes are too high to rest on one critic.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's most direct examination of the foundation under its biggest running theme, AI capex and its returns: if Marcus is right, the 650 billion dollars of hyperscaler spending Eisman keeps tracking has no payoff. It pairs explicitly with the Daniel Guetta episode four weeks later, which Eisman commissions as the counter-opinion, and it feeds his lone wolf theme from the January 23 wrap, where Marcus sits alongside Michael Burry as a contrarian gaining traction.

> *“Just making it bigger is not going to solve these problems. We need to do foundational research.”*
>
> GARY MARCUS

> *“They never really abstract the model of how chess works. That's just so damning.”*
>
> GARY MARCUS

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If scaling is exhausted, what happens to the hundreds of billions of AI capex already committed for 2026?
- Can OpenAI keep raising 100 billion dollar checks if Google wins a pure scale race?
- How long would world-model research take to produce deployable systems, and who funds it in the meantime?

The Mystery of Stablecoins, Visa, & Fiserv’s Collapse with Ken Suchoski | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 43

2026-01-26 | WITH KEN SUCHOSKI

THE THESIS

Suchoski maps payments into three worlds: stablecoins, the newer players like PayPal, Block and Toast, and the old guard of Visa, Mastercard and the bank processors. His core argument is that stablecoins are real but narrow: their genuine value is 24/7 cross-border settlement with no cut-off times, attacking the correspondent banking system that still handles 90% of cross-border flows, yet the on and off ramps remain the choke point. Circle itself is best understood as an asset manager earning a reserve return that tracks short-term rates, so Fed cuts directly hurt it, which is why Autonomous was negative at an IPO valuation of about 75 times EBITDA. Across the rest of the group, a brutal year has left only Visa and Mastercard as durable long-term holdings, with everything else a trade whose main appeal is that beaten-down starting valuations mathematically improve prospective returns.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman drives the risk questions rather than disputing conclusions. He flags what he calls potentially the biggest risk of the entire sector, what stands behind the peg, and walks Suchoski through the reserve mechanics until the rate sensitivity is explicit: the Fed cutting rates is a negative for Circle. He also forces the Fiserv autopsy, admitting he knew the stock had blown up but not why, and pushes on PayPal's premium pricing against Apple Pay, which Stripe passes to merchants for free. The episode ends with Eisman extracting a summing up and effectively co-signing it: Visa and Mastercard for the long term, the rest a minefield.

THE NUMBERS

- Circle traded at about 75 times EBITDA around its IPO, when Autonomous went negative on the stock
- USDC reserves sit in very short duration assets, about a two week average duration in Treasuries
- Specialist cross-border payment networks have about 10% of the cross-border market; correspondent banking still has the other 90%
- The year's scoreboard: Fiserv down 71%, PayPal down 27%, Block down 30%, Bill down 36%, FIS down 17%, Toast down 2%, while Visa and Mastercard are up slightly
- Only 2 of the 32 payment companies in Autonomous's screen outperformed the S&P 500
- Merchant acquirers earn roughly 50 basis points on transactions; Cash App is about 60% of Block's gross profit and Square about 40%

WHAT MOVED

Convergence rather than conflict. Suchoski concedes the year was a minefield but holds that these remain high-return businesses whose lower valuations improve forward returns, and he stays optimistic. Eisman ends exactly where he started, with the position both men share: own Visa and Mastercard, treat everything else as a trade.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's crypto scepticism theme meeting real fundamental analysis: stablecoins get taken seriously as plumbing while Circle the stock gets dismantled on valuation and rate exposure. The Visa and Mastercard conclusion becomes a running Eisman rule he restates in the February wraps and again in the March 9 episode with Schorr and Collins, where stablecoin yield emerges as a threat to bank deposits.

> *“Only two companies out of the 32 payment companies in our screen have outperformed the S&P 500.”*
>
> KEN SUCHOSKI

> *“It's like a minefield.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can stablecoins actually take share from the 90% of cross-border flows still in correspondent banking, given the on and off ramp problem?
- What happens to Circle's earnings model in a sustained Fed cutting cycle?

- Is Fiserv's 71% collapse a broken franchise or a mispriced processing annuity?

Jason Trennert on Populism, Policy & a Distorted Market System | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 44

2026-02-02 | WITH JASON TRENNERT

THE THESIS

Trennert argues that populism has dominated American politics for a decade because ordinary people got tired of social experiments from both left and right that never improved their lives, and that populism is now distorting the market system itself. Politically popular interventions, above all setting the price of money by pressuring the Fed, plus talk of policing buybacks and executive pay, replace market discipline with political discipline. Meanwhile the Fed has drifted from referee to active participant that shows up for every problem, Silicon Valley Bank included, and a government running large deficits as the reserve currency will eventually find the escape valve in higher inflation, a significantly weaker currency, or both. Near term he is constructive anyway: the One Big Beautiful Bill injects roughly 150 billion dollars of immediate refunds and stimulus plus supply-side provisions, so the 2026 economy should be pretty strong and the market should keep broadening beyond tech.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The two agree on fundamentals, so Eisman's pressure is Socratic rather than adversarial. When Trennert flips the SVB question back at him, Eisman answers flatly that he would have let it go down, never understanding why a bank that size was a big deal, sharpening Trennert's referee point. Eisman also presses on private equity marks, walking viewers through why the secondary market always clears at a discount, never at par, so a pension selling a stake marked at 100 is not getting out at 100. And he forces a midterm call from a self-described rock-ribbed Republican: if held today, Republicans lose the House.

THE NUMBERS

- Trennert, 57, was diagnosed with multiple myeloma two weeks before starting as Assistant Treasury Secretary for financial markets, spent about 3 weeks at Memorial Sloan Kettering, and now needs dialysis three times a week plus a donor kidney
- The One Big Beautiful Bill should inject roughly 150 billion dollars of tax refunds and stimulus that gets spent right away
- Private equity secondary market stakes always trade at a discount to par, never at 100
- CME's prediction market deal with FanDuel went from five states to essentially 50 states in about 3 weeks
- Polymarket, partnering with ICE, is a not insignificant Trump family holding
- The UK's Liz Truss budget episode in the fall of 2022 stands as the template for a bond market disciplining a government

WHAT MOVED

No side moves because there is little distance to close: both hold that setting prices politically is corrosive, that the Fed should be a referee, and that prediction markets probably need regulation as the venue most ripe for insider trading. The one concession is political, Trennert admitting his own party likely loses the House. Eisman keeps his recession-free base case; Trennert keeps his strong 2026 call.

IN THE ARC

This episode threads the show's banks and Fed theme through a political lens, with Fed independence under literal criminal investigation pressure in the same period's wraps, and extends the private credit worry into private equity monetization and marks. The prediction markets riff also feeds Eisman's crypto scepticism: speculation migrating to FanDuel-style venues becomes the setup for George Noble's line three weeks later that Bitcoin is now for old people.

> *“I don't think setting prices for anything is a good idea.”*
>
> JASON TRENNERT

“I can't think of anything that would be more ripe for insider trading than these markets.”

JASON TRENNERT

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If the escape valve for deficits is inflation or a weaker dollar, what is the trigger and the timetable?
- Does the One Big Beautiful Bill stimulus outrun the drag from tariff escalation in 2026?
- Can prediction markets scale to 50 states without a regulator before an insider trading scandal forces one?

Consumer VibeCession & Private Credit Risk with Lakshmi Ganapathi | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 45

2026-02-09 | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

THE THESIS

Ganapathi argues that the benign credit data in bank earnings is masking a deteriorating consumer, a disconnect she calls a vibecession. Invisible costs, health insurance, car repairs up roughly 45 to 50%, maintenance, have outrun wage growth, so households earning 100,000 to 150,000 dollars are cascading down into the lower leg of the K. The stress stays hidden because lenders are managing it out of the data: auto lenders extend and pretend, stretching a 3 year loan into 7 years or even a reported 100 month car loan, while BNPL spreads payments so thin that 19% of users simply forget obligations across Klarna, Affirm and PayPal. Lenders themselves do not believe the calm, quietly building near real-time consumer credit tracking and cutting limits at the point of sale. The cracks surface in the second half of 2026, showing up first as a pullback in consumer spending, not in credit statistics.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman opens by stating the opposing evidence himself: bank numbers are fine, provisions flat, spending up, so she must reconcile her thesis with the data, which she does via the silent restructuring of loans. He then forces the falsification question, what pushes the consumer over the edge, and pins her to a timeline and a first canary. On stocks he exposes the limits of the short book: on Carvana she admits Unicus never looked at it because you do not short a cult, and on GE Vernova she concedes their short was run over as the stock mooned from about 250 to 700 on the AI power trade, leaving them sidelined.

THE NUMBERS

- Car repair costs are up roughly 45 to 50%, one of the invisible costs squeezing budgets
- About 19% of BNPL users forget they have payments due because obligations are scattered across issuers, and rent and DoorDash can now be BNPL'd
- A 100 month car loan on a depreciating asset has been reported as lenders extend terms to keep payments current
- Consumers historically borrowed up to a 30% debt-to-income ratio; COVID-era originations ignored insurance, food and car maintenance costs
- Michigan consumer sentiment sits at a multi-decade low while reported credit quality stays clean
- Carvana went from about 4 dollars to over 400, a 100 bagger Unicus refused to touch
- BNPL and card lenders are underwriting in near real time at the point of sale, declining customers without explanation

WHAT MOVED

Eisman buys the framing but not the timing as fact: he restates her case as the consumer being on the edge without yet being pushed over, and adopts deteriorating consumer spending as the first canary to watch. Ganapathi holds her second-half-2026 crack call and concedes nothing on it, while admitting the short side has no answer for cult stocks and AI moonshots.

IN THE ARC

This is the sharpest statement of the show's K-shaped economy theme, giving a mechanism for why the bottom of the K is invisible in bank data that Eisman praises weekly. Her closing points on private credit opacity, First Brands as the pattern where nobody knows until it is too late, feed directly into the Tom Gober and Schorr-Collins episodes in March, and Eisman quotes her getting in was easy line in his March 6 wrap.

> *“No shorting the cult, no touching the cult.”*
>
> LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

> *“Basically what you're saying is the consumer is on the edge, but hasn't been pushed over the edge.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does deteriorating consumer spending actually show up in the second half of 2026, or does extend-and-pretend keep working?
- How much consumer risk has quietly migrated from banks into BNPL and private credit where nobody can see it?
- If lenders are cutting limits in real time at the point of sale, does that itself trigger the spending downturn?

Daniel Guetta on the Guts of AI, Agentic AI & Why LLMs Hallucinate | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 46

2026-02-16 | WITH DANIEL GUETTA

THE THESIS

Guetta, brought on as the explicit second opinion to Gary Marcus, agrees with Marcus's diagnosis but rejects his conclusion. Yes, LLMs are at bottom statistical parrots: they embed text into a space of numbers and predict what words sit nearby, which is exactly why they hallucinate and why they will not reach artificial general intelligence. But commercially that does not matter, because agentic AI, chatbots wired to tools that can book flights, send emails and act on systems, is already good enough to produce genuinely efficacious products. The binding constraint is not the model but the customer: companies must first build a fertile environment, IT systems a machine can actually operate, before AI pays off, and incumbents whose moat is control of a database are newly vulnerable.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The pushback runs through the episode's framing rather than combat: Eisman stages Guetta against Marcus and then adjudicates on air in a solo close. He tests the disruption logic with his own example, a hypothetical owner of the best commercial real estate database whose moat AI could now attack cheaply, and Guetta confirms the vulnerability. In his verdict Eisman raises the strongest objection himself: even if Guetta is right that products will work, nobody knows whether returns will justify the hundreds of billions being spent, and no answer is coming this year, only exciting announcements until 2027 or 2028.

THE NUMBERS

- The top four hyperscalers are set to spend about 650 billion dollars on AI-related capex
- Guetta's route to the topic: a PhD in data-driven supply chain management with time at Amazon, years at Palantir's commercial business, then about 8 years building Columbia's data and analytics curriculum
- Deep learning's breakthrough dates to the mid 2010s, with LLMs as one species of deep neural network defined by enormous parameter counts
- Agentic AI announcements have already knocked around insurance brokers and wealth managers on single headlines
- Eisman's timeline: whether the capex earns its return will not be knowable until 2027 or 2028

WHAT MOVED

Eisman moves, and says so: he sides a little more with Guetta than with Marcus, accepting that LLM products are good enough to matter even without AGI. What he refuses to concede to either side is the returns question, which he leaves explicitly open for two more years. Guetta gives ground to Marcus on hallucinations and AGI while holding that usefulness, not intelligence, is the investable fact.

IN THE ARC

The direct companion to the January 19 Gary Marcus episode and the clearest statement of where Eisman lands on the show's AI capex theme: spend continues, products arrive, verdict deferred. It also frames the AI panic mechanics of the February wraps, where software, brokers, logistics and real estate services stocks get shot on any agentic AI press release, the market pricing Guetta's thesis before the returns exist.

> *"These models are just, at least right now, statistical parrots that are just parroting existing data."*
>
> DANIEL GUETTA

> *"We may not know till 2027, 2028 whether all this investment is going to produce returns that justify it."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If products work but returns stay unprovable until 2027 or 2028, what keeps funding the 650 billion in the meantime?
- Which database-moat businesses get attacked first now that the data, not the software, is the only barrier?
- How many enterprises actually have the fertile IT environment agentic AI needs, and how long does building it take?

George Noble on Gold's Rise, Crypto Doubts & Tesla's Struggles | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 47

2026-02-23 | WITH GEORGE NOBLE

THE THESIS

Noble's argument is R is for rotation, not recession: the market is not dying, it is changing leadership, so he is extremely negative on anything tech related and incredibly bullish on energy, materials, gold and silver. The gold case rests on fiat debasement, governments spending without constraint until a global Liz Truss moment when a bond market somewhere refuses the budget, as the gilt market did in the fall of 2022. Crypto fails its own test, digital gold that never hedges anything, its narrative machinery of four-year cycles and stock-to-flow just chart-and-story investing with no fundamentals. Tesla is the emblem of narrative over numbers: 2025 consensus earnings were 8 dollars three years ago and reality arrived around 1.70, on a stock that went nowhere for five years. Even the AI trade is underpriced product economics, ChatGPT-style teaser rates that must eventually rise, like Uber and DoorDash when free stock market money ran out.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman engages Noble harder than most guests because they disagree on the core. On gold, Eisman is the open skeptic: as long as there is no alternative to Treasuries, he does not see the dollar getting flushed, and he notes people have made the debasement argument for 40 years while the US economy got a lot bigger along with the debt. He grants Noble's track record and stays open-minded on rotation without endorsing it. On Tesla he agrees with the analysis but not the trade, refusing to short anything that involves a cult. Only on crypto is there complete agreement.

THE NUMBERS

- Noble's Fidelity Overseas Fund was the country's number one fund in its first year, up 79% in 1985, and number two of all mutual funds over his six years
- His 2008 fund was down only about 1% yet got redeemed heavily because it did not gate, becoming the ATM for investors
- Tesla's 2025 consensus EPS three years in advance was 8 dollars; the actual number came in around 1.70, and the stock has gone nowhere in five years
- The fall 2022 Liz Truss budget collapse in the UK gilt market is Noble's template for the coming global fiscal moment
- An engineer contact pays 20 dollars a month for AI tools and sees no reason for the 200 dollar tier, and says the products are way underpriced for a decent return on equity
- Young speculators have moved to FanDuel and prediction markets, leaving Bitcoin, in Noble's telling, to older holders

WHAT MOVED

Explicitly scored by Eisman in his close: open-minded but unconvinced on rotation into energy, a declared skeptic on gold and the dollar's demise, in complete agreement on crypto as speculation on speculation, and aligned on Tesla's fundamentals while refusing the short. Noble concedes nothing; both walk away holding their books.

IN THE ARC

The stock-jockey episode that stress-tests several show themes at once: crypto scepticism gets its sharpest line yet, the AI capex doubt gets a product-economics angle to complement Marcus's science and Burry's depreciation math, and the gold debate gives Eisman his cleanest statement of dollar confidence amid the silver mania chronicled in the surrounding wraps.

> *“R is for rotation, not recession.”*
>
> GEORGE NOBLE

> *“I generally do not like to short anything that involves a cult.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What would force the global Liz Truss moment Noble expects, and which bond market breaks first?
- If AI products must reprice from teaser rates to real economics, what happens to adoption and to the capex math?
- Can the rotation into energy and materials persist if tech capex, the source of much demand, slows?

The Next Financial Crisis? Private Equity, Private Credit & Life Insurance | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 48

2026-03-02 | WITH TOM GOBER

THE THESIS

Gober, a forensic accountant and former state insurance examiner, argues that private equity's takeover of life insurance has quietly rebuilt the pre-crisis playbook. First, PE owners treat insurers as captive buyers of their own affiliated private credit paper, so asset risk is far higher than the plain vanilla bond books of old and the transactions are not at arm's length. Second, insurers cede liabilities to affiliated captive reinsurers, special purpose vehicles with no buildings and no employees, domiciled offshore or in five industry-friendly states that grant permitted practices exempting them from statutory accounting, which lets them hold fewer assets against the same promises. The result is hidden leverage nobody can measure, policed by fragmented state regulators who are outmatched by Apollo, KKR and Brookfield, and ignored by sell-side analysts who cover the parent asset managers but never read statutory filings. Policyholders and annuitants carry the tail risk.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman does not resist the thesis, he stress-tests its remedies and its timing. When Gober offers his fix, make affiliated reinsurers file the same US statutory statements as domestic insurers, Eisman's response is good luck getting them to do that, because it would show they are not fully funded, and Gober agrees that is exactly why they will not. Eisman also supplies the reason nothing has blown up, a massive bull market in credit deferring problem one, and in his solo close he concedes the bear-case caveat that the risk is a slow boiling frog with no visible credit losses yet.

THE NUMBERS

- Five states grant permitted practices that loosen statutory accounting: Vermont, South Carolina, Delaware, Arizona, Iowa
- One company took reserve credit for 7 billion dollars laid off to three of its own captives, and when Gober saw inside such vehicles, assets were substantially short of liabilities
- Gober has spent 41 years on insurer accounting since starting as a Mississippi examiner, including 7 years as an examiner passing twelve accreditation and certification exams
- Reinsurance done properly requires sending assets commensurate with liabilities to an arm's length third party; only an affiliate would take 5 billion of liabilities with 3 billion of assets
- Deferred acquisition cost treatment lets companies spread commissions already paid out over 25 years, underfunding future death claims
- Athene recently ratcheted up its allocation to illiquid affiliated private credit investments significantly

WHAT MOVED

Eisman adopts the thesis wholesale and extends it. His close lays out four problems in his own words, captive purchases of affiliated paper, hidden offshore leverage, an analyst community not reading statutory filings, and lenient state regulation, and concludes the industry is a hell of a lot more leveraged than it looks, with regulators certain to act only after it blows up. Gober gives ground on nothing; the only open caveat, aired in the following wrap, is that no major credit losses have actually surfaced yet.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's private credit theme reaching its systemic endgame: the loans Lakshmi Ganapathi called opaque and Blue Owl gated now turn out to sit inside the vehicles backing life policies and annuities. The episode was pulled forward a week on Eisman's insistence, previews the Schorr and Collins discussion of the PE-insurer complex, and consciously echoes The Big Short structure, unregulated risk, captive structures, and regulators who move only after the explosion.

> *“Just because the promise is somewhere else, it doesn't mean we no longer need to worry about our policy holders.”*
>
> TOM GOBER

> *“The only thing I can guarantee is that it's a hell of a lot more leveraged than it looks.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What ends the credit bull market that is keeping the affiliated private credit books from being marked?
- Could any state or federal actor compel captive reinsurers to disclose assets before a failure forces it?
- If a PE-owned insurer fails, do state guaranty funds actually cover policyholders at today's scale?

Private Credit Cracks, The AI "Boogeyman" & Why Crypto is for Boomers | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 49

2026-03-09 | WITH GLENN SCHORR, DWIGHT COLLINS

THE THESIS

Schorr's core argument is that the panic in private credit stocks has run far ahead of the credit facts. Blue Owl and peers are down 30 to 50%, a BDC merger implying 80 cents on the dollar was cancelled after investors revolted, and retail is walking away, yet high yield spreads sit at all-time tights, bank CEOs report a healthy consumer, and direct lending deals typically carry roughly 75% equity beneath 25% debt, so a lot has to go wrong before lenders lose money. The stress is concentrated where five years of growth went, direct lending to software, while real estate credit, infrastructure debt and investment grade asset-backed finance are in decent shape. Collins adds the breadth: AI headlines are now repricing whole sectors on single press releases, bank M&A has disappointed the golden-age hopefuls, and stablecoins with yield workarounds are a real threat to the 29% of US deposits that pay zero interest.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman's forcing question is the coexistence test, which Schorr poses with him: can private market stocks get pummeled while high yield spreads stay tighter than ever, every bank CEO calls the economy good, and every broker calls the capital markets cycle awesome? Something has to give, and neither guest fully resolves which side breaks. Eisman also makes them narrate the Blue Owl 80 cents fiasco in plain English, great news, we will give you 80 cents for your dollar, and pushes Collins on why bank M&A never became the tsunami with juicy premiums that he, too, had hoped for.

THE NUMBERS

- Private credit has grown to about 1.8 trillion dollars in total size
- Blue Owl and similar stocks are down 30, 40, even 50% in 2026, and a merger that would have haircut fund investors about 20% was cancelled after bad press
- Public BDCs were trading around 80 cents on the dollar as the merger was being pushed through
- Direct lending buyouts are financed with roughly 75% equity and 25% debt, a thick cushion before the loans lose money
- High yield spreads are at or near all-time tights even as private market stocks sell off
- Insurance broker stocks fell about 10 to 12% in a day after OpenAI approved a Spanish AI insurance app on its platform
- About 29% of US deposits pay zero interest, the pool yield-bearing stablecoins would attack

WHAT MOVED

Eisman comes away tentatively reassured on the credit itself, adopting Schorr's two anchors, tight spreads and the 75% equity cushion, as very interesting points against the panic, while leaving the coexistence paradox unresolved as the thing to watch. On payments the three converge on Eisman's old conclusion, Visa and Mastercard as the only long-term investments, everything else a trade. Schorr holds that real losses have not appeared and investors are de-risking ahead of evidence.

IN THE ARC

The calm-side rebuttal in the show's private credit arc, landing one week after Tom Gober's alarm about PE-owned insurers and a month after Blue Owl froze redemptions: Eisman deliberately alternates the prosecution and the defense. It also stitches together the AI headline-risk mechanics from the February wraps and the stablecoin deposit threat first raised with Ken Suchoski, tying private credit, AI fear and payments into one financial sector picture.

> *“Can all those things coexist? Can that really happen?”*
>
> GLENN SCHORR

> *“The only long-term investments in payments these days is Visa and Mastercard. Everything else is just a trade.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Which breaks first: all-time tight high yield spreads or the pummeled private market stocks?

- If retail keeps walking away from direct lending funds before losses appear, does the redemption pressure itself create the losses?
- Does software disruption ever burn through the 75% equity cushion in direct lending deals?

The Iran War Crisis: Ex-CIA Analyst Helima Croft on Oil Shock & Energy Risk | The Weekly Wrap

2026-03-13 | WITH HELIMA CROFT

THE THESIS

Croft argues the administration underpriced the risk of the Iran war because it anchored on two recent templates: Venezuela, where installing Delcy Rodriguez showed goals could stay manageable without full regime change, and the June 12-day war, where markets faded the story once no supply disruption materialized. This war is different because energy infrastructure does not restart like a light switch: Saudi Arabia's best-in-class Aramco could resume quickly, but Iraq's degraded infrastructure means a long restart, and LNG liquefaction facilities take even longer once cooled down and shut. If the strait stays closed, storage hits tank tops and the market breaks again, with the Saudi East-West pipeline to the Red Sea the main comfort. Her deepest warning is her own admitted bias from Iraq: enlightened interventions go wrong through mission creep, because the adversary gets a vote and will try to raise costs high enough that America never comes back.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman plays interrogator on mechanics rather than adversary: he forces her to explain exactly why restarting liquefaction is not a light switch, makes her trace the East-West pipeline country by country to the Red Sea, and pulls out her CIA background for the audience. When she names Iraq as her formative bias, he sharpens it into the direct question of whether the same failure to prepare for the day after could repeat here, which she accepts.

THE NUMBERS

- Oil breached the $100 level on Monday and collapsed in real time as Trump told CBS News the war would be over soon
- Croft walked into the CIA on December 1, 2001, at the start of her career
- The June 12-day war between Israel, Iran and the US produced only a brief oil run-up before markets faded the story
- Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline lets it export from the Red Sea, bypassing the Strait of Hormuz
- Iraq's infrastructure and investment problems mean a much longer production restart than Aramco's
- If the strait stays closed long enough, oil storage hits tank tops and the market starts breaking again

WHAT MOVED

No clash to resolve: Eisman absorbs Croft's framework and calls the interview one of the most informative he has run. Croft holds her caution that the administration's Venezuela and June templates may not fit, and Eisman adopts her mission-creep warning as the thing to watch.

IN THE ARC

This is the episode where the show pivots from the K-shaped economy and private credit to a war-driven unipolar market, with Eisman declaring that geopolitical uncertainty has overwhelmed all traditional equity analysis. It launches the Iran arc that continues with Steven Cook on March 30 and John Spencer on April 14, and it is also the episode where Eisman retires the chemotherapy hat, bought at The Gap.

> *"You start with one set of objectives, and those objectives change. And then you get caught, because your adversary has a say."*
>
> HELIMA CROFT

“The level of uncertainty that is created overwhelms any traditional equity analytical tools.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How long can the Strait of Hormuz stay closed before storage tank tops force a genuine supply break?
- Does the administration's Venezuela template survive an adversary determined to raise the cost of ever coming back?
- If restart timelines differ this much by country, who supplies the marginal barrel when the war ends?

Mark Cuban Shares His Plan For Fixing Drug Prices in America | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 50

2026-03-16 | WITH MARK CUBAN

THE THESIS

Cuban argues American drug prices are high not because drugs cost too much to make but because the delivery system is built on perverse incentives. Pharmacy benefit managers, which exist only in the US, collect rebates from pharma companies that function as bribes for placement on preferred formularies, and those rebates get pocketed rather than passed to consumers, while the so-called wholesale acquisition cost is actually the retail price people pay. The PBMs are owned by the giant insurers, an oligopoly with thousands of subsidiaries that can shift profit between pockets and game medical loss ratios. Meanwhile, deductibles many Americans cannot afford mean they effectively have no insurance, turning doctors and hospitals into subprime lenders who extend care they will never be paid for. Cost Plus attacks all of it with one published price for everyone: cost plus a 15% markup.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman keeps forcing the who-actually-pays question: if a drug wholesales for a thousand and the rebate is 400, is the consumer paying a thousand, 600, or something in between? That extracts Cuban's cleanest structural point, that in pharmacy the wholesale price equals the retail price. Eisman also presses on whether anyone has copied the model (no one has, though companies borrow his published contracts) and draws out the claim that insurers threatened to cut off pharma companies that worked with Cost Plus.

THE NUMBERS

- Cost Plus sells prescription drugs at cost plus a 15% markup, one published price for everyone
- PBMs exist only in the United States, and the largest insurers own them
- In the example discussed, a drug wholesaling for 1,000 dollars carries a rebate of about 400 that the consumer rarely sees
- The biggest insurance company has 2,600 subsidiaries, enabling left pocket, right pocket intercompany transfers that distort medical loss ratios
- A 1,500 dollar deductible counts as low, yet many Americans cannot afford it, which means they effectively have no insurance
- Cuban's own employee health plan uses no insurance company at all and has zero out-of-pocket costs for employees
- Cuban says he made 80% plus a year trading tech stocks in the 1990s but is now mostly in cash, in the Warren Buffett camp

WHAT MOVED

Eisman is fully persuaded: his closing monologue adopts Cuban's framework wholesale, calling rebates bribes and PBMs a hidden scheme, and ends hoping Cuban succeeds. The surprise concession runs the other way on markets, where Cuban reveals he is largely in cash waiting for the tide to go out.

IN THE ARC

The third installment of the healthcare investigation, after Michael Ha on insurance economics in September and Waris Bokhari on claim denials in January, and it feeds directly into Ha's return one week later. It also reinforces two running Eisman rules: opacity is itself a sell signal, and misaligned incentives, not costs, are what break American healthcare.

> *"In pharmacy, the wholesale price is the retail price."*
>
> MARK CUBAN

> *"Essentially, pharma companies bribe PBMs to get on those formularies via the rebates."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can one transparent price list actually force an oligopoly of insurer-owned PBMs to reprice?
- Why has no one copied Cost Plus after years of published prices and contracts?
- If providers are the new subprime lenders, who eventually eats the losses they are quietly accruing?

The Only Health Insurance Stock You Can Own with Michael Ha | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 51

2026-03-23 | WITH MICHAEL HA

THE THESIS

Ha argues managed care is being hit by a one-two punch across every business line at once. Risk adjustment crackdowns are squeezing the coding gains that inflated Medicare Advantage revenue, while rate notices came in flat when everyone expected roughly 5%, repeating the margin deterioration and benefit cuts of 2024 and 2025 and now threatening 2027. Medicaid is broken separately: redeterminations dropped the healthy members, leaving a sicker pool whose rates will take up to 24 to 36 months to reprice actuarially, which is the real answer to when to buy Molina. The deepest problem is structural: the industry became vertically integrated through acquisitions rather than organically, so companies with thousands of subsidiaries and databases that do not talk to each other are vertically integrated without being integrated, which is why an oligopoly cannot extract even normal rent.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman forces the macro how question: vertically integrated oligopolies are supposed to extract excess rent, so why is this industry a disaster? Ha's answer, that the integration came by acquisition and never operationally happened, becomes Eisman's headline takeaway. Eisman also translates Ha's Medicaid actuarial walk into the blunt investor question, we are basically asking when do I buy Molina, and pins him to the 24 to 36 month answer.

THE NUMBERS

- Medicare Advantage rate notices came in flat against a consensus expectation of about a 5% increase
- Medicaid rates take up to 24 to 36 months to reflect today's sicker acuity mix after redeterminations
- Risk scores are multipliers on a benchmark: the average is 1.0, but comorbidities can push a member to 2.0, 3.0 or 5.0
- The largest insurer has 2,600 subsidiaries whose technology databases do not speak to one another
- Ha estimates the tail risk of Congress breaking these companies up has moved from maybe 1% to 5 or 10%
- European investors Ha visited were sitting on hundreds of millions, if not billions, of unrealized losses in the sector

WHAT MOVED

Eisman ends more bearish than he began: too early to buy the sector, expect it to keep doing terribly. Ha holds that managed care remains a good long-term space if you are very selective, singling out ALHC as the one name he loves, which Eisman admits he has not yet examined.

IN THE ARC

The fourth healthcare episode and Ha's return after his September UnitedHealth breakdown, taped one week after Mark Cuban made the PBM case from the outside; Ha confirms from the inside that PBMs have fee-based levers to survive rebate reform. The vertical-integration-without-integration insight becomes a recurring Eisman explanation for why scale has failed this industry.

> *"While they are vertically integrated, they're not integrated."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *"If the tail risk was 1% before, it might be 5% or 10% now, which you should really risk weight."*
>
> MICHAEL HA

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does Medicaid pricing actually catch up in 24 to 36 months, or do states cut the timeline first?
- Can any acquirer-built insurer genuinely integrate 2,600 subsidiaries, and what would that cost?
- If flat rates repeat for 2027, which seniors' benefits get cut next and who wears the political blame?

The Iran War is Masking Economic Problems: Why Housing is So Expensive | The Weekly Wrap

2026-03-27 | WITH PHILLIPPE LORD

THE THESIS

Lord, CEO of Meritage Homes, argues housing is expensive because the country is structurally underbuilt: after the Great Recession builders pulled back, lots never came to market, and pent-up demand then collided with the last five years of shocks. The affordability crisis is concentrated below the median, so Meritage deliberately builds product under half a million dollars nationwide, the price point where people are actually struggling to attain ownership, while the median US home now costs more than that. On strategy, he defends a land-light model: bringing land on the books only when ready to build homes maximizes working capital efficiency and returns, but he concedes the off-balance-sheet route is not free, since competitors using REIT mechanisms pay for it in margin. It is all math, trading IRR impact against capital efficiency.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman pushes on the valuation hierarchy: why do Lennar, DHI and Pulte earn higher ROEs and price-to-book multiples while Meritage and other roughly 5 billion dollar builders trade near tangible book, which is exactly why he recommended the stock. On land banking he forces the concession that off-book land costs margin, summarizing Lord's answer as no free lunch here, which Lord accepts before reframing it as a capital efficiency trade worth making.

THE NUMBERS

- The median home price in the US is over half a million dollars, and Meritage targets product below that line
- Meritage's market cap is around 5 billion dollars versus roughly 20 billion for Lennar and up to 45 billion for DHI
- Eisman recommended MTH earlier in the year when it traded at tangible book value
- The US has been underbuilt since the Great Recession as builders backed off bringing lots and supply to market
- Private builders had a captive audience of shoppers until roughly the middle of last year
- Competitors using a REIT land mechanism carry an incremental margin burden for keeping land off the books

WHAT MOVED

Neither side moves much: Eisman sticks with his Meritage recommendation and his tangible book framework, and Lord concedes the margin cost of land-light strategies while holding that capital efficiency wins the trade. The interview hardens Eisman's view that midsize builders below tangible book are the right way to own the affordability story.

IN THE ARC

The housing affordability thread made flesh: Eisman has argued for months that homes are unaffordable for the bottom of the K-shaped economy, and here the builder confirms the structural undersupply diagnosis. The episode pairs with the January MTH recommendation and the April earnings wraps, where Meritage prints 82 cents against a 51% decline and Eisman restates the long-term tangible book case.

> *“We really underbuilt in this country.”*
>
> PHILLIPPE LORD

> *“No free lunch here is basically what you're saying.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How long can builders profitably serve the under half a million segment if land and rate costs keep rising?
- Does the land-light model's margin cost show up as a disadvantage when the cycle turns down?
- What closes the ROE gap between the big three builders and the 5 billion dollar tier: scale, land strategy, or just time?

Inside the Iran War with Steven Cook: What’s REALLY Happening? | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 52

2026-03-30 | WITH STEVEN COOK

THE THESIS

Cook argues the war is genuinely hard to read because information streams are corrupted, but the asymmetry of aims is legible: Israel's objectives are clear, regime change, the missile program, the nuclear program and the proxies, while Trump has deliberately left US aims vague to preserve deal-making maneuverability. The regime has proven far more resilient than expected even with degraded command and control, because at every escalation the Iranians have had an answer, and closing the strait does not take much. His base case is messy: the regime survives, Gulf states arm up, the strait may or may not reopen, and victory stays unclear, though the Iranian people are yet to be heard from and revolutions unfold over many months. Any negotiated end requires verifiable limits on restarting the nuclear program, or the whole war will have been for naught.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman's sharpest press comes on the highly enriched uranium: when Cook relays the Israeli view that the Iranians cannot get at it, Eisman objects that it is sitting in their own country, forcing Cook to explain that the sites are so devastated the material is buried and any recovery attempt would be seen. He also makes Cook drop the analyst's hedge twice, first asking what goals Cook would set if he were in the room, drawing out the JCPOA-style answer, and then demanding a bet on what the Middle East looks like in a few months.

THE NUMBERS

- Recorded March 23, the day Trump announced a 5-day pause on bombing oil infrastructure that Iran promptly denied negotiating
- Trump said 4 to 6 weeks; the war is in its fourth week with energy prices elevated and questions mounting
- The upward estimate is 30,000 civilians killed by their own government in the December to January crackdown

- The Iranian revolution unfolded over roughly 15 to 18 months, Cook's caution against expecting instant uprisings
- After the Abraham Accords, Trump ordered Israel into CENTCOM, obliging even hostile neighbors like Qatar to work with it
- Some 18 foreign ministers gathered in Saudi Arabia last week and issued statements far tougher on Iran than on Israel
- Iran fired on Dimona after the Natanz strikes and missed by about 12 miles

WHAT MOVED

Eisman concedes ground: he hopes for a clear victory but accepts Cook's messy base case as the likelier world, closing that if things are messy, the markets will just have to deal with it. Cook holds his structural pessimism while granting the damage to Iran's missile and nuclear programs is real.

IN THE ARC

The second leg of the Iran arc after Helima Croft's oil-shock framework, and the scholarly counterweight to John Spencer's more bullish military read two weeks later. It feeds Eisman's running market rule for this stretch: a unipolar, headline-trading market where war aims kept deliberately vague translate directly into unpriceable uncertainty.

> *"Otherwise, this will be all for naught."*
>
> STEVEN COOK

> *"He's a deal guy and he wants as much maneuverability as possible."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can any ceasefire include verification strong enough to prevent a nuclear restart?
- Does the regime's survival plus an armed-up Gulf produce stability or just a paused war?
- When, if ever, do the Iranian people move, given the revolution's 15 to 18 month precedent?

Is Private Credit the Next Systemic Crisis? Steve Liesman Weighs In | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 53

2026-04-06 | WITH STEVE LIESMAN

THE THESIS

Liesman argues the economy faces four simultaneously consequential stories, tariffs, AI job losses, private credit and the oil shock, any one of which would normally be enough, and the only honest method is scenario analysis because short, medium and long wars produce dramatically different outcomes. Against the gloom he sets the unforecastable resilience of a segmented US economy that contains an oil economy the size of Saudi Arabia inside it. On private credit his two key insights are that the equity private equity puts into buyouts may itself be borrowed from banks, so true leverage is unknowable, and that opacity itself is the panic mechanism: if losses were small but everyone knew who held them, nobody would be scared. On the Fed, hawks are floating policy action to keep inflation expectations anchored against the oil spike, while Powell stands pat.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The sharpest disagreement is over the hawks: when Liesman reports Kansas City-style voices suggesting policy action against oil-driven inflation, Eisman objects that raising rates to fight an exogenous event makes little sense, and Liesman largely agrees. Liesman also plays devil's advocate on private credit, relaying the software industry's counter-story to Eisman's relentless weekly bad-news drumbeat, and reframing private credit's 2 to 1 leverage as conservative next to banks at 12 to 1, perhaps proof that Dodd-Frank pushed lending out of banks too far.

THE NUMBERS

- Recorded after 4 pm on March 31, following an enormous rally on a Wall Street Journal report that Trump would end the war without reopening Hormuz
- About 80% of direct lending finances private equity buyouts, an incestuous loop since PE firms own the credit funds
- Roughly 25% of direct lending is estimated to sit in software companies bought out between 2018 and 2022
- Banks are levered about 12 to 1 versus private credit funds at roughly 2 to 1
- The US oil economy is about the size of Saudi Arabia's entire economy
- Bank of America's internal consumer data shows the lower-end consumer, who did well during COVID, is now clearly hurting

WHAT MOVED

Eisman comes away with two insights he admits he did not have: buyout equity may itself be levered, and opacity rather than size is what drives the panic. Both hold their base positions, Eisman that a credit cycle is coming through software, Liesman that scenario uncertainty and the economy's resilience make confident forecasts impossible.

IN THE ARC

This episode fuses three of the show's running threads: the war-driven unipolar market, the private credit investigation, and the K-shaped economy, with the Bank of America low-end consumer data extending the affordability theme. Liesman's opacity point becomes a fixture of Eisman's wraps, where he argues nobody knowing who holds the risk is itself the systemic problem.

> *"If all I had to do was figure out the effects of a surge in oil prices on the economy, that would be enough."*
>
> STEVE LIESMAN

> *"We have an oil economy the size of Saudi Arabia inside the US economy."*
>
> STEVE LIESMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How much hidden leverage sits beneath private equity's supposedly unlevered buyout equity?
- Would disclosure alone, knowing who holds what, defuse the private credit panic without any losses being taken?
- Can the Fed hold inflation expectations anchored through an oil shock without raising rates into a war?

Catching a Falling Knife: The Truth About Software Stocks Today | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 54

2026-04-13 | WITH ROB OLIVER

THE THESIS

Oliver argues software's decades of outperformance rested on systems of record: businesses outsourced what they did not want to build, the resulting platforms became sticky because change management is painful, and stickiness meant pricing power through every platform transition. AI attacks the foundation, because anyone can now create software in minutes, which is simultaneously a golden age of creation and a threat to the moats, seat counts and per-seat pricing that anchor every software model. His key defense is that nothing has actually happened yet: contacts among buyers and companies report no changed behavior, and the group's collapse is investors fighting an unprovable negative. Clarity requires three to four quarters of pattern-forming anecdotes on retention and upsell, and innovative incumbents with proprietary data should make it through to the other side.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman grants the survival case but presses the pricing point: even if Salesforce is still great in two or three years, revenue growth must slow because pricing power cannot survive a collapse in the cost of creating software, and until he knows how much lower estimates go, he will not touch the group. He also tests the proprietary database thesis, that a Moody's or S&P selling data plus software is the best position, and detours into disclosure, marveling that only one company in Oliver's entire coverage reports GAAP numbers.

THE NUMBERS

- Software valuations have been cut by more than half, and the group trades at a huge discount to the S&P for roughly the first time ever
- The whole revenue model reduces to two variables: growth in seats times average price per seat, and both are now at risk
- Only one company in Oliver's coverage universe reports GAAP earnings
- Web content creation is exploding, visible in domain creation data and traffic at companies like Cloudflare
- The iPhone analogy: it took multiple years after launch before it killed the yellow cab, so AI's damage may arrive slowly
- Oliver expects three to four quarters before public investors can see whether buyer behavior actually changes

WHAT MOVED

Nothing converges: Oliver stays constructively optimistic that innovative incumbents cross the tunnel, while Eisman closes that the tunnel's end is at least a year away and buying now is catching a falling knife. Eisman's one concession is that cheapness itself is meaningless here, since software investors read low valuation as a symptom, not an opportunity.

IN THE ARC

This episode gives the fundamental engine behind the private credit story the show has tracked for months, since roughly 25% of direct lending sits in bought-out software companies, and it frames the AI capex debate from the demand side: AI as a destroyer of existing software economics rather than a boon. It sets up the April wraps on internalization and the Apollo interview two weeks later.

> *"Nobody loves software right now."*
>
> ROB OLIVER

> *"Trying to buy the group here is like catching a falling knife."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can per-seat pricing survive when the marginal cost of creating software approaches zero?
- Which anecdotes, retention, upsell, internalization, would count as the pattern that ends the uncertainty?
- If proprietary data is the real moat, how many software companies actually have one?

John Spencer on What the Headlines Get Wrong About the Iran War | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 55

2026-04-14 | WITH JOHN SPENCER

THE THESIS

Spencer argues the contradictory headlines miss that the US and Israel have systematically degraded Iran's military: the missile program, the nuclear program, the navy, and the internal suppression apparatus like the Basij, using technology, deception and intelligence penetration that did not exist a generation ago. Regime change is not the goal, only a nice-to-have; the four real goals, ending nuclear capability, ballistic missiles, and power export while changing regime behavior, are all achievable, and Iran's lashing out at its neighbors has validated the operation's necessity to every Gulf state. The larger stake is demonstrative: the US has staged an unprecedented show of military prowess, and Russia and China, whose untested

equipment just failed by proxy, are taking notes, which should make Xi rethink Taiwan. On the other side of the war he expects more stability, not less.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman confronts him with the opposite narrative directly, citing the Foreign Policy editor-in-chief's headline that Trump is losing the war, and asks what Iran has actually accomplished with its missiles and the closed strait; Spencer answers that Iran has mostly validated the case against itself. Eisman also plays the useful novice, forcing concrete details, where the B-2s flew from, how long the missions ran, how the pilot rescue worked, that turn Spencer's argument from assertion into mechanics.

THE NUMBERS

- The war is in its fifth week at recording, the day of Trump's press conference on the rescued pilot
- B-2 bombers flew from Missouri, roughly 18 hours each way, to strike Iran
- The deception plan sent seven B-2s toward the Middle East and six toward Guam as a feint
- Twenty years ago an entire corps of about 20,000 soldiers attacking Baghdad had exactly one drone
- The supreme leader was reportedly tracked partly by tapping Tehran's highway cameras as sensors
- The pilot rescue succeeded without a single death or injury

WHAT MOVED

Eisman buys the core claims: the degradation of Iran's military is unquestionable, the Taiwan implication is the sleeper insight, and postwar stability would be very positive for markets. He does not fully adopt Spencer's optimism on timing, noting the only open question is how long achieving the goals takes.

IN THE ARC

The third and most bullish leg of the Iran arc, balancing Steven Cook's messy base case from two weeks earlier and completing the show's escalation from Croft's oil mechanics to grand strategy. For the market thread, it feeds Eisman's view that the war is the single variable and that a decisive, stabilizing outcome is the underpriced scenario.

> *"As Sun Tzu said, deception is everything in a war."*
>
> JOHN SPENCER

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How long can achieving the four goals take before market patience and coalition cohesion crack?
- Does China actually update on Taiwan, or does it read Iran as a poor proxy for its own military?
- Can regime behavior change be verified without the regime change Spencer says is not the goal?

Market Patterns Work and Jeffrey Hirsch Explains Why | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 56

2026-04-20 | WITH JEFFREY HIRSCH

THE THESIS

Hirsch argues market seasonality persists because stocks are bought by people, people run on psychology, and even the algorithms are written by people, so patterns like the midterm election cycle, the January barometer and the best six months keep working across decades. The discipline is in the method: seasonality is never used alone but confirmed with a momentum tool like MACD before entry or exit, and patterns must be tracked honestly and retired to the indicator graveyard when they die, as the September reverse barometer did. His father Yale's rules anchor the book: write down your losers, because if you do not profit from your investment mistakes, somebody else will. Newer wrinkles include a 5-year Trump-era cycle of Q1 shocks negotiated away through year-end.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The liveliest friction is over Bitcoin, where the skepticism is mutual: Hirsch complains he cannot even define a close for an asset trading 24/7 across venues, and Eisman answers that Bitcoin acts opposite to its thesis, trading like 2x to 4x the Nasdaq, so just buy a levered Nasdaq ETF instead. Eisman also probes for falsification, asking which patterns stopped working, and gets the graveyard answer rather than a defense of everything, while Hirsch dismisses black swan forecasting outright: if you could foresee them, you would not need the book.

THE NUMBERS

- Yale Hirsch started the Stock Trader's Almanac in 1966, and the book is now in its 60th year of annual editions
- The midterm-year pattern: volatility bottoms around September and October, then the market rallies through April of the following year
- The January barometer: when the market rises in January, the year is up more often than not
- The September reverse barometer stopped working and was retired to the indicator graveyard
- Since 2008, working with technician David Aronson, the Almanac has used MACD to confirm best six months entries and exits
- Bitcoin trades like roughly 2x to 4x the Nasdaq, and its old seasonal patterns no longer work

WHAT MOVED

No real contest: Eisman endorses the book outright and adopts its core premise that human psychology creates durable patterns, algorithms included. The shared conclusion is methodological, that patterns earn trust only while they keep working and must be buried when they stop.

IN THE ARC

An evergreen entry that still lands on two running themes: the crypto skepticism thread, with both men dismissing Bitcoin as a levered Nasdaq proxy without a definable close, and the war backdrop, where Hirsch's taco trade cycle of Q1 shocks maps onto the March to April double bottom. It is the show's lightest episode in a stretch dominated by Iran and private credit.

> *“If you don't profit from your investment mistakes, somebody else will.”*
>
> JEFFREY HIRSCH

> *“Who creates the algorithms? People.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How would you know in real time that a 60-year pattern has died rather than paused?
- Does the midterm bottom pattern survive a market where a single war headline swamps seasonality?
- If algorithms increasingly trade against known seasonals, do the patterns arbitrage themselves away?

Apollo's Private Credit Exposure: Chris Edson Weighs In | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 57

2026-04-27 | WITH CHRIS EDSON

THE THESIS

Edson argues the private credit panic conflates the industry's riskiest corners with lenders built nothing like them. Apollo is primarily a diversified originator, 16 lending platforms with 4,000 employees spanning fleet, aircraft lending and more, funding the real economy the way insurance capital has for a century, and CFOs come to it to de-risk multibillion dollar capex borrowing after years of market shocks. Its software exposure is small by design, because Apollo underwrites value and collateral and software offers neither, being a dollar and a dream. On alignment and liquidity, the two live controversies, he argues Apollo is structurally different: it owns Athene and holds 35 billion dollars of its own capital as first loss, less than 5% of its capital sits in redeemable retail vehicles, and Athene's regulatory filings list every single loan, rebutting the

opacity charge.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman raises the traditional principal-agent question directly and lets Edson answer with the Athene first-loss structure, then presses on the redemption gate scandal, extracting the contrast that under 5% of Apollo's capital is redeemable while peers like Blue Owl carry much higher exposure, with Edson conceding the industry must honor what is fair. Eisman also pushes the software question until Edson, while declining to bad-mouth competitors, admits the range of outcomes is wide and companies with no moat, no proprietary data and quick installation are genuinely at risk.

THE NUMBERS

- Apollo runs 16 origination platforms with about 4,000 employees
- Apollo holds 35 billion dollars of its own capital in Athene as the first-loss position
- Less than 5% of Apollo's capital is redeemable on a regular basis, versus much higher percentages at firms like Blue Owl
- Fleet leasing serves the largest corporates running 10 to 20,000 vehicles, and PK Air Finance was bought out of GE Capital
- Edson built a Junie B. Jones math game for his 8-year-old with AI in seconds, his own exhibit for why software moats are in question
- Athene's regulatory filings list every loan it holds, with counterparty and amount

WHAT MOVED

Eisman concedes the specific while keeping the general: Apollo's software exposure looks genuinely small and its alignment and disclosure claims check out, but his conclusion is unchanged, a credit cycle is coming and it will run through software. Edson never disputes that software has major AI-driven issues, only that Apollo is standing where the flood will hit.

IN THE ARC

The defense's turn in the months-long private credit investigation, after weeks of wraps cataloguing redemption gates, frauds and software exposure, and two weeks after Rob Oliver supplied the AI-versus-software mechanics. It sharpens the show's emerging distinction between collateral-based lending and the direct lending funds levered to bought-out software, the same split Eisman uses when parsing Ares and Blue Owl in the wraps.

> *“We own Athene. We're the first loss in Athene.”*
>
> CHRIS EDSON

> *“A credit cycle is coming. It's going to be there in software.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If Apollo sidesteps the software bust, which lenders are actually holding the concentrated exposure?
- Does listing every loan in insurance filings amount to real transparency if nobody reads them until trouble hits?
- Can quarterly redemption vehicles survive a real credit cycle, or are gates now a permanent feature?

Is a Market Melt-Up Coming? Why Tech & Semis Are Dominating Again | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 58

2026-05-04 | WITH CHRIS VERRONE, TODD SOHN

THE THESIS

Verrone and Sohn argue that price action, not headlines, is telling the truth about this market. The 2026 war swoon, with the Nasdaq down 7% and the S&P down 4% into a March 31 low, is a near replay of 2025's

tariff swoon from late February to April 9, and in both cases the market snapped back to new highs faster than anyone reading the news would have predicted. What matters most is that leadership came right back to the same names, AI and power stocks, semis, industrials and banks, which by their work confirms the trend rather than ending it. Because leadership reasserted so quickly, Verrone raises his odds of a 1999-style melt-up over the next several months. Sohn's caveat is structural: semis are now so large inside the S&P 500 that passive investors own far more of the story than they realize, so the prudent move is to diversify into energy, materials and alternatives before the story hits a speed bump.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman does not fight the bullish read so much as stress test its edges. He forces them to explain gold, which should have soared when war broke out and instead went nowhere, and Verrone concedes gold jumped the shark from safe haven to risk asset back in the October to January runup. Eisman also injects his own fundamental jab on the banks, mocking Wells Fargo for a culture of blowing a quarter like clockwork after its net interest margin fell 13 basis points sequentially, and he presses on whether any defensive group can lead, which Sohn answers in the negative: staples outperformed for two weeks and gave it all back.

THE NUMBERS

- At the March 31 low the Nasdaq was down 7% and the S&P down 4% for the year; both are now up, with the S&P at new highs
- Semis are now about 17% of the S&P 500, roughly half of the entire tech sector weight
- Software has shrunk from the teens to single digits as a share of the index
- Wells Fargo's net interest margin fell 13 basis points sequentially, a massive move for a bank
- GE reported orders up roughly 80%, which Verrone cites as a non-recession indicator even as street economists raised recession odds in March
- Gold underperformed throughout the war episode after a blow-off condition in January
- Consumer staples outperformed for only 2 weeks during the swoon before giving it all back

WHAT MOVED

Eisman ends up adopting the deja vu framing wholesale in his closing thoughts, and says he is thinking about increasing energy exposure, not cutting it, because the group is oversold in a long-term uptrend. Verrone holds his melt-up call, Sohn holds his diversification warning about semi concentration, and no one aired a bear case beyond getting too static in one's views.

IN THE ARC

This episode sets the market backdrop for the whole late spring run of the show: the war swoon and recovery that the weekly wraps keep referencing, and the semi concentration that the Rasgon episode in June treats as the center of the universe. Eisman's melt-up nervousness shows up a week later in the May 15 wrap title, and the banks and defensive weakness threads connect to his recurring banks and Fed commentary.

> *"Ignore the headlines, put the newspaper away, and focus on the price action."*
>
> CHRIS VERRONE

> *"Wells has a culture of screwing up the quarter every four to five quarters. Like clockwork."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If leadership is this concentrated in semis, what happens to passive portfolios when the AI story hits its first real speed bump?
- Has gold permanently lost its safe haven role, or does it recover once the war premium unwinds?
- Does the melt-up scenario require the war to end, or just for headlines to keep being ignored?

FICO’s Monopoly is Fading & Consumers Are the Winners w/ Kelsey Zhu | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 59

2026-05-11 | WITH KELSEY ZHU

THE THESIS

Zhu argues FICO has abused a monopoly to the point of breaking it. The company raised the price of a mortgage credit score pull from about 60 cents in 2022 to 10 dollars, roughly a 1,500% increase over 5 years, and because a single mortgage can involve five or six pulls across three bureaus and multiple lenders, the cost compounds through the whole origination chain. That pricing has angered the entire lending ecosystem just as a real alternative arrived: Vantage Score has been validated for mortgage underwriting while FICO's own next-generation 10-T score has not, so lenders finally have somewhere to go. Zhu rates FICO underperform because share loss is coming and consensus estimates do not reflect it. Zooming out to the rest of her coverage, she ranks financial information companies by moat: Verisk, effectively a monopoly in insurance loss cost data, and MSCI, a beneficiary of passive investing, are the best businesses, while FactSet is the most problematic because its end users, active managers, are no longer growing, and she sees AI as a cost tailwind for the group rather than the existential threat the market fears.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman forces the arithmetic and the how at every step. He makes Zhu walk pull by pull through what FICO actually earns on a single mortgage, from 60 cents times three bureaus times three lenders through the five or six pulls of a full origination, and he pins down that the flat fee model is now 10 dollars against Vantage's roughly one dollar, drawing her dry line that ten dollars is nine dollars more than a dollar. He also presses on the confusion itself, the pricing grid and success fee that lenders and investors cannot model, treating opacity as evidence of a company behaving badly. In his closer he directly challenges management's public claim of zero expected share loss, saying he finds it hard to believe from a company that has infuriated its entire customer base.

THE NUMBERS

- FICO mortgage score pricing went from about $0.60 a pull in 2022 to $10, a roughly 1,500% increase over 5 years
- A mortgage applicant shopping three lenders can generate five or six pulls, each pulled from all three bureaus, with FICO paid on every one
- Vantage Score has been validated for use in mortgage underwriting; FICO 10-T has not been validated or implemented
- Vantage Score pricing sits around a dollar a pull against FICO's $10 flat fee model
- Two years ago investors asked Zhu whether score pricing could reach $50; now they ask whether it goes to $1
- Verisk's loss cost segment, its largest, is basically a monopoly in P&C insurance data

WHAT MOVED

The two converge rather than clash: Zhu holds her underperform on share loss and too-high estimates, and Eisman ends more negative than he started, committing to watch the next several quarters for evidence of share erosion. The one gap left open is AI, where Zhu thinks the threat to information services is overblown and Eisman counters that no one will have real clarity for at least a year.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's cleanest case study in its recurring rule that monopoly pricing abuse eventually invites its own destruction, and in the May 15 wrap Eisman disclosed he is short FICO, calling the price hikes among the most egregious monopolistic acts he has seen. The episode also extends the show's AI-and-software anxiety thread, since the whole financial information sector trades as software and carries the same negative AI narrative discussed with Rasgon and Marcus.

“They have angered the entire lending market and they're going to lose market share.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How fast does Vantage Score actually take mortgage share once lenders can switch, and what does the first quarter of evidence look like?
- Can FICO ever get 10-T validated in time to blunt the bureaus' attack, or has the window closed?
- If AI turns out to threaten rather than help information services, do even the Verisk and MSCI moats hold?

Conspiracy of Credit Part 1

2026-05-13 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

Eisman argues that the United States has not had a credit cycle induced recession since 2008, and that the credit built in the interval is both concentrated and unobservable. The Fed's post crisis regime forced banks to delever and to stop making risky loans, so lending growth migrated to private credit, where it sits behind a veil of privacy that he treats as a synonym for secrecy. Because markets are clearing mechanisms, hidden risk cannot be priced, and unpriced risk resolves through panic rather than repricing. The specific error is concentration: rates fell in 2018, the SaaS subscription model turned software into a predictable cash cow, and private equity and private credit piled into the same bet through 2022, only for AI to threaten the value of exactly those assets. His conclusion is a real recession risk without 2008 scale systemic risk, because the loans are not resecuritized and the banks are capitalized.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

A solo lecture, and he raises the strongest counter himself: this is not 2008. He sizes 2006 subprime at 600 billion resecuritized into CDOs at perhaps ten times that, giving trillions of exposure, against a roughly 1.8 trillion private credit industry with almost no resecuritization, and he says plainly he expects losses and perhaps a recession rather than a total disaster. He then partly undercuts that comfort by noting the banks are lenders to the funds anyway, and that the equity underneath may itself be borrowed.

THE NUMBERS

- Roughly 300 billion of bank lending extended to private credit funds, the regulated system's workaround
- Public BDC leverage capped at two to one, with other private credit vehicles able to lever further
- Blue Owl's flagship OCIC fund, about 36 billion in assets, receiving first quarter 2026 redemption requests of 21.9% of assets, with the 3.3 billion OTIC also elevated
- Retail facing funds gating redemptions at 5% to 7% per quarter and taking requests above the gate all year
- 2006 subprime volume of 600 billion, resecuritized into CDOs at roughly ten times that amount
- At least 25% of direct lending loans made to software companies bought by private equity between 2018 and 2022
- The Wall Street Journal analysis of March 30 showing software loans booked under the end industry, so healthcare software counted as healthcare

WHAT MOVED

Nothing converges because nothing is contested. The lecture moves from a claim about opacity to a claim about concentration, and lands softer than the framing implies: a bad credit cycle with real losses, not a systemic event.

IN THE ARC

The spine of the show's private credit thread, and the piece that connects it to the K shaped economy and to AI capex. AI is cast here not as the capex story but as the thing destroying the collateral behind the last cycle's software LBOs, which is the sharpest version of that argument the show has made.

“Labeling the rotten eggs differently doesn't change the number of rotten eggs.”

STEVE EISMAN

“Even expensive, well-paid cows prefer to join the herd.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If the true software exposure is above the disclosed 25%, at what level does his not systemic verdict break?
- Do redemption gates buy the funds time to work out the software book, or just concentrate the run into the next quarter?

A Conspiracy Of Credit Master Class: Part 2

2026-05-14 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

Eisman's argument is that the bond market's apparent complexity is mostly a language barrier maintained by the small group of institutions that run it. Every industry has a mafia that sets the rules and the lingo, and the lingo keeps insiders in and outsiders out, but underneath it the fixed income world is common sense plus arithmetic. He then builds the toolkit: bonds priced off the treasury curve, the curve sloping because time is risk, ratings functioning as the sole subjective input in an objective market and therefore setting rather than influencing price, and credit judged on cash flow, collateral, covenants and character. The payoff is deferred to part three, where the same tools explain how subprime securitization nearly ended the system.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

None is aired. The nearest thing to a counterweight is his handling of the repeat question. He asks directly whether today's unregulated private lenders are a historical rhyme with 2008, answers maybe, and then narrows it: exposure today is significant and deep in certain industries rather than unlimited, so there will be pain without a rerun.

THE NUMBERS

- Treasuries treated as the risk free benchmark for all bond pricing even after Moody's and S&P dropped the United States from triple A
- The ordering he keeps returning to, treasury yields below high grade corporates, high grade below high yield, with the gap defined as the spread
- Rating agencies described as the only subjective element in a totally objective mathematical market, with institutions positioning ahead of downgrades
- The four Cs of credit analysis, cash flow, collateral, covenants and character
- The amortization worked example, a five year bond at par of 1,000 dollars with a 7% coupon paying 70 dollars a year and returning principal only at maturity
- Residential mortgages as the self amortizing exception, where each payment retires interest and principal together
- Private loans described as having very little to no liquidity, leaving a lender in a thirty year contract stuck

WHAT MOVED

Nothing moves, by design. This is instruction rather than argument. The one live position carried through is that the current cycle rhymes with 2008 without matching it, held from the opening minute to the close.

IN THE ARC

The bridge episode of the private credit series and the show's clearest statement of its own method, that opacity is usually vocabulary plus incentive rather than genuine difficulty. It also sets up the life insurance thread with Tom Gober, which he names here as an example of what may be coming.

“Lingo keeps insiders in and outsiders out.”

STEVE EISMAN

“The ratings of the ratings agencies don't impact the price, they set the price.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If ratings set prices and agencies are structurally late, what marks private credit loans that no agency rates at all?
- Which covenants in current direct lending deals would actually bind a sponsor that decides to walk away?

Why Energy Stocks Are Down When They Should Be Up with Bob Brackett | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 60

2026-05-18 | WITH BOB BRACKETT

THE THESIS

Brackett explains the puzzle in the episode title: the war has closed the Strait of Hormuz and taken roughly 20% of world oil production off the market, yet energy stocks are down since the invasion. His answer is structural neglect plus hope. Energy is only 4% of the S&P 500, so generalist portfolio managers consumed by AI can buy Exxon and forget the sector, and oil prices themselves are capped by the market's persistent hope that the war ends soon. His framework for owning the group is cash return rather than commodity heroics: Exxon and Chevron each return 30 to 50 billion dollars a year in dividends and buybacks, and those yields should be compared to TIPS, not treasuries, because commodity producers are inflation protected. For risk-averse investors he points to toll-booth midstream models, especially Cheniere, which trades near an 8% free cash flow yield against the roughly 5% where S&P midstream gas peers settle, with no price risk and no geopolitical risk.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman keeps forcing the disconnect between the physical shock and the share prices, pressing on why oil is not far higher with a fifth of production offline, and on the political wildcard of the UAE dropping out of OPEC this year. He also plays devil's advocate on valuation logic, asking why anyone takes a 3% dividend when treasuries pay five, which draws Brackett's TIPS comparison, and he probes whether the transparently great EOG becomes a takeover target, which Brackett deflects into the premium problem of great companies being expensive stocks. In closing, Eisman reframes the whole sector more harshly than his guest: these are trading vehicles for value investors, bought at commodity-price lows and sold into excitement, not long-term growth holdings.

THE NUMBERS

- The closing of the strait took roughly 20% of world oil production out of the market, yet oil prices are lower than that shock implies
- Energy is only about 4% of the S&P 500, so generalists can own Exxon alone and ignore the rest
- Exxon pays roughly $20 billion a year in dividends plus 20 to 25 billion in buybacks; Exxon and Chevron each return 30 to 50 billion a year while still growing
- Cheniere trades near an 8% free cash flow yield versus about 5% for midstream gas companies inside the S&P 500
- The UAE dropped out of OPEC this year, a break in the cartel's structure since the 1970s
- Exxon outperformed in January and February and has fallen since the invasion, tracking hope of a quick end to the war

WHAT MOVED

No real disagreement to resolve, but Eisman walks away with a sharper version of the cyclicality rule than Brackett offered: buy these stocks only when the commodity has collapsed and nobody will touch them, and

expect strong production for a year or two as countries restock inventories after the war's destruction. Brackett holds his likes, Exxon, select drillers like Diamondback, EOG at a price, and Cheniere as the safest risk-adjusted return in the group.

IN THE ARC

The episode is the war's commodity chapter in a spring dominated by the Iran conflict, and it pairs with the Arment defense episode the following week as the two sectors the war should be repricing. It also feeds Eisman's running argument that the AI trade has starved every other sector of attention and capital, with energy the clearest orphan.

> *"Don't compare the yields you get from a commodity company to government yields. Compare them to TIPS."*
>
> BOB BRACKETT

> *"EOG is so great and almost so transparently great that it's typically an expensive stock."*
>
> BOB BRACKETT

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If 20% of world production offline cannot lift energy stocks, what shock would?
- Does the UAE leaving OPEC mark the beginning of the cartel's unraveling and a structurally lower oil price?
- When the war ends and restocking demand fades, does the sector give back everything except the cash-return names?

How Silicon Valley Took Over the Defense Industry with Peter Arment | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 61

2026-05-25 | WITH PETER ARMENT

THE THESIS

Arment's argument is that a single dinner reshaped the defense industry and its consequences are now reversing. At the Last Supper at the Pentagon on July 21, 1993, the government told roughly 60 prime contractors to consolidate for the peace dividend, and the survivors became enormous, profitable and slow. Now, with defense budgets at a trillion dollars and rising and wars in Iran and Ukraine, an unprecedented wave of venture capital and private equity money that entered between 2020 and 2024 is funding nimble startups that build low-cost, purpose-built systems faster and cheaper than the primes can respond. The result is a share shift away from exquisite platforms, exemplified by the F-35 at 80 million dollars or more per aircraft, toward affordable mass like drones, effectively swinging the industry back toward its pre-1993 structure. In aerospace, Boeing's spend-billions-to-lose-billions-to-make-billions model has been diluted by its capital raise, and the quiet winners are nuclear-exposed suppliers Curtiss-Wright and BWX Technologies, riding both defense demand and commercial reactor life extension.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman pushes on cost and relevance rather than direction. He gets Arment to admit the F-35's real unit cost exceeds Lockheed's quoted 80 million, and the two build the case together that for a customer like Taiwan, with China at most 117 miles away, cheap drones make more sense than a hugely expensive F-35 acquisition. On Boeing, Eisman forces the dilution math into the open: a company once capable of about 40 dollars of free cash flow per share is now headed to about 20 because of the capital raised to repair the balance sheet, which caps the upside even if the story works.

THE NUMBERS

- The industry had about 60 prime contractors in the 1980s; the July 21, 1993 Last Supper dinner at the Pentagon triggered consolidation to a handful
- Defense budgets are around a trillion dollars and going higher

- The F-35 costs at least 80 million dollars each; at 156 aircraft a year the program approaches 2,000 delivered by the early 2030s, more than a third of the total buy
- The longest distance between China and Taiwan is 117 miles, undercutting the case for expensive long-range platforms in that theater
- Boeing roughly doubled the cost of what it expected to spend developing the 787
- Boeing's free cash flow potential has fallen from about $40 per share to about $20 after dilution
- Curtiss-Wright services the installed base of 94 US reactors, an aftermarket business now growing mid teens as plants extend from 40 to 60 to 80 year licenses

WHAT MOVED

Eisman ends where Arment pointed him but with sharper portfolio conclusions: not much to do in the primes, real interest in the nimble drone names like AeroVironment, and a commitment to do his own further work on Curtiss-Wright and BWX Technologies, which he calls the most interesting companies discussed. Arment concedes nothing because Eisman never contested the thesis, only the price tags.

IN THE ARC

The war backdrop that lifted oil in the Brackett episode gets its defense counterpart here, and the episode adds a new instance of a recurring Eisman pattern: government-engineered consolidation creating incumbents too big to pivot, the same overconsolidation critique he applies elsewhere to monopolies like FICO. The nuclear supplier thread also links forward to the AI power constraint discussed with Rasgon, where reactor restarts feed data center demand.

> *"We have to spend billions to lose billions to make billions."*
>
> PETER ARMENT

> *"Lockheed Martin will tell you 80 million. I'll say it's more than that."*
>
> PETER ARMENT

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How much of the trillion-dollar budget actually migrates from the primes to the new defense tech companies, and how fast?
- Do the venture-backed entrants survive a peace settlement in Iran or Ukraine, or does the capital wave recede with the headlines?
- Can the nuclear aftermarket names stay reasonably valued once the market notices the defense plus data center double tailwind?

Inside the Hidden Consumer Crisis with Lakshmi Ganapathi

2026-05-27 | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

THE THESIS

Ganapathi's argument is that the clean consumer credit data is evidence of suppression rather than health. Since 2020 lenders have run extend and pretend, holding borrowers current as long as a minimum payment arrives, which spares the lender from recognizing a default, marking to market or raising provisions, any of which would read as a panic signal. So the gap between reported credit quality and actual household condition keeps widening, and it shows up instead in usage data: buy now pay later funding groceries and rent. Her historical claim is that this is the normal sequence, from Japan in 1987 and 1988 through 2007 and 2008, where a lender breaks first and the consumer appears only as the second order effect. Eisman accepts the mechanism and applies the same denial logic to private credit's software loans.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman opens by pressing her hard with the data. He says he went through nonaccruals with a fine tooth comb for the first time in years, found them flat on both the consumer and commercial books, notes every management flagged it and even Jamie Dimon conceded no issues so far, and insists the numbers are the

numbers. He does not abandon that. He forces her to argue outside the bank data rather than dispute it, and she concedes the surface is clean before arguing the surface is the problem.

THE NUMBERS

- Flat nonaccruals across consumer and commercial books at every reporting bank
- Roughly 45 million buy now pay later users, with 30% to 50% having used it at some point
- 29% of buy now pay later users buying groceries with it, up from 14% two years earlier, and 13% using it for rent
- MUFG seeking to move 2 billion off its book via synthetic risk transfer to insurance companies
- Roughly 11% of private credit loans refinancing next year, rising to 20% after, into software marks down more than half
- Banks funding private credit through warehouse and direct lending, which reaches buy now pay later books through forward flow agreements
- Her short list, FICO, AutoZone and Dorman on invoice factoring and receivables, GPI in used cars, Wingstop and DoorDash

WHAT MOVED

Both sides give ground and meet. Eisman keeps the bank data intact and stops treating it as a verdict on the consumer, and Ganapathi concedes the stress has not surfaced in credit yet. They converge fully on private credit: the software refinancing wall arrives next year, sponsors will either add equity or walk, and until then it is noise.

IN THE ARC

This is the K shaped economy and the private credit thread arriving at the same door. The show has argued for months that headline credit metrics describe the top half of the distribution, and here that argument gets a mechanism, extend and pretend, and a tell, installment plans for groceries. It also links the bank, private credit and insurance chains into one exposure.

> *“The data is clean on the surface. And that's exactly what we consider as a problem.”*
>
> LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

> *“The numbers are the numbers are the numbers.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What breaks extend and pretend, a regulator, a funding cost, or a lender that decides to reserve first?
- If sponsors walk from the software loans rather than adding equity, who ends up holding the companies?

Is AI a Bubble? Gary Marcus on What Could Break the Story | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 62

2026-06-01 | WITH GARY MARCUS

THE THESIS

Marcus's argument runs from cognitive science to unit economics. LLMs are sophisticated next-word predictors that memorize and pattern match but fail under distribution shift, and the hallucination problem he flagged in 2001 remains unsolved despite a quarter century of promises that more data would fix it. Around December 2024 the labs discovered, privately and partly publicly, that scaling was no longer delivering the expected returns, yet capex keeps climbing on FOMO, with single companies spending on the order of 180 billion dollars. The deeper crack is economic: because inference runs on massive GPU fleets in the cloud rather than on hardware users already own, every token has a real cost, and the companies have been serving an all-you-can-eat buffet at slim or negative margins that agents make dramatically worse just as they need clean numbers to IPO. If medium-sized models plus tools and symbolic AI turn out to be the right architecture, the giant data centers may never earn their keep, and the industry collectively cannot

generate the revenue its spending requires.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman mounts the strongest bull rebuttal he can, explicitly through his subprime lens. He points out that Nvidia just reported 85% revenue growth, accelerating from 65% two quarters ago, and says that if he wanted to short this story like he shorted subprime, he could not make the argument right now, because the biggest company on earth is accelerating and its customers, Google, Meta and Amazon, are not stupid people. He then forces the mechanism question: subprime broke when the end investor stopped buying the paper, so what is the analogous switch here? His own candidate is the move to real token pricing, where customers simply refuse to pay; Marcus accepts that as plausible and starts to offer his own scenario just as the free feed cuts to premium.

THE NUMBERS

- Nvidia revenue grew 85% in the latest quarter versus 65% two quarters ago, so the buildout is accelerating, not slowing
- Marcus identified the hallucination problem in 2001 and published on distribution shift in 1998; both remain unsolved
- Scaling returns visibly flattened around December 2024, when labs stopped getting the expected gains from bigger models
- One company is spending about 180 billion dollars on AI infrastructure, which Marcus calls lunacy
- Token-serving margins are slim or negative, and agents multiply usage, so growth deepens the losses
- Agents also consume heavy CPU time alongside GPUs, which is helping Intel and hints that the data center mix bet may be wrong

WHAT MOVED

A genuine partial convergence: Marcus concedes the bull case is a bet with a nonzero chance of paying off, and Eisman concedes he cannot short the story today despite finding the spending incomprehensible. Both agree the resolution test is about a year away, when it becomes clear whether tokens can be priced profitably. Neither yields on the core: Marcus still calls it a low-probability bet, Eisman still refuses to fight 85% revenue growth.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's clearest statement of the AI capex and returns dilemma, sitting directly between the bullish Rasgon semiconductor episode a week later and Eisman's wrap-level warnings that hyperscalers now need public equity markets to fund a trillion dollars of annual capex. It also launches the token pricing and addiction-business-model thread that dominates the June wraps, where Eisman likens subsidized AI usage to Uber-style dependency building.

> *“What I've heard for a quarter century is, oh, Gary, give us a little more data and we'll solve all these problems.”*
>
> GARY MARCUS

> *“I want to short this story like I shorted subprime. I couldn't make that argument right now.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- When token subsidies end and real pricing arrives, do enterprise customers pay up or walk away?
- If medium-sized models plus tools win, who is left holding the depreciation on the giant data centers?
- What is the AI equivalent of the subprime end investor whose exit stops the whole machine?

The AI Semiconductor Boom and What Could End It with Stacy Rasgon | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 63

2026-06-08 | WITH STACY RASGON

THE THESIS

Rasgon argues the AI trade has gone into overdrive since his last appearance seven months ago and is now dragging everything along with it, inside semis and out. Demand for compute is accelerating faster than the exponentially growing supply, which is why rental prices on even old GPUs are rising rather than falling and why he dismisses the depreciation worry: if demand ever falls enough to strand old compute, everything is broken anyway. The bottlenecks have migrated to memory and CPUs, the latter because agentic AI needs heavy CPU time alongside GPUs, and Nvidia has recut its disclosure into hyperscale versus non-hyperscale to reflect where demand lives. The only real long-term risk he sees is that returns on AI disappoint, in which case the whole thing is a shell game with nowhere to hide, but he judges it far too early for that question to bite, so he stays bullish while flagging power, not chips, as the binding constraint, with China able to throw up coal plants while the US resorts to on-site generation and restarting Three Mile Island.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman keeps steering the conversation to the systemic downside, getting Rasgon to spell out that if there is no return on AI, everything comes crumbling down in semis and out of semis, with AI capex cited as roughly 75% of last year's GDP growth and the railroad buildout the only historical comparison by share of the economy. He also drills into the how of the CPU story, making Rasgon explain the GB300 NVL72 rack, 72 GPUs and 36 Grace CPUs, and why agents change the compute mix, and he presses on Intel, where Rasgon stays unimpressed, noting 18A yields near zero at the comparable point and calling the company still not great despite packaging demand and foundry rumors.

THE NUMBERS

- Nvidia reported 85% revenue growth versus 65% two quarters ago, so the buildout is accelerating
- Nvidia's flagship GB300 NVL72 rack carries 72 GPUs and 36 Arm-based Grace CPUs, and agentic AI is raising CPU content per rack
- AI capex was roughly 75% of US GDP growth last year, a share comparable only to the railroad buildout
- Rental prices for older-generation GPUs are rising, not falling, because demand outruns even exponentially growing compute supply
- Nvidia recut its data center disclosure into hyperscale versus non-hyperscale customers
- Intel's 18A yields were close to zero at this point in its life, and hoped-for foundry wins like Apple would start small
- Nvidia the stock is up only 14% this year while memory and CPU bottleneck plays have led the group

WHAT MOVED

Nothing converges because there is little disagreement to start: Eisman ends still bullish alongside Rasgon, noting that the bottleneck stocks have run enormously yet earnings rose faster, so multiples actually contracted. Both hold that disappointing AI returns are the eventual kill switch, and both judge it too early in the story for that to matter now.

IN THE ARC

The bull counterweight to the Gary Marcus episode a week earlier, framed by Eisman's opening line that semis are now the center of the universe the way financials were before 2008. The power constraint and nuclear restart discussion ties back to the Arment episode's reactor suppliers, and the shell game exchange feeds Eisman's June wrap thesis that hyperscalers have become capital-intensive hardware companies asking shareholders to fund the buildout.

> *“If it turns out there's no return on AI, it's all a shell game. Everything's coming crumbling down, in semis and out of semis.”*
>
> STACY RASGON

“The center of the universe right now is semiconductors, because that is where the entire AI infrastructure is being built out.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How would investors actually detect disappointing AI returns before the capex stops, given every current signal is accelerating demand?
- Does the CPU and memory bottleneck trade keep outrunning Nvidia itself, or does leadership rotate back?
- Can the US grid and on-site generation scale fast enough, or does power cap the buildout regardless of chip supply?

Is Private Equity Destroying the Life Insurance Industry? | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 64

2026-06-15 | WITH TOM GALLAGHER

THE THESIS

Booked explicitly as a second opinion after former insurance examiner Tom Gober's alarming earlier interview, Gallagher argues that private equity's takeover of life insurance is riskier than the old model but not recklessly so. Since Apollo bought the platform that became Athene in 2012, followed by KKR's Global Atlantic, Carlyle's Corebridge stake and Blackstone's minority-stake model, the alternative managers have earned roughly 100 basis points more than traditional insurers, whose zero-loss-cost investing he considers overly conservative rather than prudent. He went bond by bond through the top 30 to 40 private credit positions as a gut check and did not find risk that scares him at the big platforms, though he does worry about smaller aggressive sponsors. The industry's real historical wounds came from long-tail products, variable annuities hedging 20 year liabilities with 3 month options and secondary guarantee universal life priced for mid-to-high single digit lapses that ran at 1%, and that distrust is why the sector trades at 3 to 5 times earnings. Offshore reinsurance persists because regulators accommodate it rather than lose jurisdiction entirely.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman pushes twice. First on the regulatory arbitrage: he asks flatly how offshore reinsurance is even allowed, and Gallagher's answer, that punitive regimes accommodate rather than watch companies exit their jurisdiction, leaves the accommodation looking uncomfortably circular. Second and harder on capital return: if these stocks trade at 3 to 5 times earnings, the companies should be buying back stock like crazy, and Gallagher agrees they should but notes even the disciplined ones like Corebridge and Equitable only run buybacks around 8% of market cap a year, while Lincoln must first refinance a preferred costing around 9 to 12% before it can get aggressive in 2027. Eisman openly says he was surprised by Gallagher's comfort with the private equity insurers.

THE NUMBERS

- Private equity's entry began with Apollo's 2012 purchase of a fixed index annuity writer from Aviva that became Athene; Apollo is the biggest player, KKR second via Global Atlantic, bought from Goldman Sachs
- Alternative managers earn about 100 basis points more on portfolios than traditional insurers running zero-loss-cost models
- Gallagher reviewed the top 30 to 40 private credit positions bond by bond as an eye test on the big platforms
- Secondary guarantee universal life assumed mid-to-high single digit lapse rates; actual lapses ran about 1% once rates collapsed
- Parts of the sector trade at 3 to 5 times earnings on decades of distrust from long-tail blowups
- Corebridge and Equitable repurchase roughly 8% of market cap a year; Lincoln is about a year from aggressive buybacks and must deal with a preferred costing around 9 to 12% by 2027

- Apollo and Athene's net interest margins have been squeezed for a couple of years as low-cost liabilities rolled off while retail private credit flows turned negative

WHAT MOVED

Eisman moves, at least partially: he came in primed by Gober's warnings and admits surprise that Gallagher, whom he has known and trusted for decades, is comfortable with the large alternative insurers, reserving his worry for smaller aggressive players. He still concludes there is not much to buy in the public names, but reclassifies the sector from danger zone to essential monitoring post for the broader alternatives complex. Gallagher holds his ground throughout.

IN THE ARC

The deliberate counterweight in the show's private credit arc: Gober prosecuted, Gallagher defends, and Eisman triangulates, consistent with his masterclass thesis that private credit will produce losses but not a 2008 rerun because banks are well capitalized. The retail private credit outflows and spread squeeze Gallagher describes echo the redemption-gate stories Eisman tracks weekly at FSK and Partners Group.

> *"How do you win in a commodity market? You get bigger. You have scale, you have distribution advantages."*
>
> TOM GALLAGHER

> *"People basically just don't trust these companies. And that's why some of these stocks sell at three to five times earnings."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If regulators tolerate offshore reinsurance only to avoid losing jurisdiction, what happens when a Bermuda-sided balance sheet actually breaks?
- Are the smaller alternative-sponsored insurers Gallagher worries about big enough collectively to infect the large platforms?
- Why will managements start buying back stock aggressively at 3 to 5 times earnings when they have declined to for years?

The Lawsuits That Could Change Social Media Forever w/ Ben Zipursky

2026-06-17 | WITH BEN ZIPURSKY

THE THESIS

Zipursky's argument is that the addiction suits against Meta and Google turn entirely on framing. Section 230C has been read extremely broadly for twenty years, protecting platforms even where the content is plainly harmful, so any claim built on what users posted loses. The plaintiffs therefore recast the platform as a defective product whose design knowingly addicts adolescents, which routes around 230 and lands in a body of product liability law that has been expanding since the privity rule collapsed. He separates the theories by strength: negligence and design defect are legally serious, and public nuisance, the theory plaintiffs' lawyers will push hardest, he considers made up but frightening enough to force settlements. His final point is that nothing is settled, because only two cases have been tried and no appellate court has ruled.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman keeps testing whether this is genuinely new, and gets a careful no. Zipursky says it is not unique, there is a sprinkling of cases where 230C fails, but it is huge because it is a mass tort with one plaintiff among 1,800 in a single filing. Eisman also challenges the made up charge directly, asking what he actually means by it, and later pushes on jurisdiction, asking how a global company complies with an American injunction, where Zipursky concedes he does not know. Eisman's final push is the bleakest: is litigation the only route left given frozen legislatures, and Zipursky rejects the premise.

THE NUMBERS

- The Los Angeles verdict against Meta of roughly 6 million dollars, argued as negligence and supported by Zuckerberg testimony about a knowingly addictive model
- That plaintiff being one of 1,800 in her filing, itself one of scores of similar actions nationally
- The Sixth Circuit extending Section 230C to the operator of thedirty.com over user submitted allegations about a Cincinnati woman
- The New Mexico case split in two, a consumer fraud phase tried to a jury and an injunctive phase heard by a judge, with the public nuisance phase beginning in May
- The injunction seeking an actual algorithm redesign to reduce addictiveness, alongside relief Zipursky calls a fake injunction
- The exploding Coke bottle line, where proving the bottle defective suffices without proving negligence in the inspection process
- Zero appellate decisions to date on any of these issues, with every tried case heading up on appeal

WHAT MOVED

Eisman moves and Zipursky holds. Eisman arrives treating the California verdict as a possible inflection and leaves with a much longer time horizon, describing the story as early, multi chapter and unresolved until appeals run. Zipursky holds his split verdict throughout: design defect serious, public nuisance made up, legislation the better road.

IN THE ARC

A rare non financial episode that is still a valuation episode, since an unquantifiable mass tort against the largest platforms is exactly the kind of hidden liability the show hunts for elsewhere in private credit and insurance. It also matches his standing preference for disclosure and rules over litigation as the mechanism that actually changes corporate behaviour.

> *“I think the nuisance theories are kind of made up, but they're so scary that people settle.”*
>
> BEN ZIPURSKY

> *“There hasn't been one appellate decision yet in this country on any of these issues.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does the design defect framing survive the first appellate test, or does Section 230 swallow it back up?
- If New York's unenforced statute gets its regulations written, does legislation overtake the litigation entirely?

The Real State of the American Consumer w/ Three Evercore Analysts | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 65

2026-06-22 | WITH MICHAEL BINETTI, DAVID PALMER, GREG MELICH

THE THESIS

Three Evercore analysts give the K-shaped economy its bottom-up confirmation. Palmer's framing device: restaurant spending divides into equal thirds across households under 50,000, 50,000 to 100,000 and over 100,000, so when the low end retrenches and the middle weakens, the damage is visible immediately, and it is: low-end chains like Wendy's and McDonald's struggle while protein-led high-end concepts like Texas Roadhouse and LongHorn comp around 10 to 11%. Binetti's version in retail is barbell survival, Ralph Lauren and Coach at the top and off-price value at the bottom, with an ocean in the middle that is failing even after the best tax refund season since COVID, while Nike's rushed direct-to-consumer pivot destroyed its competitive intelligence and let rivals in. Melich closes the loop: the housing market is locked by 3 to 4% COVID mortgages, killing Home Depot and Lowe's, while the squeezed middle trades down into Walmart, which has also built same-day delivery of anything to anyone that no one else can match. Legacy packaged

food, skewed against protein in a GLP-1 world, has no end in sight to its decline.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

With three guests, Eisman plays prosecutor for specificity rather than opposition. He runs Binetti through the murderer's row of broken stocks one at a time, Lululemon, Ulta, Gap, Kohl's, Canada Goose, demanding what is actually wrong with each, and he extracts the admission that Nike's problem became the product itself once competitors seized the moment. He forces Palmer to name one or two names he really likes and really dislikes rather than talk categories, and he challenges the housing paradox with Melich, that unlocking the market should mean lower prices yet prices keep rising, which Melich resolves as pure supply shortage against plentiful demand from household formation.

THE NUMBERS

- Restaurant spending splits into roughly equal thirds across income cohorts under $50,000, $50,000 to $100,000, and over $100,000
- This year saw the best tax refund season since COVID, and the middle-income retail cohort still failed to deliver
- LongHorn is comping around 10 to 11% same-store sales growth while Olive Garden struggles, the protein versus non-protein divide in one company
- Nike's direct-to-consumer shift cost it visibility into head-to-head brand choices in multi-brand retail, and a returning veteran is finding the turnaround slow
- Homeowners locked into 3 to 4% COVID mortgages cannot sell against 7% rates, freezing housing turnover and inventory
- Home Depot's growth hope rests on the pro segment and an aging housing stock, not on a housing recovery
- Walmart can now deliver essentially anything to anyone the same day, a capability no competitor matches

WHAT MOVED

Eisman ends by synthesizing rather than conceding: the middle is cracking, which is bad news for the consumer overall but great news for Walmart, and he leaves calling Walmart the big positive story of the episode while writing off packaged food and housing-linked retail entirely. None of the three analysts moves; each holds his subsector read and Eisman adopts all three into his K-shaped framework.

IN THE ARC

The capstone of the show's K-shaped economy thread, giving company-level texture to what Lakshmi Ganapathi's buy now, pay later work and the Walmart and Target wrap commentary had sketched from the top down. The locked housing market analysis extends Eisman's standing housing affordability theme, including his own advice that a home is shelter, not an investment, and the Walmart trade-down story becomes a fixture of his subsequent market commentary.

> *“There's an ocean in the middle that's not doing so well.”*
>
> MICHAEL BINETTI

> *“Everything's a protein world. If you're not on team protein, it's harder for you.”*
>
> DAVID PALMER

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How long can Walmart's gains from middle-class trade-down outrun the overall weakening of the consumer that produces them?
- Is Nike's problem fixable brand execution or a permanent loss of share to structurally stronger competitors?
- What finally unlocks the housing market if neither falling prices nor rising supply is anywhere in sight?

Why Cannabis Rescheduling Changes Everything for Glass House Brands

2026-06-24 | WITH JONATHAN DECOURCY

THE THESIS

Glass House has spent its life as the lowest cost cannabis grower in the world while being legally confined to one state. Schedule I status barred interstate commerce, so the company's cost advantage collided with California's saturated wholesale market and capped realized prices near 200 dollars per pound. Reclassifying medical cannabis to Schedule III opens interstate sales between DEA compliant operators where states agree, and opens export to a European medical market with almost no domestic cultivation. Because the incremental cost of serving those markets is essentially shipping, the price gap between 200 in California and 800 to 1,000 elsewhere converts almost entirely into margin. Eisman's own arithmetic on the follow up episode turns that into a stock worth several times its price.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman does not challenge the growth story so much as force it into numbers. He repeatedly interrupts to pin down concrete figures, making DeCourcy restate that Glass House is the largest cannabis grower in the world, extracting the 80% wholesale split, and pressing on why New York fetches 800 when California fetches 200 until he gets the supply and demand answer. He also presses on the exchange listing question and gets only that discussions are ongoing. His own disclosure runs as a constant hedge: he owns it, he is happy, and he says three times he is not trying to sell it to anyone.

THE NUMBERS

- Medical cannabis reclassified from Schedule I to Schedule III on April 23
- Expedited DEA hearing on recreational cannabis set for June 29, required by law to conclude by mid July
- First quarter revenue of 40.5 million dollars, roughly 80% wholesale
- Production cost near 100 dollars per pound against a California wholesale price around 200
- Average selling price of 800 to 1,000 dollars per pound in other US medical markets
- Capacity of about 1.4 million pounds of biomass with one greenhouse still vacant, versus roughly 700,000 pounds in a normal year
- Curaleaf and TerrAscend uplisted to the TSX on non Schedule I revenue as small as 200,000 dollars per year

WHAT MOVED

Nothing converges because nothing diverged. Eisman came in a shareholder and left more convinced, ending on the claim that operating margins could travel from about 50% toward 80% to 90%. The only ground he concedes is the one he keeps naming himself, that this is speculative, that regulatory hurdles remain, and that anything can happen in cannabis.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's clearest non AI idea, a pure regulatory arbitrage sitting outside the K shaped consumer debate and the capex cycle. It also picks up the exchange access thread, since the same institutional plumbing that shapes who can own a stock shows up wherever Eisman discusses market structure. He returns to it a week later inside his portfolio episode, where the qualitative case becomes a valuation table.

> *“We are the largest cannabis grower in the world.”*
>
> JONATHAN DECOURCY

> *“There are no extra costs here other than shipping. It's just all margin.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does recreational cannabis actually reach Schedule III after the June hearing, and how many states then permit inbound supply?
- Can Glass House fund its expansion without an equity raise that dilutes the margin story?

- Once institutions can buy the stock, does European medical demand absorb California volume at anything close to 1,000 dollars a pound?

The Market's Biggest Warning Signs Right Now with Todd Sohn | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 66

2026-06-29 | WITH TODD SOHN

THE THESIS

Sohn argues that charts are the most efficient summary of what money is actually doing, and right now every chart tells the same story: the market has collapsed into a single tech trade. Information technology alone is about 38% of the S&P 500, and once you add Google and Amazon, which sit outside the official tech sector, the AI complex is well over half the index. Because most funds are market cap weighted, anyone who owns the S&P, Russell 1000 Growth or a thematic fund is stacked with the same handful of names, so index ownership no longer equals diversification. Flows confirm it: money pours into tech ETFs and into the booming leveraged ETF space, industrials only attract money because of the power story, which is tech in another costume, while financials, cyclicals, defensives, gold and Bitcoin see indifference or outflows. His prescription is not to sell but to look under the hood and know how much of one theme you actually own.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman plays translator and stress-tester rather than opponent. He forces Sohn to define RSI and overbought in plain English, makes him defend the claim that a consolidating semiconductor chart is buyable rather than broken, and deliberately tries to construct a bull case for REITs, to which Sohn answers, good luck, before both concede that at under 2% of the S&P the sector is too small for a portfolio manager to care about. On Bitcoin, Eisman offers his own thesis, that the young traders who made it cool have decamped to prediction markets like Kalshi, and Sohn accepts it as a good point.

THE NUMBERS

- Information technology is about 38% of the S&P 500, and with Google and Amazon added the tech complex is well over 50%
- There are roughly 5,000 ETFs, more ETFs than there are listed stocks, though mutual funds still outnumber both
- Leveraged ETFs give two to three times exposure, and leveraged single-stock ETFs did not exist until 2022
- REITs are about 2% or less of the S&P, and the REIT index holds only about 30 stocks
- Flows show money going into industrials on the power story but essentially none into financials
- Money is coming out of both gold and Bitcoin ETFs, leaving a low bar for both assets
- Google's chart still looks good while Meta, Oracle, Microsoft and Amazon charts range from mediocre to bad

WHAT MOVED

No disagreement to resolve; the episode ends with Eisman radicalizing Sohn's flow data into his own darker conclusion. Sohn's parting advice is to know what you own; Eisman closes that if the tech trade ever reverses there will be no place to hide, since even the diversifiers have become the same bet.

IN THE ARC

This is the chart-based version of the argument Torsten Slok makes economically two weeks later in Ep 68: everyone is overindexed to AI whether they know it or not. It also extends the show's running crypto scepticism, with the Kalshi-killed-Bitcoin thesis that resurfaces in the August 14 wrap, and the power-is-just-tech observation that frames the Ben Kallo episode.

> *“Pay attention to what you own. It's a bull market, but you might be loaded up on more exposure than you think.”*
>
> TODD SOHN

“If the stuff ever reverses, there'll be no place to hide.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What level of interest rates or AI disappointment actually triggers the rotation the flow data says nobody is positioned for?
- Is the boom in leveraged and single-stock ETFs a sign of healthy retail participation or late-cycle speculation?
- If financials see no flows despite strong earnings, is that the contrarian bullish setup Sohn hints at?

Steve Eisman Reveals His Personal Portfolio: Every Position Explained

2026-07-01 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

Eisman's method is to buy a story rather than a chart, size it fully at once, and hold until the thesis breaks rather than trade around it. He argues that the AI weighting in his book, seven of 16 names, only looks aggressive until measured against an index that is 37% infotech and closer to 50% counting Google and Amazon. Within AI he is suspicious of the software layer, because price cutting this early implies no moat and the industry already undercharges for tokens, so he prefers the physical bottleneck: power, grid buildout and equipment with multi year backlogs. Around that he holds value names, monopolies and duopolies he calls great franchises, and a small speculative tail. He then makes the whole structure falsifiable by naming four conditions that would force him to rebuild it.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

This is a solo lecture, and the strongest objection is the one he raises against himself. He states that at least 50% of AI spending traces back to Anthropic and OpenAI, that both burn billions and depend on venture funding, that OpenAI is the weaker of the two, and that over 50% of Oracle's data center backlog is tied to OpenAI. He follows it with the admission that this is a guess. He also volunteers mistakes: not buying Cisco alongside Arista, bad timing on Charter and Meritage, and notes that Chris Hohn exited Microsoft entirely while he only trimmed.

THE NUMBERS

- Sixteen long positions across five themes, at the low end of his usual 15 to 30 range after pruning
- Infotech at 37% of the S&P 500, rising toward 50% once Google and Amazon are included
- Over 50% of Oracle's data center backlog tied to OpenAI, per his estimate
- Arista down 14% for insufficiently raising guidance
- GE Vernova at 45 times 2026 EPS estimates, Quanta at 50 times 2026 earnings
- Charter bundling cable and mobile at 100 dollars a month versus 180 to 200 for competitors
- Glass House scenarios at 45%, 55% and 65% EBITDA margins on 500 dollars per pound, yielding 40, 49 and 58 dollars a share against a 13 dollar stock

WHAT MOVED

He does not change position during the episode, but he narrows it. He holds the AI infrastructure names on backlog visibility while explicitly downgrading his confidence in AI software economics, and he keeps Microsoft only in reduced size. The closing conditions are the real movement: data center buildout proving harder than expected, corporates retreating on usage cost, the 10 year holding above 4.5% for more than a few weeks, or a weakening economy opening short opportunities.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's inventory episode, where the running themes become positions. AI capex and returns splits into a bullish hardware and power book and a sceptical software book. Rates enter through his 4.5% trigger and through Meritage, bought near tangible book as housing affordability stays strained. The Glass

House valuation table brings the previous week's regulatory idea into the same portfolio.

> *“If I think I'm right, I take a full position without leveraging up slowly. If I'm wrong, I sell.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“AI might be great for mankind, but it has no or little moats to protect the long-term viability of these franchises.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If OpenAI does hit post IPO trouble, how much of his power and infrastructure book survives the ripple through the backlogs?
- How does he distinguish a broken thesis from bad timing in Charter and Meritage, both of which he says he bought too early?
- Does Microsoft's June 1 move to charge for token use become the industry norm, or does OpenAI price cutting kill it?

Who Wins the Midterms & What It Means for Markets with Dan Clifton | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 67

2026-07-06 | WITH DAN CLIFTON

THE THESIS

Clifton traces everything about the midterms back to April 2, 2025: the tariff announcement was the first moment voters ever turned negative on Trump's handling of the economy, an approval asset that had survived even COVID's 30% GDP contraction. From that break he gets to a likely Democratic House, a genuinely 50/50 Senate, and a Democratic party that, if it wins both chambers, will choose accomplishment over ambition, banking modest healthcare and renewable energy wins to argue for full control in 2028. The same electoral math explains the Fed: Powell is holding his seat through the midterms because if Democrats take the Senate, any successor needs confirmation, which forces Trump toward a mainstream economist and protects the New York Fed, where the balance sheet is run. Finally, he argues data centers are the new fracking, a local-politics fight the industry can win because the tax math overwhelmingly favors host counties.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The sharpest exchange comes when Clifton predicts a moderate Democratic agenda and Eisman stops him cold, arguing the party has moved much further left than people think and directly challenging the premise; Clifton answers with his four-parties framework, two factions inside each party, to explain why the governing wing would still steer outcomes. At the close Eisman also rejects Clifton's read that Trump can end the Iran war soon, countering that Iran does not really want to negotiate, so the war grinds on.

THE NUMBERS

- Trump's approval rating on the economy went negative for the first time after the April 2, 2025 tariff announcement
- The market currently prices about a 50% chance that Democrats win the Senate
- The Fed balance sheet has ballooned to about 6 trillion dollars since the GFC, and Clifton expects Kevin Warsh to shrink it by about 1 trillion over time
- Data centers in Loudoun County, Virginia pay 40% of the county's education bill, and counties with data centers show falling property tax rates and rising home prices
- Clifton's Virginia math: roughly 2,500 dollars a year in property tax savings against perhaps 20 dollars more in electricity costs

- The first Clifton episode aired April 4, 2025, the morning after the tariffs, and the market bottomed about three days later

WHAT MOVED

Eisman accepts the electoral map, split government with a Democratic House, but neither side gives ground on the two live disputes: Clifton holds that a winning Democratic party governs from its moderate wing, Eisman holds his doubt, and on Iran Eisman explicitly says he hopes he is wrong but expects the war to last.

IN THE ARC

This continues the show's banks-and-Fed thread by reframing Fed policy as personnel politics, with Warsh's balance sheet ambitions reappearing in the Slok and Trennert episodes. The data-centers-as-new-fracking thesis gives the political leg of the AI capex story that Kallo covers industrially in Ep 69 and Ives and Luria cover as a PR problem in Ep 70.

> *"Our big thesis is data centers are the new fracking."*
>
> DAN CLIFTON

> *"If you're saying that if the Democrats get both houses they're going to have a moderate agenda, I challenge you on that."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If Democrats do win the Senate, does a confirmation-constrained Fed pick actually change the path of the balance sheet rundown?
- Can the tech industry win the local data center fights before moratoriums spread beyond Virginia?
- Does an unrestrained J.D. Vance campaign help or fracture the Republican field against Newsom's messy Democratic one?

The Bearish Case for Oil and Gold with Queen Anne's Gate Capital

2026-07-08 | WITH KATHLEEN KELLY, NANCY O'FLYNN

THE THESIS

Kelly argues the market has mistaken wartime distortion for tightness. Before the shooting started oil was at 50 and heading to 40, and the surplus that was forecast for this year did not vanish, it was pushed into late this year and next. Meanwhile roughly 5 million barrels per day of new supply arrives next year against demand growth of perhaps 2.5 million even on generous assumptions, the UAE is adding about 1.5 million now that it sits outside OPEC, and China keeps cutting its own demand. US demand looks healthy only because record distillate and jet fuel exports are filling gaps left by China, the Middle East and Russia, and that flow reverses when the war ends. On gold, O'Flynn's point is that the metal already priced the catastrophe in advance, so the catastrophe itself became a selling event.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman tests the downside repeatedly rather than accepting it. He asks how low prices can go, reacts to the answer with visible disbelief, and pushes back on the deflation conclusion by asking whether consumers would actually feel it, drawing the concession that gasoline prices fall but the effect probably arrives after year end. He also questions why cheaper oil would show up in inflation at all when electricity, not oil, now drives the US energy bill, and the guests agree the offset is real. On gold he presses the simplest version: why did it not act the way it is supposed to act.

THE NUMBERS

- Oil in the 70s at recording, with Kelly saying the 20s are easily reachable and Eisman summarizing 40 to 50 as her likelier case
- Roughly 5 million barrels per day of new supply next year against demand growth of about 2.5 million
- The UAE adding around 1.5 million barrels outside OPEC

- Iraq, the producer judged most exposed, saying it can restart within two weeks
- Gold running from about 2,500 to 5,200 over the prior year, then selling off when the feared event occurred
- Crypto's correlation to the Nasdaq at roughly 75%, so it falls on the days it is supposed to hedge
- Kelly's background as a Fed economist, 12 years at Tudor, then Kingdon, plus four years advising the Saudi energy minister

WHAT MOVED

Eisman moves toward the bearish oil case and says so in the afterword, noting explicitly that this is a minority position most people reject and that a resolution should arrive within six to nine months. He does not move on gold because he was never on it, having never owned any in his life, and the guests point him toward silver instead. No one defends crypto, so nothing there is contested.

IN THE ARC

A rare episode where the macro call is deflationary rather than inflationary, which cuts against the Fed and rates thread running through the show. It also lands one more blow on the crypto scepticism theme, this time from commodity specialists rather than from Eisman. And the AI capex story intrudes from the side, since data center electricity demand keeps power prices high even if oil collapses.

> *“There's really not anything that you can come up with that makes this a better situation for oil markets right now.”*
>
> KATHLEEN KELLY

> *“You couldn't find a gold bear anywhere.”*
>
> NANCY O'FLYNN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If the surplus is this visible to specialists, why is positioning still long, and what unwinds it first?
- Does 40 dollar oil actually reach US consumers as disinflation, or do data center driven electricity prices cancel it?
- Does silver hold up if gold keeps unwinding, or does the industrial bid go with it?

AI Dominates Economy and Markets with Torsten Slok | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 68

2026-07-13 | WITH TORSTEN SLOK

THE THESIS

Slok decomposes roughly 2% US GDP growth into three unusual engines: a full percentage point from the AI spending boom, including data centers, energy and the wealth effect on high-end consumption, about 0.3 points from the industrial renaissance of reshored chips, pharma and defense, and roughly 0.9 points from one-off big beautiful bill tax refunds. Because growth comes from these sources rather than traditional rate-sensitive sectors, housing and autos can stay weak while the economy stays strong, and the Fed has little reason to cut. That mix produces a K-shaped economy along three separate axes, wealth, wage growth and inflation exposure, with the bottom of the distribution losing on all three. The kicker is a diversification illusion: with AI dominating the equity indexes and AI data center debt flooding fixed income, a 60/40 portfolio is overindexed to AI on both sides, and software companies with 2021 to 22 vintage debt face a maturity wall in 2028 and 29 if rates stay high.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman probes rather than disputes, and mostly sharpens the numbers: he forces the arithmetic that half of this year's growth is pure AI spending, presses Slok on whether the industrial renaissance is real given prior guests shrugged at it, and Slok concedes it adds only 0.3 points against AI's full point. Eisman also pushes the tangent that the tax refund leg disappears next year, implying sub 2% baseline growth in 2027, and

tests Slok on why China would not weaponize its Treasury holdings, drawing the answer that crashing US demand would crash Chinese exports.

THE NUMBERS

- AI spending contributes about 1 percentage point of roughly 2% GDP growth, a single-sector contribution bigger than housing ever managed
- The industrial renaissance adds about 0.3 points to GDP, with the ISM improving over the last five to six months
- About 90 basis points of growth comes from big beautiful bill tax refunds that will not repeat next year
- Atlanta Fed data shows lower wage growth at the bottom of the income distribution, and New York Fed data shows higher effective inflation there
- Software debt vintages originated in 2021 and 22 carry seven-year maturities, creating a refinancing wall in 2028 and 29
- Federal debt to GDP is around 100% and on a path toward 175%

WHAT MOVED

Broad agreement deepens into a shared warning. Slok holds his structurally strong but AI-dependent read of the economy, Eisman adopts the overindexation point as the episode's takeaway and pushes it further: the AI story better work, because if it does not, the losses across both stocks and bonds will be mammoth.

IN THE ARC

This is the macro anchor of the show's summer 2026 AI arc, quantifying the K-shaped economy theme Eisman has run since the healthcare series and giving the economic scaffolding for the July 10 wrap's claim that diversification no longer exists. The software maturity wall lands exactly where the private credit worries of Ep 72 and the SaaSpocalypse debate of Ep 70 converge.

> *“Normally GDP growth is at two, and now 1% is coming from the AI spending boom alone.”*
>
> TORSTEN SLOK

> *“This AI story better work, because if it doesn't, the losses people are going to experience are going to be mammoth.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What replaces the 90 basis points of tax refund growth when it lapses in 2027?
- Can heavily indebted software companies survive the 2028 to 29 maturity wall if Warsh keeps rates high?
- Is there any practical way for an ordinary investor to be diversified when both equities and credit are indexed to AI?

Beyond Ozempic: The Next Wave of Biotech Winners with Boris Peaker

2026-07-15 | WITH BORIS PEAKER

THE THESIS

Peaker's argument is that biotech's investment map is drawn by economics, not by science. The old technical divide between pharma small molecules and biotech biologics has dissolved, since Pfizer, Merck, Roche and Lilly can now build anything a small company can, leaving size as the only real distinction. What remains is a division of labor: small firms carry drugs toward the finish line and large firms buy them and commercialize, so the recycling of capital through acquisitions is what funds the sector. Within that structure, capital flows to oncology because efficacy reads out fast, prescribers adopt anything marginally better for dying patients, and safety tolerance is high. Fields that lack that economics, notably antibiotics and aging, stay underfunded no matter how badly the drugs are needed.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman pushes on whether the celebrated wins are actually wins. Told that Revolution's pancreatic drug takes median survival from about 6 months to about 13, and that this is scientifically impressive, he answers that you are still only living for 13 months. He also presses the aging question hard, proposing that not ageing is itself the endpoint, and Peaker refuses it: the FDA needs a measurable functional endpoint like muscle strength, and biological age is not one. On AI in drug discovery Peaker volunteers his own scepticism, saying the gains are marginal against the real cost driver of running clinical trials, and noting that enthusiasm often tracks whose paycheck depends on it.

THE NUMBERS

- Genentech treated as the first biotechnology company, founded in the late 1970s
- University and hospital administrative overhead of 30% to 40% charged on top of trial costs
- Revolution's pancreatic cancer drug extending survival from about 6 months to about 13
- A German lupus study holding B cells undetectable for three to four months, after which autoantibody producing cells largely did not return
- A typical tumor carrying several hundred mutations, which is why single mechanism attacks fail
- Grapefruit blocking a liver enzyme pathway and disrupting many drugs, an uncontrolled variable in large trials
- Eli Lilly described as having conquered the GLP-1 world, with the next wave aimed at preserving muscle mass lost during weight loss

WHAT MOVED

Eisman moves from stated ignorance to a working framework and says so, calling it educational and admitting he learned a ton. What actually changed is his model of failure: he now attributes the Phase 1 to Phase 3 collapse to patient curation rather than to bad science. Peaker does not move at all, because nothing he says is contested on the facts. Neither ends with a stock recommendation.

IN THE ARC

The longest episode in the batch and the show's second sector tutorial in the healthcare arc that began with the UnitedHealth work. It sits apart from the AI capex debate except where Eisman probes whether AI shortens drug development, and Peaker's answer, marginal at best, is a quiet data point against the everything is transformed narrative.

> *"You're still only living for 13 months."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *"The nirvana for a biotech stock is to have a drug and get it pretty close to the finish line and then have a big pharma take you out."*
>
> BORIS PEAKER

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If B cell reset works across autoimmune disease, which companies capture it and which get bought?
- What would make antibiotic development commercially viable, given the drug of last resort trap?
- Does GLP-1 muscle preservation create a durable franchise, or a feature Lilly folds into its own products?

AI Has a Power Problem: Why the U.S. Power Grid Can't Keep Up | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 69

2026-07-21 | WITH BEN KALLO

THE THESIS

Kallo argues that the binding constraint on the entire AI story is no longer chips but electricity and the physical grid, and that the strain predates the data centers now grabbing attention: his own Midtown office

already gets curtailment notices on hot days, before any gigawatt-scale data center has even been built. The buildout runs through long, unglamorous pipelines, gas turbines ordered today are not installed at a utility until 2030 or 31, air permits alone take about six months, and high-voltage electrification equipment is scarce, which gives companies like GE Vernova visibility deep into the 2030s and makes nuclear a real but post-2035 earnings story. Grid-scale batteries are the fastest-growing piece, with Tesla's megapack business compounding over 30% a year. On the demand-and-vehicles side he is selective: positive on Tesla via autonomy and a likely SpaceX acquisition, positive on Rivian's cheaper R2, and negative on residential solar, whose door-to-door economics cannot survive 10,000 dollar customer acquisition costs. The final constraint he flags is labor, whether the US can physically staff everything it has committed to build.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman keeps dragging the conversation from stories to mechanics, summarizing Kallo's turbine timeline as, so you don't build this stuff like tiddlywinks, which Kallo confirms. He also airs the irrational extremes of the substack debate, including the claim that no data centers are being built at all, and asks Kallo to adjudicate. The one open clash is Tesla: Kallo's bull case rests on autonomous vehicles, and Eisman flatly refuses it, noting Musk has promised autonomy for a decade and counting himself a sceptic, while letting Kallo's SpaceX-buys-Tesla call stand as a prediction to monitor.

THE NUMBERS

- The US is adding on the order of 30 gigawatts of power per year, which Eisman likens to building a couple of cities' worth of demand
- A gas turbine ordered this quarter will not be built and installed at a utility until about 2030 or 2031
- Environmental air permits for new plants take about six months even with federal CO2 rules gone, since hyperscalers keep their own targets
- Tesla's megapack grid battery business is growing over 30% a year on the top line, with plants in California, Texas and Shanghai
- Residential solar carries customer acquisition costs of about 10,000 dollars per household
- Rivian's next-generation R2 SUV targets a price of roughly 40 to 45 thousand dollars
- GE Vernova's nuclear business is unlikely to matter to earnings until at least 2035

WHAT MOVED

Eisman fully adopts the power-constraint frame and the long-tailed turbine economics, but the Tesla disagreement ends unresolved: Kallo holds his autonomy-plus-SpaceX thesis, Eisman holds his decade-of-broken-promises scepticism, and both flag labor supply as the next thing to watch.

IN THE ARC

This is the physical-infrastructure leg of the AI capex theme, one ring out from the semiconductor center of the universe Eisman explored with Stacy Rasgon, and the industrial counterpart to Clifton's data-centers-as-new-fracking politics in Ep 67. The multi-year turbine and permitting lags also give the AI trade its long fuse, context for why Eisman keeps saying the capex reckoning is a story for later, not tomorrow.

> *“There haven't really been gigawatt data centers built yet.”*
>
> BEN KALLO

> *“Elon's been promising that for 10 years. Count me a skeptic.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can the US find enough skilled labor to build the plants, turbines and transmission it has already ordered?
- If gigawatt data centers have not even arrived yet, how much worse does grid stress get when they do?
- Does SpaceX actually buy Tesla, and does that resolve or deepen the governance questions around Musk?

Payments Industry - Fear and Reality

2026-07-22 | WITH KEN SUCHOSKI

THE THESIS

Suchoski's report separates what agentic AI is doing in payments from what investors fear it will do. Today agents handle discovery, search and comparison, while the payment itself is still executed by a human, and even the automated end of the spectrum is nothing more novel than a recurring subscription. Any real agentic commerce still needs what cards already supply, chargeback protection, rewards and universal merchant acceptance, and building that from scratch faces the two sided adoption problem that has killed every challenger network. So agentic payments will most likely run over the existing rails rather than around them, which is exactly what Visa and MasterCard are arranging by partnering with stablecoin issuers. Suchoski adds that some of the selling is not even an opinion on payments, it is investors raising cash to fund faster growing AI names.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman is the more sceptical party and pushes past Suchoski's careful framing to blunter conclusions. On stablecoins he lets the logic stand and then demands proof, calling adoption glacial and answering the argument with show me the money. On agentic rails he interrupts to explain the consumer protection point himself before Suchoski can, arguing any new rail must replicate what Visa, MasterCard and American Express provide or nobody will use it. He also stops the conversation to explain to listeners that shorting as a source of funds is not the same as a bearish view, and he closes harder than his guest, dismissing Fiserv outright.

THE NUMBERS

- Bitcoin falling from roughly 120,000 near its October peak to about 65,000, hurting stablecoin volumes tied to digital asset trading
- Most stablecoin usage still tied to bouncing in and out of crypto positions rather than payments
- Visa and MasterCard partnering with stablecoin issuers so wallet holders can spend over existing rails
- PayPal still charging premium pricing after Apple Pay and others matched its checkout experience
- Toast hit as both a payments and a software name, plus rising memory chip costs, while Micron revenue grows around 200% year over year
- Fiserv losing a CEO after only a year, with roughly 20 billion dollars of debt mentioned in the same stretch
- The whole group trading down together despite a 2021 stretch when everything went up

WHAT MOVED

Neither moves much, and they converge because they started close. Suchoski stays measured, framing agentic disruption as early and card stickiness as real. Eisman hardens into a rule: only Visa and MasterCard are ownable long term, everything else is a trade. Stablecoins are where he moves most, downgrading them from an interesting growth story to disappointing, and he keeps Fiserv permanently out with a 10 foot pole.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's crypto scepticism and AI disruption threads meeting in one sector. It also inverts the usual AI trade: here AI is not the thing being bought, it is the fear that repriced everything else, and the flows out of payments fund the AI names Eisman holds in his own portfolio. The stablecoin verdict is his most concrete test yet of whether crypto infrastructure ever leaves the trading loop.

> *“Great thesis. Wonderful. Show me the money.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“There's habit, there's rewards, and then you have protections.”*
>
> KEN SUCHOSKI

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What evidence would show agents actually executing payments rather than assembling carts?
- If cross border B2B is the strongest stablecoin case, what is the specific blocker keeping adoption glacial?
- Does the source of funds selling reverse if AI names stall, and does that lift the whole group regardless of fundamentals?

The AI Revolution: Who Wins, Who Loses & the SaaSpocalypse | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 70

2026-07-27 | WITH DAN IVES, GIL LURIA

THE THESIS

Luria frames the two live debates: whether the data center buildout ever earns a return on the capital pouring into it, and whether anyone in AI has a moat. His answer is that open source eats most of the stack, companies will pay OpenAI or Anthropic for mission-critical work and run free open-source models for everything else, so value accrues to businesses with distribution and infrastructure, Microsoft wins on data centers plus insurmountable Office franchises, Salesforce loses because it stopped investing and just raises prices, and Google is a winner but not the winner, bleeding key researchers to OpenAI. The Oracle episode is his cautionary tale: a backlog jump from 150 to 450 billion dollars in a day turned out to be one deal with an OpenAI that had no money and 1.1 trillion dollars of further commitments. Ives stays the bull: the US leads China in tech for the first time in 30 years, AI creates more jobs than it destroys, cybersecurity budgets double as every agent expands the attack surface, and the industry's real wound is a self-inflicted PR problem of promising to wipe out white-collar jobs while raising electricity bills.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman announces the structure himself: let me press you both on three counterarguments, capital intensity that has crushed free cash flow, the possibility that there are no moats, and a coming price war as corporations experiment with much cheaper Chinese models. The guests answer that scale itself becomes the moat as hyperscaler data centers compound, but Eisman does not fully buy it, saying in his close that he still has doubts about whether Anthropic or OpenAI have any moat at all, and that the wealth may accrue to the supply chain instead.

THE NUMBERS

- Oracle's backlog jumped from 150 to 450 billion dollars in a single day, later revealed as one OpenAI deal
- Beyond its roughly 300 billion dollar Oracle commitment, OpenAI made about 1.1 trillion dollars of additional commitments without the capital to fund them
- Oracle traded around 350 intraday at the peak of the backlog euphoria before the market reassessed
- Cybersecurity budgets are expected to roughly double over the next two to three years as AI agents multiply the attack surface
- A Google researcher described as one of the inventors of modern AI has left for OpenAI, evidence of Google's internal bureaucracy problem
- Google sits a distant second in consumer chat and roughly third in enterprise AI, a winner but not the winner

WHAT MOVED

The guests remain long-term bulls but openly concede what would have been unthinkable a year earlier: the debate now has a respectable bear case built on capital intensity, missing moats and price war risk. Eisman ends persuaded on the breadth of supply chain wealth creation, unpersuaded on model-company moats, and both sides agree to reconvene in the fall because the thesis changes weekly.

IN THE ARC

This is the centerpiece of the show's AI capex and returns theme, giving names and mechanisms to the SaaSpocalypse Eisman tracks weekly through ServiceNow, IBM and Equifax in the wraps. The Oracle-OpenAI circularity story becomes the show's standing exhibit for what a reckoning looks like, echoed in the August 14 wrap's claim that everything hinges on Anthropic and OpenAI.

“For the first time in 30 years, the US is ahead of China when it comes to tech.”

DAN IVES

“They made an additional 1.1 trillion dollars of commitments without having any money.”

GIL LURIA

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If open source takes everything but mission-critical workloads, what revenue base ever justifies the model companies' commitments?
- Do hyperscaler data centers really constitute a moat, or just a shared cost of staying in the game?
- How quickly could cheap Chinese models turn subsidized token pricing into a full price war?

The Real Estate Brokerage War, For-Profit Education, & the Art of the Short with Brad Safalow

2026-07-29 | WITH BRAD SAFALOW

THE THESIS

Safalow argues the residential brokerage industry looks chaotic but has barely changed where it counts. Commissions still sit at 5 to 5.2 percent, for sale by owner share has not moved, and the brokerage value proposition is still marketing, technology, back office and brand. The real fight is over the MLS itself, where Compass is pushing private listings and building a national MLS equivalent it would steer, and where states are now legislating against it faster than the industry can move. He stays long Zillow on the view that it remains ground central for the whole ecosystem even after a violent re-rating. On the short side he reads for-profit education as structurally impaired by fewer high school students, the loss of Grad Plus, and AI collapsing the cost of educational content, and he updates three single name shorts where the thesis is deterioration nobody has marked yet.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman keeps dragging the conversation out of the weeds and back to mechanics, stopping Safalow to define MLS, private listings and FSBO before letting the argument continue. He tests the disruption story directly and gets Safalow to concede a lot of noise and not a lot of change. In the wrap he splits from his guest in one place, saying Compass's attempt to circumvent the MLS does not sound successful while noting that Safalow, who owns the pain, still likes Zillow after the stock hurt him.

THE NUMBERS

- National commission steady between 5 and 5.2 percent, split roughly 2.5 percent to each side, with brokers returning about 80 percent to the agent
- Roughly 500 MLSs in the country, which Safalow says is far too many
- Washington's private listing ban taking effect and Connecticut proposing rules, both within four to eight weeks of taping
- Transaction volume expected in high single digits to low double digits for the year
- The One Big Beautiful Bill Act eliminating Grad Plus, which let graduate students borrow to cost of attendance
- Costco going from zero to more than 10 percent of Fresh Pet revenue between 2022 and 2025, with Costco and Walmart the sole sources of growth
- Kinsale trading at three and a half to four times book with earnings estimates Safalow believes are 40 to 60 percent too high

WHAT MOVED

Nothing converges and nothing needs to. Safalow holds Zillow long and all three prior shorts, Eisman accepts the short cases and records his own doubt about Compass's ability to route around the MLS, and

both end where they started on for-profit education being uninvestable on the long side.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's housing affordability thread approached through the plumbing rather than the price. It also sits inside the running AI capex and returns argument, since Safalow reads Google's spending as a scorched earth bid to outlast Meta and Microsoft while being short the stock, and inside Eisman's habit of treating industries run by bad people as a permanent short bias.

> *"It's a stock that I've been recommending, and it's been nothing short of a disaster for me personally."*
>
> BRAD SAFALOW

> *"So a lot of noise, not a lot of change."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If state legislatures keep banning private listings, does Compass have a business model left that is not leverage?
- What breaks the Trupanion spiral other than repricing an aging book that cannot be regrown?
- Does AI lower the cost of educational content enough to impair non-profit higher education too, and what is the tradable expression?

250 Years of American Capitalism: Hamilton, the GFC, & the AI Boom | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 71

2026-08-03 | WITH ADRIAN WOOLDRIDGE

THE THESIS

Wooldridge, Alan Greenspan's co-author on Capitalism in America, argues the through-line of US economic history is that America embraced creative destruction on a bigger scale and with more enthusiasm than any other country. The preconditions were structural: a massive internal market, a constitution that constrains government and frees markets, and a self-selected population wired toward ambition, all built on Hamilton's victory over Jefferson, including the infant-industry tariffs that let American manufacturing grow strong enough to face Britain. The busts are part of the same machine, and policy can make them worse: the Depression deepened partly because the roughly six-month Hoover-to-FDR handover left the country effectively without a government mid-calamity, and before the GFC finance had become untethered from the real economy, self-serving and absorbing too much talent and capital. His closing ledger is optimism about a culture where genius expresses itself by building companies, set against political instability, creeping corporatism and unnecessary corporate concentration.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The real collision is over the GFC. Eisman extracts the admission that Greenspan wrote the book's GFC section entirely solo, then asks what Greenspan believed caused the crisis; the answer, that Greenspan mostly blamed Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac, is exactly the exculpatory account Eisman spent his career against, and he says on air that he disagrees, locating the cause in the excess leverage Greenspan himself allowed into the banking system.

THE NUMBERS

- The book is Capitalism in America by Alan Greenspan and Adrian Wooldridge, revisited for the 250th anniversary of the Declaration of Independence
- Hamilton's infant-industry tariff argument was later adopted by Germany, and protected industries in both countries grew into dominant ones
- The Hoover-to-FDR transition took about six months, leaving no effective government in the middle of the Depression

- Greenspan wrote the book's Great Financial Crisis section solo and placed most blame on Fannie Mae and Freddie Mac
- Wooldridge and Greenspan argue pre-GFC finance had become self-serving, absorbing too much of the economy's talent and investment
- Wooldridge's worry list for America: political instability, creeping corporatism, politicians interfering with business, and excessive corporate concentration

WHAT MOVED

Nothing converges on the GFC: Wooldridge faithfully reports Greenspan's Fannie-and-Freddie account, Eisman states his leverage counter-thesis and lets the disagreement stand, while warmly recommending the book. The shared ground is the creative destruction frame, which Eisman clearly enjoys as history and as an implicit argument about the AI boom.

IN THE ARC

A deliberate step back from the weekly AI grind, this episode gives the show its longest lens: booms, busts and infant industries as the normal metabolism of American capitalism, with obvious echoes for the AI capex debate and Eisman's own reading-is-my-superpower theme from the July wraps. The GFC exchange is also the series' most direct confrontation between Eisman's Big Short history and the official Greenspan account.

> *"In America, an expression of genius is to build a great company, and to keep that great company going."*
>
> ADRIAN WOOLDRIDGE

> *"I think it was much more to do with the excess leverage that Greenspan allowed into the banking system."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If busts are the price of creative destruction, which kind of bust does the AI buildout most resemble, railroads, housing or something new?
- Does today's corporate concentration break the historical pattern of American turnover that Wooldridge credits for its dynamism?
- Would Greenspan's Fannie-and-Freddie account of the GFC survive the disclosure standards Eisman demands of companies today?

Streaming Hits Hollywood Hard: Here's Why with Producer Peter Hoffman

2026-08-05 | WITH PETER HOFFMAN

THE THESIS

Eisman's frame is a margin story. Television and film used to earn twice, once on first run and again on repeated syndication sales, and the incumbents traded that away by selling their libraries to Netflix until Netflix could fund its own hits. Streaming replaced it with a structurally lower margin business that supports only a handful of players, and it is already maturing. Hoffman supplies the production side of the same collapse: independents once financed films on presales against foreign rights and presaleable talent, which let them make pictures the studios would not, and that financing machinery is gone. What remains is a small set of proven creators who get funded and everyone else who does not.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman does not argue with Hoffman so much as press him on the unanswerable. He asks why Angel Heart failed despite being, in his own account, so good he and his friends walked out speechless, and whether film outcomes can be predicted at all. Hoffman refuses the flattering answer and says nobody knows. Eisman also presses on why Neuromancer resisted Hoffman for nearly 15 years and Apple could simply make it,

forcing the plain answer that Apple has the money and does not need to presell anything.

THE NUMBERS

- Netflix earnings per share growth of 11 percent in the most recent quarter against 47 percent in the second quarter of 2025, with the stock down 25 percent on the year
- Disney's share price back where it sat in late 2014, about 12 years of no return
- AMC at roughly 10 dollars against 80 dollars ten years earlier
- Prime Video at about 2 percent of Amazon revenue, YouTube at about 15 percent of Google
- Hoffman stopping a James Cameron picture at 30 days over schedule, and the rule that a director who shot 90 percent of a film cannot remove his credit
- New Orleans film production falling from about 1.2 billion dollars in the year of Hoffman's indictment to about 200 million the next year, with Georgia now at about 2 billion

WHAT MOVED

Nothing moves, because the two are describing the same decline from opposite ends. Eisman keeps the financial frame that streaming is a maturing lower margin business, Hoffman keeps the craft frame that the financing that funded risk is gone, and neither disputes the other.

IN THE ARC

One of the show's clearest illustrations of a K-shaped outcome inside a single industry: Netflix and the balance sheet buyers on one side, everyone dependent on presales on the other. It also serves as Eisman's standing warning about incumbents monetizing an asset today at the cost of the franchise, and it sets up the Paramount and Warner Bros thread he returns to three weeks later.

> *“We will hang the capitalists with the rope they will sell us.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“Apple is like the studios. They have the money. They decide to make it. They spend the money.”*
>
> PETER HOFFMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If streaming supports only a few players, which of the legacy transitions gets abandoned rather than completed?
- Does anything replace presale financing for films that lack presaleable talent, or does that category simply stop existing?
- How much of a state's production base is really policy-driven rather than sticky, given how fast New Orleans emptied into Georgia?

Private Credit's Clock is Ticking w/ Glenn Schorr & Ken Worthington | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 72

2026-08-10 | WITH GLENN SCHORR, KEN WORTHINGTON

THE THESIS

Recorded the morning after Microsoft soared and Meta cratered, the conversation builds a two-speed picture of financial services. In private markets, monetization timelines have stretched enormously, roughly seven years even with record equity markets and a better IPO window, some sponsors have already handed lenders the keys rather than inject more equity, and the real test of private credit's software overexposure only arrives with next year's refinancing wall, when much lower valuations meet maturing debt. Meanwhile the public side is humming: trading thrives on disagreement, and banks and brokers are printing records. Worthington adds the digital layer: blockchains and tokens proliferate, venues like Coinbase benefit, and stablecoins plausibly become the settlement layer for 24/7 trading, but agentic AI money management is

premature because internal studies show the agents are wrong most of the time, telling investors what they want to hear.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The sharpest moment is Eisman's Bitcoin cross-examination: after Worthington lays out the token proliferation thesis, Eisman grants every word of it and then asks, twice, what any of it has to do with owning Bitcoin, and Worthington has no strong answer. Eisman is also openly more negative on private credit than either guest, and he flips their good news at the end, noting that when everything in the investment banks is humming is precisely when he starts to worry.

THE NUMBERS

- Microsoft rose over 10% on results while Meta fell about 10% on 28% revenue growth against 55% expense growth
- Situational Awareness, a 20 billion dollar hedge fund run by a former OpenAI employee, was liquidated after leveraged AI losses
- Private equity monetization timelines have lengthened dramatically, even as KKR posted record monetizations in the same quarter
- In extreme cases sponsors have handed the keys to lenders rather than put fresh equity into struggling software borrowers
- Equity trading revenues rose about 68% on volume growth of only 9 to 10%, with margin balances up about 50%
- Internal studies at JP Morgan found AI agents managing money are wrong the majority of the time, echoing user prompts rather than optimizing portfolios

WHAT MOVED

Worthington effectively concedes the Bitcoin point, holding his blockchain infrastructure thesis while admitting he lacks a case for the coin itself. On private credit, nobody moves: the guests stay constructive, Eisman keeps his doubts, and all three agree the verdict waits for the software refinancings early next year.

IN THE ARC

This is the show's most direct treatment of its private credit theme, putting a date, early next year's software refinancing wall, on the risk Slok quantified via debt vintages in Ep 68. The Bitcoin exchange extends the running crypto scepticism from the Circle collapse coverage and the Kalshi thesis, and the humming-banks unease sets up Verrone's new-highs observation in Ep 73.

> *“When everybody agrees on something, trading's not going to be so good.”*
>
> GLENN SCHORR

> *“I grant you everything you just said. Everything. What's that got to do with Bitcoin?”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How many software borrowers survive next year's refinancings when lenders demand fresh equity at today's lower valuations?
- If AI agents are wrong most of the time managing money, what has to change before banks let them touch client cash?
- Can stablecoins become the settlement layer for 24/7 trading without Visa and Mastercard controlling the rails?

Why the Iran War Is Stuck & What Comes Next with Steven Cook

2026-08-12 | WITH STEVEN COOK

THE THESIS

Cook argues the war produced a massive tactical success and a strategic dead end. Israel decapitated the Iranian leadership in the opening minutes, which removed both the target set and the counterparty the president hoped to pluck out and deal with. Iran had spent the nine months since the earlier strikes dispersing missiles and decentralizing command and control, so heavy damage did not stop it firing at Israel and then at the Gulf states, and the Strait blockade turned a military campaign into an economic one the president would not pay for. Because the regime prioritizes survival over the economy, the pressure that was supposed to force capitulation simply does not bite. Cook's forecast is continuation: low level violence in the Strait, intermittent bombing, and no negotiation.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman refuses the diplomacy premise. He sets the Strait aside as technically solvable and puts the real question as nuclear fuel, then asks why anyone would believe an Iranian signature on paper. Cook does not defend the deal, answering that he does not know and pointing back to the same doubt that surrounded the 2015 agreement. Eisman also pushes Cook to name what kind of regime accepts economic collapse, and Cook accepts the framing that this is not a normal regime.

THE NUMBERS

- 40 of Iran's top leaders killed in the first minutes of the Israeli operation
- Nine months between the June 2025 Operation Midnight Hammer and the later Israeli campaign, used to distribute missile capability and decentralize command
- Iranian strikes on the UAE, Saudi Arabia, Qatar and Oman, including Dubai Airport, data centers and Amazon web services facilities
- The president calling off the campaign in early April, with the Strait of Hormuz still closed at taping on July 28
- Israeli withdrawal from two Lebanese villages handed to the Lebanese armed forces under a United States monitored framework
- Cook seeing no woman on a 2002 trip to Saudi Arabia until he sat outside a Riyadh Prada on his last day

WHAT MOVED

Nothing shifts, and both say so. Cook holds that the stalemate persists and predicts the same conversation in three or four months, Eisman ends agreeing that things will be ugly for a while because Iran wants power rather than a deal.

IN THE ARC

Iran is the macro overhang the Weekly Wrap has carried for months, and this is Eisman's attempt to price the geopolitics rather than react to headlines. A closed Strait feeds straight into the energy and inflation questions that govern his read on the Fed, and Cook's Gulf detail, including strikes on data centers and cloud facilities, ties the war to the AI buildout the show tracks elsewhere.

> *“As long as the leadership remained in power and alive, that's all that they really cared about.”*
>
> STEVEN COOK

> *“Why would you trust the Iranians at all on that subject?”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What actually reopens the Strait if neither escalation nor negotiation has moved it since April?
- Can a nuclear agreement be verified at all once the officials who would sign it have been killed?
- Does the Lebanon framework survive first contact with Hezbollah refusing to disarm?

The AI Trade, Rising Rates, and Why the Market Is Still Standing | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 73

2026-08-17 | WITH JASON TRENNERT, CHRIS VERRONE

THE THESIS

Trennert sees a gathering storm, war, resurgent tariffs, the hyperscaler capex debate and a Fed remaking itself under Warsh, and worries chiefly about concentration in the top ten names. Verrone answers with the internals: even as the index churned for eight weeks and semis corrected, the share of S&P stocks above their 200-day average rose from about 50% in early June to 75%, a rotational tape that keeps repairing itself. Their old rule that a 4.5% ten-year would pull money out of equities has simply failed, so the threshold must be higher than most people think, and until yields find it the bull market stands. Around that core they argue private credit was largely a regulatory arbitrage against Dodd-Frank-constrained banks, that traditional asset managers now outperform private equity stocks as the zero-rate subsidy unwinds, and that worldwide bank stocks at new highs are inconsistent with an imminent crisis. The Warsh Fed's retreat from forward guidance means more volatility, which Trennert regards as healthy discipline rather than danger.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman keeps demanding the number: if 4.5% on the ten-year did not break the market, what does, and Verrone concedes he can only say higher than most people think. Eisman pushes Verrone for a verdict on Meta's ugly quarter and gets a candid no strong view, just the reminder that the stock's 2022 collapse is what forced Zuckerberg to change course. He also draws out the tension in their own bullishness, that private equity was the single greatest beneficiary of zero rates, seven-year monetization timelines and all, yet the market is being led by the traditional managers instead.

THE NUMBERS

- About 50% of S&P stocks were above their 200-day average on June 2 versus 75% at recording, improvement during a churning tape
- The old assumption that a 4.5% ten-year yield would pull money from equities has failed, and the true threshold is unknown but higher
- Private equity monetization timelines now run about seven years
- Regulated utilities have traded poorly all year despite the AI power theme running through the sector
- Meta bottomed near 90 dollars in late 2022 before Zuckerberg reversed course on metaverse spending
- Money managers from State Street to T. Rowe to Invesco are leading the asset management group, outperforming private equity stocks

WHAT MOVED

Eisman comes away more constructive than he arrived: his stated takeaway is that the economy is quite strong, and that absent a much bigger yield spike or an AI breakdown, Trennert and Verrone are effectively bullish through year-end. The guests hold their one confession of ignorance, nobody knows the rate that finally matters, and Trennert holds his welcome-the-volatility read of the Warsh Fed.

IN THE ARC

The season-closing temperature check before the two-week break, it stitches together the show's threads: the concentration risk from the Sohn episode, the private credit as regulatory arb argument that complements Ep 72, and the banks and Fed theme now centered on Warsh killing forward guidance. Verrone's every-bank-at-new-highs observation directly answers the crisis-hunting instinct Eisman confessed to in the July 17 wrap.

> *“I can't think of too many times where you're on the verge of a big problem and every bank stock is at new highs.”*
>
> CHRIS VERRONE

“I can't think of an industry that benefited more from near zero percent interest rates than private equity.”

JASON TRENNERT

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What ten-year yield finally makes bonds compelling enough to break the equity market's internals?
- Is the rotation beneath the index genuine broadening or just the AI theme migrating between sectors?
- Does a Fed without forward guidance produce healthy discipline or the policy accident the whiners fear?

Why Europe Can't Fix Itself & Why It's Getting Worse with Wolfgang Munchau

2026-08-19 | WITH WOLFGANG MUNCHAU

THE THESIS

Munchau's argument is that Europe's stagnation is not cyclical and not fixable with the usual levers. Germany led global technology until the 1980s and 1990s and then stopped innovating, extending nineteenth century breakthroughs in chemistry and engineering into a car industry that carried the whole economy through suppliers and finance. That engine is now losing to China with no diversification plan, and the reflex is to subsidize the car industry rather than replace it. Europe compounded the problem by choosing to regulate digital industries it never participated in, starting with GDPR. Underneath all of it is a political structure Munchau likens to a confederacy that refuses to become a federal state, so even correct diagnoses cannot become decisions.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman tests whether the problem is fixable by policy and gets told it is not. He says plainly that the conversation is depressing, because a story about tax cuts and regulatory burden would have an answer and a story about culture does not, and he adds that he does not think anybody knows how to solve a culture problem. He also interrupts to check a hard number, asking whether German GDP has simply not grown in three to four years, and Munchau substitutes the sharper statistic that productivity has been flat for eight.

THE NUMBERS

- German productivity flat for eight years, with 2018 as the peak and industry falling over the period
- GDPR named as the first of the big European tech regulations and the origin of the cookie banners
- The UK the most active AI investor in Europe, with spinoffs around its London AI cluster, against small scenes in Munich and Paris and almost nothing in Italy or Spain
- Munchau's attribution of American technology scale to capital markets rather than tax breaks
- German coal likely to run longer than planned because nuclear was switched off
- France unable to touch pensions and Germany unable to touch welfare while defense spending must rise, producing debt build up across every European country

WHAT MOVED

Nothing shifts, and the movement is downward rather than toward agreement. Munchau came to report deterioration and reports it, Eisman arrives looking for a policy fix and leaves calling the situation sad and pretty hopeless.

IN THE ARC

This is the counterweight to the show's American AI capex debate. Where Eisman worries that United States hyperscalers are overspending, Munchau's Europe is the control case for underspending, and it argues that the returns question is a luxury only a region with capital markets gets to ask. The fighter jet anecdote Eisman highlights, where a Franco German program collapsed because Germany could not politically accept building in France, is the whole thesis in one story.

“They could regulate the tech industry, which was a stupidity, a sound of arrogance.”

WOLFGANG MUNCHAU

“This is a culture problem. And culture problem, I don't know how to solve a culture problem.”

STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What tipping point would force restructuring, given Munchau says anger is rising but the point is not close?
- Can the UK cluster reach a scale that matters without European capital markets behind it?
- If subsidy is the reflex for every failing sector, where does the fiscal room come from once debt is already exploding?

The Juiciest Corporate Scandals with Becca Platsky

2026-08-26 | WITH BECCA PLATSKY

THE THESIS

Platsky's premise is that corporate fraud is a people story hidden behind formal disclosure, and that the tell is usually a mismatch between what a company says on television and what it reports. She works the Charlie Javice case as the model: a product that automated student aid claiming 400,000 users with extraordinarily valuable personal data, banks that passed, and JPMorgan that bought. The court held that JPMorgan's diligence was not on trial, which Eisman endorses on the principle that the buyer's stupidity is not a defense for the seller. From there she extends the pattern to Paramount governance, prediction markets with no functioning regulator, and FIFA sponsorship money going straight into executives' pockets.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

The real disagreement is about human nature. Platsky raises the humility argument, that fraud can happen to anybody and good people can cross the line, and asks whether Eisman has ever felt that pull. He rejects it outright, saying somebody who does something illegal always did things illegal and that Javice was guaranteed doing bad things before. Platsky says only that it is interesting and does not concede. She also pushes back on his media consolidation view, arguing that one family owning Paramount, CBS, CNN by way of Warner Bros and TikTok is a diversity of news problem, while he answers that nobody cares about traditional media any more.

THE NUMBERS

- Frank pitched as 400,000 users with socials, parental income, schools, majors, emails, home addresses and phone numbers
- Multiple name brand banks declining before JPMorgan bought
- The JPMorgan executive who ran the diligence, once in conversation to replace Jamie Dimon, since demoted
- A teleprompter technician for Trump's speeches betting on which words he would say in prediction markets
- Polymarket defending itself to the CFTC on the ground that it is an innovative company
- Chuck Blazer of FIFA keeping an 8,000 dollar a month Trump Tower apartment plus a 6,000 dollar a month apartment for his cats and parents
- No executive prosecuted or, by Eisman's account, even investigated by the Justice Department after 2008

WHAT MOVED

Neither budges on the character question and both end in the same place on remedy. Platsky asks three times what an ordinary person can do, and Eisman offers nothing beyond whistleblowing, which they agree can destroy your life, so she lands on shrinking your circle and managing the anger.

IN THE ARC

This is Eisman's founding grievance restated for a new audience, that 2008 was the largest fraud in history and produced no investigation, and he explicitly says the laws were already there. It also folds into two live show themes: his preference for Paramount and Warner Bros merging so Netflix does not own the entire content business, and his crypto and event market scepticism, here aimed at venues that let insiders trade on information with no regulator in place.

> *“You being stupid is not a defense for somebody else to take advantage of you.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *“Frauds can't last a hell of a lot longer than you.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- If the statutes already exist, what changed inside the Justice Department that made 2008 unprosecutable?
- Does the CFTC settle the event contract question before or after the first market-moving insider case?
- Is Eisman's rule that fraudsters always offended before a real base rate or a survivorship artifact of the cases that get caught?

The Art of the Short with Lakshmi Ganapathi: FICO, DoorDash, and AeroVironment

2026-09-02 | WITH LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

THE THESIS

Ganapathi argues FICO has shattered its own monopoly by raising prices about 1,600%, angering the mortgage ecosystem and giving the FHFA reason to push VantageScore. Management first dismissed Vantage at about 2% share, then cited roughly 20 to 25%, which tells her it was caught off guard. She does not expect FICO to vanish, only to lose its authority, and sets a target under 500. AeroVironment is priced out of its own market by far cheaper drones, and DoorDash faces European lawsuits plus demand propped up by buy now, pay later credit.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman presses DoorDash on timing: the stretched consumer keeps paying, which hurts the thesis for now. Ganapathi concedes the pattern has run since 2020 and refuses to predict a collapse, calling the strain persistent and prolonged. He also doubts sell-side share data; she says to add plus or minus 10 to any number.

THE NUMBERS

- FICO raised prices about 1,600% over four to five years
- FICO stock a little over 1,000 against her target under 500
- Kelsey Zhu's latest figure for Vantage-scored securitized mortgages was about 8%, against about 2% the prior month
- Vantage says it can score 33 to 37 million people FICO cannot
- AeroVironment, market cap about 9 to 10 billion, sells drones at 50,000 dollars plus against rivals at 5,000 or less
- France criminally convicted Deliveroo, with suspended sentences for two former general managers

WHAT MOVED

Eisman stays short FICO and grows more confident. He is tempted to short AeroVironment but holds off over volatility. He accepts the DoorDash consumer credit logic while Ganapathi gives no date for it.

IN THE ARC

FICO is his one disclosed short, and this episode reinforces it with fresh share data. The DoorDash credit argument extends Ganapathi's earlier call of a consumer crack, which he accepted as direction but not as date.

> *“I would always add like plus or minus 10 with whatever number that comes out.”*
>
> LAKSHMI GANAPATHI

> *“It looks like, at least to me, that FICO is on the verge of losing its monopoly.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Does VantageScore's share of securitized mortgages keep rising now that it is open to all lenders?
- What would force a pullback in buy now, pay later credit to DoorDash users?
- Can AeroVironment close the price gap with low-cost drone makers?

P&C Stocks Worth Owning: The AI Hedge with Ryan Tunis | The Real Eisman Playbook Episode 74

2026-09-07 | WITH RYAN TUNIS

THE THESIS

Tunis argues property and casualty insurance runs on its own pricing cycle, which makes it a place to hide when investors want stability over growth. Commercial lines are about a year into a soft market that is spreading into casualty, so buying on business mix no longer works. He prefers self-help, chiefly AIG near book value, plus Travelers and the reinsurance brokers. Personal auto faces a slower threat as car technology cuts accident rates and shrinks the market.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman is more negative than Tunis on Trupanion, calling it a bad business despite being a satisfied customer. He questions whether reinsurers are franchises, and Tunis concedes the industry has accepted unacceptable returns. On Kinsale, Eisman says its approach sounds dishonest; Tunis defends its mid-50s loss ratios but flags low broker pay as a soft market risk.

THE NUMBERS

- The commercial soft market is about a year old
- Tunis recommends Travelers and AIG, not Chubb
- AIG trades around book value
- Trupanion policies cost about 1,000 dollars a year, with free cash flow near 2% of revenue, about 30 to 40 million
- Kinsale's loss ratios sit in the mid-50s
- Reinsurance brokers are his top subgroup

WHAT MOVED

Eisman leaves more negative on personal lines than he arrived. He sees little to do yet in brokers, stays extremely negative on Trupanion and sees Kinsale as potentially problematic, while Tunis calls it a good company.

IN THE ARC

The first property and casualty deep dive on the show, framed as a hedge against the AI trade he worries about in the same week. It bears on two holdings: AIG, which Tunis backs, and Progressive, whose personal lines business Eisman now views more warily.

> *“We've seen this industry willing to accept returns that are unacceptable.”*
>
> RYAN TUNIS

> *“I have no complaints about Trupanion as a company. I just think it's a bad business.”*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How long can the commercial soft market last?
- Will falling accident rates cut Progressive's growth more than its margins?
- How does Kinsale perform in its first real soft market?

Inside AI’s Fragile Ecosystem with Ed Zitron

2026-09-09 | WITH ED ZITRON

THE THESIS

Zitron argues AI revenue is small against more than a trillion dollars of hyperscaler capex, and most of it comes from OpenAI and Anthropic, which lose heavily and depend on constant fundraising. Hyperscalers spend to capture revenue from two labs they must keep inflating, while Nvidia funds customers who buy its chips. Heavily subsidized subscriptions and a token maxing boom flattered growth, and enterprises are now cutting costs. Data center buildouts are slower and harder than assumed, so the chain faces both a funding wall and a physical one.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman does not dispute the numbers but challenges the premise: these companies are not run by idiots, so how could they be in a mania? Zitron traces it to the zero-rate boom of 2021, and Eisman answers with the GFC, where Wall Street could not stop until subprime blew up. Eisman also frames Zitron's OpenAI view as preparing for failure, not predicting it.

THE NUMBERS

- Microsoft's fiscal 2026 AI revenue was 34.33 billion, 24.1 billion from OpenAI, per a Bloomberg estimate
- OpenAI lost 20.9 billion on 13.07 billion of revenue in 2025
- OpenAI's latest quarterly operating margin was about minus 183%
- 110 billion of OpenAI's 122 billion raise came from Amazon, SoftBank and Nvidia
- OpenAI subscriptions let users burn about 14,000 dollars of compute for 200 dollars
- About 70% of hyperscaler AI revenue comes from the two labs, about 25 to 35% of cloud revenue

WHAT MOVED

Eisman ends aligned with Zitron. He calls the dependence on the two labs nerve-wracking and names OpenAI the problem child, while Zitron holds that none of the spending is worth it. Eisman stops short of calling a bubble.

IN THE ARC

This sharpens his long-held top AI risk, dependence on Anthropic and OpenAI, into a specific claim that OpenAI is the weaker lab. It follows the Anthropic S-1 question and his sales of Oracle and Meta over capital intensity.

> *“They're doing it so they can capture revenue from two companies that they themselves have to keep inflating.”*
>
> ED ZITRON

OPEN QUESTIONS

- What will Anthropic's S-1 show for second-half 2026 revenue after token maxing faded?
- Can OpenAI keep raising money as its press sours?
- How much of Oracle's 600 billion backlog survives an OpenAI funding failure?

The Big Short Partners Reunite: Rates, AI, Gold and Two Stock Picks | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 75

2026-09-14 | WITH PORTER COLLINS, VINCENT DANIEL

THE THESIS

Collins argues the US fiscal position has passed the point of repair: interest expense plus entitlements run at about 110% of tax receipts, interest cannot be cut, entitlements will not be, and big tax increases will not happen under this administration. That leaves printing, which is why he holds more conviction in precious metals than in anything for years. Gold is a debt-free asset that central banks, China included, keep adding, while Treasuries are someone else's liability. Bessent's bond buying and pressure for lower rates are a six-to-nine-month bet that growth slows enough to cool inflation, played with signaling games in the interim.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman makes Collins explain the link between rates and gold for viewers who do not see it, and presses on why the Treasury needs six to nine months. The partners in turn push Eisman to concede that the deficit hawks were right once promised fraud cuts came to almost nothing; the answer comes back that the old deficit view still holds, argued less passionately than before. On Carvana the group agrees profits look enhanced but accepts that proving it has been impossible for eight years.

THE NUMBERS

- Interest expense plus entitlements at about 110% of tax receipts
- Bessent's initial long-bond purchase of at least 4 billion dollars
- Citadel illustrated with about 25 billion of capital running roughly 125 billion of positions at five to one
- Carvana at about 30 to 40 times earnings
- Cannabis selling for about 200 dollars a pound in California, with 50% to 65% EBITDA margins possible abroad
- All three are short FICO

WHAT MOVED

Little moves. Eisman and his partners agree on FICO, on the futility of Treasury intervention and on AI nerves. The partners hold their gold conviction; Eisman asks questions rather than taking a position on metals.

IN THE ARC

The first conversation with his old partners since the show's launch in April 2025, and it anchors the September theme of a rising long end he no longer thinks the market can ignore. It restates his FICO short, and the unnamed cannabis pick appears to be Glass House Brands, his own speculative holding, now tied to a 2027 catalyst.

> *“I think I've had as much conviction in this precious metals trade as I've had in anything in a long, long time.”*
>
> PORTER COLLINS

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Can Treasury buy enough long bonds to matter without an alternative buyer?
- Does the cannabis margin case survive if interstate or overseas sales slip past 2027?

How to Analyze Bank Stocks (Part 1): Leverage, Accounting, and Loan Losses

2026-09-16 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

Banking is a low-margin business, so a bank earns an adequate return only by putting its ROA through leverage: ROE equals ROA times leverage. That same arithmetic gives managements an incentive to lever up, which is why regulators set capital ratios, and why risk weighting invites banks to stuff balance sheets with low-weighted assets. Risk weights rest on loss history, but loss history depends on underwriting that can loosen. Because CECL forces reserve true-ups at once, provisions become the variable investors fear most, and the non-accrual data at the four largest banks becomes the best window on credit.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

His strongest objection to himself is on Burry's chip depreciation charge: he concedes chips do last longer and a secondary market exists, so the longer schedule can be justified, while holding that the timing of the change is still a red flag. He also warns against the lesson that all bank leverage is bad, since without it lending would cost too much and the economy would stall.

THE NUMBERS

- A bank with 1 billion of equity and 1 billion of loans has one times leverage and a 1% ROE on a 1% ROA
- Large-bank CET1 ratios have fallen since 4Q24 as capital rules loosen
- JPMorgan provisions of 8.3 billion in 1Q20 and 10.5 billion in 2Q20, then 611 million in 3Q20
- JPMorgan non-accruals of 9.4 billion in 2Q26, down 5% year on year and 2% on the quarter
- Bank of America non-accruals of 5.8 billion in 2Q26, down 4% year on year and flat on the quarter
- JPMorgan's earnings supplement runs about 29 pages

WHAT MOVED

A solo lecture, so no exchange. He lands on the view that large-bank credit is benign and that bank data will lag, not lead, any private credit problem.

IN THE ARC

This extends his 2008 teaching that leverage is the root cause, and restates his July 2026 revision that bank credit is no longer the leading indicator. He names investor redemptions as the signal to watch instead, and calls bank exposure to private credit meaningful but not disastrous.

> *"Without leverage, the ROE of a bank is simply pathetic."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *"The credit trends reported by the large banks are very benign."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- How far will loosened capital rules push CET1 ratios, and will looser standards reset the loss history behind risk weights?
- How large is bank lending to private credit and private equity, and where will it first show up?

Stock Picking in Difficult Times with George Noble | The Real Eisman Playbook Ep 76

2026-09-21 | WITH GEORGE NOBLE

THE THESIS

Noble argues the market has entered a regime change: after the GFC, printing had no visible cost, but with 40 trillion dollars of federal debt, Treasury cannot repress long rates for long, and foreign buyers are walking away. Japan is the swing risk, since its ten-year has crossed 4% and by a debt-to-GDP curve should sit near 7%, which could pull Japanese money home. On AI he judges the return on investment exceptionally low and sees an ecosystem hinging on OpenAI, with related-party financing that echoes the structures Eisman chased before the GFC. SpaceX and Tesla, carried by passive buying and narrative, are his shorts.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

Eisman mostly agrees and uses the hour to draw Noble out. He asks how Noble knows Tesla sales are imploding and gets the public July data. He adds the footnote that much Japanese debt is held at home, which weakens the direct yield comparison. Noble turns the tables with a hypothetical homebuilder to have Eisman walk through related-party and VIE accounting.

THE NUMBERS

- US debt of about 40 trillion dollars and debt to GDP of roughly 125% to 130%, against Japan's 240%
- Japan's ten-year above 4% for the first time in about 30 years; Noble's curve implies about 7%
- US ten-year at about 4.8% at recording
- SpaceX market cap of 1.7 trillion against Noble's sum of the parts of roughly 300 to 500 billion, and 200 to 300 billion in Eisman's recap
- Tesla US sales down 26% in July
- Tesla's share price roughly flat over five years

WHAT MOVED

Eisman ends where he started on Bessent and rates, now with the added Japan channel he calls interesting. He concedes Noble may be more negative on AI than he is. Noble holds his SpaceX and Tesla shorts; Eisman states no position on either.

IN THE ARC

The guest reinforces Eisman's worry about the long end the same week he moves his rate threshold to 5%. It also sharpens his existing AI risk, the dependence of the buildout on loss-making OpenAI and Anthropic.

> *"Do you realize Tesla's stock price is unchanged over five years? It's done nothing, despite all the hype."*
>
> GEORGE NOBLE

OPEN QUESTIONS

- At what Japanese yield do domestic institutions start selling dollar assets in size?
- Can SpaceX and Tesla hold their valuations once passive index buying is complete?

How to Analyze Banks (Part 2): Deposits, Valuations, and Silicon Valley

2026-09-23 | SOLO LECTURE

THE THESIS

The one thing only a bank can do is take deposits, and deposits are normally the cheapest, most stable funding, but only if they are diverse. Silicon Valley Bank had many depositors who were all venture-backed companies with negative cash flow, so when rates rose they drained deposits together, while the bank had loaded up on long bonds at near-zero yields. Under the accounting, those unrealized losses cut book value without touching earnings until forced sales crystallized them. The lesson is that rules matter, that SVB was never systemic, and that valuation turns on returns, which is why he prefers the big banks today.

WHERE EISMAN PUSHED

He turns the strongest objection on his own regional bank M&A thesis, conceding that its only strength is its logic, because bank CEOs love their jobs and First Horizon declared itself a buyer. He also notes that Goldman at about 3 times tangible book is no longer a value stock, only a bet that good times continue.

THE NUMBERS

- SVB rose from 50 dollars in 2010 to 760 in November 2021 and failed on 10 March 2023
- SVB's 212 billion in assets escaped the 250 billion stress-test threshold
- Bank of America carries about 100 billion of unrealized bond losses
- Loans generate about 70% of bank interest revenue

- Goldman moved from 1.3 to about 3 times tangible book
- Bank OZK's 32.6 billion loan book is 50% commercial real estate, and the stock trades at one times tangible book

WHAT MOVED

His bank stance moves. He drops his hopes for regional bank consolidation as an investable thesis, advises sticking to the big banks, and says he owns none because they sit at peak valuations and would add AI risk.

IN THE ARC

He has held banks to be safe since Dodd-Frank and wanted a regional merger wave; here he keeps the first view and effectively abandons the second. Linking investment bank profits to AI financing ties the lecture to his growing unease about AI concentration.

> *"Unfortunately, the only thing my thesis has going for it is its impeccable logic."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

> *"Believe me, the system was not at risk."*
>
> STEVE EISMAN

OPEN QUESTIONS

- Will looser regulation eventually push regional bank CEOs to sell?
- How long will unrealized bond losses weigh on Bank of America's net interest margin?
- If the AI financing boom fades, how fast do investment bank valuations reset?